Butterflies (editing in progress)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33271312.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence, Major Character Death

Category:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Adora's absoloute badass fighting style

Additional Tags:
Ex Force Captain Adora, Alt Episode, hella angst, Adora Has Issues (She-Ra), Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Catra is not having a good time, Bow is trying his best, Glimmer is trying, Entrapta Being Entrapta (She-Ra), Horde Prime Being a Jerk (She-Ra), no regrets, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Adora actually confesses, what is this a romance novel, Adora is kinda scary in this tbh, She-Ra is on a different level, Angst, Episode: s05e05 Save The Cat, Post-Episode: s05e05 Save the Cat, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Alternate Universe, Super Renegade Adora, It literally just keeps getting worse, POV Adora (She-Ra), POV Glimmer (She-Ra)

Language:
English

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Kaffees Useless Lesbians, Banco Fic

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Butterflies (editing in progress)

by KaffeeKup

Summary

How far will Adora go to save Catra from Prime?

She left Catra behind once before - she’s not making that mistake again.
A long time ago they made a wish together, to care of the other and...Adora's going to make sure of that.
A wish for a life together, away from war and pain. The happy ending they've always deserved.
Adora'll do whatever it takes-

To Save the Cat. No matter the cost.

A reimagining of S5 E5

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A/N notes for content warnings are at the bottom of the fic

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Chapter I: On The Edge Of Greatness

Adora's introspection turns outward, the BFS+1 make a plan for the upcoming assault.

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Adora is *here* and Catra is over *there.*

A blank looking training dummy in Mara's ship serves as the perfect distraction for Adora's frustrations.

She's already thrown away her red jacket and then the white top to the side, and stripped down to a grey tank top. The dummy is hard enough to be a useful distraction but soft enough to punch without injuring her bare knuckles to uselessness. Although the

pain of each satisfying hit provides a useful enough impetus to keep herself awake after the disastrous events of the past twenty four hours, an entire day of *fucking misery* .

Emotionally,physically and mentally jumping from repeated contradictory events.

Highs and lows strung together like clothes on a washing line.

The high of hearing Catra and knowing that Glimmer would be coming home, the low of bearing witness to - being unable to do anything when Catra had been captured again and her voice…

The memory ,already lurching in the back of the mind, is coming back in full force. Just Adora, Bow and Entrapta on the command deck of their barely functioning spacecraft.

"Adora? Adora?" Came in from the sparking intercom. All it took was a single second to bring back realization of repressed hope from hearing Catras' voice for the first time in years that hadn't been laid with malice or anger.

Catra? Adora whispered back to herself at first in disbelief and then outloud to get others' reactions to make sure she wasn't *dreaming.*

Adoras mind spans with multiple outcomes, things to say. A conversation that they could have together without the war, without She-Ra and without being on opposite sides.

Heart pounding, pupils dilated. Fingers gripping the dial so hard that it'd break if it wasn't made out of spaceship.

Adora wanted Catra to stay on that line forever if they couldnt see each other again. It'd be the next best thing.

Instead. Nothing. Just the conversation. The talk. A distracted and hurried Catra stating the how, the why, the when and where and the who while Adora muddled through her replies and responses.

How, Adoras confusion became a muddled but agreeable state when she learnt it was teleportation. Why? They had to get off Primes ship and Catra had managed to figure it out, now was the time and the reason why Adora was contacted. Glimmer would be dropped off in the same quadrant as them.

Thump. One aching arm.

And it was *just* Glimmer who teleported for them to pick up.

Adora's introspection is making her spiral again, the fact that she and Catra were so close for that brief few minutes and yet so far away from each other.

No Catra. She. *Adora can't even think straight.*

Maybe if the Clones hadn't rushed in and stormed the teleportation room then maybe Catra would have been able to teleport to same coordinates she'd sent Glimmer to and joined them and there'd be five instead of four and they would be back

on their way to Etheria right now instead of hurtling towards Primes ship on a rescue mission.

Adora listened to Catra tell them through the intercom, pleading with them not to come. For Adora to leave, to go. To not fly to Horde Primes ship and attempt a rescue guns blazing.

"Adora?" Catra's scratchy voice came up again, full of tears and strained.

"I'm sorry". Catra cried out. Adoras knuckles gripped white on the console and she desperately tried to think of something, anything. The two of them hadn't spoken to each other in casual terms in *years* , not since the Crystal Castle and now Catra was going to be-

"Catra I don't understand?" Was all she managed to croak out, her unfocused mind desperately and blindly latching on to some sense of reason.

"For everything". Adora's finger trembled at a fumbling reply that never crept past her lips and stayed in her throat. The intention from Catra, for Adora to not come back. *Just like so many times before except nor with malice or hate this time. A genuine, actual warning.*

Hearing that stroke a chord red raw, years ago Catra had begged Adora to stay and now it's the painful opposite.

It reminded her of Thaymor where it all began between the two of them in the ruins of a village, Catra clad in her red and brown Horde outfit with her new red headpiece begging Adora to stay.

The confusion that Adora wouldn't come home back to the Fright Zone. *Painful memories.* Adora stood in shock and unable to move, as much as she *screamed* at herself internally to say *something* , to come into action. Nothing happened. *Useless.*

And then it all came screeching down to reality, the emtional high of hearing Catra again. The rescue of Glimmer where Adora watched Bow desperately scramble out of his crop top and fashionable Etherian get up and into a purple spacesuit that Entrapta somehow pieced together in record time, that Adora held on her end of the rope that Bow clung to as he rescued Glimmer, their queen. She was still wearing that golden crown, blue cape and regal clothes even now. Adora watched helplessly in every aspect other than to keep the rope steady as the other two slowly floated into Mara’s spacecraft.

When the three of them, the best friends squad finally came together again. It was just a simple hug, none of the charmadiere or bright spark like before Glimmer became queen after her mothers death but neither the awkward fights or harsh language that existed between them afterwards. Just a hug this time, if Adora was able to focus on something other than the previous events with the revelation that Catra wouldn't be coming back then maybe she would have reacted differently.

The low came back after that small high, the sad note of not managing to properly speak back a reply to Catra that wasn't mumbled, confused or spit out with hesitation.

No no no no. Catra. Come back .

Thump. Back to the punching dummy with split knuckles that told her she'd been at it for too long and other arm down to the fingers was hurting now too. Catra'd help if she was here like she did back at the horde when Adora would over exert herself during the training sessions that Shadow Weaver pushed her through multiple times a day, Catra'd giggle and call her a dummy while helping to patch up or bandage things.

But Catra wasn't here, she was over *there* .

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Nah you wanna talk to Bow, he's your "talk your feelings out guy". I'm your "punch your feelings out guy!"

Since She-Ra had left…. *mostly* and was unable to be summoned or really properly controlled and instead appearing only in times of great emotional stress and even then briefly or in the same glitchy hurty mess that Glimmer had been in when she had been affected by Shadow Weavers magic poison meant that She-Ra. Princess of
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Power, two meter plus *demigod* that was practically indestructible could *no longer* be relied upon.

Thus. Adora had to pick up the pace, as someone with no magic,no technological skills or a specific gimmick she had to *push* herself ahead and keep going ever since Primes forces had landed on Etheria and began wrecking the place.

Someone had to stand up and run interference nonstop.

Someone needed to play guard at the entrance when everyone was asleep.

Someone made maps, battleplans. Led the troops, attacked, counterattacked.

Someone *forgot* they were *only* human and *not* She-Ra anymore.

Attack plans to push the Prime Horde away from the camp. *She's not She-Ra.* Defensive posturing and use of dummies and decoys to lure bots and those flying drones from assaulting populated areas and rather towards either nothing or carefully planned ambushes which she'd lead at the front, just like She-Ra.

Except without a sword, the height, the durability and the status of a demigod. She'd come out of every encounter bloodied and bruised and with less sleep gained the following night. Instead of rest she'd ponder other every mistake and distract herself. *Keep busy.* From the loss of Catra and Glimmer and the overwhelming dread that there was nothing she could do and that in reality they'd lost the moment the portal had open. The numberless

horde of clones and drones proved that doubt at the back of her head that in cold reality everything action was just holding and slowly losing ground until they lost via sheer attrition alone.

Finding the planet and the raw materials needed to power the ship was the next emotional high that managed to throw off the doubt, anxiety and insecurity that kept her awake while the others slept was next.

Good progress, more rebels found and they promised to help in some way or form. After that it was battling earthquakes and the very planet itself as the “BFS” and Entrapta repaired the engine and won a small but crucial victory.

She-Ra even appeared.

A stark reminder that without the sword she was at best a contradictory coin toss of an emergency use weapon and just like Beast Island she was something that Adora couldn't properly fight in or use anymore with any certainty and relegated only to random moments when the spark to power her became briefly alight. *Unreliable.*

A bigger failure of *her* against a small victory of *them* .

Things were spinning again, spiraling out of control and the moment Adora lost concentration , when she stopped being *busy* then the anxiety sauntered back into her life, pushing her into rooms where no one could listen or see. The other three were none the wiser thankfully, she'd managed to keep herself going constantly and the stares and the whispers were always about the mission rather than her and she'd keep it that way for as long as possible.

Still she was happy to see her one of her best friends, she'd swamped Glimmer with the tightest of group hugs that she could provide along with Bow and the three of them huddled against a wall, comforting the Queen of Bright Moon in a positive loop that kept their spirits up for the brief moments. Adoras heart soared and she nuzzled her friends. Content, happy.

Even if it was for a brief isolated moment.

Because then the emotional low came. The talk. The fact that they hadn't picked Catra up. (?Failed?)

Catra was a day ago, the planet was half that. Twelve hours in and the talk *(?interrogation?)* with Glimmer ended. Well it seemed like one considering Adora had been verging on regressing back to her days as a Force Captain, squeezing information out like she did with the raiders of the Crimson Waste during her tenure in the Horde. Gathering intelligence on the *enemy.* Second nature in a way. But this was Glimmer, a friend and she shouldn't view it like *that.* Or even be in the headspace to view it as such.

Still she listened as Glimmer spoke at length. She'd done her homework while being captive.She knew the layout of the ship. The clones. What to expect, that it felt more like a flying and technologically sophisticated version of the Fright Zone with its massive and spiderweb layout of corridors and multiple floor levels and that could easily be hidden cameras everywhere and there was always the possibility of Clones at every corner now in a step up of security since she'd been broken out.Glimmer spoke at hand about the vulnerabilities next, that the clones were sort of a hive mind with Prime able to swap to them within a brief moment, that he could be anywhere and everywhere at once.

But she also mentioned, with a smart hand wave and with Bow's rapt attention that she'd detected that Prime performed all of this without magic, and without magic then they had an edge over Prime.

Entrapta summarized that in order to perform his technological mastery then there must be signal relays or something to bounce Prime around into his clones, that he was a puppet master and that his strings could be *cut.*

They just needed to get there. Break in, rescue Catra and set the ship on fire.

A good plan, a rough mental map built out. Orders issued with a series of knives dug into a piece of paper. Marching orders of course, just like back in the Fright Zone as a Force Captain. Glimmer goes here to rescue *Catra* ., Entrapta and Bow go there to cut off the *puppets* strings. Adora heads to the throne room to confront, kill or distract prime.

Not She-Ra.

Adora.

The others asked with some concern about going in solo, Adora simply shrugs and laughs it off with a fake chuckle. If Glimmer was going solo then why shouldn't she?

Glimmer had magic and knew her way around the ship.

She gave a friendly wave and told them not to be bothered, even with the worried looks and the whispering.

Bow and Entrapta are technologically inclined.

She said she *just* needed sleep and headed off.

She didn't.

The moment she knew she was out of sight Adora ran headfirst into the nearest room and jammed the lock with her extendable staff.

She wasn't She-Ra. Heart thumping and going completely nuts.

They all had something special, she was just fortunate enough to be along for the ride. Head spinning again and concentrating was difficult, was she thirsty?

She didn't have the sword and instead just a crappy staff that could be broken, no weapon otherwise. Body crashing against the nearest wall and hands desperately holding onto something *anything* to keep herself upright.

She barely knew where she was going other than in a vague "middle direction". She had to confront Prime and do something, to convince him she was still She-Ra? She had an escape plan right? What if Catra was there and she'd need to fight her way out?

Nonononono. She couldn't, she'd have to-find a way somehow. She could plan for it right now and stick to it, bottle up and put away everything into a box that'd have to be opened later but not *right.now.* Was that tears? Why was she breathing so heavily and in such badly, *uncoordinated* and ragged fashion? You didn't do that in the Horde you *stuck* to your task and kept at it until you collapsed.

Tears coming down and joining her cough-breathing-thing. Turning it wet,heavy and threatening to dislodge her from the barely kept standing upright position. Catra always helped with this when the pressure of command and exception came up, she'd find a warm, soothing, purring friend cuddled up right next to her.

Catra would whisper in Adoras ear that everything would work and be okay, that all Adora needed to do was listen to Catra's noises ,wrap their arms around each other and hold on tight and it'd be fine as long as they were *together* . Adora'd motion in for a cuddle that only Catra could give and receive exactly the same when they were *together* .

She missed Catra so much. She-. She-. She wanted Catra, needed her.

Adora's chest heaved of its own accord, in direct violation of the stiff orders that Adora relayed down and she lurched backwards into a fall and barely managed to avoid hurting her elbows further, she clutched herself and tried desperately to remember the purrs and the soothing words and they never came.

Because she was *here.*

And Catra is over *there.*

Overwhelming thoughts came next. The strange pang and twist in her gut when she witnessed the married couple Netossa and Spinnerella for the first time, how weird and yet uplifting when she saw the kisses, the closeness and the interactions between the two. That they were in *love* and *together* .

She idly compared *that* to the emptiness in heart and tried in vain to bring back memories of her and Catra when they slept together in bed, the closeness they shared. The feelings it gave Adora, that she truly missed those times and would do anything to bring them back. But Catra was over *there* . And Adora was *here* .

Jealousy over Glimmer and Bow, intense with twist in the stomach when witnessing how tight and close the two became during the expedition to the planet to replace fuel cells, the kiss the two shared and how she wanted that to be included with what she *missed* .

But she couldn't have it, she wasn't allowed to. Shadow Weaver broke her relentlessly and trained her in the way of the horde where fight came over feelings, punching them out or bottling them was the way of the game. Light Hope taught her that she was meaningless without her destiny and that having broken the sword and by extension She-Ra, she too was broken. Adora was *not* without Catra and. The weight of the world, the expectations that Angella and the rebellion had. The other princesses expected her to do came crashing down in that moment to-

Her body is betraying her, exhaustion and physical downtime long put off by lack of sleep and forcefully keeping herself awake is coming back like a bad case of karma and she cant hold herself up any longer.

Heart palpitations, erratic movements, clutching chest, eyes sweltering with tears that dropped and covered both the floor and *her* . Moving was impossible, staying was all she could do, she'd

locked the door so no one could come in and even if they wanted to, they couldn't.

She wouldn't let them see her like this. She needed to be strong, a substitute for She-Ra and someone just as powerful and unrelenting and unstoppable.

Not a fragile girl who was crying herself to death, working herself to the bone and utterly disconnected from the reality of her situation.

In the brief moment of time.

Adora realizes she’s having a panic attack. And that Catra isn’t *here.*

And Adora wants her to be

The purrings, the noises, the soothing. The fur, the hair. The eyes, the personality. The person clutching their fingers and claws together,foreheads touching in sweet closeness. Bundled up together in bed where nothing could hurt them as long as they had each other. And that. That longing for something that wasn't *there anymore* hurt the most.

Catra. *Touch*

Adora. *Feel*

Wanted. *Together*

They spent twenty years joined at the hip and did everything as one since being able to walk and talk, they trained together, they ate together, they slept together. Adora had Catra and Catra had Adora. When the time came for her appointment as a Force Captain, Adora appointed Catra to become her number two there was never a single person more qualified for the position in Adora’s mind.. During their deployment in the Crimson Waste to secure resources and territory in the Hordes' vulnerable backyard they grew ever closer. Adora’s nightmares and Catra’s trauma from Shadow Weaver reinforced their bond and even though it's been two years, nobody has ever come close to that level of commitment that Adora shared and felt towards the Magicat.

Her worst mistake wasn’t leaving the Horde, she had no regrets towards that with their unacceptable levels of violence towards civilians and the innocent and their true goals revealed.

No.

Adora’s worst mistake kept her beating herself up at night was leaving Catra alone to fend for herself against the crushing pressures of command on her lonesome and Shadow Weavers abuse.

Adora promises in that moment where she gazes at a bloody reflection of herself that she’ll bring Catra home.

Horde soldiers are issued with a single stimulation drug. Keeping the soldier alert and ready for up to six hours with energy and restless desire it's kept in a single small red container. Force Captains are given three.

Adora still has hers in a pocket.

Catra is anywhere from six to eighteen hours depending on the ship fuel reserves, evasive maneuvers and the need to be stealthily and quiet. And three drugs are eighteen hours if taken in moderation or a complete pain suppressing, injury ignoring and adrenaline fuelled six. If she can time it right then..maybe.

Just maybe. She can match She-Ra.

A/N CW content warning for trauma, panic attacks, violence, post traumatic stress disorder,self harm, suicidal thoughts and actions for the fic.

How'd I do? Comments,feedback and reviews would be greatly appreciated

Comission by Dylan R Fagan Artwork

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II

Chapter II: We’re Right Beside You.

The assault on Prime's ship is finally underway. Adora channels her inner Force Captain.

The person staring back in the mirror vaguely resembles the bright women who stood at a similar one in Brightmoon just six months ago.

But barely.

Cracked and bloodshot blue eyes that hadn't seen sleep in days , wiry veined muscles that had shrunk slightly by a combination of exhaustion and malnutrition, hair split in every way and end possible. A person that couldn't stop moving either, constantly shifting from side to side from either nerves or a worry that if Adora stopped she’d fall asleep forever. She hadn't been able to take even a brief trip to a hairdresser and now her side shaves are growing back.

That's who she saw in the mirror, *briefly.*

Adora’s hiding in the bathroom.

And she’s having another panic attack, born of painful memory of the first months of assuming the mantle of She-Ra without any idea of how to operate as her and yet already buckling under the sheer weight of the assumed responsibility as the Princess of Power..

I know the legend of the warrior, the First Ones called “She-Ra” , that she’d return to us in the hour of our greatest need. Rise, the rebellion accepts your allegiance. She-Ra ! Princess of Power.

She-Ra! She-Ra! She-Ra! She-Ra! She-Ra!

Adora should have felt elation or joy at the appointment but instead another weight, an extra mantle of responsibility. Adora’s name failed to be important that day. The mirror in front of her reflects that, the sole bathroom on the ship covered with vomit, towels wiped with most of the blood from her knuckles and the sink now host to two trembling hands that gripped the sides.

Who are you? Where’s She-Ra?

She’s just a girl.

“I’m She-Ra, just not the same She-Ra” She admitted to the town folk, glancing away from their judging eyes and holding the sleeve of her jacket in a bid to remain in control.

Then you cant save us?

The memories of that day, her first near panic attack in public that'd only been saved from a sudden Horde attack, the fact that the townspeople suddenly stopped caring once she admitted who she was. They didn't care did they? Didn't want to know her real name, only that She-Ra could do *something* .

Adora manages to make eye contact with herself in the mirror for a brief second, two bright eyes staring back, a quivering upper lip that barely managed to hold itself together and even staring down don't help because her knuckles split again from the sheer force of grip.

A figure in white and gold, long flowing hair and a significant sword stood apart, back turned. Adora reached out to ask the figure what her name was and she received nothing in reply. The figure then turned and looked her dead in the eyes and-

Her throat guttered the same noise a dog made when it was about to throw up and she vomited another barely digested ration bar in the sick, water previously drunk wasted on tears. Bloody fingers hold on to tattered or matted blonde hair to stop vomit from becoming embedded in the threads, breathing quickly descending from barely audible to a series of increasingly rapid and near uncontrollable short bursts, each one firing off in her eyes as she-

Alone? You really ought to bring backup since you're not . You know? You-know-who-anymore.

Adora, you can't rush into battle like that. Not anymore , gotta stop acting like you're invincible cuz you aint-

-started heaving again, heart pounding so hard that if she wasn't concerned about four hundred other things she'd be worried that it'd leap out of her chest, every time she got a quiet time alone this fucking shit happened, memories, flashbacks, being reminded of who she presented, who she *used* to be, *should* be, *could* be.

For the HONOR of GREY-skull, fuck.

Everything going completely haywire, thoughts running amok. Body shaking uncontrollably from stress, her muscles trembling and quivering from her legs to her arms because even never resting and always on the move, training, fighting, eating, planning meant *jack fucking shit* if she wasn't a eight foot tall lady with a sword that could lift a tank. Everything hurts again and she holds onto that sink for dear life as she manages to spit into it instead of vomiting. She tries to raise her head again and-

Plus your friend over there can turn into a eight foot tall lady with a sword.

Even at the beginning, it was only She-Ra that mattered.

Do what you did before! We need the scary sword lady back.

Even when they didnt know her name, what She-Ra could bring to the table is what mattered, what initiated *Adora* into the rebellion. Not her merits as a force captain or anything. Just destiny that Light Hope said, that She-Ra was only the thing special about her by a random birth lottery.

Angry now, vein bulging in panic fueled rage , body shaking violently as she went through all the times she failed as Adora and succeeded as She-Ra, that even now She-Ra would be a better fit for everyone, fuck. She-Ra probably could have rescued Catra by now and if it wasn't for her then-

"Fucking dammit!" Adora punches the mirror as hard as possible in blind rage , then promptly accompanied by a pained scream in realization of what she did.

And again.

The other fist.

And again.

Shattering most of it and leaving only a shard left. Pieces of glass embedded in her balled up fists and forearms like defensive knife wounds.

Only then can she look at herself.

Breathing returned to normal since she couldn't hear it blanket her senses like a never ending sequence of explosions.

Knuckles cleaned up, another ration bar eaten. Urge to take the pills thrown away.

Mirror? A regrettable loss but there was plenty back on Etheria. *She spat out blood in the sink.*

Five minutes later, messy hair turned into a hair poof and ponytail, jacket prim and proper, complexion set and neutral, posture and gait adequate.

Everything else thrown into a safe, locked with the key discarded and the safe then promptly dumped into the deepest river at the back of her consciousness, the only thing that matters is the mission and how *Adora* was going to handle it. Just like in the Fright Zone as Force Captain Adora she was going to *fix* this, *execute* her mission and get it *fucking* done. Come home, and then do it again.

Cracking her knuckles together and flexing joints, each letting their discomfort known with a loud pop or pained hiss.Adora joins the others, hopefully none the wiser.

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“Yeah-yeah. I uh it’s just” Glimmers voice wavered and a brief spark of anxious magic appeared between her fingers before she made it disappear. “There’s so much I want to say to the both of you, about what happened and I-”

If Glimmer was going to have a emotional outpouring and a heart to heart then Adora would fucking explode and not come back, not during the mission. They *needed* to be on *task* .

“It’s okay, we can talk about this in a better time” She reached out and placed a reassuring hand on Glimmer's shoulder with a light shake.

“You mean later like Etheria later?”

“Yeah back on soil, once we’ve gotten Catra back and killed Prime then we can talk about everything” Her hand was shaking, *shit* the hand on Glimmer *is* shaking and she needed to-

Fuck Glimmer is stuttering now and close to tears,

“Adora I, I r-really want t-to?” Glimmer hadn’t done this since Angella threw herself into the portal with the present Queen suffering from an emotional breakdown. Fuck. *Fuck.* Fuck. Adora is not equipped to handle this, she’s used to ordering around cadets or making battleplans,not the mushy stuff, she punched those instead.

“Later Glimmer, I promise” Was the best she said, with a “reassuring” trembling hand that couldnt sit stilll and she felt like she was fucking lying instead by kicking the conversation down the road but she couldnt deal with it right now.

“Are you sure Adora, I-”

“I’m sure”

She sort of snapped? Not the angry kind but the *this conversation is over kind.* Besides Glimmer had Bow and he had already shifted over to comfort her while Adora made herself to leave and wandered over to the captain's chair, gripping onto it for strength while she silently heaved and marshaled what little strength she could spare.

Five minutes? Ten? Went by to the sound of hushed whispers and body movement behind from Glimmer and Bow, Adoras *heart ached* that she couldn't join them in the best friends squad way that they were used to but so much had changed now and she’s simply unable to afford the emotional toll even as a welcoming distraction, she needs to think,rethink, make adjustments to the plan. She’d already given away that she was planning to hopefully kill Horde Prime aswell as mark herself as bait and-

She needs to breathe again, in. out. Count to ten. Inhale, exhale. Possibly the only part of Perfumas therapy sessions that ever stuck in the few times that Adora ever managed to listen without her brain constantly jumping between ten different subjects.

Adora’s too focused on handling her situation that she failed to hear Bow’s loud footsteps on the hard spaceship tile come up from behind until it was too late.

“Adora.”

Just one.simple word. Bow’s voice is hard this time and nothing like the usually upbeat tone that she’d become used to.

She knows he’s standing beside her, she doesn't dare make eye contact though.

“Adora, look at me”

She breathes in, out and straightens up her form again to mimic that of the rigid unwavering Force Captain posture that she’d been trained to do since birth.

“Yes Bow?” Adora turned around too quickly, eye contact straight and with the most neutral expression and voice she could muster, exactly like she was leading a parade.

Bow’s face remains unconvinced. He knew . “Don’t do that with me please”

“What am I doing?” Adora shifted back with arms crossed, leaning onto side of the captain's chair.

Bow blinked, sighed and blinked again.

"Do I really need to list it out? Fine. From the start you've been ignoring everyone, blowing off Perfuma and anyone that tried to help you back on Etheria with anything! Strategy, battlers- whatever, you insisted on working yourself to death and the only time I ever found you sleeping was when you basically *collapsed Adora* "

"Bow I-"

He's not done yet, the sound of his voice alone conveyed that this was a *long time coming.*

"You think I really haven't noticed that you'd rather throw yourself into every battle and spend all night planning, its unhealthy and you're doing it here too, smashing mirrors and leaving blood in side rooms and now you've gone and blown off Glimmer when she tried to apologize for everything that happened between you too? Seriously Adora, what the fuck?"

Adora stood silent, mouth wide open and brain desperately scrambling for a reply that'd *fix this* . How did Bow know? She'd tried to be quiet and she was the only one who could do all of that, didn't Bow know that She-Ra was gone and Adora's had to pick up the pieces and continue work as normal?

"Adora, *stop* . We've known each other for *two years* and I can tell when you're getting like *that.* You're not okay, Glimmer aint either and I'm stuck in the middle wondering how things got like this"

She can't respond to that or speak. Bow's words cut deep truths into the armor that she wrought around herself and it's getting close to touching that safe at the bottom of the river.

"If you want to let it out when everythings done here, fine. But I'm holding *you to t hat ."* Bow scoffed and walked away.

"Bow I-" Brain, mouth and feelings finally kicking together Adora making a desperate play and with a hammering heart reached out to clasp at Bow's hand, when he turned round with a scowl she instinctively flinched to avoid eye contact.

"What is it?" He said coldly. "Glimmers waiting for me "

"Wait" She managed to make actual physical skin contact that stopped Bow dead in his tracks, his icy exterior softened and she shivered in response.

"I I-can't"

She struggled with sagging shoulders, clamping her jaw and then resetting everything seemed to sort of work. She had one shot to tell him or else she'd clam up again.

"I *have* to focus on the mission, you know that. Prime has Catra on his ship and despite everything we've been through, I still *care*

about her but I’ve gotta focus on that or else..”

“Adora?” Bow softens and turns round, cupping the blonde's hands in his own.

Adora sniffed, upper lip quivering as the memories of her and Catra came flooding back even as she desperately tried to hold back the water..but. *She didn't want to shut Bow out, or any of her friends. Did that make her a bad friend? She had a choice right now, let him go or do something. Something.*

“I can't leave her there Bow, it’s all I can think about and do or else I feel like I’ll just collapse and explode or something, I’m sorry for what I did with Glimmer but I can't handle it right now” She admitted for once, turning away and expecting to be rebuked.

A second, two, three, four. Bow said nothing. He came closer, past hand length, forearm, arm and to shoulder.

“I sort of understand where you're coming from *but you* need to talk to us about it, we’re your best friends *Adora* ”

Adora sighed in resignation, letting her arm go limp. “I’m shit at feelings Bow”

“I know, “punch your feelings out guy””.

She wasn't sure who did it first but eventually they ended up in a hug, a tight one that cupped the back of the head and promised to not let go until everything felt better, even for a moment.

Eventually even Glimmer joined in after hanging on the sidelines and while there was silence. Adora felt okay with that.

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or destroy it, while Adora would distract Prime and hopefully assassinate him. In short. She was to be the bait.

No.

Glimmer argued first, arms crossed and scowling as she pointed out that Adora made things “difficult for herself again” she stood her ground, apparently she’d have trouble finding her way to Prime since she didn't know the layout like Glimmer did and neither did Adora posses Entrapta’s genius and eidetic memory memory, not to mention Prime would probably be protecting himself with enough guards that she couldn't hope to take them all on at once.

Adora countered, explaining that all she needed was a single opening and that she was planning to let herself be captured by Primes guards once they entered the hanger and that be introducing herself as She-Ra she’d take all the attention and heat away from the other two teams, it being a calculated risk and one that she was prepared to take. And besides, if the theory was correct then Prime would lose connection to his clones and then that’d be the moment to strike, Adora would just need to keep him busy for long enough.

Bow stayed on the sidelines, attempting to moderate. Entrapta probably wasn't paying attention but Bow would guide her along with the steps of the plan.

In the end, the case was made. The chance to take down or cripple Primes network and assassinate the man himself since he

was the sole focal point of failure for his entire empire or at the very least delay reinforcements to Etheria significantly enough to allow a fighting chance for them or to be able to teleport back to the empty (but safe) dimension of Despondos outweighing any other concerns.

Eventually the argument winded down, with tears in her eyes and sagging shoulders Glimmer admitted that she didn't want to lose Adora again and for once the crack in the facade broke, Adora emotionally replied that she knew and that if there was another way she'd take it. No hug this time but instead reached a silent agreement between them.

And that was the plan. Anxiety and nerves shoved down again and nothing but the mission in mind, six or so hours to go and Adora has the three pills at hand if things get messy. While she and Glimmer managed to remain civil enough for basic physical contact, the animosity,the fights they had when she became Queen remained unsolved but at least it was progress, like they were getting somewhere.

Even if Adora wished things had gone differently, that she'd been better with conflict resolution instead of burying her head in the sand.

It'd be a problem to solve later .

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While they had received the best possible information on the internal layout of Horde Primes ship, the large and tall corridors that could fit a skiff down with multiple avenues of approach in seemingly every direction that would make the Fright Zone appear like a fishing hut in comparison it was only now that Adora realized when she made visual contact in her captains chair, that the sheer size of Primes fleet with those battleships gathered around in the hundreds if not thousands that she mentally kicked herself for not reaching the obvious conclusion neither she or indeed any anobody on Mara's ship had actually witnessed the outside of Primes ship or even understood the vast scale of it.

While space itself was unfathomably huge, like even the planets they passed were *just specks* in comparison to the sheer vast depths of the universe at least they were constructed in the sense of the natural order. What she sees here simply boggles the mind *and* takes her breath away *and* kills nearly any sense of conceivable scale of the war she'd nearly broken herself over fighting.

The arrowhead shaped battleships, ones that she had been familiar with since Etheria had at least six to ten orbiting daily that dropped thousands of troops off, constructed infrastructure in record time and scorched entire cities were not even rare in the massive fleet that slowly crept into view, they were *common.* As common as assigning an electric staff to a cadet that had just graduated. Thousands upon thousands of artificial lights that each singled a battleship came into view and they just kept *growing* to the point of which an educated scholar probably could have penned out entirely new constellations and filled an entire book series.

And they are *tiny* in comparison to the terrifying height, width and length in all directions that Horde Primes white mothership was, before Adora believed it to be perhaps a adorned battleship or one that was specially constructed and instead the gargantuan artificial structure had ships that were kilometers in length themselves *docking* in hangers. If those ships are rowing boats, this "structure" is every city in Etheria morphed together and maybe even larger.

Not even with every single robot ever constructed, all the battalions of the Horde army and every single person in the Rebellion would Adora have even a fair chance of taking out that station, back on Etheria they were already horrifically outmanned and outgunned by a *paltry scouting* force that probably wasn't even a single percentage of the war machine that could be arrayed against them.

Adora's mental battleplan ,a product of conditioning since birth, lessons, combat against both the Crimson Waste, Rebellion and Hordak's forces with years of experience called for hundreds of clones and robots to fight through in the worst case scenario for this situation. That projected count went up to potentially millions and that was *at best.* Nobody was speaking, not even Entrapata and she gushed over every technology in every shape and form. Just simple stunned silence and they couldn't be blamed, this was beyond anybody's wildest expectations. And Adora?

Well this just confirmed her absolute worst suspicions and justified the basic objectives of the plan, they would never ever even come remotely close to a knockout blow like this and she knew that, this is *it* - the all or nothing, the now or never and a good portion of the following hours rests solely on her shoulders and adds to an already overburdened mind.

Catras rescue would need to be addressed, to Adora the Magicats safety and extraction is prioritized to the same degree that killing Prime was. She’s not going to leave Catra behind this time, no matter the cost. Any emotion that would have since compromised her thoughts and feelings right now are repressed ,tied down and thrown into the river. Anxiety, trepidation, fear and anything like that are pushed aside. She needsto marshall all of her strength and bravery to show the others that she had complete confidence in their mission's success, it's one of the duties she performed as a Force Captain and later as a leader of the Rebellion and she’ll do it again.

Every second she glances in any direction the more window space is taken up by the sheer uncountable numbers of Horde Prime’s fleet and the weight on her shoulders, the burden that she took up when she pledged herself as She-Ra becomes significantly heavier on Adora’s shoulders.

Alert, we are being pulled in by an unknown force.

The ship shakes, alarms beep in deafening crescendo and Adora acknowledges that there's no turning back now, nowhere to run as Mara's ship is dragged to an open hanger to Horde Primes domain.

Red jacket on, staff slung across the r back and a dagger strapped to the hilt. Adora leaves the others as they take up their hiding positions inside Maras ship, the ramp lowers on her command and she battens down the flush of anxiety as eight clones in a diamond formation greet her.

They’re armed, stun batons like in Hordak’s Horde and she greets them back with open palms, they wait for her and the moment she comes into close contact she’s immediately man handled and brought straight to her knees , four of the eight glide up to the ramp inside the ship and for a moment that knot appears again but she has to act like she has nothing to hide.

“You won't find anything, I came alone”

No reaction, just silent faces glare back with green eyes and in all white and gray.

She tries a different approach, staring directly into the Clone's eyes before her. “I hear Horde Primes been looking for me, figured we should meet up”

That brings a reaction, the Clone looks up and down in uncertainty for a moment before a strange half smile comes across his face.

“Yes. You will be bought before Prime” The clone speaks in revelation of his master and it's sickening to watch, how the vocal tone is completely neutral but not how the eyes briefly dilate and then immediately fade back to neutral.

“When can I-”

“You will receive your Judgment” The end part comes with a smirk

and the lead Clone turns and walks away, the four ones sent into the ship come back and turn off into a different corridor, with no commotion heard it's safe to assume that Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta succeeded in hiding.

The two Clones at Adora’s side lift her up and shes “gestured” to walk along with them if the brief poke of a stun baton is a gesture, greeting her is silence except for footsteps. The Clones march in perfect synchronized step, not one foot goes out of bound and all click together as they hit the floor. There's no gun turrets or cameras lining every single panel, no guards at any entrances to the corridors and it’s looking less like a base or a staging area and more than a place of worship-a temple? If the way the Clones occasionally muttered about Prime with disturbing reverence anyway.

Everything is stagnant, like someone poured cleaning fluid over everything and left it at that and the Clone’s rebuke any hope of a revealing conversation so Adora lets her mind wander rather than let the knot in her stomach build anymore, she distracts herself.

The entire... *everything* of Primes ?temple? Is unnatural, whoever built this thing did so without care for beauty or grace. While anywhere in Etheria, *even* the smog ridden military complex of the Fright Zone is colorful and dynamic in its own way , there's always a *spark* of something. This place, this station is hollow with bland colors that fail to ignite even basic passion, the corridors while huge and with intimidating arches are sparse with every single one having the same architecture involved, there’s no individuality or creativity, everything is the same.

Just like the Clones, they all look identical,speak in indistinguishable forced accents with zero change. It's haunting to be around them, Adora feels that everything around her has been stripped of anything and everything unique and personal and replaced with factory line, industrial production items with the same serial number, makeup and shape. There's nothing here, no *magic* to anything. Just a bleak desolate wasteland in its own way.

What would be a normal brisk walk with no fighting, action or danger is already spiking adrenaline and she's automatically leaning towards the “flight” part. That she wants to leave this place, that the endless corridors and soul sucking colors will render her into the same fate as these Clone’s, if they even were people once. No wonder Glimmer didn't mention this, it's just depressing to look at, be in and travel through.

They go through identical rooms, walkways with the same bolts in perfect places and no outliers, her four “guards” say nothing. Adora’s head turns every so often to see the clean lines in every direction with no trace of the previous material or worker present as though each and all in Primes temple had been pressed from a mould. While she could appreciate the perfection of craftsmanship, nothing stirred from within like if she gazed upon her battalion of soldiers when she was a captain as while they wore the same armor and carried identical batons, each serial number differed, every suit of armor had personalized markings and underneath those dark green helmets was a person, everyone to their own. While here? Nothing. Just nothing.

Caught in her own internal monologue, it took Adora an embarrassing situationally deficient moment to notice that she had reached a great pair of opened doors that beyond lay Horde

Prime and his great sactumn. Nerves began to start up, leading to a clamp down with tightened fists and hitched breath? What if she was going to be simply executed? What if Mara's ship was simply destroyed? What if Catra was dead? She- she couldn't bear to consider those possibilities, she had to collect herself before Prime-

"You will go, alone" The clone leading stops and he stands adjacent to the door. Adora walks forward alone for the first time in twenty? Thirty? minutes to the massive sanctum of Prime. Her earpiece could be buzzing right now with activity but she insisted on radio silence, that the only communication should be of the utmost importance.

Adora walks alone across a drawbridge that spans at least a hundred meters amidst a dead drop, a city of lights is all around her, are they apartments? Do people live here?. She crosses the threshold and up a staircase, she steels herself as she finally makes visual contact with the man responsible for the destruction of half of Etheria, for the Horde. It's a raised platform Prime sits on with avenues of approach in a eight pointed star, around his chair is dozens of screens of different planets, the fact this man was waging war with all of them at the same time and yet had so many ships just sitting around added to the terrifying realisation of how fucked everyone back on Etheria was.

He's not even looking at her, instead his back is turned with a pair of clones tending to him. Adora's not playing this dumb fucking waiting game.

"Prime"

She speaks, firmly - the two clones immediately back off and raise their weapons. The man they tend to looks like them but different, older, larger, green tubes bisect every part of his body and an artificial beard covers the bottom of his face.

He spins around in his chair.

Prime leans forward, his artificial bearded chin rests on a gloved hand and his other gestures Adora to come hither. He smirks and with a perfect pitch voice of a commanding officer, he speaks.. "Report, Force Captain Adora".

"Sir I-" Her body snapped to attention automatically, years of reports and training made the process of resisting difficult and she managed to stop herself from salulating and actually giving a report. The bastard *knew* who she was, her name and not just that she *was* or used to be She-Ra.

She stiffens, then relaxes, brings herself to a more neutral stance. "Prime"

Prime cocks his head, if amused. "Welcome Adora, forgive my unseemly state. The task to maintain this body is tedious but necessary"

She makes to reply but he keeps going in that uncaring and unsettling way that Prime considers himself to be the only speaker of note. "My little brother had so many reports and files on you ,you know? Former Force Captain, one of the leaders of the

Rebellion. Transforming into a magical Princess. Wonderfully embellished reports don't you think?”

She takes a firm stand forward. “But it’s true, I *am* She-Ra”

“Oh? Forgive me but you seem to be a blond girl with a stick” Prime chuckles, his pair of Clone’s making no visual or audible reaction and just *stand there* motionless like white statues.

“Showing my hand? I ain't that naive” Adora retorts with narrowed eyes, she needs to keep this guy talking and distracted so hopefully the others can rescue Catra and blow up the hivemind.

Prime shrugs, seemingly dismissing that comment. “Should I expect an assassination then? A magical princess sprouting forth from within and leaping forward with righteous anger to strike Prime down? naive *child* , Prime knows all. Prime sees all”

“Primo novit omnia!,Primum omnium videt!” The two clones chant on repeat, as if a button is pressed that suddenly forces them to be ambient.

The earpiece in her radio crackles, its Bow. “Adora,there's not many guards around. We’re close”

Perfect.

She takes a deep breath, remembering everything that's led up to this point and makes her way up the short staircase, never losing eye contact with Prime as with curled fists and Adora prepares herself mentally and physically.

“This is how it's going to go. Prime. We’re going to make a deal just you and me”

“Oh really now, what makes you think you can negotiate with-”

She hisses and shuts him up before he can continue. “You’re gonna give me Catra, then your gonna let me go free and clear”

Prime scoffs, rolling his eyes. “Come now child, a deal works both ways”

“You need something? The Heart of Etheria can only be activated by *me.* If you don't honor our deal then I’ll turn it on you” She threatens the Emperor of the known galaxy with just a pointed finger and her words.

Prime laughs it off, waving it away with a hand. As he stands up dozens of green tubes are disconnected from his body and he suddenly grows in power and stature, his voice turns deeper and far more than Hordak ever managed. “You can't, or you would have done so already. You cannot risk the safety of your Catra here, your ship is here and tethered to my Temple. You can't leave, you can't escape”

Adora stiffens.

“Child, why did you ever begin to possibly fathom that coming here, threatening Prime and thinking you could leave was ever a good idea?” The way Prime speaks alone sends a shiver down Adoras spine, it promotes doubt and insecurity and peels away the layers of protection she’s set up.

Fuck.

Glimmer hasn't said anything yet but this right now? It's now or never, she should be able to rush the Emperor and gut him open like a fish and then hopefully survive long enough to escape, Adora steadies herself, plans the avenue of attack and gets *ready.*

Her heart is pounding in her ears as Prime stands tall, two? Maybe three meters? He raises his arms in a mimic of a triumphant war statue.

“Prime has reigned eternal throughout the centuries, *he is* immortal, child. His brothers lend him life force and every single person in Primes great care has their place”

He looks down at her, and he fucking smiles. “Such as your *dear* Catra, a poor wasted thing, so tormented and emotionally compromised that she welcomed the light of Prime with trembling but open arms.”

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide

He gestures behind Adora, forcing her head to swivel back and to show a rapidly approaching hooded figure.

“She hoped you would come for her, she hoped you would stay. And instead *you left* ”

His voice goes even deeper this time, it's frankly terrifying.

“And yet thanks to the graces of Prime, Catra is with us”

“WHAT?” Adora finds herself screaming at that revelation, thoughts and feelings manifesting from internal to external.

“Poor Catra, she hoped you would have come for her. And all I had to do was wait” Prime simply tilts his head in a cruel smile, the fucker knew all along.

The hooded figure approaches to within spitting distance, they’re not a Clone but they have claws, and a tail and-...

Fuck.

It's Catra.

Well it looks like Catra.

“I’ll leave you two to it shall I? As Catra would have said. You are so very *predictable* Adora”

And with that, he disappears in a flash of blinding blue light. How did Adora *not* factor in that Prime could teleport, her plan failed to

connect the dots that if Glimmer could be teleported from the Templeship to them then its logical to assume that teleportation arrays existed to travel to and from the ship especially given its gigantic size.

Catra stands motionless and then as if on cue, pulls back her hood to reveal a pair of glowing green eyes that completely replace Catra's definitive heterochromia, her ears stay in the same place and she's wearing shoes . Adora would go fucking white at the realisation that Catra is one of them but Instead her brain is desperately pulling at every single thread for answers, that the assassination mission has gone badly wrong and now she has to somehow rescue Catra and kill Prime and-

Catra's head cocks to the side, she stares with unblinking eyes and performs that creepy fucking smile that the clones.

"Catra?" Is all Adora manages to whimper out in a small voice, this is the opposite of how she imagined their reunion.

"Hello, Adora" Catra speaks aloud in a perfectly pitch neutral tone like the Clone's, none of the emotional undertones or teases that defined her before, it's alien. It's weird. It still sounds like Catra and yet it doesn't.

Adora stumbles forward, reaching out with a outstretched arm in disbelief that this is Catra standing right before her and- "Catra I-"

“Adora?” Catra’s head tilts in that strange and alien way, it's just disturbing to watch her lips move while the face remains still.

“Catra? Fight it!” Adora’s grip on her staff tightens and the itch of twenty years of training screams to reach for her knife but she wouldn't *ever* harm Catra, even as She-Ra Adora was gentle.

Adora pants out. “I’m not leaving you, I promise. Not this time”

Catra stiffens and then wavers for a few seconds, her upper lip trembles before it's brought back under control but in that brief second the bright green eyes flicker.

“I don't wish to leave, Prime has brought me peace. Something you could never do - you broke my heart Adora but Prime has made it whole again” Hearing those words nearly broke Adora right and then, the dam holding back repressions nearly cracks and spills outright.

A single tear drops down Adora’s face as she struggles to keep herself together, Catra advances with open palms and slides a gentle hand over Adoras, cupping it and she's powerless to resist.. The touch sends shivers all around and leaves coldness in its wake.

“Don't you see? I’m happy here”

The same hand travels up the forearm, elbow and leaves goosebumps all around, it ends up on Adora's neck and she stifles a whimper as Catra comes even closer, the Magicat presses her forehead against Adora's while she holds Adora's left hand with her own, forcing the blonde to drop her staff.

"You could be happy here, Adora"

Adora can't deal with this, they haven't been this physically close since their days in the Horde where they'd sleep together and the memories are lurching back, isn't this what she wanted? To be with Catra and have these kind of touches?

They lock eyes, despite herself Adora cant resist to momentarily peer down at Catra's lips, despite everything they still look wonderfully soft and her heart is practically threatening to burst out of her body.

And then Catra says *it* , the words that would make Adora's knee buckle and submit.

" *We* could be happy here, Adora"

"I know" Adora finds herself agreeing, despite everything that happened. Catra is *real* and she's here, even with the eyes and the stiff body it still feels genuinely affectionate like this is the Catra she knows *doing* .. The other girl always knew her weaknesses, the places to pinpoint and every single button is being pressed and held down until the buzzer breaks.

Deep down Adora wants this and always has, a life of peace and without war or stress, to return to the fun days of being side by

side with Catra, her resistance breaks and she cant help but trace her own lines of touch onto Catra, Catra audibly whimpers and visually shudders when Adora’s warm fingers make contact, the person within that's locked and trapped comes out for a second and it's beautiful.

“Hi Catra” Adora breathes out , resting her forehead and gently bumping into Catra’s.

“Hey Adora” The true Catra reveals herself fully for a split second,ears and tail twitching in harmony. The green eyes fade out and are replaced with blue and yellow.

They smile at each other, and it warms Adora’s heart like no other could. It’s just them, together like it should *always be* .

“You see Adora? I could give you Catra. You finally reach that happiness that you crave, if you just give me something in return” Catra’s voice deepens and its replaced with Primes, the body mannerisms transform into that righteous posture that is indicative of the Emperor.

“I want She-Ra”

“I”

This is a lie.
“No”

The sickly green eyes return. The ears and the tail stop. The body goes frigid.

And the spell breaks. On pure instinct alone Adora stumbles back from that now cold embrace.

And then without warning Catra lunges forward and attacks.

(Soundtrack, Icarus - Main Theme)

For the past year and a half, Catra had proven herself to be the most dangerous enemy to fight without exception, for that reason alone all of Adora’s concentration and effort immediately went to defending herself.

Every single time the two of them fought on the battlefield, Force Captain Catra versus Ex Force Captain Adora as She-Ra, Catra’s fighting style, her motivations, methods and ideology are passionate in movement with fast strikes and high jumping leaps, emotional with her claws and dodges, when Catra fights she holds nothing back and uses every trick in the book and more so, she's quick, deadly and efficient and unafraid to utilize *everything* .

This time though, when Catra performs her typical jump slash routine with extended claws it's all mechanical, there's no flair or slight imperfections and differences between each attack it's the same rhythm with locked ears and tail.All the claws extend and retract at the same time. When Adora blocks with her staff Catra

retreats and chooses a different but robotical template of assault each time, there's none of the aggression and wild nature of She-Ra vs Catra or even the banter and playful feel of their training spars back in the Horde.

Catra is artificial in this, her body makes no movements except to attack, her ears always stay still when they should be twitching or moving in tandem with emotion and there should be a tail flicker somewhere. Instead this fight is as depressing as the white blank walls and surroundings.

Adora fights back another attempt, using her staff's monumentum and dual headed reach to fling the Magicat back enough steps to create breathing room, Adora is panting at this point. She should have taken that fucking pill when she had the chance and now shes bleeding energy that she cant afford to lose.

The staff holds up for a while, but it's a weapon she bought to pierce Prime’s jugular and let the bastard bleed out ,not to fight a Magicat with rending claws. It buys a minute, maybe two of constant near hand to hand combat and fends off blows and allows mistakes to be kept but in the end it does break, while Adora is stronger in a grapple, possessed Catra’s claws slice near exposed fingertips and Adora has to let go.

Catra goes to make another leap attack, Adora braces but it's a feint and she's brutually slugged in the face, Possessed Catra is changing up her style with a series of slow heavy moves that manage to bypass Adoras defenses and its extremely confusing to

counter since its the contradictory opposite of Catras fighting style.

Adora *focuses* , in a way she's fighting against herself now,her own moves and she needs to remember all the way back and apply the correct strategy, duck when needed, be elastic instead of rigid and keep herself on the ball.

But it hurts, a lot. A uncountable number of hours of missed sleep and non stop exhaustive activities are taking their tool and Adora is slowing down *too fast* and while Catra's movements are telegraphed there's no room to reach into her pocket and take a pill and instead all of her time and energy is spent on dodging and evasion.

Catra does make a mistake though, she goes to perform a roundhouse kick that misses and Adora takes the split second opportunity to grab the outstretched leg, while Catra then throws her across the superstructure its a rookie mistake as Adora lands perfectly and kicks out to buy space and time.

Part of her hair is hanging down and touching a flushed face when she finally gets to go on the offensive, Possessed Catra makes a clumsy punch, Adora dodges and grabs her arm, yanks it and pulls the Magicat infront of her, trapping the girl in two places.

"Catra? Listen to me, I know you're still in there I-"

She takes a moment to collect her breath, remembering those brief seconds when heterochromia replaced green orbs, proof that

Catra, the real one was still *there.*

"I'm not leaving with you, I promise" She remembers their pact they made as children, one she broke at Thamyor but one that she'd renew *right now* , right this second if she could.

She cant help but reminisce of the good times, a stupid goofy grin replaces and Catra stops struggling.

"It's gonna be okay, we're gonna get out of here together alright?"

Bones start cracking in response, Adora is too horrified to react as the limb she kept locked flips around and claws Adora in the forearm, she screeches out in pain and Possessed Catra turns the tables immediately, pinning Adora. Catra is purring? But in a weird distorted way as her voice turns deeper once more, echoing Prime as she errantly slides extended claws up and down Adoras forearm creating light but painful marks.

Adora whimpers as Possessed Catra presses a light kiss to her neck, accentuated with a threatening claw at her jugular making Adora hiss.

"Everything is already okay. We are with Prime now. There is no need for you to suffer, Adora. Come into the light with me".

Adora does the opposite of that, she grabs Catra instead and throws her behind her, Catra uncharastically yells and smashes headfirst into a monitor screen, cracking it in a sea of sparks.

Gritting her teeth and pulling herself together, forcing damaged limbs to obey and standing on two shaking legs Adora advances with coiled fists, if she has to beat Prime out of Catra she *will* - preferably without hurting Catra though.

"Fucking snap out of it! You *never* listened to anyone in your life for fucks sake" She snarls, Catra throws a punch but Adora twists it round and sends Catra flying.

Somehow that just makes Prime or Possessed Catra mad. They start wildly throwing punches and letting loose multiple kicks that go nowhere, Adora is forced onto the defense with raised forearms as she tries her best to block the multitude of assaults that would have gotten a cadet sent for discipline if they ever tried such reckless maneuvers, but this isn't the Fright Zone and this Catra is letting loose.

Everything is on the line, Glimmer hasn't reported in. Bow and Entrapta are near the mainframe but should have *done something* by now, Prime has teleported away and out of reach and she's stuck fighting the one person she never wanted to.

Catra has to run out of energy at some point, she's a fast and quick fighter that relies on overpowering an opponent quickly rather than fight attrition.

At some point ,Adora does eventually manage to punch Catra in the face. It's one bourne of reactions and pent up anger at everything t *hat's gone completely to shit* and it sends the Magicat *flying* backwards. Towards the edge. A drop that would kill her if she falls.

Shit. Prime Catra has noticed and she looking down now, playing games by rocking backwards and forwards with the incredible balance and agility only a Magicat could do, laughing and chuckling in that weird fucking way all the time.

Adora runs, outstretched arm and catches Catra before she falls. There's a brief spark somewhere in the neck and Catra goes limp in her arms, breathing a sigh of relief with tears streaming down either from pain, tiredness or relief Adora holds *her* Catra tightly, pressing an intimate hand on the back of Catras scalp.

And downwards, slow breathing back to normal. Her fingers touch shaved hair and neck. And then they brush up against something, something that sparks and Possessed Catra comes back to light by slashing all ten claws right into Adoras spine with a horrifying rip of fabric and epidermis.

It's so painful she can't even scream. She's nearly hanging off the end, she doesn't want to look down.

Possessed Catra sparks and her voice distorts, it's mocking, it's weird and it hits home.

“Oh Adora?, how long will you drag this out versus Prime? He knows all, he sees all. Did you know how afraid this one was in the end? She knew *her* Adora wasn't coming, she suffered alone and with no one to save her”

Adora’s response is a primal war cry and an angry grunt.

She rams straight into Possessed Catra and keeps going with all the strength she can muster, keeps pushing and practically throws Catra in the nearest holographic screen, the neck buzzes again and sparks fly out, Catra starts to shake and vibrates but says nothing.

Wary at this point of another feint., Adoras trembling hand is reaching for her knife. But those glowing eyes slowly fade away as the sparks grow fewer in number and peter out. For once, Catra’s mismatched eyes fully return and she looks down in shame, unwilling to make eye contact.

Her voice is just a whimper at this point, one bourne of regret and near to tears. “Why’d you come back for me?”

“I’m not giving up on you”

“We both know I dont matter Adora,not to anyone. You should have left me”

Coming from Catra those words hit deeper than anyone else could have said, Adora softens and visibly sags, she stumbles forward and embraces her Catra, at first the Magicat freezes up and

doesn't react.

“You matter to me. I couldn't leave you here”

Stiff arms regretfully wrap around Adora’s torso with faint crying, claws are finally retracted and Catra holds up her end of the embrace and clings to Adora weakly, her breathing coming out in ragged steps.

Adora can't help but choke on her words, she wants a life for both of them away from the war and the death and the invasions, one of peace where neither girls will be threatened or abused or manipulated, when they won't have to give orders or take.

“I’m gonna take you home, somewhere green. Somewhere nice, a place that we can get away from everyone” She starts blubbering the first thing that comes to mind, *but she means it.*

Catras hold tightens and Adora keeps going even as the tears swell and drop freely onto Catras scalp. “It's gonna be a building, a home. Without others, just us”

“Promise?”

It's weak and taken painfully, but Adora hears it. She changes their embrace, moving closer and more intimate, more like their carefree days as cadets rather than the awkward feint Prime performed only moments ago, it's just them now, the two of them.

“I promise”

Adora should have known that would be when Prime used the last vestiges of control that his filthy claws had in Catra and sent her backing away quickly and running towards the edge, Catra fights back and the two are in a battle for control of her body as Adora sprints like her life depends on it to save the cat.

Prime wins, Catra wins.

One leg hangs off the edge, the other stays.

And she begins to tumble, the horrifying lurch in slow motion that would send Catra over the edge and into a bone crushing heap of dead body if she ever reaches the floor, however deep it must be.

The leg goes first, foot dipping away from sight followed by the rest of the limb, then white trousers are gone altogether with the horrifying sight of the torso coming down go. One arm flops carefree in the depths while the other is outstretched in vain hope for help, an action mirrored by Catras terrified expression, she doesn't want *to go* , she doesn't want *to die.*

If it was anyone else they would have missed the outstretched arm, if it was anyone else they wouldn't have been able to wrench the body of a magicat backwards and upwards and tell gravity to fuck off in the process.

If it was anyone other than Adora, they could have been slower off the mark to a headlong ground breaking sprint to a reckless forward dive onto the cliff edge of a drop a hundred metres deep or simply frozen up and watch helplessly as a terrified Catra tumbled to her death over the edge. A different Adora maybe, but not this one.

Well ,a different Adora maybe. But not this one.

A/N.

Third chapter is coming along in a week then 4th and 5th will hopefully be ready in the same week.
Comments/feedback/reviews are greatly appreciated, I'd honestly like to know how you about this Adora and how everything is coming along :)

IIIA

ChapterIII A:

We’re Gonna Win In The End

Trapped on all sides by enemies and with a worsening situation underway, Adora and Catra resort to fighting their way out.

(Better Look Me In The Eyes)

Adora finds Catra with her tail between her legs, hiding behind a crate when they’re both around the age of five or eight or somewhere in between - the memory is hazy. For whatever reason when she tries to touch Catra, the girl backs away with a flapping tail and a “get away from me” expression.

“You don't want ration bars? It's the gray kind tonight” Adora asks, again reaching out to Catra with that childlike wonder that she wished she had for more years. They made contact, Adora lightly pushing into her friend.

Catra scowls and pushes her away again.

"What are you doing?"

"Well if your gonna miss dinner, then I'll miss it with you"

Catra's scowl deepens and she cries out for Adora to be with her new best friend Lonnie. They "argued" or whatever arguments were for children, Adora reiterating truthfully that her best friend was in fact Catra with the Magicat struggling to process that Adora could have more than just a single person in their life.

"Catra? Come on!?

"I'll never say sorry to anybody, never!"

They chase throughout the Fright Zone, past bored guards that have the top of their boots stepped on by Catra intentionally while Adora avoids , they go through other cadets at their age and Catra makes a point to barge through the biggest group.

"Catra!" She calls out again as she loses her bestfriend at a deadend. Catra's probably hiding up top somewhere so she needs to look for the telltale sign of a tail. Being a Magicat Catra's unique appendages such as a tail and ears mirror her emotions and states perfectly, they wiggle, they unfurl, they wrap around and they move.

It's a slow moving tail that gets Adoras attention, Catra is sitting atop a pipe that would be a first floor, even as a child she's angry and obtuse, like she's already been hurt and lashes out the moment she's afraid, as a child Adora sort of understood but didn't.

“Catra?” She cries out as she manages to vault over a broken wall, scales up a secondary ladder and onto the same pipe Catra is, the girl has her back turned and she's sitting down with crossed legs, ears turned sideways and a slowly thrashing tail that goes from side to side.

“Catra!” Adora calls out in relief as she runs along the pipe, closer towards her best friend who hasn't turned round but the shape and position of her ears indicate that she knows who’s coming.

“It doesn't matter what they do to us. You know?”

“Adora?” Catra turns round slowly, she’s been crying? Adora just wants to hug her best friend and tell her that everythings okay. That-

“Hey Catra”

“Hey Adora”

She reaches her Catra, sits down by her. Catra’s tail is wrapped around Adora’s torso and Adoras arm is slung around Catras shoulders, the girl is lightly purring, she's sniffling now but Adora is fine with that.

“I-” She begins but finding the words or more the intent behind them is difficult.

“Adora?” Catra’s mismatched eyes stare at her, reminding Adora of everything they’ve been through. Shadow Weaver electrocuting Catra and spanking Adora, older cadets teasing them, training

officers forcing the two of them to go through endless sessions. Adora always had the option to back out but she never chose it.

Because there was someone she'd rather be with.

She takes Catras hand in her own and squeezes it as a sign of trust between them, an agreement.

"I look out for you, you look out for me. Nothing really bad can happen as long we have each other"

"You promise?"

Catra stutters, almost cries again hearing those words, it wasn't until years later and a therapy session with Perfuma that Adora only began to understand just how strong of an attachment Catra had to her even as a child.

"I promise, do you?"

Catra doesn't even hesitate.

"I promise"

Sometimes she wonders if it's a curse, that terrible things only started happening when she and Catra split at Thaymor.

But now they’re together again, Catra is in her arms.

Adora doesn't get the time to process it though, Catra is horrifically stiff and barely alive and she’s being electrocuted. Two years of separation and it already feels like she’s going to *lose* Catra.

Again.

That's when Catra starts screeching a horrific combination of writhing terror, pain and the unimaginable sensation of one having ones body basically cooked from the inside. Again Adora’s reactions take over, she frantically searches all along the girl's slowly increasingly warm body for a device, something. Anything.

This is clearly a sucide switch,just like a cyanide pill that a Horde soldier carried in their mouths disguised as a false tooth. Even then it was up to the user if they wanted it. Catra’s increasingly unintelligible screaming, her body writhing and shaking all over and the past minute showed that she didn't want this. That Prime had decided that if he couldn't keep Catra, then nobody else could. That his *property* was his alone to do with as he pleased.

Adora flips Catra on her back, searching all the places, hair, armpits, chest, legs. Anywhere and everywhere for the device, frustration mounted, panic grew. She’d been all this way and through so much just to watch Catra die in her arms? *No.* She wasnt gonna let that fucking happen on her watch.

“Catra!” Adora shouts with tears in her eyes.

“Adora?” Catra asks with glazed over eyes and a “barely here” expression.

There's a green nub on the back of Catra’s neck, an alien green pod-like thing that's buzzing and glowing. Just like the neck adornment on the Clones and the same technology and craft that equipped everything in the Galactic Horde.

To remove it would probably take someone with a knowledge of a Magicats anatomy, skill with surgical tools and needed equipment, maybe hours of delicate work and a good deal of luck.

They don't have hours or a qualified surgeon at hand, just Adora and her knife. She could remain still and let Catra die or she could make a fucking decision, go for it and let whatever happens next be a problem for a future *Catra and Adora.*

So Adora bites down and forces herself to do it.

The sound it makes is a disgusting squelch, a biomechanical groan and a feedback of static shock that travels up the knife and attacks Adora too but she ignores it and twists the blade further in and underneath, she's practically stabbing Catra in the neck but it's either that or let the most important person in her life die on a Spaceship in the middle of nowhere. Catra has stopped making

loud noises at this point and has reverted to a fetal ball, whimpering and clutching her limbs in desperate agony.

Slowly the device is wrenched out, its honestly repulsive how many wires its connected to, how much blood and tissue and deep layered skin stain the floor as the device is thrown over the edge, while there's not much blood coming out it still needs to be covered and Adora uses ripped clothing to cover the patch.

She holds her Catra's face in her hands with a sigh. She can rest now, the both of them could.

Except Catra's still writhing in agony with a silent scream present in an open mouth, she's in pain - great pain from being nearly shocked to death probably.

Catra needs a painkiller.

Adora has *three.*

Poor girl cant even move her mouth to accept the pills, if she's even aware it's happening so it falls on Adora to pry and hold open Catras mouth, even if the fangs are rubbing and scraping along her battered fingers, she has to set each pill between Catras teeth and crack it together by pushing Catras jaw *up.* She even has to force the Magicat to swallow and it's an invasion of privacy and will but Adora's not letting her die, not here.

After a few minutes, the screaming stops, the writhing ends and the Magicat is free. Well for *now* , there's a Temple ship full of Prime's Clone's, a hostile environment by itself and an enemy that can teleport endlessly.

Glimmers hasn't reported in and there hasn't been an explosion from Bow and Trapta's side. It could be just the two of them against the world. In an ironic way it follows the same logic that the two girls formed as kids.

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Adora rubs her forehead against a slowly awakening Catra's.

"It's over"
The response is a soft purr, one that hasn't been felt by Catra and heard by Adora in years.

"Are you sure?"
Adora holds her Catra tight, stroking at the back of her head gently, enjoying the short period of bliss.

"He's gone"
"Good fucking riddance"

Is the reply, although they're practically trapped on a spaceship in the middle of nowhere and surrounded by a battlefleet comprising millions or more of clones, in that short period of time. It is just the two of them.

And strangely enough. That's okay.
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(soundtrack, In The Office · Justin Burnett)

Three days ago if you'd told Adora that she'd be utterly exhausted and spent, with claw wounds, rent clothes and cuddling her former best friend, sort of enemy and someone that she had incredibly mixed and strong feelings for she'd tell em' to fuck off.

The state between them is relaxed, intimate. Nice. Adora hasn't felt this way since Catra used to sleep in her lap back when she owned one of the prime captain's cabins and dragged Catra (who was only joking about sleeping without Adora) to bed. The knot in her stomach is gone, the anxiety has faded to the tune of purring and the weight of Etheria's fate dissipates with simple touches. Somehow and despite everything that's happened Adora feels good.

She's missed this and it feels just right.

Did it matter how long they spent together? It's feeling like years and it has been, Adora can't suppress her smile and soaring heart even if she wanted to, Catra's head is resting firmly on her chest and the rest of the girl's body is sprawled out and intertwined with Adora's warm lap and legs. Theres purring too, a deep and longing string of sounds from Catra that hums a beautiful tone and one that she's solely missed.

"I've missed this, you. This. Everything" Adora hums quietly, rubbing at Catras warm ears with one hand and leaving them red

with each soft touch while the other brushes soothingly through Catra's scalp. It feels like therapy for the both of them.

Catra nods weakly, still recovering but on the mend. The Horde pills worked as designed thankfully. It's peaceful here, calming on the overworked mind, soothing on frayed nerves. A kiss on battered and bruised knuckles

"I guess, I miss you Adora"

"I miss you too Catra"

Adora blinks, opens, blinks again. She tightens her hold,loosens it. She touches faintly and then rubs and runs her fingers across. It's almost not real in how ludicrous this state is, they'd been enemies for so long and all she ever wanted was things to return to normal. And they are, sort of.

This feels just *right.*

"Did you mean it?" Catra asks and brings Adora out of her self reflection.

Adora muses, pulling at an ear tip and enjoying the cute squeak Catra follows up with.

“Hm?”

“The-” Catra stammers out with a blush, Adora giggles and fends off the light swat”

“The house, you-you talked about it earlier”

Ah, the state of mind Adora was in that she rambled on about the first thing she could clutch to when Prime tried to manipulate her into giving up She-Ra, that he used Catra as a point and got Adora to stumble and ramble and on the back foot.

Adora doesn't even miss a beat on the reply.

“I meant it”

“Thank you” Is the only reply, it's short and it means exactly as described on the tin. While the words were said in haste, Adora wouldn't go back on them, she *wants* to get out of here with Catra and the others, tell Horde Prime to *fuck off* and retreat to somewhere in the country so she’ll never have to fight ever again.

“Thanks for the pills aswell I guess, still can’t believe that you have them after all this time”

Adora chuckles, lightly caressing a thumb over a forearm. “Knew they’d come in handy one day,proved right in the end”

They stay like this for a whole, content to just be together and without words or noise from external sources that are replaced by their own, be it soft purrs, satisfied breathing or the shifting of limbs to more comfortable interlocking places.

“Thank you by the way, I-” Catra starts but bites her lip.

Adora encourages her though with a supporting chuckle and a light pinch. “Keep going”

“I thought it’d be the end of me, I sent Glimmer off and hoped it’d be enough for everything I’ve done. I missed you so much but I put her before me because I didn't think you’d want me anymore Adora”

“Catra-I”

“Lemme finish”

“I missed you, I really did. Everything was so hollow and I felt that way inside too, I don't think I can describe it right now because you're finally here and I never thought I’d get to see you again”

“Your welcome”

Adora gets punched for that but they laugh together, it's a part of the healing process she supposes. At some point Catra'd have to answer for what she did but Adora'll step in if anything goes south and take the girl with her. She owes it that much to the person she grew up with and was her best friend for over twenty years.

As a Officer Cadet, Catra helped with planning and tactics, as Force Captain and leading her troops from the front during the bandit raids and conquests that secured the Hordes backfield Catra fought by her side as together they led their battalion through thick and thin, through storming ramparts and destroying crude artillery pieces, often wading knee deep in bodies that were stuck down by baton and claw.

And once again they were together.

And once again, the tranquility was shattered by the bark of a voice in Adora's earpiece.

"Adora? Adora you there?"

"Bow?" Adora's world is snapping back to reality, their location, the mission. *Everything.*

"The others are here I-?" Catra asks a question but is cut off by the audible after shock of three Clone's dressed in that blank and depressing white advancing on their position from across the bridge, Catra is in no shape to fight and Adora is barely functional.

Sounds of fighting, Entrapta’s shrill voice cutting over the electric sounds of shock batons, there's magic too.

“We’re here! Entraptas rigging the mainframe with a fuel cell from the ship, where are you?”

“The center?” Adora looked back to Catra who gave a shrug. “I’ve got Catra, where's Glimmer?”

“You’ve got Catra? Shit. Did you get Prime? And yeah Glimmer’s here” Bow says with some relief.

“No, he teleported” Adora’s pretty sure Bow is nodding, he’s been getting increasingly more technologically inclined so internal teleportation is probably a topic of interest to him.

“Entrapta’s here?” Catra whispers with some alarm in her voice.
“Yeah?”
“We uh, didn't part well”
You can work it out whenever, I don't think she's mad at you”
Adora rubbed the Magicat’s shoulder softly producing additional rhythm to the purring.

“Adora? You there?” Glimmer's voice crackles over the earpiece, there's still mixed feelings evident both in the Queen's voice and Adora’s stomach and Adora knows in her gut that she fucked it up back on the ship. But with her nerves settled by Catra in her arms rather than the near blow up, maybe she can fix things.

“We’re here, you alright?”

“Ye-yeah, managed to get out of an ambush. We need to get out of here ‘Dora”

“Blow the mainframe , if you can take any data out of it go for it, meet up at Mara’s ship?” She glances at the upcoming clones, they’re here with weapons so they probably don't want either of them to be alive.

“You two safe?” Glimmer calls out faintly, she must be talking from outside Bow’s earpiece.

Just one more hundle, the last mountain to climb, another objective to tick off on the list she thinks as she replies and gently takes a disgruntled Catra off her so she can stand up.

“I’ve got Catra, we’re coming in a sec”. At least the others have succeeded in their mission, that leaves Prime to be dealt with, she's already planning. They can leave Catra and Entrapta on the ship while she,Glimmer and Bow seek the Emperor out and fucking kill him.

Before they can leave, actually before Adora has even made to get up a blue flash of light that begins with the forcible injection of air into the space around it and then sucks up said air back into nothing, there's a audible crack and the three clones clad in that same white and gray with the same dull expression as the material around them materialize from across the nearest bridge,

the bridge that Adora initially came from. The three changed positions to block the girls off.

Catra’s in no position to escape on her own and Adora has no idea of any way back so..

Adora sighs and rolls Catra off her, cracks her knuckles, shifts her shoulders.

She’s tired, her limbs ache from constant fighting and little to no rest. She can take on maybe two at once so the third will have to be taken care of somehow. She has her knife, and maybe a minute to prepare given that the clones are both slowly marching and chanting in a language she can't understand.

She thinks, headspace is less cluttered and more clarified now that Adora has the soothing, calming presence of Catra. She has a plan, a means and a motive and someone to protect. She glances over at the vacant throne of Prime with all the disconnected tubes and errant machinery lying around.

Hmmmm.

She turns to Catra who’s looking up from the floor, she has that worried expression on her face and Adora can't really blame her. She’d probably be worried too if she was basically or mostly immobile while her only source of protection had to leave.

“Be right back”

“Adora?I-” She doesn't hear the rest.

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The Clone’s are coming, albeit slowly with two infront that take up the maximum width of the bridge and one behind bringing up the rear, all armed with shock batons that are standard issue in the Horde but like everything else Hordak’s crude army in comparison was based on these are more advanced with great power capacity, reach and style in general. Actually if she makes direct comparisons between the Galactic Horde and Etherias it's not hard to draw conclusions about the general fighting style, organization and tactics of the two since it's obvious now that Hordak literally copied everything. The focus on heavy blows and structured regimented formations with zero individual initiative and complete reliance on officers?Yeah it makes sense now.

Green tube thing, worthless. Microchips? Worthless. *Come on* what kind of self styled megalomaniacal narcissistic god complex space dictator would Prime be if he didn't have a weapon or two lying around?

Adora’s gaze briefly flickers to the Magicat and produces an uncomfortable flutter in her stomach. If they weren't trapped on a space temple ship thing then she’d try to figure it out but *not* right now.

That's it, she's done searching in every nook and cranny and there's literally *nothing* . She’s got to somehow take on three Clone’s with a body that's barely keeping its own above water, she's tired and heavy and while her brain is very functional right now the spirit is willing to take the Clone’s on but the body is not. And also somehow get Catra out of here alive.

Weird green tube thing it is, it feels weighty and durable enough in her hand to be used as a short range whip and if she can't

puncture the Clone’s internals Adora’ll go for the next best thing and bludgeon them instead. The Clone’s have reached the halfway point and that creepy repetitive chanting is filling the air.

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide Primo novit omnia.

They don’t shut the fuck up even when Adora is blocking them at the narrowest point of the bridge with no guardrails or even basic safety at the edges, she’s leaning forward and widening her arms out with the green tube in one and the other is kept free and near her knife to use or support the other hand with wielding the tube.

The Clone’s mirror a cadets stance and fighting style, no actually it's the exact *same* . Their stances are narrowed with arms pressed tight and presenting a single shock baton - faces are perfectly neutral as the chanting ceases and each Clone’s head suddenly goes stiff and upright , for a few seconds nothing happens and Adora waits with bated breath. The Clone’s heads then cock to the side like they’re receiving orders (just like a cadet) , when they’re done (the green eyes brighten) the Clone’s start marching again and this time there's no words - rather just that same blank expression and dull eyes.

Adora blocks the first blow from the left Clone's shock baton with the green tube, the electrical field simply does nothing to it and she backs up and away from a claw attempting to grab her arm

and force her forwards. The other Clone’s baton misses her head as she ducks but the electric instead forces her partially regrown sideshaves and destroyed hair poof to stick up on all ends.

The Clone’s are wedged in together and shoulder to shoulder on the bridge and Adora’ll run out of room soon and then it’ll be over, she needs to think of something - anything to narrow the odds and separate them. She studies the two advancing clones, the one behind is probably going to take a fallen one's place but then it’ll be a two versus one, somewhat manageable.

Again the attacks come from the Clone’s with the left and right coming from outwards and Adora’s got both hands on the green tube as the batons smack into the casing and dent it hard and with enough force that she’s unexpectedly reeling backwards and lands on her butt. Adora manages to nimbly twist herself to avoid getting her limbs broken in by two batons that come flying down and they smash into the ground where her legs had just been. She barely scrambles out of the way of the next two lunges and blocks the third strikes with the green tube.

Heart racing and beating like it's going to fly out of her chest and her already problematic exhaustion is setting in with the beads of sweat going from a light smatter on her clothes to nearly drenching her skin pores. She needs a plan, a basic one that can remove at least one clone from the fight.

Adora considers her options as fast as she can. Her advantages? She's faster, more nimble and can actually think for herself and on her feet. She can take a hit from a stun baton, maybe two but her energy is limited and playing to the Clone’s strengths,aka their durability, lack of feeling pain and sheer strength will result in a

war of attrition that she'll lose and if she loses then Catra does too and that is *not* acceptable.

Adora takes a shorter breather - in, out. Braces herself and coils her fingers around that tube as tight as possible. She can take but she'll have to give.

Adora steps forward into melee range, the Clone on the right goes for her but she's quicker off the mark and simply throws every bit of force she has into a single swing with the tube that connects with the Clone's head and produces a horrifying crack that disorients and forces them back. The Clone on the left's baton connects with her chest and not only forces all the air out of her lungs with a single coughing exhale but the pain alone blurs her vision with white flashes at the edges but she soldiers through the pain and push kicks the unbalanced right clone off the edge. The left Clone attacks again but she manages to avoid its strike and use its monument as a shield against the third Clone.

Clutching her chest and whining in great pain Adora backs off again, she's gotten one Clone. Two to go. Her green tube's knocked out of her hands and she's down to her knife now.

"Adora!? Catra calls out from behind and she's starkly reminded of why she's doing this, or rather who she's doing this for. Adora *is* going to get Catra home,alive and safe. No matter what it does to *her.*

Her ribs are on fucking fire.

“Stay behind me!” Adora replies back breathlessly and half distracted, mindful of the fact that the Clone’s have crossed the bridge and are moving to surround her but as long as she can keep them away from Catra, she’ll be fine.

If She-Ra could come out right now that’d be great but of course she won't. It’s down to Adora who needs to reach inside again and marshall whatever strength is left to take out this time and then do it again for the other.

This time it's a fight that she can dominate, she doesn't need to use her knife yet because the Clone’s fight with the exact same style that Horde Soldiers do with the reliance on heavy blows and stiff controlled movements. Predict, react, counter attack. Once she's put that Clone away from the other and separated them with distance she has precious few seconds of one on one. So she makes the most of it. Adora lunges with a quick right hook that intentionally misses and baits the clone into lunging forward and attacking and as predicated it does and misses her rolling shoulders and agile frame entirely, Adora again beats the Clone’s speed with her own and slaps the baton as hard as possible out of the Clone’s outstretched hand and it flies away, her hand is throbbing badly and it’ll probably go purple at some point but-

The Clone’s facial expression changes from that dull look into something of rage, its eyes flash bright green and it snarls ,before Adora can react or process a counter move shes picked up by the neck and shoulders by two great white arms and her throat is immediately being fucking crushed, she chokes out, whails, legs kicking out in a vain attempt to do something.

She forgot to plan for the fact that unlike Horde Soldiers, Clone's are really fucking strong.

"Adora!" Catra's voice hits her ears and the only thing she can worry about right now is that Catra needs to leave right now and get away as fast as possible.

Head lolling to the side in a desperate move to break the lock, is she crying? Adora endeavors to marshal inner strength like she did before with the planet's earthquake and tightens her fist before opening it and praying she can summon a weapon.

Her eyes make contact with the ceiling rather than the Prime possessed Clone ,grits her teeth and shouts. Remember what she needs to do, what needs to be done. The mission, saving Catra, killing Prime, crippling his base of operations and returning home safely, the promises she made and the ones she vowed to keep both old and new.

She remembers the time she broke the sword because she'd rather go out on her own terms than let a birth lottery determine her fate, Adora squints and with the loudest and clearest words she can muster, she calls to the heavens a single sentence that'd she uttered and practiced many times to success.

"FOR THE HONOR OF GRAYSKULL"

Her knuckles fizz with lightning magic and a solid but a sort of mouldable (at the same time) object forms in between them.An aura of the same energy surrounds her body and the Prime Clone's eyes become wide in fear and she grins, this time. This time she'll crush her enemies and rescue Catra she just needs to *believe.* Believe and will the She-Ra back, the skirt, the exposed legs and the ridiculous get up with the impractically long hair that came with Adora's twisted idea of femininity two years ago.

She tries, she really tries. The glowing shield aura, the fist smack that conjured bracelets. Everything

Seconds pass, the fizzing begins to fizzle out and the aura that protected her for that split second of power dies out.

The dread sets in.

She-Ra isnt coming to save her this time.

"Catra? Run!" Adora chokes on her words and fumbles for her knife that sits secure in its satchel. Her trembling fingers struggle to open the release and the edge of her vision is darkening and it's coming closer to the center as she's being strangled to death.

Come on, come on. *Run* Catra Run.

Adora has the unpleasant and frankly horrifying sensation that her eyeballs are going to pop out, her hand is so close and if she can-

She can.

A mad swipe upwards, one that isn't aimed or co-ordinated at all manages to bury the blade deep into one of the Clone's wrists enough that it severs the muscle completely and combined with her weight and now coping with an imbalance the Clone drops her to the floor. Adora wastes no time in using the fight or flight adrenaline (probably the last) from the near death experience to land a solid punch into the clones force and send it reeling backwards, she follows it up with a kick and forces the Clone onto its back, she tries to pry the knife out of its wrist while she's still stunned and prepares to stab it right in the neck-.

Except she took too long.

A pair of hands grab her and she's sent flying into the same monitor that she threw Catra into, smacking into the hard material with a horrific near bone cracking sound and at least two limbs are near numb from being ragdolled.

Adora's dizzy as she attempts to stand up - supporting herself on stumbling legs and uses whatever time she has to get as much breath into her vacant lungs as possible, she spits blood onto the floor and winces in an attempt to gather herself before heading headlong into the fray again.

"Catra? Please! Get out!" Adora finds herself wheezing as she makes immediately a beeline for the uninjured Clone that's

stalking towards a slowly crawling away Catra with its stun baton readied, Adora stumbles again as the other Clone with the knife still stuck in its wrist makes a clumsy attempt to grab her, Adora flails rather than dodges and almost falls over face first. She can deal with being injured maybe even permanently but Catra needs to live, Adora wouldn't be able to live with that. They've gotten so far and-

She-Ra isn't coming. Third time unlucky if the fizzing in her hand confirms again.

Whatever else her brain was attempting to focus on fizzled out completely the moment it made the connection that Catra is going to be murdered by the Clone and that she needs to fucking do something. Anger starts to pool in heaps as Adora's vision narrows with specks of red, fingers gripping onto the hard tiling and aiding her half-launch into a mad dash that completely ignores personal safety and instead rockets her straight to ram the Clone with the shock baton, they collided with Adoras speed and body weight knocking the Clone over flat, adrenaline fueled punches have her snarling and screaming curses as she clambers on top and pins the Clone's left arm down with her weight while she grapples with the rights shock baton. The footfalls of the injured Clone comes closer but she just needs a few more seconds to-

The scowling Clone below headbutts her in the face as she's distracted momentarily, human skull meeting artificially laced skin as she's reeled backwards and her efforts are completely wasted, she calls out for Catra to run again but the Magicat's disappeared when a frantic Adora tries to locate her in vain. Her heart drops and she's kicked in the shoulder and straight onto her back.

Catra?

Forearms come up in a quick crossguard to stop and block the electrical baton from connecting directly with her face and instead sends her grimacing in pain as her arms buckle under the shock. Adora manages a futile kick that lands with a satisfying but useless crunch into the clone's torso, the other one is nearly on top of her and she’s probably going to die.

But if Catra made it out alive and escaped to the ship, Adora can accept that. Catra being saved was after all one of the mission objectives and she made a promise. So she holds the Clone's shock baton in her place with her own arms and continues kicking before the other comes, it's a futile attempt but she always knew she’d go down fighting.

The Clone’s baton creeps closer to her face, the tug of war between them is increasingly going negative on her end and she cant match the Clone’s great artificial strength, through the electric haze Adora swears she can make out the Clone is grinning - if it is then Horde Prime is personally supervising her death.

But that death never comes, instead two sets of five Magicat claws pierce the Clone’s torso and it shakes in its immediate death throes and flops to the side, behind it is a panting and pale but very alive Catra.

“Catra!” Adora’s heart soars and her stomach flips at the sight of her Catra standing before her.

“Hey, ‘Dora” Catra wheezes weakly and points behind Adora, tossing her the shock baton as Adora climbs unsteadily to her feet and stabs the last encroaching clone with it in the chest, turning and pushing the pointed end in that results in a quivering but dead body on the ground.

She sighs when it's over, shoulders sagging and body leaning to the left as she shifts the weight on her good leg but she's alive, and she’s joined by a very much alive Catra too who wraps her own arm around Adora’s shoulders, bringing the two of them close together and in a way, connected.

Catra blinks slowly and lightly presses her nails in Adora’s back. “Hey dummy”

“Hey you”

“You’re such a idiot you know, that stupid hero complex of yours?”

Adora sighs , nodding. “I know, but I had to do something”

“Dummy” Catra chuckles, laying her head on Adoras shoulder and letting her light purring rumble connect the two of them. It's a pleasant feeling, one that she’s missed for so long.

Should she say something?. “Hey Catra-I”

“A LOCALISED THERMO NUCLEAR EXPLOSION FROM THE FUEL CELLS? I NEVER PREDICTED THIS HEY GLIMMER YOU RECKON WE CAN DETONATE THE REACTORS TOO AND CREATE A NEUTRONIUM EXPLOSION IN THE CORE YOU KNOW THAT WOULD BE SO COOL GLIMMER CAN WE TAKE A-”

“Stop nerding nerd! Mwah!”

The sudden arrival of Entrapta’s voice in the earpiece nearly sends the both of them jumping as two seconds later the floor underneath them shakes with pieces of the walls turning into debris, the monitors that circle Prime’s throne blow out and send glass ricocheting everywhere while a series of teleports that signals the imminent arrival of more Clone’s prematurely detonates and throws grisly pieces of them in separate shockwaves. The lights flicker and turn different shades before an emergency dimmer shade kicks in.

“Mainframe down! Hey Adora, we did it!”

“Fuck this guy seriously I hope his stupid fucking ass got torched”

The hug between Bow and Glimmer is actually audible, Entrapta is squealing in ecstasy in the background and someone else is either screaming or praying in what seems to be halfway between an existential crisis and joy.

“Hey Catra?” Adora turns to meet beautiful freckles and a head that lays snugly on her body like it belongs there, like she belongs there.

“Wanna get out of here?”

It’s going to be a long walk, might take a hour or more with Adora needing to prop up Catras limping body and deal with her own exhaustion, she has the feeling that they’ll probably end up talking about something on the way but for once she's okay with it, things are looking up for the both of them and if she can resolve things with Catra.

Maybe she can too with Glimmer.

This was supposed to be one chapter but I figured 16k words would be too much. Anyway part 2 of this chapter is already written so it'll be up on sunday. Comments and reviews are welcome, I'd really appreciate it :) Tell me how I'm doing?

IIIB

ChapterIII B:

We’re Gonna Win In The End

Somehow still alive, Catra and Adora attempt to flee to safety after a nuclear detonation.

Presumably it was Entrapta.

Something wrecked their local part of Prime’s templeship, busted but still sparking wires flay out from all directions and the bodies of dead Clone’s split apart from failed teleportation litter surrounding areas.

But they’re alive, Adora has Catra slung around her shoulder and they’ve managed to survive and get out of the immediate danger zone.

And now, they’re heading home. Skirting along walls and alternating speed from a brisk walk to a slow crawl depending on Catra’s ability to move and Adora’s failing strength to keep her cat up and going.

Catra motioned for them to stop and she leaned breathlessly into a nearby wall, hugging it and panting. She took a second to catch her breath.

“I wanna know something, you forgave me really easily Adora. Why? It feels waaay too easy?”

“Because I want to, I like having you with me and everything feels right”

“But that doesn't answer the question, I know I’ve done a lot of shit things in my life. I tried to blow up the world. I hurt you! And you’re just ready to say it's all good and move on?”

If this was Adora a year ago she would have agreed with how strange that sounded, but that was a year ago. A year when she never understood or sympathized with Catras action, a year that started and was borne in her own betrayal of Catra and the Horde at Thaymor and a refusal to acknowledge Catra’s words and position in the Crystal Castle.

Too much has happened since then. Raw nerves and stubbornness gave away to new perspectives, a glimpse into the portal of the perfect life they could had together breathed a fresh awakening within that Adora fucked up too. The destruction of her once rock solid friendship with Glimmer that became the equivalent of quicksand too forced Adora to reckon with her own side of betrayal. In a way, allowing her to empathize with how Catra felt post Thaymmor.

In short, exposure to a similar situation. That and the world almost ending multiple times. It makes one tired of things and brings a desire for something new, or at least that’s how it feels to Adora when she turns to Catra and replies.

“It's something Perfuma kept harping on about, forgiveness - trauma whatever. You need a new chapter in your life and I think

I do too, one that doesn't involve us marching off to war and killing people. I’m ready to leave it behind because honestly, I felt like shit when you weren't with me and I have you now Catra and I’m not gonna give that up.”

Adora meant that, while her “therapy” sessions had been mostly useless partly because she struggled to understand the point of them for her and also because she always had her mind on something didn't mean that she couldn't recognise the value of them for someone that probably needed them. And she picked up on a few things too.

“Ador-”

Adora doesn't let her continue. “I feel better, like everything's right. I want that. You, everything” Instead affirming buried suspensions that she’s allowed to surface now everything seems to be going *right.*

Catra scoffed at that, but not in the bad way. To Adora it was a sound and a head movement that showed that Catra was probably ready or at least considering that she had a way out in life, to a new one.
“Whatcha reckon Shadow Weavers gonna think?”

“She won't be a problem”

“She left Brightmoon?”

“Bitch is on the bottom of the seabed”

“She killed herself?”

Adora’s right fist tightend automatically in a mixture of remembered cold rage and at the memory of wrapping rope around the sorcerer's legs in the same furious way one would tie an extra knot to secure a mast at edge of a tropical cyclone.

“No ,I helped her.” Adora admits.

Catra’s response is a raised eyebrow and a scoff in the way that says “no way that narrascasstic would have killed herself”.

But Adora isn't done yet, she relieves the memory and its sort of closure for both of them that a chapter of their previous lives is over.

“Right after Prime teleported you and Glimmer and after the Crystal Castle exploded I marched back to Brightmoon and found her fucking gloating, Glimmer was gone and no one was in charge, that smug fucking grin I-. Something snapped Catra”

Adora breathed in and steadied herself, Catra’s arm around her torso gave her the needed bit of support to get the list bit out.

“I lost focus - picked up a chair and slugged her in the face with it. Guards tried to stop me but I think that was more because I broke good furniture. I-I got a boat and some rocks, already tied her up and when she came to she was screaming at me and I didnt fucking care at all. I tied the rocks to her legs and threw her overboard”

Catra stopped for a second, her brow tightened as in deep thought and when Adora brushed a hand over to help she waved it off.

"So she's dead?"

"Yep" Adora popped the "p". "Some visiting Sorcerer from Mystacor confirmed it, said summin' bouta' a loss of dark magic"

"Do you regret it?"

"Honestly? No. She had it coming and she deserved it"

"Good fucking riddance" Adora honestly agreed with that, the woman no *bitch* abused Catra and manipulated Adora with not a hint of sorrow or remorse and she had the fucking gall to *expliot* Glimmer's vunerable state after her mom died and immediatly switch her side from Horde to Rebellion with not a hint of care to those she trampled underfoot. Killing Shadow Weaver was not something Adora would take back.

Catra was visibly exhausted by the time they made eye contact again, Adora had to support most of the Magicats weight with growing concern and needed both hands, they went from a brisk walk to a slow down. Clearly Catras wounds had been more extensive and damaging then Adora initially thought and two pills obviously weren't enough, Catra had to guide them to the hanger and listen out for errant clones so neither of them could afford her to lose consciousness.

But Adora had hope in this situation, they were together for once and heading for an escape.

They had each other.

Catra groaned out in pain again and she lurched forwards with Adora managing to catch up her in time.
“Fuck!” Catra swore and grimaced, she went to turn her head so she could scratch the back of her neck but..

“Catra? You alright?”

“Fucking ow, necks stiffened up. I, I cant move it. Feel fucking dizzy too I-”

“Do I need to carry you?”

“No?”

Catra wriggled free out of Adora’s support, the girl biting her lip and attempting to prove she could move on her own two legs. Adora watched in horror as the Magicat’s legs simply buckled like they were jelly and she barely managed to stop Catra from falling over.

Evidently and horrifyingly, Catra’s condition was getting to the point of which she couldn't walk and one look at the “bandage” at the back of her neck, a wet and soggy thing that Adora immediately changed out for another ripped article of clothing

with the apparent need that they needed to speed up and find something on Mara's ship to hasten the condition or heal Catra entirely.

Catra did protest initially as Adora placed her arms around the Magicats back and the bend in her knees, lifting her up and pulling her in close as Catra buried her head into Adora's shoulder as she stumbled at the start but then kept herself straight.

"How far is it?" Catra stuttered out weakly, if her neck wasn't stiff then her head would be lolling from side to side.

"Soon, ten minutes. We'll get there. I promise" Adora affirmed.

"You promise?"

"Yeah, I promise"

She'd get Catra home in one piece no matter what it took, she made a promise. Well more than one promise and Adora intended to keep all of them. She imagined a future without needing to wake up at 06:00 every day and plan out at a wartable, obsessively go over every single possibly past,present and future events. A life without crushing responsibilities and one that she genuinely wanted Catra in.

Just ten minutes to go, the corridors were still oppressively large but slowly darkening as cleverly hidden light bulbs flickered or shut off entirely, it was eerily silent too like the Clone's had just stopped functioning and the ones they did find were either staring into space, acting like someone had fried their brains or just straight up wandering around aimlessly.

Ten minutes to go, one more hurdle to climb. Hopefully the last. Adora's mood never faltered or failed, with Catra she had a sense of hope, of relaxation and a loosening of the weight on her shoulders that everything would be better.

One more mountain.

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The tail twitches, wrapping around or flickering. A body part that Adora played with as a child in those soft and innocent days became a tool that she often found herself missing when she was touch starved in the rebellion.

Adora’s gaze and perspective would flicker between amusement and just simply watching in childlike awe, the same she did when she first encountered the Magicat as a child, soon after they became friends and an ever curious Adora continued to research (often physically) how much different her Magicat friend would be..

The ears, two pinnas that Adora stroked and often kissed at the tip when she was young provided a welcome distraction during the tense escape to Mara’s ship, they would fold back at danger, go forwards and cue in that Catra was listening intently with Adora or twitch and move in touch with the Magicats emotions during their talk.

She didn't realize how much she missed her best friend, *her* Catra up until now. And that realization tugged at Adora’s heart strings and threatened to not let go.

Ten individual stings pricked at her chest, not exactly painful but neither unnoticeable along with a strange vibration drumming against her insides bought Adora out of her inner monolog and into a battle ready position, going from automatic to manual in expectation of a enemy or someone who had gotten close enough to hurt her and Catra and she needed to check up on the girl right now-

“Are you kneading me?” Adora asked incredulously as she made eye contact with a now blushing Catra whose gaze flicked away.

“No?” Came the very small reply.

She couldn't help but chuckle at that, all this. The world nearly ending - Primes ship, nearly killing each other or being killed by clones and attempting to navigate through a destroyed path and Catra was *kneading* her just like old times.

She grinned and tried to stifle a laugh that became a snort instead, still funny though.

“And purring aswell?”

“No!”

“That must be SO embarrassing for you” Adora took the god-given opportunity to needle Catra , the fact that she could reveal just like in the old times was not something she was gonna give up.

Catra fumbles and twists in her tight grasp but it comes to nothing, instead it's sort of comedic how the Magicat tries to escape but also tries not to escape the bridal carry. Because if twenty years of being together taught Adora anything, its that Catra secretly (but won't ever admit) that she enjoys kneading Adora, she used to knead her clothes and scent them if Adora was out on a mission or late.

But Adora didn't mind. For eighteen years they shared the bottom part of a bunk bed and slept together, sometimes Catra'd be at the foot of the bed, sometimes they'd find themselves basically spooning. When Adora's promotion to Force Captain came and she was deployed to the Crimson Waste in the Hordes' vulnerable backyard she made certain that Catra's own promotion to staff officer came and that the two of them were together in the same room. With a double bed of course.

"Admit it"

"No?"

"Admit it!"

"Noooo!"

Adorable.

Eventually the ribbing settles down and Adora returns to her automatic state, Catra keeps on the watch but while Adora know's that she's tired, exhausted and with every fibre and muscle in her body hurting and complaining and begging that she should lie and go the fuck to sleep for at least a week, Catra is more so. Catra was basically dunked in a vat of vile liquid and forced to change, then electrocuted half to death and forcibly orally injected with super charged pills in a combination that can fight against the clutches of death itself.

“You haven't seen Mara’s ship before right? I don't mean the Crimson wastes I mean flying like, like spaceship thing flying”

Adora couldn't help but babble. Carta had this effect on her back in the Frightzone where she’d transform from a awe inspiring Force-Captain that dominated a space into a passionate girl that never stopped to talk about her interests. In a way, the old Adora was back. The peace she craved with Catra that she went for two years without? Right in her arms now and she wasn't going to let it go without a fight.

More lurking and attempted stealth by walking as light as possible past a trio of confused Clone’s, Catra dipping in and out of unconsciousness seemingly tied directly to how much information she could provide, initially it would be at least twenty meters ahead of movement, a minute ago it was five and now, nothing. Instead the Magicat’s head rested peacefully on an awkward arm that Adora had moved to support , her body was stiff but she complained of feeling numb and it being difficult to move anyway.

“Almost there ten minutes I think?, I remember this part of the journey with the Clone’s cuz they surrounded me and it was boring and terrifying at the same time” Adora commented idly, she was talking to herself at this point but even if Catra couldn't hear her, it helped.

“Scorpia’s at Bright Moon you know? I’m not sure what happened between you two but she’s into Perfuma and likewise, I think talking? will help when all of this blows over ya know?”

No Clone’s, the ship is close. The dull vibration of the engines can be picked up even with her human senses, they’re so near to

freedom! The both of them can finally escape everything and leave the fucked up past behind.

“She seems to be a good person, a massive talker and a hugger like too much personal space but eh whatever, we’ve mentioned you sometimes and I honestly think that when everyone’s in a healthier place than I can do-”

She’s kinda unsure of how she got to this stage, did Catra’s presence really provide such a positive aspect to her this much? Two years ago she would have been able to answer that question with a hundred percent accuracy but right now it's like a ghost coming back into your life and having to relearn certain missing items that you didn't realize were gone - that *you* miss them.

“Therapy with Perfuma and talk it out with Glimmer, we’re kind of at odds and its mostly my fault but things are honestly looking up Catra, I know you're sleeping right now but I wanna say that-”

Mara’s ship is real close, she can make out Entrapta squealing at something, a man’s voice probably Bows and the tell tale hum of magic from Glimmer, there's someone else but they’re all in conversation.

“If I can do therapy, you reckon you could make things up with Scorpia and Entrapta? You’ve really come this far Catra and I believe in you” She added a little friendly shake and a squeeze to reinforce that Catra really was there, in her arms and that they were *together* again.

That the promise they constructed as kids, fulfilled.

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She's so fucking tired and Catra's so heavy, ships almost there. One more corner. One more ramp, one more obstacle and then she can let Catra rest on a real bed and maybe get some sleep herself.

Glimmer looks like shit, exhaustively resting on her battered magic staff that mirrors how she looks when Adora finds her when she rounds the corner, Glimmer's cape is tattered, purple hair stuck up in some places and outright messy in others.

Glimmer squints when she notices them, almost like she doesn't believe it. There still some of that residual tension between her and Adora and it shows in her slow movements and quiet voice

"Adora?"

"Glimmer!" Adora cries out ,she'd wave that her hands are too occupied to wave. She'd been dreading coming back to see the Queen earlier but with Catra nearby (practically in her arms) she's actually excited to see her friend again.
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Glimmer perks up almost immediately at the sound of Adora's voice, she manages a tired wave and heaves in and out before she replies like she's just run a marathon.

"Hey 'Dora...that Catra? Did you get out safe? Where's Prime?"

"Yeah she's sleeping right now"
Glimmer nods with a relieved soft smile.. "And Prime?"

"Teleported away, dunno where he is. Teleports into his throne are gone though and all the clones I've seen are just wandering. Was that you guys?"

"Yep" Glimmer accunates the P, she jerks a thumb back to the ship. "That was Entrapta's doing - while me and Bow held off the Clones, dunno what she did but she called it a themeunuclar? Explosion? Anyway she told us to run and we ran and like ten minutes later the lights went out and all the Clone's died so ask her?"

"Will do, is Bow safe?" Adora asks with concern, Bow was her friend and she cared after all for the "straight guy" in their trio of a relationship.

"Ship, with Entrapta and Wrong Hordak - I think his name is??" Glimmer points back at the ship again,there's a little fizzle of magic around her staff that connects to her fingertips but it's a puddle compared to the mighty river that she possessed back on Etheria. It's clear that she's on her last drop of reserves and if she's the one that's guarding the ship then…

"Is he okay Glimmer?"

"Yeah...yeah, Bow" Glimmer groans and rubs a shaking hand across her sweated forehead. "He's uh, well broke his bow and a Clone nearly broke his leg so, he's letting Entrapta do the heavy lifting"

With a nod that's given one back in silent agreement, Adora makes her way past Glimmer. The Queen does make a move to help but Adora's eye contact assures that "she's got this for now". If she could put a hand on Glimmer's shoulder and apologize for everything she would but she's physically occupied so Adora settles for a small whisper that she leans into Glimmer's ear as she passes her by and goes up on the ramp.

"I'm sorry Glimmer"

"I'm sorry too Adora" A equally small voice replies as its purple haired owner waits a few seconds of physical space and follows Adora up the ramp that automatically closes once they're both inside.

Catra is so soft. So peaceful like this, so innocent. She's sleeping now. She's not breathing with the lack of slow rhythms in the chest or breath expelled through the mouth but she's a Magicat and they're different right?

"I missed like you, that I'd find you on our bed and you'd be conked out and just wasted. Not even bothering to curl up and instead just lying flat on your side of our bed"

Adora’s smiling, a genuine soft one that she hasn't felt in years, a private and guarded emotional reaction turned physical when she threads a finger through Catra’s scalp and gently ruffles brunette hair and undo’s knots with her single hand, her other is propping up Catra’s stiff neck and supporting the head since she complained of it when she was conscious and Adora isn't exactly going to fetch pillows. Someone else can, she needs to be here, wants to be here - with Catra.

“So peaceful like this you know Catra? I know you can't hear cuz you're sleeping and all that. What are you dreaming of right now if you could tell me? Is it the Fright Zone with the machinery or something else?”

She chuckles, letting her fingers run down Catra’s sharply angled face and marveling at how little it's changed since she was last able to touch Catra like this, the day before Thaymor, before the sword. Practically the prelude to everything going wrong.

“I miss the noises and everything, I can't sleep on my own without something whirring in the background or umm” She’s embarrassed to admit this, to finally come to this result but it's easier with a sleeping Catra than a alive one that would probably brush off her confession and call Adora a dummy.

“Someone, I miss having you with me and when this is all over and Prime’s dead then maybe we can go back to before I-”

She chokes on the last bit, it's a result of missed years of physical touch, starvation of the self and a complete disregard for the

person underneath while constructing a hard exterior shell that fought against the world and did its best to win.

Right now that person is coming out, a slow awakening from a deep hibernation born out of necessity that was shut out and walls sent in.

“There's a married couple in Brightmoon um. Netossa and Spinerella and they do these weird things like kiss and live together and they say they love each other. To be honest I’m kinda jealous of them and Bow had to explain to me the concept of marriage and kissing and people-”

She’s gone red at the last part, bright war paint marking her face and ears and especially her cheeks.

“And um sex and commitment and everything because thats what people do when they love each other and I was completely embarrassed when he told me! We never had that in the Fright Zone and I didnt even know babies came from people like that fuck I sound like a idiot but fuuuck, you know?”

She probably does sound stupid, she’s in her twenties and this is basic shit that kids in the Rebellion knew? Still Catra wont remember any of this so her stupid secret is safe with the person that she-. She-?. She draws a blank at that.

“So the only experience I had with all of that was in nightclubs or just bumping into people, it’s weird and gross and messy but I-”

I’d like to do all that with you.

Adora licks her lips, breathes in. Sighs and keeps going, her confession is mounting like a train going its tracks and it feels like an emotional now or never situation rather than a one sided conversation with unconsciousness. There's anxiety at the unknown, awkwardness in how she perceives compared to how she says it but she keeps going because it's been two years and that person is finally out and able to say it.

“I dont know I’m being right about this but there's just one person that I’ve ever thought about coming even close to all that and that’s you Catra”

Grasping the back of Catras neck firmly in her hand with the fingers and stroking at the edges with the little one and thumb while her other moves down to link its fingers around Catra’s arm, Adora buries her wet face in Catra’s chest and turns left towards the head. She can't feel a heartbeat but that doesnt matter, Catra’s heart works differently and slower compared to everyone else's anyway.

“I think-I think”

“Uh words”

“I think”

There's mounting pressure to say it, acknowledge it. It’s so close

and peeking out of the battlements and just needs a final push. To let everything go and rid herself of the weight.

Gazing into Catra's eyes, those emotive and different, powerful and colorful - strange but beautiful heterochromia orbs that caught her attention on day one and never let go, blue and yellow that's facing the ceiling but have the presence to bore into her soul.

"I want that house with you, I want to be rid of the war and I *want* to never have to command anyone ever again in my life. I wanna sleep in the morning and wake up at ten and laze around for a few hours, I want a ring on my finger and on yours and I never want to see you wear shoes again in your life"

Its a fucking bubble thats gonna pop and she takes a needle to it. She's basically choking on her words and even crying out of one eye and it's hard to concentrate now but she needs to do it, *she has to do it* . For both of their sakes.

Deep breath.

Adora *confesses* . Finally.

"I love you Catra. I can't imagine my life and this world without you, I've missed you so much and it's taken until now to realize that I've loved you all this time, I always have"

The bubble bursts open and she-. It’s a combination of realization and relief, an invisible and weightless feeling turned overt and opaque and she’s finally let it out. She’s performed the emotional equivalent of a work out and the post runners high feels *fucking great* and Adora’s smiling like a fucking idiot but she doesnt *care* - the weight of the world is lifted a little but still there and of course she has to actually confess her heart out again to Catra when she’s awake but practice makes perfect and her chest is mostly settled now, the nerves are slowly down and going back to normal and there’s a strange sense of peace filling empty spaces.

She even laughs, it's dry and throaty and and she even surprises herself when she accomplishes it cuz she’s gotta tell Catra again and she’ll probably get punched for it when Catra wakes up. “Hey Catra I laughed and it's weird cuz I haven't done so in months"

Still, she feels better. Everyones together and safe, Prime’s operations are crippled as far as she knows and Catra needs medical attention.

Adora kept her promises to everyone.

Somehow.

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She’s stroking idly along Catra’s ears when the door behind her opens with a pair of steeps shortly followed by a “squee” like sound.

It’s Bow and he looks like shit.

“Oh my gosh!” Adora turns round to find Bw with his face in his face making an obscenely cute noise, just like Glimmer Bow’s clothes are torn open in most areas and from the markings and bruises he's been through hell.

“Hey Bow” Adora greets back, still stroking along her Catra as Bow slides up next to her on the bed and at Catra’s legs. He’s still himself despite his battered appearance that more resembles the external physique and look of a Horde Soldier that's come back on a three month deployment from the Crimson Waste than a Rebellion Commander.

“Hey Adora!”

He wraps an arm around Adora’s shoulder and hums. “Glad you made it, was worried when you went silent after the bomb went off. Catra’s uh sleeping?”

Adora nods, smiles and blushes a little. “Yeah, been asleep for about thirty minutes”

“She’s really peaceful isn't she? All that time on opposite sides and I never knew someone could be so cute like that!” Bow comments but keeps his hands to himself, the hesitation of two years of the

war keeps him as a respectable difference. Adora notes with a bit of sadness that reparations and rehabilitation for Catra will probably take a long time when they get back to Etheria.

"She is, I havent had her like this since Thaymor and-. I missed it" She admits to both herself and her friend, she can't believe that she's able to caress Catra's ears like this, it used to be a distant memory or a far off fantasy and now it's real.

"You look better too, you know? Colors in the cheeks and shoulders looking like they belong to a person rather than a hunchback!"

"You do too, well after Glimmer" She teases back and ribs her friend, lightly elbowing him in the stomach.

"Nah I look terrible to be honest and everyone does I guess. Even Trapta' has one of her hair cybernetics out and its just Wrong-Hordak whose presentable right now"

"Wrong-Hordak?"

"Oh? Glimmer didn't tell you?"

"She told me the name"

"Clone guy, 'Trapta pulled him out of this pod and he had an emotional breakdown cuz he got disconnected from Prime.

Anyway he joined us,showed us where the mainframe was and he's pretty much followed us around like a stray puppy. Guys really useful though and stupidly helpful”

Bow shrugged, if this was a week ago Adora would have asked if he was drunk but enough weird things have happened today that she completely unconditionally accepts it as fact.

“Glimmer said you were different ,that you uh. Seemed happy to see her? Not putting any conflict down here but she was really surprised.” Bow said, he seemed surprised aswell and Adora kind of agreed along those lines given her that her physical interaction with Glimmer and Bow previously was an awkward hug that followed a near argument and her blowing off Glimmer.

“Yeah, I. Things have changed?” She offers in return not really sure what else to say, Catra’s honestly been such a positive benefit to her mood that she was genuinely happy to see the Queen of Bright Moon.

“Is it Catra’s doing?”

“Yeah”

“Damm. She really means something to you?”

“Yeah she does, I missed her. I missed this”

“I’m glad you’ve got her”

“Glad you’ve got Glimmer”

She joins Bow in the arm linkage by wrapping hers around his shoulder when he hands a pillow to put under Catra’s neck. Adora hums quietly and relaxes with her friend, it's so strange that everything is so quiet now when barely three hours ago they were heading straight towards certain death.

They make eye contact, they smile. Just like old times.

“Gotta do one of those debriefings you love so much, coming?”

“Yeah gimmie a sec”

That second is Adora taking off her iconic red jacket and placing it to cover Catra’s smaller body from the shoulders to the thighs.

And also making sure it doesn't leave any exposed skin uncovered.

And leaving a small but loving peck on the forehead.

And of course straightening up the jacket so it doesnt give the appearance that she threw it on Catra.

And looking back when she moves out to make sure that Catra is still there of course. "I'll see you soon"

"Awwww"

"Shut up, I know you'd do the same for Glimmer"

"I have actually-ow!"

Someone managed to find five chairs from one of the various storage of Mara's ship and set them up around behind the captain's chair. The cold and gunmetal interior of the spacecraft stood in confused juxtaposition to its strange and current occupants that stood either as a new bright age for the ship or the last who would ever set foot inside, a brightly coloured queen with a magical staff, a bowman with his own array of brilliant clothing, a techwizard with cybernetic hair with the world's worst regard to physical appearance, a clone? with the same color scheme as the ship but still somehow different and Adora herself, her ponytail non-existent at this point and proud ex-horde clothing more like "hanging on" than "worn". But still and regardless of their appearances and their own exhausations, everyone who sat at their chairs fought off the increasing demand that their bodies desperately cried out for sleep and rest and set their minds to finish the debriefing and continue on. Adora was no exception.

“Sooo Glimmer, you’ve told us already but how was your part?” Bow leans forward and starts the conversation towards Glimmer whose slumped back in her own chair and her staff is on the floor somewhere.

“Crept out first and had to dodge those four guards who left Adora. I went looking for Catra and didnt find her in the prison section which is *long as fuck* by the way. I got jumped by a few Clone’s but with the backup staff Bow gave me it was pretty easy to fend them off with magic”

Adora nodded, her mental map going over the routes and sections that Glimmer marked on the map and compared it with how her part of the plan went, sort of like a board game with different moving figures on a 3D level.

“Eventually I realized that Catra wasn't being held prisoner like I was so I communicated with Bow and Entrapta to find out where they were and headed to help them out since they were heading into the mainframe Catra would either be there or with you Adora and-”

“It was a stealth mission until Glimmer arrived and brought all the Clone’s with her - thanks Glimmer” Bow interjected but with no venom in his voice, he seemed to take it in stride actually.

“So that's how you all met up then?”

“Pretty much, just in time to watch Trapta’ pull out a Clone from its bay, we named him Wrong-Hordak and he led us to the

mainframe while about a hundred Clone's ran after us" Glimmer replied nonchalantly like fighting a hundred clones was a average day for her, but then again she had magic and she was their most powerful piece at the time. If Adora still had She-Ra then she probably would have managed the same.

"Thanks again for the staff Bow"

"No problem, babe" Bow teased openly for the first time and prompted a *blush* and an *actual* stutter from his girlfriend, it was kinda cute seeing Glimmer go red. Adora even managed a small smile herself in the hope that she'd be able to do the same with Catra one day.

"And the mainframe?" Adora questions, she actually did wonder how exactly they managed to turn a fuel cell into a literal bomb that crippled Prime's station, stopped all teleportation and turned the clones from a perfectly controlled hivemind into wandering zombies.

"Uh, Entrapta?" Bow leans over and pokes a wandering gazed Entrapta in the shoulder, she probably hadn't been paying attention at all judging by how she stared at the consoles at the front of the ship longingly.

"Hhmmm?"

"The mainframe and the fuel cell, Adora wants to know"

"Oh, hi Adora!" Entrapta noticies Adora for the first time and waves eagerly, with a raised eyebrow Adora returns a more question mark filled wave.

“Yeah, you pretty much took out most of the systems. I thought you were just gonna pull out some plugs or something and not take a actual bomb there”

Entrapta’s eyes dilated and she performs a motion similar to a wind up toy.

“Oh? No! You see I realized that Darla’s fuel cells with the right temperatures and environment could be converted to a similar state of explosion to a thermonuclear warhead but then the blast radius would be too big and would kill us all so I had to experiment while Bow and Glimmer fended off the clones, thank you Wrong-Hordak for showing me how to manipulate the casing into a shaped charge-”

Wrong-Hordak as his name went simply smiled (very much unlike a clone since they sneered) and waved an embarrassed hand. “You are most welcome friend of Prime? No, friend”

“Anyway after cracking the casing at both ends I realized that it could be used as a field study into cracking starship hulls while inside the starship! Unfortunately Bow and Glimmer made me take data samples and information out of the mainframe before I could conduct a full survey and I managed to set a timer for the bomb, Wrong-Hordak! How much damage did it do?”

The clone replied almost instantly and socially clunkily in the same stiff manner that the others would.

“Entrapta-friend bomb disrupted the mainframe ,teleportation systems, lighting, Prime’s information and clone control systems

and destroyed three percent of the station while venting one percent of it to outerspace. I-Wrong-I estimate the repair to be at least three weeks”

Adora nodded, thinking of the time and space that would bring them. Would they be able to construct a defense in three weeks and be able to teleport Etheria back to Despondos?.

“Three weeks isnt a lot of time” She noted.

“Not much we can do from here, everyone's exhausted” Glimmer sighed and pointed out. “Bows got no bow, I’ve got no magic and Adora’s pretty much ready to drop”

Adora actually agreed with that, if Catra wasn't with them and provided a real reason to head back to Etheria she would have argued that all she needed was a nap and either explosives or something to damage.

“Do we have any more fuel cells to use? There's got to be a reactor or something to kill the station for good”

“As much as I'd like to use our remaining fuel cells, even taking one would ensure that we wouldn't be able to make it back to Etheria” Entrapta surprisingly reasonably added, killing Adoras idea of simply using Maras ship to bust into the interior and ram a fuel cell down the reactor shaft or whatever powerplant the Temple-ship was using.

“Ok”

“Huh” Glimmer mused.

“What?”

“Honestly I expected you to put up a fight about it, no offense”

That got Adora thinking, was Catra that important to her that Catra getting medical help superseded the mission? Well furthering the mission since the two objectives they had were met. Even a basic introspective thought bought up the very real fact that Catra was... *here.* Rather than over *there.* That Adora had Catra with her for once and she wasn't letting go *this time.*

Bow spoke up, leaning forward. “It's because of Catra isn't it?” Adora blushed in response, she wouldn't be able to hide it if she answered with a no because everyone knew she was a terrible liar anyway.

Glimmer broke the silence with a large exhale and glanced over at Adora, no abrasion like she was as the queen on Etheria, no ulterior plans and no apathy between them, instead actual genuine concern mixed in with surprised affection was plain on her face.

“She’s changed you, an hour? Two hours? And we’re not fighting Adora, you actually *want* to go home?”

Adora swallowed, the realization really hitting her that she had changed, that. Maybe she didn't have to go back to her previous life and could start again. “Yeah-I...well yeah”

Glimmer bit her lip

"I'm happy for you Adora, I really am. But you know that well, she's *Catra* ."

"I know"

"I'm on your side for this, but once this is over and everyone goes back to living, we'll have to. Probably rebuild and hold trials and stuff like mom would have done"

"I know"

Fortunately, and probably sensing that there was going to be some tension building up again towards the two women. Bow interjected by changing the conversation with a hand flap and a very eager characteristic voice crack.

"So! Adora, how did your part of the plan go? We know you rescued Catra but how come she's unconscious and how did it go with Prime?"

Adora sat back, blinked and replayed the previous events of the past hours in her head, going through the important details and leaving out the boring parts such as the weird alien construction and the embarrassing part of the conversation with Prime in that she *almost* defected because of Catra.

“Hey Entrapta could you take the clone and check up on Catra, she had a weird tech thing in her neck that I had to cut out, could you make sure she's alright and replace the bandage with a real one?” Adora figured that she might aswell make Trapta’ useful, the girl was a genius but would probably view Adoras part of the debriefing as boring, plus she was the only one smart enough to actually understand whatever Prime did to Catra.

Glimmer motioned for her to start.“So, Adora?”

Fuck Adora hasnt realised how tired she is until she started pre planning her part, her eyes are heavy and her head is weighted towards one side, muscles in her arms and legs ache and she could honestly fall asleep like this, its a familiar sensation. It's when the body finally decides “enough is enough”. She makes it a promise that she’ll go to sleep when she's finished, probably on the floor next to Catra’s bed.

“Yeah, we’re all tired too to be honest. Pretty sure I could sleep standing up” Noticing her yawn Bow jokes with Adora lightly chuckling back.

“Yeah, Clone’s escorted me to Primes headquarters?I think. He’s relying on his Clone’s to body swap himself when he runs out of life power or something, I tried to get at him but he teleported out of reach”

“And Catra?” Glimmer asks.

“She wasn't a prisoner like we thought, Prime made her into a sort of clone and controlled her to attack me but I managed to

snap her out of it but he made a fail-safe or something and electrocuted her so I had to pull this device thing out of her spine. Anyway we made out it out of there and she fell asleep at some point" Adora wanted to elaborate but tiredness was taking her and if she was being honest , reliving multiple near death experiences wasnt high on her list.

Somehow sensing her reluctance to talk further about Catra, Bow focused on something else.

"So Prime is still alive?"

"Yeah but if everythings true then he's stuck here and his Clone's are in disarray, three weeks of peace hopefully and we've managed to cripple his operations"

"It's a win in my book" Glimmer adds in support of Adora, when Adora glances round she is greeted with a tired but genuinely supportive smile and she returns one. A little bit of her heart lifts, telling her that maybe she can pull this off and begin not only the long road to recovery with Catra, but also a repair of friendship with Glimmer.

"So we all done?, cuz I need to sleep like the dead tonight" Glimmer jokes too, that bit of her, the maverick wise crack before the queen shines through and it seems that maybe she's going through the same process. Adora and Bow both nod and they make to leave. Adora waits in her own chair for a bit, content to stay and gather her thoughts but as Glimmer walks by she's struck by a sudden epiphany, a need, a want.

"Glimmer?" Adora reaches out with some hesitation at first but lightly grasps her hand around the queen's forearm to stop her.

Surprised, Glimmer sort of stops for a second and looks like she’s processing a reply. She stutters.

“Adora?, wha-what's up?”

“I uh” Words are difficult, Adora has this grand speech planned about how she feels and wants to repair everything but seeing Glimmer like this in person and actually *here.* Well that grand speech fizzles out almost immediately.

“Adora?, you alright there?”

If she doesn't get the words out now then she’ll never be able to.

“I want to try again with us, we don't have to talk about everything on Etheria, I. I value you Glimmer and I’m sorry for blowing you off” She manages to confess and not choke on her words at the same time.

Glimmer does try to make a reply but Adora stops her.

“Lemme finish, I’ve been a terrible person to you and I want to make things right, to fix them. Fix us, it feels like there's a way out for me now and I feel like I-”

Glimmer interrupts, there's no malice or venom. It's a soft expression lining her face, a sympathetic smile that relays that she understands the hurt, the pain and the bad times they went

through together. But also one that remembers the good times, the laughs, the sleepovers and the two of them standing together against the world.

“I forgive you, and I’m sorry for being a shitty person too. I shouldn't have taken out my anger on you and Bow” Glimmer makes her own brief confession with Adora mirroring the previous look of sympathy.

“I forgive you too Glimmer.” Adora’s hand drops off Glimmer's forearm and she sighs, relaxes and exhales, it's another weight lifted off her shoulders, just like Catra and everything else.

But Glimmer doesn't go, she’s still standing infront of Adora and she lowers a gloved hand that touches at Adora’s own.

“Hey! Come on” Glimmer nudges and she pulls Adora up. They share a look, a pained history of regret turns into relief, the relief that they’re not going to have anymore fights or arguments, no more backstabbing or counter moves at the war room. That they can work together as the best friends squad rather than a divided trio.

Adora leans on Glimmer's shoulder, she breathes in the faint traces of magic that her queen still possesses and closes her eyes, reminiscing of the good old days. It’ll be a hard fight to get rid of Prime or avoid him but they’ll find a way if everyone works together.

“You alright?”

“Yeah, things are finally looking up. That we’ve stopped losing and it's a actual win for once”

“You know us, once we start winning we never stop right?” They both chuckle at that as Glimmer leads Adora towards her shared room with Catra, she bids Glimmer goodnight with Bow and assures her that once she takes care of Catra, Adora’ll set the ship on autopilot for Etheria and they can finally go home and away from this nightmare. Her spirits are raised higher than they’ve ever been in months, nothing could go wrong now , the plan was executed well with no casualties and with everyone combined they could-.

“Entrapta?” The tech wizard is standing over Catra, she's not making any of the usual sounds or movements, no excited chatter or talking between her and a very quiet Wrong-Hordak. Entrapta is just still, so still and weird that her cybernetic hair has stopped too.

“Oh-oh. Um” The normal chatterbox has been replaced with a stutter, confused at the change Adora cautiously steps into the room.

“What's wrong?”

Entrapta doesnt turn around until Adora grabs her shoulder and *makes her* do so. Those bright ruby eyes are sullen and less of a pair of lightbulbs and more flicking ones down on power, mouth is downturned , her brow is creased - it's so un-Entrapta like that Adora blinks and blinks again to confirm what she's witnessing.

“Entrapta” she growls and shakes that shoulder again more firmly. What the fuck happened?

Entrapta looks down to the floor, her lip quivers and trembles as she struggles to speak, Adora’s confused expression slowly turns worried with panic starting to settle into the gut - uncertainty and unease rising.

“Its Catra” Entrapta manages to get out two words and with that tone of voice its two words together that she does *not want to hea* r right now, what happened?

“Entrapta. Listen to me. What. Happened” Adora beats down the negative thoughts with a stick and pushes them into the safe and the bottom of the river, *it's fine* . She just probably needs to confirm a few things and then she can sleep and when Catra wakes up they’ll be well on their way home to a bright new future.

Entrapta visibly and deeply swallows, Wrong-Hordak shuffles in place and makes to move out but Adora automatically grabs him by the scuff with her other hand without even thinking.

“It’s Catra-, she.” Entrapta can't finish that sentence and honestly Adora doesn't want her to either, she's come too far and expended too much of herself for even the slightest bit of bad news right now.

“What did you do to her?” She doesnt mean for it to come off as accusing but right now she couldn’t care less, *of course* she needs to *fucking know* now. It's another ugly problem that she *has* to

deal with.

“Entrapta has done nothing to Catra, she’s dead” Wrong-Hordak states in the same calm and professional tone that the Clone’s do and if Adora’s knife wasn't buried in a clone's wrist then she’d...she’d.

What?

It takes a few seconds to process, death and Catra together? No. She’s unconscious, she fell asleep. They must be wrong, they must have fucked up somehow because Catra is alive, she's *right there in front of them* and Adora simply *needs to restate it* and set the record straight.

She points at Catra with her free hand,tightens her grip on Wrong-Hordaks scruff and her voice immediately drops from neutral to Force Captain because now she’s starting to get fucking *pissed off* with this *stupid shit* . “Listen here, I-”

“She’s been dead for about forty five minutes, lethal injection I think or an overdose. I-I’m not sure Adora. I’m not good at this but she’s not breathing, there's no heartbeat and she’s in rigor mortis”

Entrapta’s words hit Adora with the force of a Horde supply train ramming through a flimsy wooden obstacle set by a Crimson Waste gang, she tries to deny it at first and throw such an accusation aside and brush it off as Entrapta messing up.

She’s that flimsy wooden barricade though - brain and mind immediately begin to piece things together as her heart fucking stops dead in its tracks and its a rush of dread instead of warm blood that fills her veins.

“What did you say?” She asks, breathless and she can swear theres a warning sound going off in her ears, its fucking ringing like a loud explosion that kills the senses and replaces them with static.

“Adora I’m sorry but your friend is dead” The Clone speaks with a more gentle and emotional voice but its fucking hollow with death sprinkled on the outside that enters her hearing and bobs around on her brain and thoughts and feelings like a fucking cork. Adora opens her mouth, nothing comes out. She looks at Catra and it's just static.

And then it seeps in, as much as she wants it to *please fucking stop* she makes the conclusion automatically like she would with triage at a casualty list. Catra not breathing, Catra screaming in pain. Death throes via electrocution, Catra not falling asleep but dying in her arms. It's all rushing in and every single nerve is firing up and screeching the obvious.

It all goes goes cold like frostbite, numbing pain that halts bodily functions and chills all the way from top to bottom.

Catra died in her arms.

Adora talked to a dead body while enroute to the ship.

Catra’s dead body is on the bed, covered in her jacket.

She kissed a corpse and confessed her love to it.

No No No No

It takes twenty three seconds, twenty three seconds of Entrapta standing there like a deer caught in floodlights with a flapping mouth and nothing else, twenty three seconds of Wrong-Hordaks useless drivel that's supposed to cushion the blow but morphs into white noise instead. Twenty three seconds of the *worst* kind of realization, the news nobody wants to hear, the words inscribed brightly that are shining right at her eyes and impossible to miss, cold frost deep in her veins and bouncing around in her head and infecting every thought.

Catra isn't *here.*

Catra isn't over *there* .

Catra is *dead* . Adora knows what a corpse looks like and she’s been in horrific denial about it for almost an hour.

Adora fully collapses down the back of the wall with a thump and buries her head in her hands and wishes for it to just fucking *stop* , she climbed the *mountain* , she went through the *hurdles* . She made so many *promises* and she *sacrificed* so much.

She’s not glowing anymore or smiling from accomplishment, she’s not well dressed or with a smart hair poof and freshly trimmed side shaves. She’s deathly pale and despairingly unhappy, her clothing is ripped and bloody, her hair is sticking up from being electrocuted or straight up just wild. She-

She’s going to scream until her voice goes hoarse and then disappears for good, she’s going to throw up every single meal she ever ate. She’s going to cry rivers until she passes out from dehydration.

Staring up into the ceiling and past the metal walls and the exterior layer of Mara’s ship that protects the occupants inside from the cold reaches of space, Adora’s gaze pierces the stars themselves with a breathless silent question.

“Why?”

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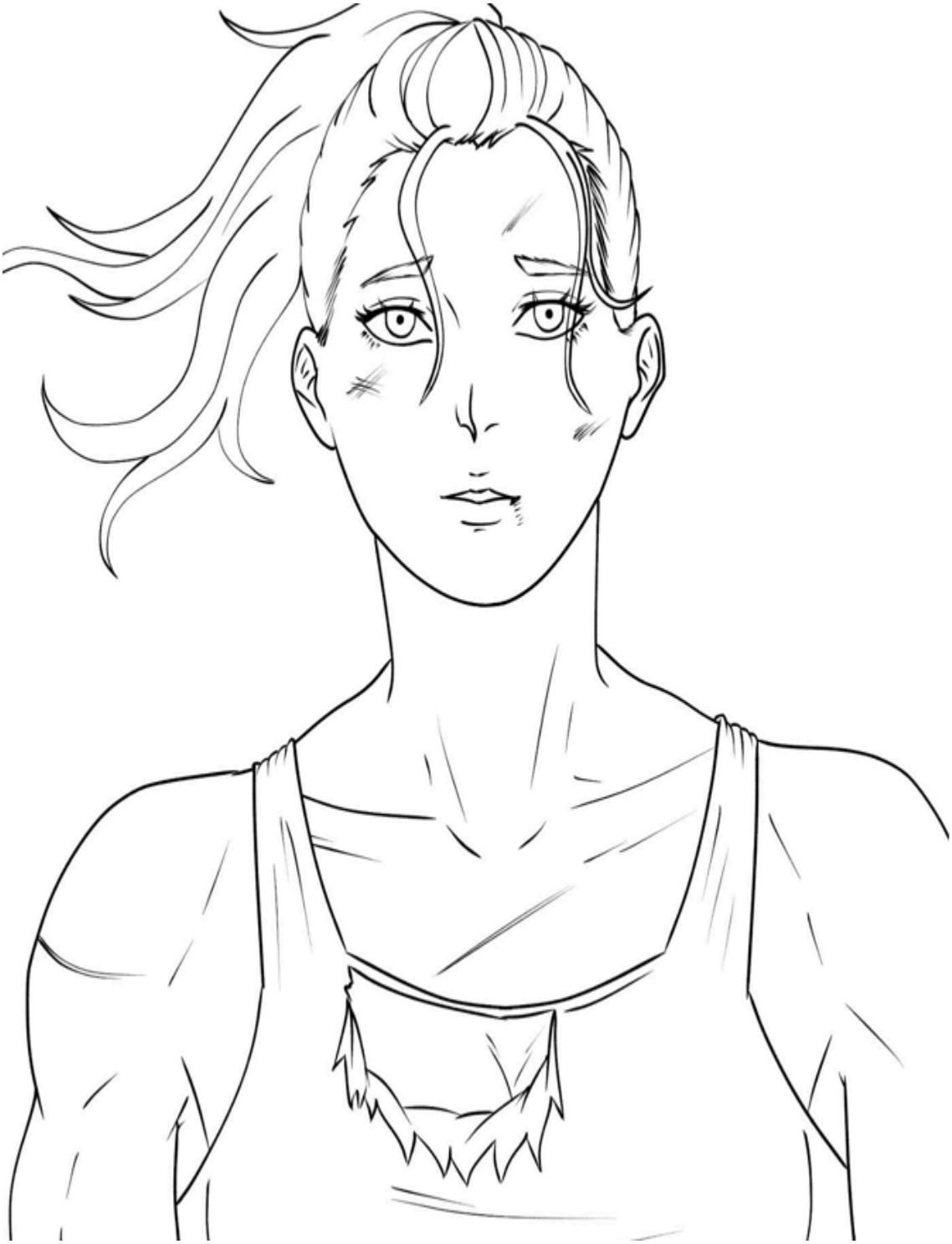
Anyway expect the next chapter to be a week and a bit away. I've gotta write it in full and after that there’ll be two more. Comments would be greatly welcome as I seriously appreciate feedback :)

IVA

Chapter IV A:

We Gotta Find Every Bit Of Strength
(That we have and never let it go)

Adora deals with reality, the BFS desperately tries to hold on together.



"I look out for you, you look out for me. Nothing really bad can happen as long we have each other"

Situation Report: Some hours after the assault on Horde Prime's temple-ship.

Catra is dead and her red jacket covered corpse is lying on the bed that Adora planned for them to take together.

Glimmer and Bow are asleep or well, *were* asleep judging by the sudden commotion.

Entrapta is still standing in front of Adora and hasn't moved since the revelation, she's muttering something to the clone and Adora is pretty sure the two of them have attempted to apologise profusely multiple times but it's on deaf distracted ears.

And her? Adora? She's pulling at strings in every direction whether they're contradictory trains of thought or her brain frantically mashing together hundreds of battleplans and situations that call for a emergency just like there but there isnt *fucking any* . She never planned for this, Catra was either going to be probably dead before they got to her since Prime would have likely executed her as an example or Glimmer would have busted her out.

Instead Adora found Catra, they fought off clones together, they held each other so tight like the past two years didnt happen and she *fucking fought* to bring Catra home. And when she did? When everything was *safe,* everyone was home free and on the ship. When Adora had patched things up with Glimmer, when Adora broke down the emotional barriers that she'd erected for two years to guard and defend herself? When she finally found that

inner strength of self and confessed her love to the only person she ever wanted?

Of course everything went to shit, of course she doesn't *get nice things.* Of course when Adora finally tries to get peace and make up, to find the person she loves and roll back her barriers that she's immediately thrust back into darkness. Of shaking limbs, of vomit, of restless nights and never ending chores.

She'll need to arrange a funeral and *bury* Catra somewhere and its only been a few minutes and *everything* is falling apart again and the world is fucking *spinning* and she needs to fucking do something and Entrapta is just standing there.

She has to contain herself, the cream shirt has gone from comfortable to claustrophobic and is pratically torn off when it constricts her rapidly spiralling out of control breathing that she's fighting to get to lower the fuck down.

Adora's still keeled over and barely able to hold herself up, on shaky limbs and shaky breath with a shaky voice when she tells Entrapta and that *fucking* clone to go. There's no verbal or body language related pushback , just two people slowly making their way out of the room with one practically deflated and the other in confusion and the lighting somehow darkens without their presence. It's already a grey atmosphere with the *bare empty walls* reflecting that and the only real color in the room is just Adora and...

Catra.

Catra is still wearing those god awful whitegreyish cultish robes that suck out individuality and replace the user with mindless conformity instead of one of her distinctive pieces that draw *attention* ,her top is mostly covered with Adora's jacket but underneath is still that whitish and disturbingly perfectly manufactured shirt, her trousers are the same, no imagination gone towards them. She's even wearing *shoes* and Adora knows clearly from years of living together that Catra *hates wearing shoes.*

Adora tries to crawl forward and use that momentum to get up but her exhausted body rebels violently with a combination of sore muscles and sheer tiredness pulling her to the side and she awkwardly fumbles over and hits the floor on her left arm, Adora rolls over and crawls instead on her arms and knees towards Catra.

"Hey..Catra" She drawls out dryly as she reaches the bottom of the bed, her gaze lingering over Catra's form as she slips the magicats shoes off, Catra may be..dead? but she doesn't deserve to be wearing something oppressive. The shoes come off with no resistance from rigid feet, there's no call out from the magicat, no recoil at such a sensitive area being touched

Oh god.

Catra really is dead isn't she?

Adora doesn't want to believe that, she wants to remain hopeful that somehow those beautiful coloured eyes will snap open in shock and greet her, that Catra's lifeless limbs will awaken and she'll bounce back into existence with that sarcasm covering wit, a

joyful tone that'll quickly pick up to their days as cadets and as best cadets. That everything'll be alright somehow and they can go home together.

Instead. Nothing. No surprise "hey i'm not dead" with a sudden jump like a childrens novelty item. No faint heartbeat in the chest or the neck or the wrist when Adora rubs fingers over them, no reaction to a pitiful amount of salty tears landing on magicat skin.

"Catra.." Adora's words fumble out of her dry throat with the texture of a cracker rather than flowing water and barely make it through a barely restrained trembling lower lip that threatens to completely destroy her resolve.

Head lolling back and forth as she struggles to stay stable, one hand holding onto and then tracing warm fingers over Catra's closet cold ones before moving up the hand, arm, upper arm, elbow, shoulder. Nothing.No matter how desperate Adora's heart *aches* for even a *sign* of *something* .

Adora croaks and with the last bit of strength remaining in her bones hauls herself upright to come face to face with a dented mirror that echoed the one she'd punched just hours ago. Or was it the same one? She couldn't, didn't know anymore nor cared in the slightest for its sudden appearance, everything is fucked anyway and she's probably hallucinating from sheer mental exhaustion.

Catra's dead and lying under her, no matter how much she wills, how much she wants. She-Ra's supposed to heal people and

where the fuck is she? Nowhere, she failed to exist when Adora could have turned the tide of battle and instead it fell to a crippled Catra to *save* the day.

She failed Catra like she failed so many others.

"I'm sorry Catra, so sorry"

When she looks up at the mirror, finally managing to wrench her gaze away from Catra there's...someone else staring back.

Someone innocent and smaller, baby fat recently discarded, bright blue eyes that'd never seen the horrors of later life. Still the same side shaves and red jacket but younger, guiltless and virginal. A cadet Adora that laughed away the troubles of the Horde life and eagerly slept in the same bed with their best friend from the age of two to eighteen and eager for a promotion. They laughed together, played together and spent almost every waking moment together. Is it a sin to desire that back? To want that person that died in her arms to somehow come back to life and encase them both in time and be transported to a place where nobody could hurt them and that they were blameless again?

When Catra was needy her tail would start thumping and then brush along Adora's arms and face, her claws extending and retracting idly with dilated pupils that became heavy purring close against Adora's body and kneading into their shared bedsheets when they were alone together where it was just the two of them against the world. It was good times, young times, innocent times.

There’s no going back, is there? No matter how much her right arm is throbbing with... *something.*

“I failed you” Catra died in her arms without her knowing, girl probably faded away to sleep with the hope that she’d wake up again in better circumstances and Adora’s inability to predict, plan and achieve her objectives in a timely manner and get it done was responsible. This is on her, she should have predicted Prime, Catra being turned. The plan was *supposed* to be simply perfect and instead it was just fucking simple.

There's tears, there's a rip in her heart and there’s rage blossoming in her arm again that she barely manages to ignore and focuses instead on the slow single tear drop that embeds itself in Catra’s mane. The ships AI Darla is muttering “Radi-something” on a sparking receiver in the captain's room but she doesn't care right now.

She failed. And it hurts so much.

There’s someone more familiar this time that stands encased in the delusional phantasmagoria image, she’s smirking to one corner of her mouth with an opened section of a head piece showing a battered but intact face. She’s wearing the coloured martial mantle of a Force Captain, a breastplate strong enough to withstand physical blows and a combination of physical and mental conditioning completes the appearance of her old rank. The terrifyingly morally grey and unquestionably loyal officer that marched straight into the Crimson Wastes with a heavy electric

staff wielded like a toy in one hand and Catra's waist held firmly in the other.

She got Kyle killed, the boy swarmed by gangers and dunked while screaming straight into quicksand to drown. Catra was there to comfort Adora that night while her former fellow Cadets face remained buried in her nightmares for three months straight. Grizzlor was next, the stubborn bastard refused help and kept fighting despite Adora's pleas for her fellow Force Captain to make a break for it while she fought valiantly to break the encirclement. He and so many other nameless and faceless Horde soldiers that relied and depended on her? Well being entangled in Catra's limbs kept her roughly sane during those dark times.

And where was she for when Catra needed her?

Right here, but unable to do anything. There's no medical technology onboard Mara's ship and She-Ra's refused to aid her. Adora failed in all three categories and that burden is heavier than any command responsibility.

That Adora, the one with the blazing red insignia and unstoppable motivated indomitable will *wouldn't* have made these mistakes, she would have sniffed out every *flaw* in the plan and adjusted accordingly. She was *strong* , *brave* and could have done this, beaten the clones to a pulp, assassinated Prime before he could teleport away and *brought* Catra back home without a sweat.

"I failed you" She repeats again as it bounces simultaneously around the empty room they share and in her head and she so desperately wants to say more but a crappy apology is all she can

manage as she tucks an errant stand of Catra's hair back into its proper place with the left arm, she doesn't want to acknowledge that her right is completely numb and there's deviant sparks flying off while that strange numbing sensation is slowing making its way to her chest.

"And I'm so sorry" Her voice is just croaky now, a few tears taking space on her trembling upper lip and she desperately wants to believe that she's just sleeping and when she wakes up this'll have been naught but a shitty nightmare. But it isnt because of fucking course, she gets to live with her *failure.* Her *broken* promises. To more than just one person.

The next Adora is one that struggled to get her footing and to figure out who she was after the sudden self-ejection from twenty years in the Horde and an *emotional dependence on someone* , an Adora saddled with great power and responsibility, one that hated the idea of being only recognized as She-Ra Princess of Power but also used the ability to simply transform into a invincible warrior at every opportunity. She was two sides of the same coin forever flipping in between a manic mental state desperately trying to hold the Rebellion; and herself together. She's wearing the iconic look that is a red jacket and cream shirt, but she's healthier, happier and with no deep permanent stress lines. Naively convinced of the righteousness of her cause and that she can get Catra back without bloodshed, win the war against Hordak and make it through.

Those two years, hopeful naivety but also the beginning of the path that would eventually set her down this route. Hardness turned soft but it never left her, only waiting in the sidelines. She relied too much on She-Ra to solve everything and when that failed, when the Rebellion broke apart under the weight of Angella's death, Adora should have been the one to fling herself into the cracks of reality and close the portal. Instead she made a

promise to Angella “take care of each other and watch over Glimmer” and instead what immediately resulted was mass infighting, deteriorating relationships and later on the erasure of She-Ra via Adora destroying the sword in a desperate attempt to stop the activation of Etheria as a planet scale bomb.

She succeeded in stopping that.
But she lost She-Ra.
She *failed* in her promise to Angella as Glimmer was teleported out of reach for *months* .

Who is Adora now? Twenty years in the Horde, eighteen as an innocent Cadet and two as a sharp and terrifying Force Captain became two more as the Rebellion's only hope, a crushing weight of responsibility that further locked her into increasing reliance on She-Ra to solve every problem no matter what it was, She-Ra was stronger, faster and basically immortal.

And when Adora broke the sword and She-Ra was gone forever?

When Prime came?

She tried.

Spinerlla died first, running into a burning town hall to save villagers, something that Adora should have planned for and already gotten them out but instead she *fucked that up* . Seahawk was next, a tragedy that also could have been avoided. Adora failed to assign enough people to his distraction force and he ended up impaled on the staff of a clone. Then came Juliet, Brightmoons primary general that threw herself into the path of two clones to protect Adora when she overextended her battleline.

Deaths that could have been avoided, a lack of perfect planning and sloppy execution. Her fault, her responsibility.

The cracks in the mirror reflect that, cracked and bloodshot blue eyes that hadn't seen proper sleep in days, wiry veined muscles that had shrunk slightly by a combination of exhaustion and malnutrition, hair split in every way and end possible. A bone tired, depleted and spent fatigued Adora. She’s constantly ricocheting from terrifyingly frozen hypothermia to blazing skin melting hyperthermia. And bouncing between several different things at once as her physical,mental and emotional tasking is stretching to the point of snapping and being completely overwhelmed.

She wants to be as *strong* as the twenty year old Force Captain Adora, one that threw people around and shrugged off electric batons, she wishes she was as *brave* as Cadet Adora that stood up to people despite being so much thinner and smaller than the older Cadets. She desires even to have the ability back that rebellion Adora did, the She-Ra summoning that pulled her out of many a tight spot.

But instead, it’s just her, no *strength* left in a weakened and twitching body , no *bravery* or else Catra would have lived and She-Ra is fucking gone *forever* . She’s disappointed with herself for letting so many die when it should have been her, she’s angry that it’s come to this point.

I look out for you, you look out for me. Nothing really bad can happen as long we have each other

But most of all, its regret. It's tearful, sobbing, lip trembling and limb shaky regret that has Adora fall to her knees once more next to Catra's upper body, its with regret and a failed promise when Adora holds Catra's lifeless body in her arms and tucks the girls head under hers and embraces the magicats upper torso.

"I'm so sorry Catra, I promised you that cottage and a home you could have, with me if you wanted"

She chokes and closes her eyes shut, that sparkling is in almost every part of her body now ,while she can't see she instead imagines soft purring that used to come from Catra during those happy days then maybe she can fool herself into believing this is real.

Adora wants Catra to live, surely that must mean something?

She imagines the uncomfortable set of clothes that She-Ra wore and attempts to mate it to herself once again, just like she did when transforming the runestone sword into a different object.

"Catra.." She breathes out and hugs her magicat tighter and not letting go for anything.

The militaristic upbringing of the Horde mated with the First Ones aspect, a buttoned up stuffy top and impractical shoulder blades.

"I want you" All the way from her knuckles down to her feet and the back of her neck hiss and fizz with something, a glowing aura is penetrating through her closed vision and she wills with every fibre of her being. To bring She-Ra back,once last time.

A skirt with open and bare legs, elements of uncovered femininity that she was never comfortable with.

She buries her face straight into the remains of Catra's mane, letting the tears and sniffles go free as she forces herself to speak even if it's hoarse. "To please live"

She's trying to fit the form like the other She-Ra's, a golden and overt tiara with long uncontrolled flowing hair. She knows deep down its not her but she's fucking trying.

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

If not for her, then for Catra. For someone who deserved life and love, a home away from pain and abuse. She fucking wants that, not to be all powerful but to make sure others can live their own. Is that so hard?. The glowing aura is getting so bright that if she

opens her eyes she’s sure she’ll go blind. It’s like there's a second skin surrounding her, ready and waiting to be worn. Or maybe it's behind her like a gathering ball of energy or something, she doesn't know what it is, only that it's *there.*

But she broke the sword. And ended the line of She-Ra forever.

But she hated being She-Ra. Self doubt made her clunky and awkward then and it's chipping-no wrenching away at the confidence and clear clarity she badly needs to do this.

But she felt like an imposter inhabiting a body rather than being at one. People expected She-Ra instead of Adora and even the Rebellion...wanted the princess.

The spell breaks and she’s back to square one, the spectacular aura has gone although it disappeared over Catra last before sinking into either the skin or the bedsheets.

Adora holds her breath anyway and dares to open her eyes.

“Catra?” Is all she manages, it's a fleeting whisper on the wind that is quickly blown away.

Nothing happened, Catra is still stiff in her grasp and there's no breathing.

She failed. The runestone embedded in the sword performed the healing work for the Seagate, Glimmer and even Shadow-Fucking-

Weaver. And that's broken, gone forever. Just like She-Ra.

Of course, even Rebellion Adora managed it, Captain Adora would have somehow been physically to simply grasp the magical aura by the collar and told it to fucking stay and Cadet Adora'd be too safe for She-Ra to be needed. She hauls herself upwards again, gently letting Catra down on the mattress with care.

Adora peers in the mirror again, sighs and combs battered fingers through unkempt and damaged light blonde hair, the wounds she took from the electric stun baton need to be addressed at some point with the nerves in her chest and back sending painful warning signals that *it isn't just* a pair of flesh wounds.

She's tired, she's achy, she's erratically twitchy.

Somehow Adora looks even worse than before, deep red lines present and scratched over exposed skin. Fabric of the grey tanktop sticking uncomfortably into her body through a combination of sweat, tears and damage, she's pretty sure that there's at least a few bruises from being thrown around and whacked with stun batons underneath. She sighs, rubs her forehead and slowly starts to comb through a checklist, a battleplan, something to do and keep herself awake in the multiple day travel it'll take to get back to Etheria.

She drops her gaze from the mirror to Catra below. She wishes and wants but she'll never get. This is something she *cant fix* and its fucking... *unfair.*

The hair on the back of her neck signals it first, a lesser form of hyper vigilance and conditioning alerts her senses and she’s made quite clear and aware that there's someone standing behind her, someone tall, big and bulky.

Probably the clone, she hasn't made visual contact through the mirror.

“Get out”

Weird that she hadn't heard the door open or close.

They’re still there. Dumbass clone probably isn't used to being around actual living people.

“Out, not in the mood”

Still no movement, it’s a weird feeling like she’s being touched all over by pin pricking feathers.

Alright.

She doesnt turn around and instead turns her eyes back to the mirror to make contact with the large figure standing behind it.

She squints, makes a second pass, a third opinion. Blinks and refreshes.

It’s not the clone. It’s not white but it’s tall, it’s head is almost touching the ceiling and absolutely dwarfs her.

It’s a shiver first, then hair sticking up. A few seconds, one two three and a full body reaction that skips panicked induced flight and redirects energy from sheer shock induced momentary paralysis from the brain that struggles to process *what the fuck is happening* and instead kicks every single button as hard as fucking possible at lightning fast speeds to produce an immediate conditioned fight response that’s been honed and perfected over twenty two years.

It's the *thing* in her nightmares, the one that has her back towards Adora and ends every nightmare the same way;by turning around. Except...it's horrifyingly contradictory this time because the golden haired ponytail woman that’s more than two metres tall is staring right at her back because Adora can make out the forehead in the mirror. And right now her heart is going absolutely fucking apeshit and she’s-

There’s a knife in her hand manifested from panic. It’s weighty and sharp. And her arm feels funny.

The fight reaction comes from conditioning, years of fighting for Horde and then against it and the inability to turn and run propels her bodys expeditious response, her left arm already compensating and judging for aiming stabilisation and automatically judging height, distance and weight even while she’s fucking blinded by the golden light with a face that’s too obscuring to make out. Adora shuts her eyes to get herself away from the

sheer fucking visual apocalypse and turns around, throws the knife as hard as she can, it whistles through the hail and *clinks* into *something.*

One second, she keeps her eyes shut.

Five seconds, same.

Ten seconds, a tentative opening reveals that the figure is gone, the door is still closed. Weird. Maybe she was really hallucinating this time, the post stress, Catra’s death and everything else lumped together probably made this happen.

She wheels back to gaze at a bare wall, the bare wall that held the mirror just now. There's no sign or indication that anything ever existed on this bulkhead. Still it lends further credence and proof about her hallucinating theory.

Except.

There’s a hole in the wall when she looks back at the door's direction, its knife shaped and hit hard enough and recent that it's practically fresh.

Except there’s no knife.

And there's still a hole when she actually touches it and feels around the edges.

It's proof.

Confirmation.

Was there someone or *something?* she threw a knife at.

That then disappeared.

And so did the knife.

The only knife she’s held today is still stuck in a clone's wrist an hour's walk away.

Oh god. There's a slither crack in the door, normally unnoticeable but not for Adora’s increasingly paranoia fueled hyper aware state . *Someone* must have opened it.

Radiation Signature No Longer Detected.

She’s edgy, she’s twitching, she’s shaking uncontrollably as her mind desperately attempts to logically wrap around the impossible.

That those nightmares are no longer that, they’re real and they *were* in the same room. Someone or something was. And those barriers? She can't hold them at bay anymore.

She’s starting to spiral, the walls are coming down and the river that holds the safe is drying up.

Adora fucking screams.

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Her head and thoughts are constantly bouncing around between a hundred different things, too many threads of thought and ideas to reach out and catch, there's a checklist of items that need to be sorted and *fixed.* Her heartbeat is starting to race again and palpating slowly out of control. She’s gone from being able to control her breathing to needing to lurch over.

She promised to make things up with Glimmer, Glimmer doesn't know that Shadow Weaver is dead and that the situation is so utterly fucked on Etheria that three weeks may not even be enough to even figure out a way to win, she’ll have to break that news to everyone.

She’s a Horde ship stuck by a jury rigged energy cannon, half of the damage control party are killed before they can muster and the captain is screaming orders to flood the magazines before they detonate from encroaching fires and to get the reactor functioning before they capize from flooding.

Eye twitching, dry mouth, no more tears but she’d rather cry than deal with the oncoming wave of gut splitting nausea. She needs time to figure this out, to fix things but there is no fucking time. And her grip on the chair is getting tighter.

Ragged shallow breaths that have her heaving, memories of Catra laughing, Catra stretching her legs on machinery and pipe while bouncing to high spot to high spot she’s happy and smiling and calling for Adora to follow but everytime Adora catches up it’s

Catra on the bed, dead and in the full knowledge that Adora *broke so many promises.*

There's a ball suspended above a bottomless well on nothing but string.

She's got so much work to do when she gets back, no sleep allowed. Only items to fix in a never ending cycle.

Someone's cutting through the string and the ball is starting to lower and lower to dropping.

Etheria is over *there* and she's *here* , worst case scenarios are already starting to be planned for and adjusted, her previous actions are lined up like a slideshow of "things Adora fucked up", she should have planned for Prime to teleport and killed him *immediately* , for Entrapta only doing minimal damage and found a way to provide her with something that could have done *more,* she should have known about Catra or expected it or had Glimmer with her, all of this is her fault and she could have *fixed it.* And that thread that she's hanging onto *continues to thin out* with her accelerated self destructive thinking.

The sword and its healing runestone is destroyed, She-Ra as she knows her is gone forever, the Crystal Castle and Light Hope is destroyed and there goes that opportunity to somehow rig the planet to teleport again, three weeks will not be enough to find a new control centre (if it even exists) considering they'll have to *somehow* fight through the gangs of the Crimson Waste , the remains of the splintered Horde that's become a hundred different

factions under a hundred different Force Captains *and* deal with a raging refugee crisis and how many more thousands of clones were dropped off and rampaging around the country while they were gone. Not to mention figure out the line of succession since the King of Bright Moon is back and Glimmer doesnt know he is.

And it's *three* weeks from *now.* And it's a guess at best, it’s a ticking timebomb that she can't control no matter how hard she tries to figure out a situation where she can *fix* things.

It’s too much.

Too much to handle, if she had Catra with her then maybe but Catra died in her arms and she didn't even know.

Tight fingers proclaim the weird experience that she’s crushing something but the horrifying prospect of a funeral for Catra is infinitely more alarming and pressing.

Oh god.

A funeral.For Catra.

She’s..

Adora isn't quite sure of how to process that, they grew up together from two to twenty,fought side by side and remained on opposite sides and all she ever wanted was her best friend back and when it finally happened it was a bittersweet hour and a bit. Just, what? ninety minutes?

It’s sobering, a heart stopping slap from reality in the face that manages to temporarily short circuit her brain's runaway ride of a checklist and remind her that she.

That she-

Lost someone today. Someone she cared about, *no.* Loved.

And that it’ll be a lonely ride to Etheria, no cottage to look forward to with an end in sight, just endless pitched battles and sleepless nights, seeing squads as statistics and trying to add and subtract in the right places so the inevitable casualties will mean *something.*

Does Adora really want to go back to Etheria?

It’s not a checklist that she can hold out in one hand and cross out sentences with a red line, it's a massive wall facing in all directions, like she’s at the bottom of the well. It’s unbearable, unscalable and too much.

Well it would have been bearable and perhaps able to have been scaled if someone was here to help, someone who understood Adora, someone who tried and cared.

But they’re over *there* , and not *here.*

Her hands come free and it’s holding something, a chunk?

A man’s voice from the left interrupts Adora’s spiralling monologue.

It’s Bow. Still in ripped clothing and battered.

“Hey Adora how-”

He stops dead mid sentence and when they make eye contact, Bow seems to be processing something for a second and then speaks again, this time with more confusion than worry.

“Adora, why-. Why-Adora. How. Adora-I what is that in your hand?”

Looking down to observe her arm which she brings it up, Adora notes that it's sort of glowing, the veins are bulging and sparks are flowing out of the skin and disappearing mid air like Glimmer's magic.

While it’s very much like the last two failed times she tried to transform into She-Ra which is a disturbingly normal *thing* , it's the unnerving shaking fingers that are holding a part of the captain's chair in her palm that is *different.*

She ripped it off.

With just her fingers.

What?

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She’s lying on her back and everything is kinda...lopsided when her eyes start to function again when streaks of black obstructing vision peels back a little to reveal something, something that she wasn't expecting.

Someone,no. *two* voices are echoing from above and beside in a familiar language but it might as well be completely underwater because she’s *elsewhere* right now. Adora is back in the Fright Zone but it's not in the perspective of a previous person, she’s motionless and paraylsed in the middle of the cadet barracks with her head turned to one side and eyes locked directly on the back of a small figure huddled in a blanket. There’s quiet faint sobbing and then a small version of herself runs past to confront the figure.
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She remembers this memory only faintly, she remembers the drab smell of processed food, whirring machinery from every direction and flat beds that hurt the back if you don't sleep on them directly.

And Catra, a little one with spiky hair, short limbs and wet blue and yellow orbs that was expecting someone else, she's just covered up in her blue blanket and still wearing tattered old red and white hand-me-downs, expecting either more abuse from Shadow Weaver or being teased by other cadets and she automatically responds with a sad pathetic kitten hiss that's nothing more than a dejected attempt at "leave me alone" when kid Adora gently pulls the blanket down, while the words the two exchange are lost to history via foggy memory. Adora *definitely remembers* that heartbreaking sound that later in life she figured out was because even early on as a small child Catra was routinely physically and emotionally tortured by Shadow Weaver.

And it started little less than an hour ago in this room.

Even now it's heartbreaking to watch, to remember. Right now adult Adora just wants to scoop up little Catra in her arms and hold her tight, plant a soothing kiss on her forehead and reassure her everything'll be okay. Catra never deserved this and its as painfully obvious as simple writing on the wall.

Adora remembers that unhappy face on an already depressed kitten, she'll never forget that Catra immediately switched from miserable to clingy when the kitten realised that it was *her Adora* .

The crying stopped, the ears perked up and the tip of a small tail tried to wrap around a wrist.

She was Catra's safety net all that time, she initially believed was just clinginess or Catra's introverted nature to being either unable or unwilling to make friends or socialise as well as Adora could, It only was years later and a cold introspection during scant downtime in the Rebellion that Adora at twenty one realised that even as Toddlers she was already Catra's entire world and of course it'd only kick in too late after she left Catra to *be on her own* .

She should have realised it sooner, she could have attempted to fix things. To confront Shadow Weaver during her tenure as a rising star and *fix* Catra's issues, she *should* have made more of a fucking *effort* and the bile rising in her throat, the strains of anger in her veins threading into muscle sinew. Self directed anger at purely herself, at her failed *responsibility.*

Toddler Adora is comforting kitten Catra, she cautiously touches the kitten gently, gives soothing pats and ear rubs and they eventually run off somewhere.

But there's something else that happens before that, something that's plagued Adora for decades.

The words spoken here at this moment in time have never been forgotten and have lingered in the back of Adora's head as a constant reminder ever since, three short lines that were taken as gospel for two decades by two girls and later adults.

It’s those words that instead of being received through normal auditory means are instead fired directly into her brain and bring back the worst and most painful thoughts. They’re cold venom injected into hot limbs and *freeze* her body, even if it's for a few pounding and unforgettable seconds.

Toddler Adora clutches kitten Catra’s hand in hers with a soft squeeze and utters *those words.* She’s already assuming a mantle of responsibility even then, as a *fucking child* .

“Nothing really bad can happen as long as we have each other?”

“You promise?” Comes the response from a depressed kitten that only ever wanted her favourite person.

“I promise” Two words, a shock of the system, an emergency wake up call. A promise gone unfulfilled.

It hurts because she failed, it hurts because Adora can't fix it.

It hurts because she broke that promise and Catra is dead.

It hurts and that thread is thinning *more and more.*

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

When she wakes up, half reeling from repressed emotional whiplash and bewilderment regarding yet another *hallulicatio* n, Adora eventually starts to life in her limbs and is able to wiggle her fingers and toes. She's caught between two states of mind, the mind that wants to kill someone and the mind that's caught in the past. She's also still sort of underwater but the surface is approaching rapidly if the two voices coming slowly clearer with each word and from either side is anything to go by.

Light filters in, she blinks rapidly at the sudden change of brightness and groans.

The two voices speak again as once in worried format and there's a hand gripping on each of her shoulders and she's being pulled up.

"Adora?"

"Wha?" Is all she's able to muster in response, head still reeling from before and while the sudden burst of energy from before is enough to keep her somewhat conscious her body is still screaming for actual sleep.

When she can make out objects, it's the familiar grey interior roof of Mara's militaristic styled ship with exposed wiring and pipes from either age or hurried recent maintenance. When she

manages to crane her neck from side to side, it's afro buzz black hair on the right and a pinkish bob on the left. The stark contrast of bright tones are almost welcoming compared to either desolate gun metal or cultish colours

She struggles at first to transition from a disorientated state to a slow gear change that brings up the fact that she *should know* these people.

"Bow? Glimmer?" Adora asks wondering if this is going to be another fucking *hallulicatio* n of her close friends, or used to be. The multiple confrontations with Glimmer as queen that turned into outright screaming matches are back in force and weigh depressingly heavy on her mind and joins the growing list of shit that she *fucked up.*

"It's us, you alright?" Glimmer answers first, lightly pinching Adora's shoulders and then moving to hoist her up with one hand on her shoulder and the other on an elbow.

"Bow help her" There's grunting from the other side with stronger hands hauling her up.

"M'fine" Adora replies weakly, she doesn't make any resistance at all and is dragged instead of pulled to her feet when Bow and Glimmer realise how heavy she is and that they're also *fucking* tired.

A minute goes by and Adora's slumped passively and tiredly against a bulkhead, Glimmer and Bow sitting in front together as they make idle but whispered conversation, as her vision and senses fully return from disorientating darkness that clouded the edge of her vision. *God* it's a sigh of fucking relief when she realises that she isnt imagining things anymore and that two of her best friends, people that she's relied on and have had her back are actually *real* this time and infront of *her* .

Adora pinches herself just above the waistline to make sure, right at the edge of a likely forming purple bruise from a stun baton, thankfully her grey tank top covers it up, although her bare arms, shoulders and collarbone are likely displaying an array of red scratches,faded wounds and marks from being tossed, thrown around, punched, damage from blunt force objects and a few punctures from Catra's kneading...when she was still alive.

It's ironic isn't it? Her stand out red jacket are covering Catra with, whose *fucking dead* while she's the one that's in colourless grey and grey trousers and grey boots (she had to swap out the red shoes), she'd laugh but it'd be mirthless and devoid of humor and would probably draw more worried attention to her from Bow and Glimmer.

Speaking of the two, its evident that they've just as exhausted as she is, although while the ripped clothing, rapidly blinking eyes and disheveled appearances are the same as before, it's the subtle glances, body movement that includes fingertips touching and shoulders leaning towards each other that confirms that

Glimmer and Bow were probably *doing something* in their room before Adora happened.

She’s had enough training either learnt, voluntary or forced to be able to pick on such small details like *that* , Adora is *happy* that she can confirm to herself that Bow and Glimmer are actually a couple now, they’ve been painfully pining for each other since they ambushed her in the Whispering Woods with the mad rush to She-Ra swords.

There is a part of her, a recent hole in the heart that longs for things to be different, that she and Catra would be in the same place Glimmer and Bow were in, that they’d have their own room and be disordered and tangled. But Catra’s dead, and while Adora tried her fucking dammdest to bring Catra back it was not to be, she couldnt fix it.

Still, she wishes for Bow and Glimmer to remain as they are, glowing appearances while they’re around each other and for them to get married, become King and Queen and have lots of receptions and meetings and children or whatever it is royalty does. In her mind’s eye she can just imagine a small future if this is ever over.

Hope, just a tiny piece that’s somehow still alive and kicking after everything that’s happened briefly re emerges in her heart with a painted picture that’s a little foggy and harsh on the details but there’s Adora in the conference room advising on a minor political matter, there’s Bow and Glimmer in the garden with their kids and...other people there too but she can't quite make them out, they’re all fuzzy. Actually she can't quite make herself out either,

it's more of a birds eye or a casual observer and when Adora tries to find the third figure that’s supposed to be her,it’s just static.

Somehow it's relaxing enough to briefly take the edge off. Remove tension in the shoulders, cancel stiffness and make that purple bruise a little less painful.

Briefly.

The idea of such a peacetime situation occurring is *near unfathomable* for someone like Adora who's been raised as a child soldier and spent her entire adult life fighting and there’s also the fact that Catra wouldn't be there…

“Adora?” The sound of her name rolling off the tongue of someone near to her pulls Adora out of her inner monologue.

“Wha?”

“Are you alright, we’re worried. About you?” Bow spoke, his arm around Glimmer’s shoulders with the expression on his face directly mirroring his words.

Adult pulls herself up against the bulkhead so she isn't slouched anymore. “I’m here?” She admits.

“We heard a door open, raised voices and Entrapta ran out with Wrong Hordak and-”

“We’re sorry about Catra, I know she meant a lot to you” Glimmer added solemnly. “When I was being held prisoner we talked about you a few times and I honestly believe that she was remorseful about everything”.

Adora nodded, squeezing her thumbs in between her fingers rather than make eye contact.

“Thank you” She said quietly.

“I mean it, Adora, she. I think-.” Glimmer hesitated for a second and looked shly over to Bow who nodded and squeezed at her shoulder in support.

“I’m really sorry that she’s gone but she didn't die alone, she missed you and I-” Glimmer’s voice broke for a few seconds and then a small choke came out instead of words, Bow comforted her silently.

It went on for a few moments, Glimmer biting her lip and probably digesting her own thoughts and feelings regarding the *Catra situation.* She didn't know Catra in the same way Adora did, only ever seeing her on the battlefield as an enemy so having that person suddenly turn around and near sacrifice themselves for you? Well Adora’s pretty sure there’s at least some emotional whiplash that the queen is coming to terms with , Adora is still trying to fully come to terms with it herself.

“So Entrapta and the Clone?” She asked tentatively to bring the subject onto something she would rather understand ,to get the full picture of things basically. It’s better than letting her mind wander and to *focus* on *something.*

Bow nods again, there’s bags under his eyes and he stifles a yawn.

“Glimmer?”

The queen gives her approval to continue, tiredly.

“Yeah, sure”

Bow cracks his right shoulder and knuckles before continuing, he looks over from where Adora’s room is and over to Entrapta’s up to probably jog his memory, he’s sleepy, Glimmers sleepy, t *hey’re all sleepy.*

“So they both ran out of your room and shut the door, we had to corner Trapta’ to spill and she told us about *y’know* ” Bow starts.

“We kinda went through processing for a couple' minutes, the Clone was raving about Prime and Trapta’ kept pacing everywhere and repeated that she was sorry *over and over* again to everything *but us”* Glimmer took the reins on the conversation

next, she looked a little shell shocked but Adora couldn't blame her really, she'd seen enough of that during her short time alive.

She also couldn't blame Entrapta either, the girl was always shit at socialisation and she may have been a bit too hard on her for simply relaying her findings, Adora'd need to add "talking to Entrapta" to the growing checklist. Actually just thinking about the list of things to do is *headache* painful.

"And after?" She adds.

Bow gulps, points to the captain's chair, Adora's hand and then the place she was previously knocked out on.

"We heard something like a banging, you were saying something and then the door slammed open. It uh, Darla was making a alert and we had to check on everything and then found you like you were but with a piece of that chair in your hands"

"After that you passed out for about five minutes ,eventually woke up and here we are?"

Bow scratched the back of his hand and chuckled nervously. "Probably missed out on a bunch of shit but running on empty I guess?"

Adora swallowed dryly and nodded. "Same, thank you though. I-I appreciate it."

The three of them give a tri-mutual but awkward smile that turns into a sad grimace , Adora didn't need mind reading powers to know what the other two were thinking, they probably wanted to know how she wrenched metal off with her bare hands but truth be told she didn't know.

"Anyway, I think we've overstayed our welcome here" Bow started and clapped his knees and made to get up.

Glimmer made to do the same and murmured. "Yeah, back to Etheria" Adora was about to start processing that they were going to head back and leave Prime's ship forever with a dead Catra in tow when the familiar droning sound of Mara's ship's AI clicked an announcement.

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

And then something falls from the left, from Adora's room and it hits the floor with a thump audible enough for it to pass through the door that's open with a slight crack and comes out with a slight echo.

Time,and the trio froze for a second.

“I’ll check it out,” Bow announced without any fanfare.

“I-” Adora began but Bow immediately cut her off with a sad expression that said ‘you shouldn't do anymore, let me handle it’. Glimmer followed and they both went into that room and left Adora on the floor with her thoughts again.

Truth be told, she didn't want to head back. That meant dealing with the checklist of things to do, plans to be made and overarching strategy to discuss, it meant breaking up fights and doing her damndest to hold everyone together, it meant funerals, it meant war. Etheria no longer represented a welcoming home to kick off her shoes and relax by a fireplace while marvelling that a waterfall wasn’t a shower.

The concept of Etheria that her consciousness imagined was colder now after recent events, it constituted a endless work schedule , sleepless nights and forever looking back on today and wondering where she went *wrong* and b *eating* herself up when no one was *looking* in a effort to *punish* herself for making *mistakes* and not being able to fix things.

She’d rather stay in Prime’s ship and-

Out of the corner of her eye there’s visible but not *audible* movement, her bare hands go from resting on her knees to by her side via an automatic reflex reaction in a instant and when the pattern recognition part of her brain kicks into gear and registers there’s golden light right at the edge of her peripheral vision, it’s hair, a shoulder pad and a person (or thing?) whose very presence

has gone from outright haunting Adora in nightmares to stalking her in person from behind.

Except this time, they’re making direct.eye.contact and even though Adora can't make out the beings face it’s obvious where their eyes are. And its absolutely fucking horrifyingly chilling to experience.

Her muscles go haywire and nearly seize with the sudden spike of adrenaline for the sixth time in a row today and half of her body completely fails in a clumsy attempt to get to her feet and instead she lands on her side but never fails to break eye contact. For once everything is clear and she can focus entirely on one *simple thing* . Adora staggers upwards and uses the sharp point of the knife in her hand as support with a *funny feeling* in that *arm again* . She wants answers, she wants to know what the fuck is happening, she’s raised and ready and rearing to go and after everything that’s happened she’s fucking desperate for something concrete. No illusions or hallucinations bullshit this time.

The figure is still looking at her, they’re near the same three metre height as Prime but that doesn't stop her as she slowly advances forward on a pair of kneecaps that tremble and pop with every determined but unsteady step that leave her wavering from side to side.

“Adora?” Glimmer’s quiet voice bursts through an eardrum and it *hurts.*

“Wha-?” Adora makes contact with her two friends as they stand completely shocked in the doorway of her room, she glances back and forth rapidly from them to the figure and expects all three to be there every time but *one* is missing.

The golden figure is gone, and there’s a knife in her hands. The greyblade dagger with a purple finish in the centre and perfectly balanced is still there, it’s the same one that she threw into the wall and it promptly disappeared, it's an exact copy of the backup weapon she used to sleep with and the one that is still embedded in a dead clone's wrist.

Bow and Glimmer’s look go to her, to her knife and back to her. They don't say anything, their mouths are open and expression’s confused.

This is absolute definitive proof that she isn't hallucinating.

“A-adora?”

Just hearing her name in that *quiet voice* , an echoing reminder of when Glimmer as Queen back on Etheria tried to get her attention after a fight snaps Adora back to full reality and everything hurts again, the bruises burn, lacerations are back to lingering along her nerves in pain and she’s got a small headache again.

“Are you alright?” Concerning and confused words come from the couple *sort of* hit her and registers and she briefly does wonder, is

she alright?

But the knife, dagger, weapon, is still in her hand. Solid and intact, weighty and throwable like she just picked it up from a physical sheath to test how it feels.

Introspection goes away, Adora stays unsteady on her feet as the mounting evidence and proof circulate into a conclusion.

"I don't know," Adora admits to Bow and Glimmer.

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Sorry about the wait, I'm getting started on the second part of this chapter tomorrow and I super-duper hope I'll have it up for next week, I also redid the summary for the fic and added in a small sentence before every chapter as a short introduction.

Anyway, we're getting close to the end now. Five out of eight chapters done since this will be (again) a two parter and then just two to go.

Thank you all for reading, your feedback is always appreciated :) Tell me how I'm doing with the A N G S T? :D
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IVB

Chapter IV B:

We Gotta Find Every Bit Of Strength

(That we have and never let it go)

The BFS is split.

The fate of Etheria rests on just ten crucial minutes.

The last Force Captain makes a decision.

This represents the original halfway point so if you're currently reading through the fic and have somewhere to be, go to bed, get some rest etc and come back when you've got time

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The debate on Shadow Weaver's fate is raging between them, Glimmer is stubbornly standing her ground and unknowingly fueling the fire manifesting in Adora's heart..

"She's from the Horde and she's evil, Adora! Evil people never change "

“I’m from the Horde, Former Force Captain here? Remember?” Adora bites back with an angry scowl and pointing to where her badge used to be on her chest.

“They kill people!”

“And I don't?!”

“You’re not like them Adora”

“What the fuck is that supposed to mean? why can't they?”

“That’s different Adora, you changed but..” Bow steps in to mediate between the two, probably sensing the tempers flaring but this is the wrong time for him to do so.

“You’re good and kind and-”

“And She-Ra?” Adora finishes Bow’s sentence with an icy glare and transforms the rope in her other hand into the Sword of Restoration to make her point.

"I was just like the rest of them, I was a Force Captain for two years remember?. But I left, and maybe they can too" Adora's mouth and brain worked in tandem before her heart could, it very much wished to replace "they" with "Catra" because despite everything that's occurred, there's still a small bit of hope that Catra'll see the light just like Adora somehow managed to.

Neither Bow or Glimmer say anything, they go from making eye contact to awkward glances at the ground.

"That's what I thought" Adora mumbles to herself as she marches off towards Shadow Weaver's "prison" . The self doubt and traumatic memories that sparked an identity crisis during her first few months in the Rebellion and being referred to as She-Ra rather than Adora are nipping at her heels and trying to climb up her legs again. That she wouldn't have been accepted for her skills or former position, that she was only worth something because of some destiny bullshit .

Deep down is the inevitable truth clawing at her core, that in some twisted and ironic way that despite all they claim to be, with their noble goals and fancy parties and glamorous titles.

When it came to the topic of Adora?

When the Rebellion found her,they acted just like Shadow Weaver did and focused on the power,not the person. They wanted She-Ra.

Not Adora.

Has She-Ra returned?

In a way they’re back to where they started. In the captain's room of Mara’s ancient spaceship, Adora in the centre quietly brooding to herself while Bow and Glimmer are off to the side in conversation and Entrapta is fawning over *something* . It’d be like they time traveled except for some notable differences.

There’s a clone that follows Entrapta around like a lost puppy.

Bow and Glimmer have had the shit kicked out of them, but Glimmer is excited with the new found news and Bow is alternating between also freaking out and attempting to be supportive.

Adora has lost her two pieces of distinctive clothing and her hair poof has devolved into a loose cluttered mess of split ends and post electrostatic. And there's a magical dagger in her hand.

It’s a quiet irony that seems to be lost on everyone else, it's a cold realisation and a hard kick to a bloated gut, for Adora anyway.

Catra is dead in the other room, there was a hard thump on the floor that led the couple to investigate and while Adora would ask

what it was, there seems to be more *pressing concerns.*

And apparently given pieces of evidence, Adora's display of unnatural strength in ripping metal apart, the dagger and the fact that her arm was glowing a minute ago. She-Ra has apparently returned.

It takes a few moments for it to sink in, Adora's still but unstable frame that is supported more on the left leg than the other with one hand clutching a dagger conjured out of thin air and the other slowly making its way up to her hurting head to prop it up.

Glimmer's face is scrunched up and she took the shortest amount of time to come to her senses and start making conclusions out of everyone present, she's been gone for months and wasn't privy or experienced the catastrophic breakdown of Etheria and The Rebellion when the true Horde invaded or Adora struggling to stay on the same level of efficiency without She-Ra.

Bow and Entrapta are next, Bow's response is more nuanced and in a way *sadder* while Glimmer is rooted to the spot and simply *pointing* at the weapon *,* Bow has already made his way round his girlfriend and nearer to a seemingly frozen Adora.

Entrapta, predictably has more effort directed to the hole in the captain's chair and a magic dagger than she is with Adora, or maybe that's just her coping mechanism for what happened earlier.

And Adora?

"Bow are you fucking *seeing* this? Holy fucking shit!. Trapta!? Get t-the thing, the. Fuck me, holy shit we've got her?"

"Adora, are you alright? You've gone pale and shaking?"

Entrapta doesn't say anything and is instead *peering.*

Whatever else they're saying is getting lost to auditory translation and goes from simple jumbling together of unreadable sentences to quiet echo's as the walls of Adora's reality close in or the room she's standing in has its only door slowly closing and taking away the hallway light.

Glimmer's excitement and bouncing like she's forgotten being tired and the weary role of queen has disappeared and instead the quirky and unconventional teenager is back, fawning at the very real possibility of Etheria's prime princess's return.

Entrapta has started measuring the hole and the piece of the chair that's lying on the ground and comparing it with the same of Adora's hand, when Adora manages to painfully crane her neck in slow motion and lip read the scientists words in the distorted fish-eye view than normal, she can just make out that Trapta' is

remarking on that “the fingers are too small to grasp” or whatever that means.

There is light touches on her shoulders, grasping brown fingers trying to get her attention and when she does manage to wrench herself away with far more effort than what would be required for a simple head turn,it’s Bow’s face looking back, expression worried, lips moving and his hands gently shaking her.

He’s saying something but the sensory perception of it is all wrong, he’s standing in spitting distance but her churning vision and cognitive processes has him tall and thin like string and not *Bow* .

“What?” She croaks back and even her own words are... *off.*

Whatever Bow is replying with is lost to her, she’s underwater again and her normal ability to multitask at frighteningly efficiency is compromised and has stopped working, all she can do is *think* . *Barely* .

Or attempt to.

Put the pieces together, construct a timeframe, *establish and organize.*

But she cant, it’s all jumbled up and wrangled together, illogical and stupid. It makes no sense.

"Why?" Adora speaks quietly to herself and even Bow for how physically close he is can only barely hear that one simple word.

Is She-Ra back? After all this time, after all she's been through? She what? Gets to sneak back into Adora's life like nothing ever happened and save the day like a mythical hero of old and simply throw her enemies aside with little effort and liberate Etheria forever with her stupid outfit and giant mobile runestone sword?

It's unfair. Adora is already resenting the attention She-Ra will get from the population, the princesses and everyone in between, she's an icon sure. An actual *thousand of* years old hero that's supposed to save the world. But what about Adora? She tried and nearly broke herself, she made sacrifices, she's watched her friends get killed, she's seen her battlelines collapse under a tidal wave of bodies, she's fought day and night and Adora has lost so much including the person she loved.

Adora tried to summon the *bitch* twice in the last four hours and her cries for help went unanswered, instead it'll be back to Etheria and *business as usual* . Like her previous self, Adora'll be forced to rely on She-Ra like a crutch and that part of her that she never asked for will receive all the credit, all the applause and be celebrated.

If she wants to go back to Etheria that is. Given what it represents right now, aka dealing with problems and fighting fires, burying Catra and having her hard fought achievements overshadowed?

Bow is speaking again, a little more firmer and a little louder, it’s enough to partially break through the mental barriers Adora’s unconsciously constructed around herself.

“Adora you dont look like your feeling so good, whats-”

Adora manages to make direct eye contact again.

“What's going on?”

She-. She attempts to wrench herself away from the leering and inevitable truth that is going back to Etheria basically empty handed and replies, even if her vision is constantly blurring at the edges and her body requires increasing amounts of effort to remain upright.

Adora sighs, rubbing at a bare shoulder with a bare hand.

Producing words is effort and it initially comes out as a growl but with summoning energy and incurring a heavier debt she *manages.*

“I’m tired Bow, like *really* tired . But I don't wanna sleep, I don't wanna close my eyes and go to bed even though everything hurts and it’s like someone keeps turning a switch on and off with me

cuz I’m getting tired and awake and then tired again and I feel like if I sit down I won't ever get back up”

Bow hangs his head and bites his lip before lightly touching Adora’s forearm with soft fingers and gently caressing up and down in physical support, he’s done this before when Adora has been stressed, somehow a light touch to the arm is soothing.

“Is it about Catra?”

“Partially, I. There's a lot of things to be honest and they’re always piling up”

“And now it’s gotten worse with *what happened* ?” Bow is a fucking mind reader.

Adora doesn't know that she’s leaning forward and being supported by one of her best friends until there’s two points of solid weight pressing on her infront, she’s slowly starting to shut down now with the combined physical, emotional and mental stress of months of poor sleep and panic attacks along with fighting and sheer wear and tear finally starting to really *incur their respective debts*

“Shhh it’s okay, I’m here” Bow coo’s softly and Adora doesnt even realise she’s trembling in some places and her bottom lip has wavered enough that she's being pulled into a tight embrace that she desperately needs and all she can manage back is one arm

wrapped around her friends back with semi effort while the other uselessly dangles at her side.

The hand holding the dagger feels empty.

“I’m so sorry Bow”

“What for?”

And now she’s racing again, thoughts and memories coming back to abuse her with kicks and reminders, Shadow Weavers and others influences over the past becoming stronger enough that she-

“I wasn't good enough, for everyone, for Catra, I should have been faster for her, she should be alive right now and I fucked it up so bad that we only have three weeks and Prime is still alive and I have a fucking funeral when I should be-”

-admits it.

“-Celebrating getting Catra back, it hurts and I don't want to go in that room, I don't want to see her lying down because I’ll believe that she’ll wake up and everything’ll be fine when it isn't and it’ll just *hurt* more”

“Bow-I”

Bow doesn't say anything, instead responding with a slight squeeze that cuts off Adora's mental and emotional self beating session and redirects it towards the embrace that they've shared together multiple times during their time as friends, enough that's been routine that Bow *is* the second person she's been physically affectionate most with after Catra. There's just something about him, his attentive endearment helped during her near panic attacks for almost two years and that he's always been emotionally attuned.

Glimmer is speaking to Entrapta about something, they're talking about the ship and a voyage and then the conversation passes to a sword?

In a way, Bow calms Adora down, her breathing de-escalates from rapid and near uncontrollable to relatively normal for Adora anyway, she relaxes, limbs stopping from shaking to safety and she loosens up a bit. Bow isn't Catra where they'd snuggle in bed together but he's the next best thing.

"Hey" He whispers in Adora's ear, probably noticing how much calmer she is. "Better?"

Adora nods with closed eyes and a better expression. Her mind has stopped racing and attempting to pull itself apart in multiple directions in a vain effort to cover everything,but now thanks to Bow she's just solely concentrating on being *held.*

It's nice, she's *needed* this for a *long* time.

“Yeah, better” She breathes out and returns the soft squeeze.

Things are feeling more muted and *calm* now as Adora’s head finds its way onto resting on Bow’s shoulder, sure she can still hear Glimmer and Entrapta *talk* but audibly to *her* it’s all noise now, or rather water gently flowing over a calm stream rather than a raging waterfall that she’s used to.

In a way, it’s nice. Just listening to Bow breathe while they wrap their arms around each other. The serotonin alone brings a welcome boost and for a brief moment the worries of the world are quietly tucked away.

“Bow?” It’s surprising even to her when her voice comes out as natural and normal rather than mimicking an authority position or just simply dry.

Bow takes an audible soft sigh before he responds lazily, it’s funny how tense they all were just an hour ago. “Mmmm, Adora?”

Adora does the same, although with a bitten lip and aching muscles but still, in a quiet voice that only they can hear.

“Thank you-I” She breathes out. “I appreciate it, really.”

The reply is another squeeze below her shoulder blades and it actually ends up embarrassingly cracking the bones there.

"S'alright, figured you could use it. Actually I kind of needed it as well to be honest, Glimmer's been a little uh intense" Bow admitted with a short chuckle.

"Oh really?"

"Yeah turns out admitting deep long feelings to each other after spending like three months apart?,yeah my face hurts"

Despite everything, Adora is happy for her two best friends , they ended up together and they seem happy. "I'm glad, you two have been pining for *ages* "

"Oh, ages?"

"Yeah I figured it out the moment I ended up at Brightmoon, took you long enough!" Adora hums with a gentle tease in her voice, in a way they're back to their old selves even for just a moment, the brief carefree days where they found themselves at Bow's dad's and spent a whole week just chilling out and relaxing.

It's a good memory that lights up in her mind for once, it's stupidly corny dad jokes, embarrassing photos of a young Bow, chai-tea and sweet scones with the occasional reading session or

translating that always resulted in a hilarious eureka! from the married couple, seven days of being a young adult rather than grappling between the triple identity of a Force Captain, She-Ra and Adora the rebel.

Adora misses those days. Sure the Rebellion was in somewhat dire straits, Entrapta had defected and constructed a horde of murderous robots and they were always fighting fires but it was to *less stakes,* they could afford to take things slow and easy, occasionally have fun, sleepovers, get togethers. And even the odd party.

Not like now.

Which is why Adora's *fucking cherishing* an actual embrace from someone she considers a actual friend, in a way it's music between them with a slow drumbeat and a well constructed rhythm from a guitar playing along together in perfect synchronization.

Fuck she misses this, everything is right, she can hum along and close her eyes and know there wont be a nightmare lurking in the darkness. It's safety, it's a steady release of endorphins that increase well-being and decrease stress, maybe the deep lines across her face will retreat somehow and she'll look young again rather than a dysfunctional twenty-two year old.

Thank you Bow.

She should also probably ask about the thump that happened in her room-

Glimmer's voice cuts through again and this time Adora hears every.single.word. She cant help it, she's been trained to pick up keywords or a complete paragraph if it registers as important to her, she can thank Shadow Weavers and Force Captain's mental conditioning and intensive mental training for *that.*

Adora's jaw clenches tight, blood pressure rises again, muscle tension is back in every single limb and point and the inhibited ,debilitated and maladjusted nervous system kicks all systems apparatus into *go.*

"Hey Bow, can you tell Adora that we need to head back to Etheria? Darla needs a "administrative command" for us to take off"

The guitar string is unhinged, its music is plucking something *twang* y and out of place, the drums are broken in tempo and off.

Adora's world is twisted and turned sharply over a hundred and eighty degrees. Bow's embrace has turned cold and raised hairs on her arms, muscles are twitchy again and she's launched straight back into that nervous, anxious state of impending danger.

It's clear. When she physically recoils and jerks away from Bow's touch, catches herself on the chair and nearly wrenches off

another part of it with a glowing hand to support her body from falling over. Glimmer's words are coating every panic fueled thought and action, not intended to hurt her but still bouncing around and have wrenched Adora right out the calm state she so desperately clung to.

"Adora?" Bow calls out with a tentative hand reaching out but Adora's gone straight back into her previous *fucked* mental and emotional state.

And everyone is looking at her again.

"Something wrong?" Glimmer says as she steps into Adora's line of sight and asks with some element of worry and part confusion and her words just..make everything else? Like high pitched noise and even footsteps are *fucking echo'd.*

When Adora does manage to speak up, it's quiet and strained. Laced with her anxiety that's come back in full force and hit the brakes on everything positive that briefly happened.

"No" Her grip tightens and *that* arm begins to *feel* funny *again* .

Adora watches as Glimmer looks to Bow silently for an answer but receives none, instead Bow gives a hushed shrug.

“Adora?” Glimmer asks, more worry this time but keeping her distance between the two, Glimmer’s eyes flicker to Adora’s arm and Adora unconsciously shifts to move it out of her queens sight and something twists in her stomach so strangely that she *wants* to throw up to get rid of it.

“I-” Adora starts, getting the words out is painful considering she’s being swamped by memories and thoughts and reminders, her need to *fix everything* is conflicting with her *failure* over being unable to *save* Catra, Prime escaping to fight another day and their light damage to the ship.

The two people closest to her, both in physical proximity and emotionally now that Catra is fucking dead are just standing there and confused and they’re probably wondering what the fuck Adora is doing or thinking or acting out about and Adora can hear what they’re fucking *thinking.*

“I don't want to go” She admits, breathes it out and finally says it.

Glimmer splutters out a single word in response. “What?”

“To where?” Bow finishes.

Adora closes her eyes, mentally prepares herself to say it.

And says it.

"Etheria"

There's nothing for her except more of what she's already struggling to deal with.

"I-"

She'll have to bury Catra, sleep even less and let She-Ra take the reins.

"I don't want to go back"

Glimmer is pacing back and forth and going through a mixture of swearing in disbelief and throwing random thoughts at her boyfriend. Judging by her body language *alone* she has no clue or understanding of Adora's position or the *why of things.*

Bow seems to be taking things better, in a way, after all he was on the ground in at least a third of the battles post sword broken with Adora on the field and privy to how *shit* downtime had gotten for her with the nightmares, exhaustion and all , but in all honesty he doesn't seem to fundamentally *understand* why Adora doesn't want to go back either.

Bow is speaking in hushed tones to Glimmer and flailing his arms about, Glimmer is still pacing and she's in a state enough that tired sparks are coming out of her fingers.

In between her world constantly caving in and opening up in regards to sound, color and smell. Her emotional struggle to contain herself (just barely) and once again beating herself up about everything in the past two years and even more so in the past *two hours* Adora is only really able to catch a few snippets of what Glimmer is saying. Is Glimmer talking to her and alternating between a conversation of two different people, is she speaking just to Adora or just to Bow or is it supposed to be a three way dialogue but only two are participating because Adora's not in the *greatest place right now.*

And she sinks ever lower when she does manage to *pick up* on some words, her brain laser focusing and then automatically firing off a checklist of reasons *why* and she's fucking spiralling again.

"-have time-and-can do it. Just like we used to as- squad" *Three weeks is not enough time to locate, plan, prepare and find a location that could be anywhere on the planet.*

"-with ra-back we should-fighting chance-hero-invincible" *She-Ra is one person and while she's near invincible she can only be in one place, relying on a single piece is too dangerous.*

"-beat Hordak, can do it again Bow- need runestones" *Didn't she look out the Window? The Horde had at most a few thousand troops, they were almost routed and destroyed by a scouting force from Prime and there must be millions of clones, not to mention they can just circumvent the princess's by bombarding the planet from orbit or just throwing waves and waves until the Rebellion is exhausted.*

Glimmer has no clue, she *doesn't* know the full reality of things.

Adora's *mind* , a product of intense conditioning , four years of war and an inability to stop thinking, is drawing the worst *and only* conclusion possible.

They *don't* have the time, they *don't* have the space, the people or the troops.

They *failed.*

They are *fucked* . Etheria is going to fall unless they do something before they can get back, otherwise it's a coin flip weighted against their favour and leaving the survival of everyone Adora cares about to chance? She’s not fucking having that. She’s *lost* too many people at this point and she doesn't want to ever imagine Glimmer and Bow being added to that list, as much as they disagreed and fought. As much as Adora and Glimmer butted heads for almost half a year and Bow strained himself to the limit trying to keep her alive during the war with Prime. Adora still loves them, the both of them and she’s never given up on *that* feeling ever.

Oh god. Now she’s looking at them, not *looking* , but looking . Analysing, finding weaknesses and likely cause of death like she was trained to do when inspecting a new squad of Horde Cadets and then to come up with a way of making them *useful.*

Kyle *drowned* , Grizzlor *screamed* , spinnerella *burned* , Sea-Hawk had his *lungs punctured* and Juliet was *shot to pieces.*

And Catra died in her arms, believing she was being carried to safety.

Glimmer and Bow are the last two people she has *left.* And she’ll survive way after they will, Adora *will* be the last one standing amongst a pile of corpses she called her friends. Glimmer will die first, using her magic to save her people and eventually overstretching herself to the point of magical exhaustion and pinned behind enemy lines, Bow will naturally come to save her and Adora will be *just too late* to stop it from happening.

The two of them are speaking again and while the words are just looping over Adora's ability to perceive she can make out the topic via lip reading alone.

Glimmer fully believes in the power of She-Ra and her optimism, while needed as a counter to Adora's nihilistic pessimism and Bow's mom-friend attitude is misplaced right now, she doesn't *know.* Glimmer trust's in the power of She-Ra far too much, she's going to place all of her eggs in one basket like she did with Shadow Weaver and activate the Heart of Etheria and whatever she's reasoning as a grand plan? *it will go wrong again.*

Adora has to do *something.* She won't let them become corpses, she won't let herself outlive them like she's done with the others, even Entrapta and everything she's done deserves to live. Adora is still rooted to the spot and her arms are parzalysed but she's beginning to break through.

She concentrates, Bow and Glimmer *will* live *.* They'll get back to Etheria safely and become King and Queen of Brightmoon.

Entrapta *will* construct civilian bots to help with the reconstruction process.

Left arm is feeling something and she can flex the fingers.

Perfuma and Scorpia *will* marry, it's painfully obvious how much they're pining for each other and while Adora may not attend the wedding, she'll wish them the same.

SeaHawk *will* get a statue commemorating him, so *will* Juliet and Spinnerella.

She can shift her legs and crack them when she puts pressure on.

Adora is starting to be able to focus, turning thoughts that are constantly reaching for the exterior and redirecting them to the interior.

Catra *will* be given a funeral, a proper one. She'll be buried outside a neat cottage that overlooks a green field that'll be out of the way of the major population but still close enough to *home.*

And then things turn towards the *present.* What she can *do,* what she can *fix.*

She promised Angella that she'd take care of them.

Her right arm sparkles again with a layer of heat coming off to the skin and evaporating in the air, Adora imagines that's she holding onto something, no. *Holding something.* In her fingers, gripping a long handle that isnt the Sword of Restoration because it's fucking broken and shattered into a million pieces but instead something familiar, not a dagger or a staff. But a weapon of war, that she can kill Prime with.

Seconds go by and then an implosion of air like a reverse explosion, something that has just physically ripped reality open in the palm of her hand with a deafening roar and then like a lightbulb it detonates the light around her.

The dagger on the floor is gone, leaving nothing behind but a slight scorch on a semi metallic floor.

It's not She-Ra, but it is a weapon. It's heavy but wieldable.

It's a two headed war pick the length of her arm from finger to shoulder with a brown wood like handle and stark metallic head and double blades, weighty enough that it'll knock anything out if she simply t *hrows it* but light enough that she can wield it.

When she juggles it in both hands, running fingers along the blade tips and down the framework, it takes a moment or two to register that she's being talked to.

Glimmer as always is the first, open mouthed and shocked, arms outstretched and staff just dropped to the floor.

"What? The *fuck* Adora?"

“Glimmer.” Adora says blanky when she turns to properly face her queen.

“She-Ra?”

“I don't know, but it’s a start” Sure she cant summon the cheerleader with the stupid hair and impractical cape yet but soon maybe, she’s still planning though. That part of her brain is productively pounding into gear and it’s *working.*

“Woah! Slow down, you think you can get She-Ra back, like for real?” Bow interjects with half enthusiasm and half worry, he’s the one that was by Adora’s side when she threw herself into replicating the goddess results for months and nearly broke herself.

“I don't know” She repeats and hefts the massive weapon in one hand and lets the tip of it scrape along the *floor.*

“So you think you can? This isn't like *just summoning* something right?” Bow points out and he’s holding his chin, he’s always been good at this, pointing things out.

Adora is still coming up with a plan and she nods in response, it’s good to have something to focus on and she’s already feeling

better now that the *Force Captain Adora* side of her that never left is slowly walking back into life and offering suggestions.

Glimmer breathes out and rubs her hands together nervously. "So back to Etheria then?, I'm sure we can have this figured out on the way hopefully?"

Oh.

Back to Etheria?.

Oh.

Adora's part momentarily short circuits when she begins the process of yet again digesting her thoughts and knowing conceptions of what will happen if she goes back.

No.

"I" She stumbles on her words and leans on her warpick as that sharp bit of confidence she was granted with momentarily disappears upon facing reality, there's a little bit of fear injection, part anxiety seeping in and a genuine unwillingness at the back of her mind.

"I'm not going" She says quietly, her arm is still glowing but its decreasing in scope as that *focus* she *had* retreats.

“Adora, what?”

“I’m not going Glimmer, I don't *want* to”

Glimmer fixes her with an incredulous look before she can reply.

“We need to go back, we need to use this time we have and get things moving, we have to find a way to beat Prime Adora!”

They don't have time.

“How?” She asks, flatly.

“We’ll find a way like we always do, there’s gotta be some back up site right? Some way to control things like we did with the Heart of Etheria?”

The Crystal Castle is gone and there’s no telling if the First Ones ever made a backup.

“Glimmer there’s no way of knowing that a back up even exists and three weeks aint *enough time* , we’ll be searching a whole planet and we can't do that with half it as a warzone”

Glimmer stiffens for a few seconds and Adora can feel that old animosity between them flicker in, Glimmer has her mind set to something and well? So does *she* , sort of. Adora is still planning.

"And there's no way of knowing unless we try, Mystactor or old records or even Shadow Weaver? They've gotta know something?" Glimmer fires back and that mention of *her...it.* It doesn't have good connotations for Adora.

"Shadow Weaver?" Adora manages to keep her voice steady when she asks, there's brief flashes of Catra being electrocuted and tortured, ShadowWeaver's face hitting marble floor as Adora swings a chair and she somehow manages to rein the brief burst of anger in.

"Yeah she knew stuff? Heart of Etheria and getting the Princesses to full power, it's *how* we *won* versus the Horde, remember?

Adora remembers Light Hope teleporting the fucking planet out of Deponsdos and into a hell that lasted for months, cities being burned, populations either executed or led into spaceships, an familiar blanksky that was suddenly full of stars.

"Shadow Weaver is fucking dead Glimmer" Adora says flaty and doesnt even try to contain the brief smattering of satisfaction on her lips of watching that *cunt* drown.

“What?” Bow’s been silent this whole time and when he half-shouts in surprise it’s enough to bring Adora out of her fiery internal monologue.

“She’s dead? How?” Glimmer comes closer and she’s genuinely confused, it would be hard to imagine since Shadow Weaver always projected an aura of class, power projection and always having the upper hand.

Adora *spits* on the ground.

“In the fucking seabed, where she belongs”

“Wait, what?”

“Adora?”

“Did you?” Bow leaves that question open.

And Adora answers.

“Yes, I killed her” And she’d do it *again.*

That glare from Glimmer that manifested multiple times as queen is *back.*

"Why the fuck would you kill Shadow Weaver, she was on our side?"

Just hearing that, Shadow Weaver being a force for good it. It makes something snap.

"I dont give a flying fuck about her Glimmer because you fucking know what? She was a cunt, a grade A piece of shit that wanted *your* throne and the MOMENT you were GONE? She was fucking sitting on it" Adora fucking roars when that memory comes back in full.

"Adora-I" Glimmer begins to say something and that fire is gone, there's a tear forming but Adora is long past that kind of conversation.

"She wanted your throne, she was using YOU. And I fucking killed her like I should have done ages ago, I dont reget it and I'd fucking do it again"

Silence,shock. Two stunned people.

"Adora-I"

“No buts Glimmer, she deserved it. For what she did to *you* , to *me* ”

Adora swallows.

“ *To Catra* ”.

Glimmer is stunned, shocked and Bow just stands there following her outburst, they’ve probably suspected for a while that there was something going on behind the scenes with her and Shadow Weaver (she never told them what it was like) and now, well they know.

“I” Glimmer begins, her body facing front towards Adora but eyes over at Bow for support.

“I’m sorry, I-we didn't know. Shadow Weaver was a-source of information and I was planning on holding a trial after this was over, I didn't know Adora…”

“I dont fucking regret it” Adora snaps and that snarl is enough to make the queen flinch. That fire that’s been burning internally is *leaking out* , it’s not a bonfire anymore that’s been kept contained it’s actually a f *ucking inferno* now.

“I know, I know. I’m sorry though. I should have talked it through with you”

“Yeah. Whatever, good fucking riddance” Adora snarks two thirds of that under her breath.

“Anyway, we uh. We need to go. No telling when the clones will be back” Bow manages to interject by *creeping in* and diverting the conversation elsewhere.

While Bow was pretty good at negotiating and redirecting conversations towards more neutral topics ,Adora suspected that he’d been learning directly from Perfuma. This is not one of those times, the mention of going home, even briefly is enough to shoot all those anxiety inducing, nightmare creating “everyone is going to fucking die and I won’t be able to do anything it” feelings right back into the forefront of Adora’s thought process.

“I’m not fucking going Bow” Adora simply states and leans backwards, dragging the handle with her and letting one prong of her warpick *scrape* along the floor just enough to make a wincing echoing noise.

“Why?” Glimmer swallows and then asks, she’s not as close as she was before and has backed up a few, Bow is standing closer to her now. As if he’s confused, or maybe it’s a protection thing.

“I don't want to” Those memories are coming back, Seahawk getting punctured in the lung and there’s probably a worse fate awaiting Bow and Glimmer, she’s still working on a plan to fix everything but it needs to happen *faster.*

“Adora, why?” Bow asks too. “What-” He stops and glances back at Glimmer who gives a simple tearful nod. “Why don't you want to?”

Adora answers with the idle, awful, nightmarish simulation that’s been running in her head and joins up datamined with the situation on Etheria.

“Because you’re going to die, both of you. Entrapta will die, everyone will die and-”

Is she choking?

“I won't be able to do anything about it, it’ll be my fault and I can't fix it”

That fire is dying down, replaced with a contrasting effect.

She speaks before they can.

“Do you know how it is on Etheria, Glimmer?”

It’s fear, anxiety, nightmares, the worst possible scenario and then some.

“Adora, I already told he-”

“I mean. *Really* ” Adora’s gripping that handle of her weapon real fucking tight. Tight enough for white knuckles and tense muscles.

“Bow only knows the half of it, we’re fucked. Completely. A fucking scouting force swooped in and half of our cities are *gone.* No ruins, just *gone.* We’ve been pushed back on every single front globally and reduced to guerilla warfare or outright sucide attacks”

The expression on Glimmer’s face is beyond describing.

She points behind them, if they were standing in the hanger then her finger would be levelled out the window? Hanger entrance? And at the space outside. Full of stars.

“And that right there? Is thousands more ships, not four or five or six but fucking thousands and they all carry thousands more clones, we can’t compete with that or even keep up. We’re fucked Glimmer”

Glimmer does try to offer a beacon of hope.

"But the Heart of Etheria? We still have time, and She-Ra? She-Ra's never *failed us* "

Adora doesn't respond, well not immediately. She sort of quietens? Her brain stutters and goes into downtime for a few seconds.

And when she does reply? When Glimmer is barely managing to not let a tear fall and Bow is sadly looking at her, it's not the booming voice of a Force Captain or even Adora's signature voice that can be recognised anywhere.

It's low, quiet. A little sadness mixed with a little distress.

"We don't have time, three weeks is not enough for us to figure out a location, scout it and somehow wire it up and get it ready, it could be anywhere, planetside or even underground"

"But we can-"

Whatever Glimmer was about to say is scattered by a tired tone, straight from a weary heart.

“No buts, I don't want to risk the people I have left on a coin toss or a diceroll, I know winging shit is *our thing* but we always did it in the knowledge that we had a fallback. If we go back, we’re locking ourselves in and won't be able to let go”

Adora’s gaze meets the floor after that, there’s a tear in her eyes too. *And a sniffle.*

“And”

“I don't want to lose you two”

And then that fire picks up again.

“Kyle is dead, Grizzolor is dead, my men? I never knew their names and only their numbers are *dead* all the way from the Fright Zone to the Crimson Waste”

“Did Bow tell you Sea-Hawk is dead? He died because of my mistakes, Juliet sacrificed herself for *me* and because I couldn't *fix it.* I had to tell Netossa that her wife burnt alive and all I wanted to do was throw myself in that building instead”

Adora takes a moment to collect herself, the faces of her fallen are staring back through the floor of Mara's ship and they'll haunt her forever because she could have saved them all if she *tried harder.*

"Angella *died* because of me, because I couldn't close the portal in time. She asked me to take care of you and I failed you, both of you"

"I couldn't fix it Glimmer" Saying the present queen's name like *that* is more of a dejected whine than anything else, Adora's shoulders are sagging now and she's putting so much weight into that warpick.

"It wasn't your fault Adora" Bow offers a hand but Adora ignores it.

"It is my fault, command responsibility and all that. I should have known, I should have been faster"

"Don't beat yourself up over it"

"She-Ra is one person, she can't be everywhere and we can't rely on her to do everything for us, that was *my mistake* "

"But"

The plan that was being unconsciously worked is starting to rear its ugly head, there's a map drawn out, expected battle lines and time taken to move from point A to B.

She manages to continue though, sighing and letting that plan whirr on as she continues to spiral into a confession.

"She-Ra won't win the planet wide war for us, there's no point to guerilla warfare or defense in depth or anything either you or I were ever taught or used when our enemy can simply drop troops from orbit or just *erase* anything we set up, I. I don't think we can win this on Etheria"

Glimmer's head is down and staring at the floor, mirroring Adora's depressed expression a few moments ago when Adora dares to make eye contact with just Bow, Glimmer is simply avoiding her or trying to process.

"So what do we do?" Bow asks, Adora's always had this respect for the guy that he can always find something to put hope in, even when everything is going got shit.

"I." Adora licks her lips. "I have a suggestion"

"Let's hear it then?" Bow is still responding back and attentively, Glimmer isn't.

Adora cracks her knuckles, left and right.

"W-I. Kill Prime, blow the ship up and stop the invasion before it happens or delay it long enough that the Rebellion has *time"*

Inhale.

Before Bow can reply.

Exhale, deeply.

"Time enough that the Rebellion and you guys can either teleport out of Despondos, fire up the Heart of Etheria or find a way out of this mess. This is *my* one shot to end this, Prime is in reach of us and he cant teleport away, his hivemind is down too and while I guess it's a coin flip it's also one that's weighted in *my* favour"

Bow noticies her "I" rather than "we" or "us" with unmistakable concern.

"I, Adora?" But Glimmer gets there first, that staff is back in her hands and she's leaning on it again but still standing upright, a tear falling off her bottom lip and the faint echo of magic in her free hand.

Adora swallows. “Yes, I”

Adora stiffens and stands tall like a Force Captain, goes through the motions of her plan in her head and keeps it brief and clear with the same tone of voice and body language that she can perfectly remember making during her command briefings on top of a tank.

With a grunt and a slight wince she hefts the warpick she’s been leaning on, and points it at the entrance outside of Mara’s ship where she was taken away by the clones.

“Exit there, continue for twenty, jump off the edge and keep going until I find him. Kill him and then blow up the ship, there’s got to be something, or just keep smashing”

“It’s simple, easy. *I can* fix this Glimmer, everyone can go home”

The plan comes together completely in her mind, it’s like a display she can cycle through and pin point everything.

“What about you?” Glimmer asks.

“Don't you want to come home?” Bow adds.

Adora shakes her head, grim faced and in a way accepting a fate that she’s avoided for a while now, involuntarily or not.

“Home.” A single word but loaded with a thousand different meanings that are both unspoken and not come out of her lips.

Flashes of the eighteen years of naive tranquillity replace the coloured pins of expected enemy positions and mind maps of movement and predicted places her battleplan previously showed, it’s a sliding screen or a picture reel of her and Catra from the earliest of memories when they were small little brats to finishing physical puberty, its laughing, smiling, holding hands and sleeping together, staying up all night whispering under covers so it’d be just the two of them and playing pranks on Kyle.

“Was there, with *her* ” Her hand trembles and fingers waver when she points to the room that Catra lays dead in, the person she loved who died in her arms and failed to save. Catra pleaded for Adora to stay and Adora won't be able to give her even that, even in death she’s unable to *fix it* .

Adora notices that Glimmer is shaking and her fists are balling up so hard that the nails are digging into the skin when she visibly finds the courage to speak.

“Stop it, just fucking stop it for once Adora! Just because she’s gone doesnt mean you have to kill yourself!”

“Glimmer!” Bow hisses with alarm and he moves over with a outstretched hand to the arm but-

“ *Seriously* ? Your fucking plan is to sacrifice yourself in some mad deathwish, dont you care that you could find someone else or live out your life on Etheria? Don’t you want something Adora, dont you want to be fucking happy?”

Adora is completely, unnervingly calm. It’s not a raging fire anymore that’d pour into the veins and open every tap full of loneliness and napalm, it won't knock out the flower vase on the table in blind rage. It’s cold, controllable. Force Captain Adora is slowing coming out

from the shadows, moving has it underwraps and used as into an

emotional weapon now;a tool in her growing arsenal to be deployed when

the time is right.

“I don't get to be happy Glimmer, I’ve fucked enough people in the Rebellion to know that, tried my hand at courtship and relationships and none of them ever worked out. I don't get *to win”*

She’s cheated death to many times and gotten up right close to its jaws, and finally she’s greeting it with serenity and peace, the present and future are just simple steps to walk down, the past

could have been changed, a path taken at a fork in the road could have led to a different outcome.

When she speaks it silences the room with its terrible honesty, it's clear punctuation and chilling intent.

And she *maintains* it perfectly, right up until that *crack* at the end.

“I was going to have a cottage with her, I promised her it’d be somewhere green and nice. A place where we could get away from war and everyone that wanted to hurt us. It’d be a building, a home for us”

She turns to Catra’s room one more time and with a sad smile, then to Glimmer and Bow. And then to the front of Mara’s ship with the vastness of space and the tiny ball lurking somewhere in the blackness and vastness of space that is Etheria *behind* her.

It’s a road ahead of her, a road she’ll walk alone.

“I wanted something, it was taken from me. I won every fight but I’ve lost the war, maybe I knew it when her voice flickered in through the receiver , she apologized to me and.. maybe she wanted me safe but I couldn't leave her alone to suffer.”

She knows she’s crying, the world outside is mute and it’s only with the physical touch of wetness rolling down her cheeks that she can even register that she is. Crying.

"And now she's dead"

Bow and Glimmer are speaking but with her back turned and senses fuzzy it's impossible to indicate, it's only when Glimmer appears at her side and is shaking her shoulder furiously with Bow copying the same on the right does she register the physical world.

Please Adora, you can't do this! You can come back with us and we'll solve this!.

"My entire life, I've had people telling me what my destiny is, that I was going to conquer the Crimson Waste as Force Captain and then the Rebellion as Force Commander and fourth in line, I never got that promotion and instead I found you two"

It-it's just a temporary set back, we'll win in the end. I promise.

"Then Light Hope bullshitted me about my *destiny* , bring balance to Etheria and set off a superweapon to wipe out her dead enemies"

There's tugging at the straps of her tank top.

Please!

Adora?

Clawing at her arm.

"Too many people have died for me and I've been avoiding it for too long. I should've jumped into that portal and closed off *my mistake* but Angella gave her life for mine. She asked me to take of you Glimmer"

Adora makes eye contact with Glimmer, the difference in height between is even more somehow when she fixes her queen with a soft smile lightly stained with a post bloody uppercut. While Glimmer's own still has tears dripping off it.

The armoured Adora with the black arm sleeve and red insignia of a Force Commander, due to be promoted from *Force Captain.* A strong Adora, a brave Adora who never hesitated nor wavered is standing beside her with an open palm.

Take my hand.

Adora's head leans down, reaches down with bare fingers to trace over coloured fingerless ones, she lingers for a second in thought.

And she accepts. There was never any doubt in her mind as Force Captain, no emotional gauntlets to deal with or anxiety attacks

that resulted in vomit or broken glass.

A stronger, braver Adora.

The one that never failed to *fix it.*

Force Captain Adora blinks, stretches and makes eye contact again with Bow and Glimmer.

“I’m taking care of you, but this is what I choose for myself”

She turns to Bow, he’s still tugging at her but he might aswell be doing it to a brick wall because Adora’s skin is fucking glowing now, she’s in calm and peaceful serenity and Bow’s normal friendly, cheerful and optimistic personality has been replaced with a grim and sullen expression.

“Take care of her for me? Be a good king and help Micah too. He’ll need it”

Please don't go.

We-I, need you.

She strides forward, her two best friends desperately attempting to hold her back but with new found inner strength converted into external *force* they're powerless to stop her as she approaches the ramp to the hanger of Prime's ship. The point of no return and the endgame that's been long overdue for the twenty two year old.

"Darla" She speaks aloud and with the same commanding presence she used as Force Captain.

"Fly out of sensor distance and keep going for at least six hours towards Etheria, then designate Glimmer as administrator"

Affirmative Administrator Adora.

Closing her eyes one last time, feeling the weight of the weapon in her hand and breathing in recycled and mimicked Etherian atmosphere oxygen, Adora begins the second phase of her plan, *preparation.*

There's a crack in the air, a small and familiar shockwave from behind that sucks out air and then it reappears in front of her, a smaller mass with pink on top clinging to Adora's front and wetness staining her tanktop.

It's Glimmer,a visibly falling apart and used the last crumb of magic left in her to teleport and try to stop her, Glimmer.

"No no no no, not like this"

There's pain in the words she speaks. Regret, worry and an unwillingness to let go.

"It's not fucking happening, I'm not LOSING you. I lost mom and I just found dad. You can't give up Adora, you've never given up on ANYTHING on your life and never on me, or Bow or *Catra* "

Glimmer is getting increasingly desperate and she's *flailing hard.* All Force Captain Adora can do is stand and watch, coldly.

"I've got you, I'm not letting go. For once in your fucking life just stay with me and *dont go away"*

But Force Captain Adora's already made her mind up. She's laser focused now

and the problems of yesterday have gone away to be locked down in a stronger safe and tied up with rope and then thrown into the bottom of the ocean so they'll *hurt her again.*

She's going to *kill* Prime, she's going to save Etheria, she's going to make sure that those Catra's and Adora's, Bow's and Glimmer's, Scorpia's and Perfuma's get to have a chance together to be safe and away from war and the pain and suffering it bough.

In her mind, it's an even trade. One soul for millions? In a command position, she'd gladly take that.

Adora lets Glimmer bury her head in the crook of her neck, sofly crying and holding as the queen goes through the stages of grief all the way from denial to depressing and end *right there.*

"You're really going"

"Yes" Adora's calm voice comes out, compared to Glimmer's confused and small one.

"And there's nothing I can really do, is there?"

"Nope" Adora pops the P.

A punch. "Fuck you Adora, *fuck you* ".

Another punch that hurts the assailants fingers and does nothing to the recipient.

"You just get to fucking walk away and leaves us, are you fucking kidding me?"

Adora's hand slips down and long battered fingers trail over Glimmer's shorter ones, lightly stroking and ending up a brief embrace.

"Bury Catra somewhere green for me, make sure she's safe"

"No no no no no" Denial in that voice.

"Say Hi to Micah for me"

"You fucking bitch! Don't you dare do it, don't you dare fucking do it Adora, please!"

Choking, barely able to get words out without tears in the way, desperate fingers grabbing at their opposite and hair brushing against a chin.

"Don't do this to me please, please don't leave us, don't leave me"

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

Force Captain Adora side steps Queen Glimmer, even as the Force Captain walks away forever the Queen exhales every single breath held and lunges forward for one last grab onto Adora's wrist, Glimmer's fingers slide down to grip and she tries one.last.time.

"Adora,wait. Please.stay"

Warning. Radiation signature detected inside ship. Warning.

Sensors from inside the ship are starting to go off even as Force Captain Adora is halfway down the ramp, they're blaring as they reach 100% capacity and if she wasnt fucking *glowing* with *focus* then she wouldnt have been able to hear Glimmer's strained desperate voice screaming at her in a terrible horse way.

She continues to focus, while before with the sword transforming was stepping into a pool into full clothing, uncomfortable but

simple easy footwork if you didn't mind being drenched this is significantly more difficult.

There is a dim light at the end of the proverbial tunnel that increases in intensity the more she grounds herself and *concentrates* , a way forward and a way to transform into She-Ra, the Force Captain knows this, even if she'll have to do it kicking and screaming.

She can fix this.

Glimmer must be left behind so she can rule in peace with no threats to her kingdom. So Adora waves goodbye even while the Queen is dragged back up the ramp by her boyfriend, crying and wailing and kicking and begging Adora not to go.

Her chest is thrumming with power and wounds that left her staggering and tired are being forgotten, even ones caused by stun batons and whiplash, ragdolling and blunt force trauma are melting away.

Bow will be able to see his dads again and be named King of Brightmoon, it's something he deserves.

She can see She-Ra now, or at least the back of her with the cheerleader outfit, a missing sword and impractical gear. Force Captain Adora will have to change that.

Entrapta will be left alone to tinker with weapons, hopefully for the better. Netossa will continue to grieve for her wife but at least Spinnerella wouldn't have died in vain, neither will Juliet or Seahawk or Kyle and Grizzlor.

She-Ra turns around and while it's a blank expression, there's some kind of confusion in those eyes like she never expected to meet the Force Captain. The twenty two year old begins imagining and then putting into action her expected She-Ra, the one she should have been, a true invincible weapon of war.

Catra will be buried somewhere soft and green and while history books may not be kind, her sacrifice for Glimmer will ensure a positive ending at the very least, maybe she'll even be celebrated. *She deserved that at least.*

Force Captain Adora clears the ramp and shouts for Darla to leave, the AI sounds confused initially at her current administration leaving but a further *order* to leave has the AI acknowledging. Even if Adora can hear the sounds of instruments and sensors being completely disrupted and a single phrase being repeated over and over again.

WARNING. RADIATION SIGNATURE DETECTED OUTSIDE SHIP. WARNING.

Force Captain Adora closes her eyes and begins to go through the motions of equipping armor, ignoring the sounds and physical kickback as the spaceship begins to lift off and then punch through the protective field the hanger has from the outside world.

From the bottom up, it's Bow's boots in gold with good craftsmanship and agility, a single heart on the back of the heel in tribute to his manufacturing skills even if the boots almost reach her kneecaps but then that's a necessary protective measure.

*She does have a inkling that She-Ra is a "sort of" living being but whether that's true sentience or just a faint collection of the experiences and memories of She-Ra's previous wielders is a dice roll, not that FC' Adora cares, She-Ra *will* do her bidding, she is a tool to be used.*

Then it's still She-Ra's bare legs and skirt but a pair of protective kneecap plates over the vulnerable joints that could be used as a weapon of their own, the skirt is coloured purple and reminds her of Glimmer's regal cape, but more durable with shorts underneath.

It's significantly more difficult to properly imagine her intended version of She-Ra, its like having to use a tool other than a hammer to put a nail in, the Sword made things so much easier which is why there's echo's and clothing and style of the cheerleader remaining, but that doesnt matter. It's still functional enough for the job ahead.

A white shirt with a large chest plate , just like her own armor in the Horde is conjured up next and it's a damn sight better than the unprotected midriff to collarbone that the She-Ra previously had, then a gold adornment covering her neck and the top of her shoulders like the sorcerers of Mystacor, a brief connection of the friendship she had to have with Castaspella.

She-Ra's disappointment is radiating through and forcing this process to be more..uncomfortable, no. A mixture of apathy and depression briefly crosses her face. Not that it matters.

The right arm, holding her warpick is going to be a black sleeve with a red diamond and a fingerless glove, a reminder of both her and Catra's promotion to Force Commander even if it just for a day for her.

She-Ra is complaining,resisting and highlighting that she's despondent with the new changes, she wants to be like ***Mara.***

The left armor is armoured in segments and coloured in gold though, intended to be a grappling or a protective shield to grab or perform physical attacks with the protection style of a Force Captain.

The goddess cries out that she should be wearing long white pants and boots with golden wing decals, a long flowing blonde ponytail and a sword of course.

Not that it matters.

Lastly there's a head piece like before but its more of a half head piece rather than full like Catra's ending with each tip adorned in red.

And lastly, a sensible ponytail.

It's not perfect, but it'll do even if it's still uncomfortable like wearing a shoe with a hole in the front and a pebble in the back. This She-Ra will *fix things though.* Even if she looks unhappy when the two of them meet each other's gaze, there will be no magicant hero that the masses will *adore* , nor will she lead a victory parade or be expected to heal since she *failed at that.*

This She-Ra is fit for purpose, Force Captain Adora's purpose.

She strides closer towards until they're nearly touching , she looks up at herself and looks down at herself and they're out of the hanger now and instead at a-fork-in-the-road corridor with one moving into a lit path and the other not so well lit.

Force Captain Adora stares into the eyes of the She-Ra she mentally and emotionally created and says five simple words without any fanfare or above her normal voice speaking range.

“For the Honor, of Grayskull”

There’s movement in her limbs and bones, shuffling body parts being extended and then connected, familier flashes of light that need no introduction, neither does she need to punch her fist into her palm. She already thought this out, planned, adjusted and acted accordingly.

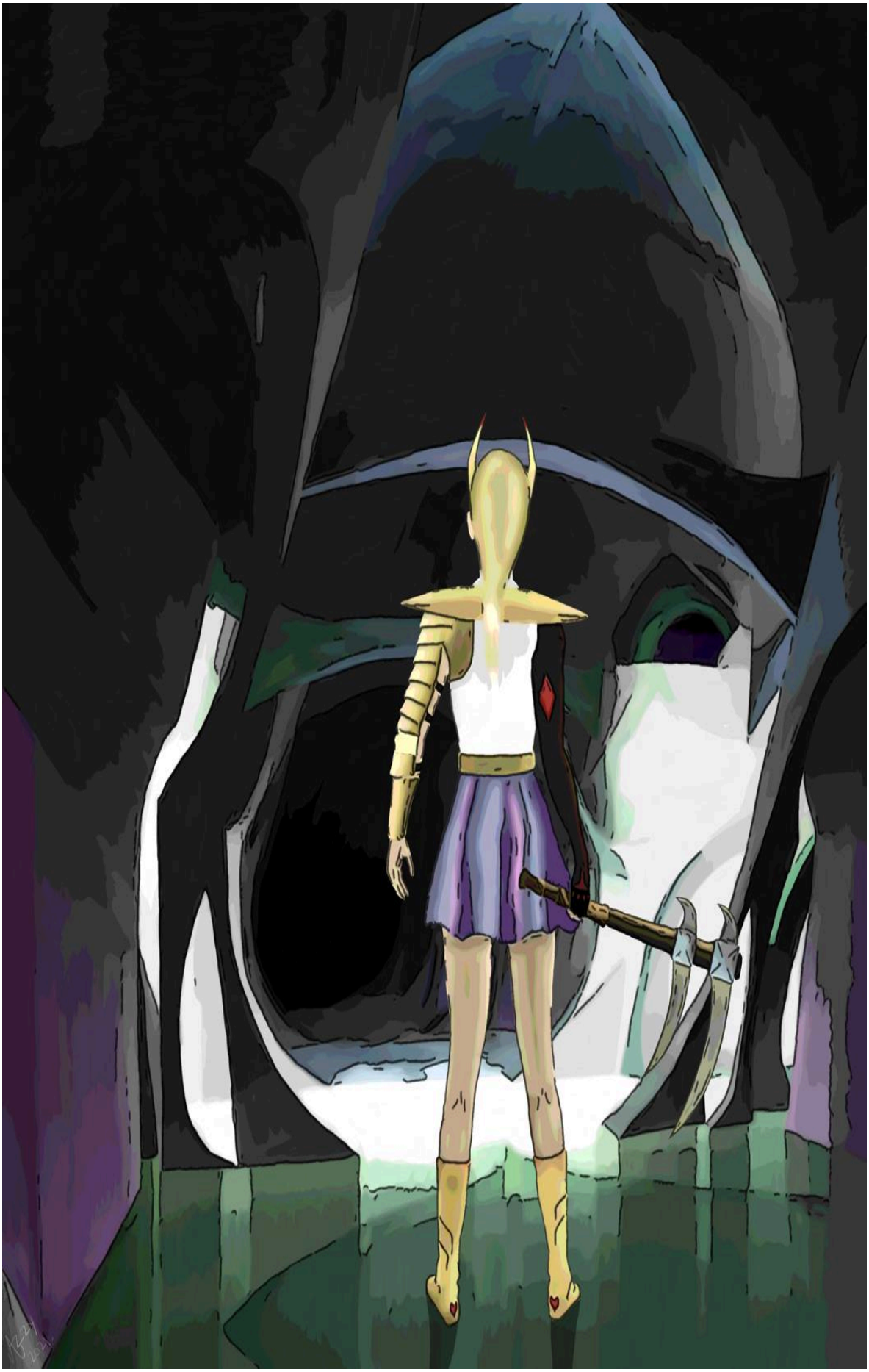
And in a few moments it’s over, she’s taller, stronger, faster and even that warpick is larger.

Step one: Find out where Prime is.

Step two: Kill Prime
Step three: Sabotage the ship and disrupt invasion plans.

She can do this.

She can fix this.



So yeah, I won't deny that this fic is the literal defination of "and then it got worse".

Somehow this was supposed to be like a 30k quick word and now we're standing...significantly more, with two chapters to go. This has been my most dialogue heavy fic and I'd like to believe that my writing has improved.

Writing this fic has kicked my ass quite a lot, I dont really enjoy hurting my favourite characters but in the end, it is what it is and I dont regret writing this.

Anyway, thanks for sticking around! I'll have the next chapter up in at least a month and then it should be finished by December, if you've enjoyed reading or just want to simply ask what kind of urge possessed me to write actual p a i n, leave a comment/review and tell me whats up! I do really love feedback <3

Artwork by Azzy https://www.instagram.com/p/CS9kDOrKrRd/?utm_source=ig_web_copy_link

IVC

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Author Notes 1/2. This is basically chapter IVB from before 24/11/2021 split into two, due to the length being 16-17k words before this date. I thought it's best to split it, so if you've read this before then there's nothing new, although please give the author notes at the bottom a read!

Chapter IV C:

Warriors.

Adora and She-Ra wrestle for control.
Defenses are activated.
The last Force Captain discovers Catra's final moments

Being She-Ra is a significantly more laborious process in every facet than it is being simply herself, the current transformation from a hundred and eighty to ninety centimetre Adora to a being topping out at almost *two-fifty* requires some *changes* and means of adaptation.

While basic body functions like walking is still as simple as any basic biological hydraulic actions, as She-Ra there's a small delay that's noticeable for anyone with enough perception to see that the person behind the mask of a eight foot tall superhuman-goddess-warrior is just *that,* they're wearing a suit significantly larger than *they are.*
~~~~~~~~

Sure that person can feel through the skin and a nervous system, see with perfect eyes and speak with a mouth or tongue that is as indistinguishably natural as any person, it's still different, *magically different.*

It's for this reason that, coupled with the noisy *thumping* of She-Ra's boots on perfect white metallic floors that Adora lets her mind wander as she proceeds closer to the first coloured pin on the mental map she devised for herself. That and she can automatically adjust herself to the slightly slower rhythm and movements of being three times the weight, and twice or more the size. Coupled with the additional weight of clothing,armor and the enlarged warpick that regular Adora would need *both hands for* and it's easier without enemies to prepare and rearrange her normal habits to this new form.

There's a tinge of regret as she passes through a walkway section that she's crossed twice, once from each avenue. She..regrets being harsh to Entrapta and not apologising or at the very least talking with the scientist, as uncomfortable as Adora felt around Trapta' with the strange cybernetic hair that she found to be off putting and the weirdly positive attitude towards failure, she should have at least said *something.* Rather than just leave.

Well, too late to go back now.

Up ahead there'll be a great pair of opened white doors with sparking blue teleportation emitters that were retracted in when she first arrived from this side (so she didn't notice) but did when leaving with Catra in tow. They're sparking because Entraptra split the fucking atom and blew up the infrastructure that allowed the Clones to simply reposition at will inside the ship in the same way they were able to pop up out of nowhere in Etheria and immediately begin fighting and those emitters *let Horde Prime escape.*

Catra.

Adora never did ask about that thump did she? Of course it'd be foolish to even consider the possibility that Catra had suddenly *rolled over and come awake* since Bow and Glimmer would have told her. Instead it's more reasonable to assume that Catra's weight had shifted during Adora's...experiences inside that room or something along those lines.

She does wish she was able to say goodbye, but she'd probably never leave that room if she did.

She-Ra is walking across the drawbridge on a far steadier gait than before, bits and pieces of Clones that were combusted by aborted teleportation lay scattered around her feet but she pays them no mind. Up ahead is Prime's command space, a circle-like star with the ends as walkways or drawbridges that branch off into other sections of the ship.

The screens are still busted and cracked and shattered from her being ragdolled into them repeatedly,traces of red blood stain the white *everything* and all of this pretty much means that it’s been left abandoned.

She picks up the dagger that was embedded in the Clone in that fight earlier where she and Catra battle for their lives against three clones, well she actually just picks up *that* Clone by the shoulder in one hand with little effort and nonchalantly slips the dagger out with her other.

It’s a tiny thing, while Adora could wield it as a half sword, for She-Ra it's a kitchen knife that stretches from the wrist to the tip of the middle finger. Glimmer and Bow gifted it to her as a backup weapon, she used to sleep with it under her pillow and during those times where she’d be interrupted, called for or startled awake Adora would always reach for it, a skill learnt during her time at the Crimson Waste.

Bow and Glimmer.

She really fucked that up didn't she? Referring to Glimmer’s father to throw the Queen off balance, not controlling herself emotionally and lashing out, she intentionally sabotaged her relationship, one that just minutes before had been one that Adora hoped to revive and strengthen and now she’s forever broken that link between the two of them.

It’s so Glimmer wouldn't come back.

And Bow? She feels like she failed him too in a way, the man always tried for positivity, for the better outcome and she blew him off *twice* . That's true regret staring her in the face but any other conclusion and she'd be on to the ship flying back to Etheria with no time, no plan and no hope of winning.

At least here she can make a difference, she has the tools in her arsenal to perform her plan.

When she dangles her feet off the edge of the hundred or more metre drop, she's reminded of when she almost failed to catch Catra, that the magicat could have just tumbled off the side and while Adora knows that she would have jumped after, surviving that kind of fall doesn't bring the same sure result that flinging herself across the floor and barely grabbing Catra by the arm and yanking her up.

A different Adora, maybe somebody younger without the bloodstained past of a Force Captain that survived two years or four deployments in the Crimson Waste and performed assassinations, battles and killed people with little hesitation would have done it differently.

Somebody younger,more innocent that never lost people could have had Catra ,an alive one and be together *maybe* but.

Well not *this* Adora anyway.

Whatever Adora wants is probably irrelevant at this point, She-Ra is uncomfortable with her presence and she feels more like an alien as the goddess than ever before, her relationship with Glimmer is busted and possibly thousands or even *millions* of Clones lay between her and Prime. No pressure, not like the fate of Etheria'll be decided on this mad charge straight into the unknown or anything.

Except maybe out of all of this all she truly wants is Catra, but for her? For Force Captain Adora? That opportunity is *dead* and buried and there's no going back. Not with Mara's ship having departed and she can't speak Clone or Prime's language anyway.

Force Captain Adora stares in the abyss that is the drop below her, behind is the spot where she tried in vain to summon She-Ra to save her and Catra from clones and it's ironic that this very spot where she stopped Catra from a plunge straight into the unknown is where she'll be jumping off herself.

In a bit.

A second?

A moment.

She-Ra is incredibly strong, able to withstand tank blasts and be smacked directly in the face with a stun baton and not even flinch. But this? This is *unknown* .

If Catra had fallen down there, would Adora, the simple human ,fragile, hurting Adora had jumped down there to save?

She doesn't need more than two seconds to answer that.

And so Adora, as She-Ra Princess of Power wearing a bastardized mixture of a goddess's outfit, elements of femininity that she never felt comfortable amount combined with the perceived armor and identification of a dual Force Captain/Commander role and then a conscious rebranding of clothes and items that she associated with Bow, Glimmer and Catra.

She squints harder when a small blinking light right at the edge of the bottom catches her eye, it's similar to the small flashing landing strips the Etherian Horde had at landing pads for their slowly dwindling fleet of Hovercraft.

It means there's something below. A few seconds and she makes out other small blinking lights that eventually become what seems to be an emergency exit or something?

Conformation it's not a bottomless hole anyway.

And so, she simply shuffles off the edge and braces for landing.

Hopefully it won't take more than a moment.

Or two.

Maybe three.

Four things occur, each happening roughly after the other.

The first is that while her ankles, legs and feet don't break the moment Force Captain Adora, transformed into a bastardized version of She-Ra hits the ground, rolls onto her back to spread out the impact and immediately manages to stagger up, her complete disregard for personal safety by throwing herself off a

literal cliff edge made something...crack. In more than a few places.

Secondly, and fortunately, She-Ra's completely insane levels of healing guarantees that the disturbing sounds are only temporary.

Next is that the small ground based lights, infact they're practically sunken into the floor transition from a faint blinking dim into lighting up the entire area and revealing that the space around is significantly larger than Adora initially anticipated.

It's actually fucking huge. Same boring and bland white but the architecture is less temple like and more maintenance, like it's not intended to be graced by Prime's presence.

Like if she peers to the left there's a tiny barely visible window that only barely reflects (thanks to distance) a distant star in the background ,although a good portion of it is blocked thanks to one of Prime's battleships being sort-of-in-the-way.

And lastly, there's either an invisible alarm that falls below She-Ra's excellent range of hearing in both positive and negative decibels or they're still connected to the Hivemind.

There's also something *strange* about how they move, they're limping suddenly and slow to react with blinking eyes and

furrowed expressions. It’s a weirdly fucked up comparison to the Clone's that moved with predictable and unchanging mechanical precision or whose only facial expressions were “smug”, “Prime” and “kill” with annoying religious undertones.

Naturally, dispatching them is easy. The war pick simply cuts through the Clone's genetically modified body far easier than any other weapon she’s used. The Clone's are slow to react and slow to move and slow to fight.

It’s kinda fucking disturbing.

The next four Clone's are in better shape, they form a small shield wall comparable to the training in dealing with numbers that she was taught (and later used) in the Horde with deployable force shields upfront and stun batons behind. It’s a physical impasse designed to make the enemy either flank or deal with it upfront.

For She-Ra, it doesnt f *ucking matter* at all. While she’s slower off the mark and takes an eternity to swing that warpick in comparison to Adora’s naturally quick movements, She-Ra simply demolishes the shield wall on the first go.

The terrifying brute strength of magically constructed muscles allows her first swing to not only puncture the energy shield but also the Clone behind and he simply flies backwards into a wall and crumples onto the floor in a boneless mess.

The Clones to the left and right react with military precision, they form up and flank her. Stun batons charged to max and shields held high.

So naturally she picks the left one up by the *throat* with her left hand and *squeezes* , the right Clone's stun weapon slams into She-Ra's elbow on full force, the electrical charge alone would have staggered even Force Captain Adora in full armor.

But She-Ra simply *doesn't care* . In fact she basically ignores that Clone who continues to uselessly strike at her and she kicks out at the third Clone who runs at her, her boot connects with the soft spot between the fuckers legs and incapacities him immediately.

She could practically do this in her sleep, simply go through the motions of training.

Clone number four loses the majority of his internal organs when both blades of connect with his chest and he simply falls down while the she was strangling is finally asphyxiated to death and drops like a brick and with three *dead* in mere moments, a feat she'd have to plan out for and account for all factors. Adora turns her attention to the annoying fly that's been batoning her arm six times in a row.

Casually, she winds up a haymaker with her *non-dominant hand* and delivers a punch so great that the Clone's head resembles a

burst watermelon.

Two things.

It’s quite evident that She-Ra is ludicrously powerful, she could have ripped those Clone's (beings made specially to be strong and tough and withstand beyond human levels of punishment) apart with her bare hands if she wanted to.

And that Prime is close, especially when she begins encountering groups of Clone's down winding corridors that she quickly separates into two categories, Clone's that are slow and unsteady and Clone's that function like the ones she’s used to.

Eventually she even uses them to navigate while casually cutting a bloody trail behind, if she finds a group that is basically half dead she’s getting *cold.*

If she finds Clone's that put up a fight (if you can call She-Ra throwing them into walls like they’re made of fucking paper a fight) she’s getting *hot.*

And they move to.

Adora hazards a guess that Prime is his own mobile version of a hivemind, the closer to him the more connected the Clone's are. With distance, they’re less capable.

Which means.

She’s getting near.

She can fix this .

With an increasingly animated set of Clone's that require more than a second to *kill* , she can *smell him.*

It’s just a set of rooms that probably lay between them now, ones with beds and tables and half eaten dinners ,some have force fields active, most done. The architecture is somewhat temple-like but more flared and dynamic , then again given the relative luxury of the rooms (on par with Brightrooms state rooms) this is a comfortable holding area for Prime’s “guests” and the area where Glimmer was held. Only her status as Queen prevented from being chipped..or executed.

There’s even one with a set of clothes scattered around the floor in the next corridor with the same layout as before. Black and red strewn about with a head piece of sorts and-

Oh.

She-Ra or is *it Force Captain Adora* or even just Adora bends down and gingerly picks up the black sleeve with her free hand, it's practically an *exact* mirror to her own right down to the fingerless glove and the red diamond symbolizing the fourth highest rank in the Horde.

The promotion she received for less than a day, the promotion Catra eventually received.

There’s the head piece next, a sore and sad looking thing now without the wildmane of hair it ties down and the user for it to sit on like a crown of some form.

These are Catra’s clothes.

There’s *twenty individual* sets of scratching clawmarks etched out on the floor all around her, the unmistakable prime hallmarks of the feet and hands of a Magicat.

To Adora’s immediate right is the shredded remains of a red shirt, judging by the number of rips it was basically *yanked apart* in four

separate directions while its accompanying garment is simply ripped in two.

Adora doesn't want to keep going but she forces herself to follow the breadcrumb trail of clothes that lead further up the hallway, past stateroom that havent been opened in years and some with dead occupants.

Catra's leggings are next in some disturbing triangle pile, each leg piece separated.

Oh god.

Even Catra's *underwear* was….

Shock and horror doesn't even begin to remotely describe that flurry of emotions that Adora feels when she begins processing the chain of events from…

Adora pushes past Entrapta to press a button that beeps on the console and calls out for Darla to patch the message through.

Catra was taken out of the teleportation room, kicking and screaming.

Catra's voice comes out of the transmitter and calls out for Adora, Adora answers back with a surprised yell of "Catra"

Catra probably resisted, clawing at least a few clones judging by the faint traces of red, at some point she tried to slow them down and went from scraping at the floor with the claws on her feet to desperately trying to use her hand ones aswell.

"Don't sound so happy to hear me, I'm sending Glimmer to you. I.. don't know where you are exactly but I can send Glimmer near you?. Adora. Be there to catch her. You have to.

"Catra, I dont understand, what the fuck is going-"

At some point while dragging her along the floor, the Clones began to strip her, initially they were somewhat gentle but as Catra resisted the Clone's hit her with a shock baton and then began ripping pieces off, starting with the overt headpiece (which they threw away) and then the arm sleeve which detonated her rank. Prime probably called for it to be removed, seeing stripping away Catra's position as symbolic or whatver the fuck the pretentious bastard thought was fitting.

"Just listen you fucking.., LOOK. I'm sorry. I know I've done bad but let me do one thing right-I"

The clawmarks eventually become knotted with blood, either with Catra's nails degrading and filing away to their roots or she found a Clone to attack, or both.

The Clone's also take the shirt off and its sister sections. At this point,they've fully dropped the niticies and stopped giving a single shit about the person wearing it and twist handfuls *off.*

Catra is grunting over the intercom, Adora can hear her fighting off attackers. And when Catra does speak it's teary and laden with emotions that bear a vulnerable scared girl at their heart.

"Adora? I-"

"Catra?!"

"I'm sorry Adora, for everything "

The fuckers dragged Catra like an animal to be slaughtered, they tore off her clothes with reckless abandon and probably with

those smug superior faces, Prime was probably watching or giving orders.

That bastard.

He.

He stripped Catra naked, even as she tried to hang onto things, walls, floors, Clones. She tried to stop herself from being transformed into a mindless drone and she was so scared. So terrified. Just like Little Catra that Adora too failed to protect from Shadow Weaver.

Adora failed Catra. She failed in her promise, she failed to take her home. She failed to protect her from Prime.

And she's wearing that arm sleeve with the diamond, and the head piece because she wanted to honor her?

She associated her cape with a royal purple sparkly style ,Glimmer's status as a Queen even though Glimmer was never prepared for her position and *hated it.*

Adora took Bow’s boots instead of the shirt that he took pride in, the hearts on the shin of the boots are forever looking backwards when Bow’s always been about seeing ahead.

She’s taken the status of being a Force Captain and forced She-Ra into it, even though She-Ra rebelled and is more uncomfortable with the idea of being connected with the Horde than *anything else.*

God.

Adora has managed to hurt everybody in her life hasn’t she? Forever pushing them apart over and over again until they’ve left. Or she’s forced them to.

She can't even pick up the headpiece, it’s staring at her and it *knows.* It recognizes what she’s done. It perceives that she’s relied on the past and look where it’s fucking gotten her. Adora’s fucked up every meaningful relationship she’s ever had, killed her friendships and left her alone in the prison section of a Temple-ship built by an obnoxious madman currently deluded that he's on the path to godhood.

Adora does not drop the arm sleeve and lets it down gently.

And then punches the energy shield protecting a room with zero occupants.

It flickers.

She punches it again.

She-Ra's hands are almost three times the size of regular Adora's, she's backed up by an incredible quantity of muscle that's considerably more powerful than anything natural.

The shield flickers again, faster.

Adora is panting, the heavy hoarse kind accompanied with a wet nose and a beating heart that comes not from sweat or exertion but a rapidly decaying grip on sanity and lurching closer to *losing it.*

It's not positivity, laughter, friendship or even hope that's filling her veins , wrapped around her heart or present in her mind.

God's she's gonna fucking explode.

It's anger, rage, self loathing and a desire to kill every single being on this ship and gut Horde Prime from top to bottom and hang his brutalized remains to be nailed to the front of his temple ship and forever flutter in space.

The shield breaks completely on the fourth (or is it fifth?) strike, there's no explosion. Just a quiet stutter and cessation of

operations.

It doesn't make her feel better, infact she’s worse off now.

Bow’s usually the friendship stuff and talk out your feelings guy!

I’m the punch your feelings out guy!

When the Clone's find her, when its a company sized task force of specifically equipped soldiers laden with heavy *white* body armor that fits seamlessly into white clothing, a heavy stunbaton on the right arm that is wired directly into the body with a large shield on the left.

When the Clone’s fill up both sides of the corridor, fifty behind and fifty infront and stop marching from perfect lockstep formation and form a physical barrier fifteen crouching Clone's wide and two Clone's deep.

When they start chanting that annoying fucking phrase over and over again that Adora cannot understand, translate or even want

to.

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide !

When Adora, still She-Ra. When she looks up at them with a piece of Catra’s clothing in her hands that are pressed to her head and she’s silently nuzzling it, breathing in the scent of a dead woman she desperately tried to keep alive with pills,willpower and her fucked up idea of love.

When the Clone's began marching forward in perfect sycronziaton, their blank faces endlessly murmuring their religious bullshit and weapons raised high.

Only then does a great ironic epiphany reach her. A moment of clear realization that is whiter than the Clone's ,the floor, the fucking walls and even the dinner plates hit her.

She can finally do one good thing, she’s surrounded from all sides and will probably die at some point but that doesn't matter anyway because she can *fix it.*

She can fix it.

So she stands and towers over even the Clone phalanx, she extends her weapon fully and tightens her knuckles, she breathes out and lets the world settle over her. Adora blinks at the Clone's that are four metres out and she can already taste and feel and smell the electroshocks that could probably overwhelm a persons system with the pain alone.

And she doesnt give a single flying fuck about them.

She-Ra swings her weapon widely and sweeps over the front of the first Phalanax and catches the faces of three Clone's in the blades, she rips their fucking noses and eyes and tongues and necks off and grabs the fourth one line in one and simply *tanks* the electric discharge of a sharpend prod in her chest when it actually hurts.

The fourth Clone, wrenched away from haphazard safety in its shield wall, is used in the same way a desperate person uses a tree branch as a weapon. *It's feet connect with another Clone and knock them over, its then flung into the shield wall coming from behind and slams its fellow's to the floor.*

She-Ra hacks and slashes next, penetrating deep into the shield wall and ignoring the pain, actual pain that she a goddess *can* feel. She punches the vital organs of Clone's right out of their

bodies, she cuts them in half or slices limbs off with her weapon, she picks Clone's up and throws them so high that they *crunch* into the ceiling and fall back down straight onto their fellows. She kicks Clone's hard enough that their spine breaks and the stream of blood gathers at her boots.

It’s mind numbing in a way, the sounds of battle are deaf to her ears even while she’s caught between screaming at the Clone's as they die in horrific expendable ways or shouting to the stars that she tried to do everything right and she’s *sorry Catra.*

Adora even calls a Clone “Glimmer” before she shatters its ribcage.

Seventy of them are already dead and their bodies lay in various stages of mutilation, there’s a small pile around Adora’s feet and even though she’s laying waste to the company of Clone's set after her, even though they’ve hurt her *and it’s not enough to even damage a limb.* Even though their comparients in battle are practically being slaughtered, the Clone's keep coming, they keep throwing themselves at her.

Sure they use tactics, sure they switch from defensive shield walls to offensive pincer attacks and surround her on all sides and come at her six at a time, none of it fucking matters when She-Ra can shrug off hits, *kill them* in one hit and predict thier every movement because their dead fucking eyes betray that thier forever bound to mindless repetitive behaviour.

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide. Even then they’re still fucking speaking the same words over and over again.

They keep coming, like they're expendable.

They die in droves, like their lives don't matter. *At all.*

And very soon, they’re all dead. Just a bunch of white corpses in a white corridor with white walls and white halls and a white roof.

It takes five minutes for the echoes of battle to die down, for Adora’s hypervigilance to singal the all clear, for her nostrils and mouth to cease expelling oxygen at the rate of overproduction, for her heart and nervous system to wind down production of adrenaline and stop causing her muscles to *twitch* and *tic.*

She sighs, takes in a quick breather and tries to avoid the *stench.* It’s always been like this if the past four years of warfare from one side of Etheria to the other, from fighting the gangs of the Crimson Wastes, her own former fellows in the Horde, Rebellion Soldiers as a Force Captain and the now Prime's forces.

Catra’s clothes are stained with blood and smell like *Prime* when she tries to pick them up . They’re tainted forever and there goes the last piece of Catra for Adora.

Everyone shits themselves when they die, they stink of blood and worse if the internal organs end up hanging out of the body or are strewn everywhere and intermingle with *everything else.*

Fuck there's a disembodied head of a clone looking right at her. It's eyes are still full of life.

She feels something pool in her stomach.

When she stands on extremely tall legs she almost slips on punctured intestines and all the *shit* that comes with it.

This is fucking disugsting and she has to put a bloody hand over her mouth to cover herself from the sheer squalid stench.

She's never experienced this many corpses in such a small space and she-

That pool is moving now.

She needs to fucking get away and calm down and-

She throws up.

Whatever remains of ration bars, MREs ,water and anything else eaten or drank from the past six hours are ejected from Adora's gullet and cover a dead Clone in acid and partially digested *whatever.*

She didn't know She-Ra was capable of throwing up.

Or that her boots are no longer wet.

Adora breathes out and slides down a un bloodied wall, her grey tanktop riding up at the back and causing her skin to scrape across metal, she hits the top of her knees and tastes skin from the ripped parts that leave skin exposed, her warpick that’s the size of her arm and impossible to lift without both hands drops to the floor with a monstrous clattering ring that makes her *wince in pain* .

She’s just killed a hundred people, well if Clone's *count as people* in the space of twenty minutes and she still doesn't feel any better.

Her hands are wet when she manages to *tear* them away from her face, there’s no scarring on her body or malformed limbs via exhaustion and malnutrition, she’s not bone tired or fatigued or spent on the outside, in fact she’s perfectly fine. Like she never left the intense physical conditioning of the Force Captain regime that allowed her to go toe to toe with Huntara.

But she still feels like she needs to sleep forever, the ghost of frozen hypothermia to blazing skin melting hyperthermia lurks beneath the epidermis layer and if she looked in a mirror, she knows who she’d be staring back at.

She’s not She-Ra anymore is she? The non giant hands, the size of the warpick, exposed armor rather than armored, and stands of dirty blond hair that get in her eyes seem to confirm that. And if she tries to go back, she *fizzies.* A mental block or a space that simply is simply negative with nothing inside where She-Ra used to be is all that her concentration can find.

She can barely lift the fucking war pick.

Adora can take on two, maybe three clones at a time.

She’s surrounded by bodies, Catra’s scattered clothing lay around and it’s fucked up and bloody and smells of death rather than a brief smattering of nostalgia.

And Prime is over *there.*

Whatever Adora wants has disappeared from her reach forever, She-Ra is gone, her relationship with Glimmer and everyone she’s ever known in her life is busted or they’re straight up dead and no one is coming back because she made sure of that, a completely unknown amount of Clone's lay between her and Prime. Her mad charge straight into the heart of the enemy has produced an

expendable pile of bodies at her feet and she’s achieved naught except jump down a death trop and casually slaughter a hundred people.

All she wanted *from whatever this was supposed to be is* Catra, butCatra is dead? Is she Force Captain Adora now, is she General Adora? Is she just Adora?

She doesnt know, she’s physically fine on the outside but the inside is a swirling mass of *fuck* and emtions that threaten to burst out of their safe if she even dares to think about introspection. All she can do is move forward and hope for the best.

And Adora is *here.*

Eventually she registers something external from her very internal world. Shuffling sounds from outside the corridor become a familiar marching movement. Three pairs of legs, heavier than normal from the Clone's fifty five minutes ago but the same weight from fifteen.

She feels hollow,empty. Catra is gone forever, Glimmer hates her, Bow is disappointed. Netossa lost her wife, Lonnie and Rogellio lost their boyfriend, Mermista had her boyfriend taken away from her and the Rebellion lost its prime General who served for thirty years.

And she’s still here somehow, surrounded on all sides. With three Clone's coming towards her, they’re casually disregarding their own and simply march over the remains of their fellows. Shielded,armored and with a different kind of baton.

They probably want to kill her.

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide!

And they’re fucking chanting, do they ever just-?

“Could you shut the fuck up for three seconds?”

Adora grunts and lifts herself up on her knees, holds the warpick in one hand and drags it along with her as she goes to meet them.

Four metres and Adora takes up a war pick that's the length of her arm all the way from finger tip to shoulder and hefts it two handed.

She sidesteps to the left as a faint, the Clone's moves to counter predictably and she uses the incredible weight of the weapon to swing to the right suddenly, it’s so *fucking heavy* that she physically *moves* with it and succeeds in both cutting through the Clone's shield,arm and torso but also nearly falling over herself as she completely fails to counter balance the extended attack.

Adora barely recovers as the next Clone comes forward, its fellow moving in tandem to flank, she manages to turn her weapon sideways and block the electric baton in the warpicks middle although the kinetic aftershock from the Clones sheer strength and force of the impact ripples in her fingers and forces a pained *grunt.*

“Fuck you” She aims a spit at the Clone's face and it doesnt even grunt, she kicks directly into its crotch and it fails to flinch, turns out Clone’s are not equipped with reproductive organs.

She’s kicked back and staggers so badly that she barely recovers in time from the second Clone’s attack that she barely manages to duck a swing aimed at her head and while she succeeds in cleaving off that Clone’s arm with her counter attack, she’s flung

so far forwards by the *weight* and her off centered *posture* that she has to drop her weapon or risk being catapulted to the floor.

Still, she fights on. Breathing and panting and trying to focus through mental baggage and emotional turmoil and hoping that these'll be the last three and then it's just *Prime.*

Down to her dagger that somehow stayed in her stark clothing despite the unintended transformation, she manages to get a knife directly between the shoulder blades of the one-armed Clone and incapacitates it immediately if the twitching limbs and sudden collapse is anything to go by..

But her wrist is then seized by the last Clone and it squeezes so hard that she *yowls* and *screeches* and *screams* in pain as her bones feel like they're gonna be completely *crushed* , her dagger is dropped to the ground and she manages a finger jab into the Clone's eye, it lets go and staggers back.

And then it's a fist fight with a Clone that's a head taller than her and twice the weight, and it's armed with a baton.

Shaking her damaged wrist and hoping it goes do limp, Adora manages to avoid the first baton strike, the shoulder smacks in her leg and she barely manages to wince that one off even though her leg is fucking *crying* for *mercy* .

Defensive forearm blocks hurt when they're electrocuted, physically battered and scorched by the static alone.

Strike number four misses, five is baited by a sidestep and the Clone over extends, it's quicker than the last two and although it recovers in record time, Adora gets behind and sweeps a *good* leg under the Clone's own, it's weight imbalance and poor timing cause it to collapse onto its back and Adora wastes no time in-

Getting on top of the Clone and pinning its arms to the ground with her body, grabbing both sides of its head and slamming it down repeatedly ,over and over again with as much force as she can muster as the Clone tries in vain to *get up* , even in this state it nearly succeeds in rising and throwing her off but she keeps *going.*

The world goes away, the blackness fades and red is all that's left.

The Clone is dead.

Adora feels even *worse* when she finally recovers and looks around to find out that the warpick has disappeared.

She's *panting* from exertion, *bleeding* from her forearms, her leg needs to be twisted back in place and her heart is still going *fucking* crazy. Everything hurts, again.

And there's more shuffling this time that turns into marching movement, perfectly placed in lockstep and parade style precision.

And it's far more than three pairs of legs.

Author Notes 2/2

So thank you for reading! As promised these are the current notes as of 24/11/2021 or November 24th 2021.

As it stands I hope to have chapter VA out by next week, roughly wednesday or before since that seems to be a decent time to upload. And while it could be just one chapter, it does seem like the total length will be more than I'd like to point out and then after that and VB then it should just be VI to write, with a current upload speed of one chapter every three weeks Be Brave should be done by the end of 2021, if not then the first week of Jan.

This fic has very much been a strain to write, I have not enjoyed hurting Adora and everyone at all but at the same time, I *need* to get this done, I *need* to get this written. And being able to close

this fic will be closing off an unfortunate portion of my life too (for the better).

Anyway chapter VA was supposed to be released earlier this month but I tried my hand at writing another Cyberpunk fic, got 60% of the way and I couldn't do it so that's where the previous three weeks have gone - into basically nothing.

Anyway thank you for the reading, and I hope you'll enjoy the final three chapters of We Must Be Strong (and we must be brave) as like the tag, everything just keeps getting worse.

VA

Adora is back in Brightmoon, just her. Just Adora. Without her sword and without She-Ra, without armor and a weapon, Michah has gone to the front to stabilize it, Bow went to the FrightZone to find Glimmer.

The planet has been "saved". The magical bomb slowly gaining power at the core for centuries or maybe thousands of years has been deactivated, they're saved from an implosion that would rip Etheria apart and kill everyone and everything on it.

It should be a victory, especially with She-Ra gone but it isn't.

Glimmer is nowhere to be found and the same goes for Catra and Hordak as the with Horde's last two remaining high level members absent the massive organisation will fracture and split into pieces. And with Glimmer AWOL, there's no one in charge with the authority or rank and Adora ain't She-Ra no more. And they've teleported and there's fucking stars in the sky.

She's checked the bedrooms, the kitchen, the war room. Running faster and faster until she's nearly out of breath, a mixture of anxiety,rage and failure pool in her gut as she's red in the face and trembling. The Guards are useless, the staff are fucking hopeless and anyone with any kind of rank is out fighting.

T *here is no sweet smell of victory when she enters the throne room, the former domain of Queen Angella that Adora failed in both her promise and mission - to protect Glimmer. To keep everyone safe.*

Victory over the Horde and Light Hope is exactly what Adora wanted, but Catra is gone. There is no sweet smell of accomplishment, no large party with the drinking of glasses and maybe a prostitute or two. No one to celebrate with, just Adora left to her thoughts and devices as she desperately attempts to fix things.

Adora enters the throne room stressed, angry and tired. Thoughts of naught but loneliness and failure bouncing around in her head.

She searches, side glaces left and right. Nobody.

The throne itself has it's back to her.

"Glimmer?" She calls out with a hoarse and pained voice in vain hope.

The two guards permanently assigned to it stand at the side nervously, giving each

other awkward looks.

"Glimmer?"

The throne turns round, instead of the short stature, royal outfit and staff with the slick hair and the inexperienced administration of Queen Glimmer is what can only be described as a black tentacle of a " living creature" with a mask, sitting on that throne with the most smug and disgustingly self-congratulatory pose.

It's fucking Shadow Weaver, the abusive, manipulate cockroach that relied on a naive Adora to heal her and a young Queen to fuel her ambitions.

And she's just…

No.

No.

NO.

No not this time.

Adora see's absolute fucking red at the edges and then it pools down to encompass everything. Shadow Weaver has always done this, wormed her way into a position of invaluable support to organisations and made herself almost impossible to dislodge, or she'll latch onto people and force dependence.

With Glimmer gone, Etheria thrown into absolute chaos and every single person of authority strewn out and unable to respond, Shadow Weaver will do it again.

Unless Adora can stop her. Stop her from assuming control and leeching on to someone or something else.

“Come now Adora, doesn't victory taste sweet?”

Fist’s tightening so hard that nails are breaking into skin and making it bleed.

“I imagine that after some time, new political organisations will be needed to mop up after the chaos but everything has worked out quite well don't you think?”

No weapons, she can't exactly attack the guard but..there has to be something else.

Shadow Weaver’s voice is still drawling and dripping with smugness and reinforced by that slouching lax position on a throne that she coveted and will finally achieve in the absence of others.

Adora searches frantically for a weapon, a dagger, a sword, a shield even. Something to throw or…

There’s a purple armchair lurking in the corner.

That’ll do.

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Chapter V A:

Promise I

Adora finds everything she's been searching for.

Love, life, friends.

Those to care for, and those who will care for her.

Her head is absolutely fucking *killing* her when the faint sliver of consciousness rears it's ugly self and prods her to wake up out of what seems to be like a medically induced coma with three pills designed to knock the *user* the fuck out for days.

There's images, flashes and static. Sounds and memories of stun batons on leather raiders and gangsters, flashes of piles of corpses and the faint smell and vocal sound of victory.

And static of well, something she can't remember since it's basically fuzzy and as incomprehensible as trying to scale a vertical wall.

When life begins to flood back into her body after a dead sleep, her senses register that she's lying on a flat,hard bed like the one she ordered specifically..somewhere? And that there's something nestled against her, specifically it's like a massive pillow that's nestled comfortably and sleepily into the gap between Adora's arm and torso.

And then whatever it is, kisses her shoulder longingly and tenderly, the feel of a wet peck on her skin is enough to light up the nerves in it and bring back the odd sensation faster than being hit with a stun baton and she wakes up *real fucking quick* .

Adora see's it, the *something.*

It's a wild mess of brown hair that hasn't been brushed since last night, no buzz cut and no headband. It's unscarred arms and legs, it's marking stripes without tattoos, it's a bare neck with untarnished and unburnt fur.

A bare neck without a *chip.*

Adora wakes up with Catra nestling into her with her head on Adora's shoulders.

"Morning sleepyhead"

What.

"C-Catra?"

Jutting awake and with open eyes and initial alarm, Adora's heart beat spikes at the sleepy vocalisation of the Magicat snuggled up

next to her but it then drops off to normal as she begins to register that it's normal for Catra to be with her, they did sleep together as Cadets and when she was going to be-..

Catra lightly kicks at Adora's shins as she stretches out with a soft yawn and lightly pokes Adora in the freckles under her eyes.

"Hey, sleep well?" That question is enough to throw off the static with Adora instead sighing and bumping her forehead against Catra's while also slowly rubbing at her back.

"Not really but-"

She hurts all over but the soothing presence of Catra is enough to overwhelm the pain, it's kind of strange though that she feels like she *should* miss Catra and it's been *years* but its stupid because they were together *yesterday* after coming back from the - uh.

The uh.

The thing?

Catra also looks different but the same? The hair tufts are there, the red and black clothing with the collarbone cover and the ripped pants are in the corner right next to Adora's own pristine and perfectly kept *ripped and shredded and* - intact red jacket. It's odd, one eye reports one image and the other visualizes something else.

“I feel better with you here, it’s like we haven't done this in *ages* ” Adora says with a smile as the familiar rumble of a light purr drifts into her ears and it’s so fucking calming, why does she miss this?

Catra blinks, reaching across to lightly scrape along Adora’s exposed collarbone lazily, it’s her way of saying *dummy.* They’re both in sleeping clothing, tanktops that show most of the skin and basically boxers, legs tangled up and they’re so pressed and touching that the body heat alone of skin on skin is *enough* to keep them both warm.

“Dummy” Catra says it anyway and it’s kind of relieving to hear that instead of...something else? Anyway Adora lets her fingers travel around Catra’s back and the Magicat rolls over fully onto her stomach and buries her head right into Adora’s shoulder and it’s adorable, so adorable that Adora’s studying all of the freckles and features on Catra’s upper face, her cute nose, her glorious beautiful eyes and the twitch of her ears with a “hrrmph” when Adora blows on them lightly.

Fuck, she missed this.

Catra shifts in her embrace and soon the warm sounds of a content Magicat are joined by the light tapping of a tail and Adora kinda just wants to take it in her hands and run her fingers along but she’s too busy lightly petting the woman lying with her.

“I missed you” She croons with the *absolute* stupidest grin but she doesn't care how sappy she looks because it’s one hundred percent *true.*

Catra raises her head and makes contact, Adora is absolutely lost in those *eyes* and that *look* and her breath hitches and she forgets what she was going to say because fuck her heart is going *nuts* and theres a *ache* in her stomach and she just wants to-

“Adora we’ve literally been in bed for ten hours, is that promotion such a big thing that you forgot?”

Catra laughs, not in the way that Adora remembers, it's not an evil kind of giggle..uh, *it’s ?not?.* It’s like how Cadet Catra *used* to sound.

And promotion, *what promotion* ? And *ten hours* ?

How did she forget? Anxiety begins to slowly pool back and Adora’s legs and arms do their telltale panic twitch of anxiety that Shadow Weaver bred into her and she begins that unsteady breathing again and-

“Hey? Adora!”

That sound, the unique vocalization of words from the one person that ever truly *understood* her, *got* her, breaks through the

momentary instilled reactionary panic state and brings Adora back into the *real* world.

With Catra, who looks at her with the most worried, loving and nostalgic expression, a Catra that strokes Adora's left cheek with trailing fingers and interlocks the digits on her other hand with Adora's. She's so *warm* , so *soft* , so. *.Catra* .

"Catra?" Is the only word she can say, the only person she can see, the only thought in her head.

Catra tilts her head,smiles and slips her fingers down slowly to cup Adora's chin.

"Don't flake out on me now - *dummy* , *Stay* with *me* , okay?"

"Adora"

Whatever Catra is saying is drowned out, the movements of vocalisation from red lips are all Adora can focus on visually and physically she's squeezing Catra's hand with her own and receiving the same pushback.

Catra is fucking beautiful. And it's like she never left.

It’s all there, pieces of a puzzle finally making sense and a love confession too many years in the making that have gone unrecognised and pushed down under the weight of responsibility.

Adora just could.

The soft feel of a tail stroking along uncovered and bare skin, touching and wrapping around a knee.

Adora could let her eyes linger on lips, let her gaze lock enough for Catra’s own multicolored ones to get the hint and maybe she’ll peer down to see Adora’s lips wetten and lips slowly pursing open.

Maybe.

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Promotion day - it sticks in her head and she rolls it around to make sense of it like she would the correct sounding command with a debating tongue in her mouth that lolls around until it sounds right. She’s supposed to be promoted to Force Commander today, number four in the Horde behind the guy who’s out keeping a considerable navy from...one of the (enemy states?) from interdicting supply lines, then Shadow Weaver as number two and then Hordak himself.
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When she dresses in the mirror, transforming from the tanktop she's worn for years there are noticeable differences that *stick out* , lines of stress that should be highlighted on undamaged features, scars and bruises that never got to time to heal should appear *there* and yet all there is - is just skin. Healthy skin, golden hair in a neat ponytail without the hair poof, eye's without bags and a torso with healthy fat lines instead of exposed ribs from malnutrition.

Catra looks different too, there is the shaking feeling at the back of the mind but that is pushed away from with the uneasy paranoia that keeps screaming *that something with a long blonde ponytail and white leggings and is invisible is somehow registering in peripheral senses* , but that too is shoved into a safe and dumped into a river.

There's no diamond shaped breastbone gap in the clothing, just ripped leggings, exposed and gorgeous tiger stripes and the Magicat herself.

It's all neat in a way, ordinary and nostalgic somehow? Despite that they clearly went to bed yesterday after they did... *something?* If Adora fails to remember then it probably isn't important so *whatever.* She couldn't remember even if she tried which is weird considering that she had a excellent memory but-

Form fitting cream shirt, red and white boots, Horde markings and a red jacket that fits a small protective breastplate over.

She sneaks glances at Catra as they take turns in the mirror to get dressed, Adora's heavier and protective clothing taking longer and Catra assist's with the armour plates and the jacket since it's an uncomfortable fit.

Adora helps with Catra's hair, making sure to hold it back for the headpiece to come on and to transform the mousy brown hair from scruffy and wild to a neat straight and tight, perfect for the ceremony and celebration of her role as Force Captain Adora's number two during the war for the Crimson Waste.

Touching Catra's arms and neck, lingering fingertip grazes over brown horizontal stripes and adjusting hair almost feels like how it used to? Like it was years ago except they literally just slept together. Like they did years ago. It's a strange delayed feedback from the skin to the nerve endings to it being registered, Adora chocks it up to the headache that's gone now in record time making her groggy.

Adora leans over to Catra, rubs her Magicat on the shoulder and goes to get promoted.

It feels like there's something in the mirror watching the two girls leave, eye's glued onto their backs and it's got a sword?

Adora doesn't dare risk looking at it though.

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The hallways of the Fright Zone are still the same, the same engineered and manufactured prefabricated corridors that link up in a perfect grid pattern, the same dull green painting and the occasional camera at the end, it all reflects a brutalist style of architecture, bare building materials and structural elements with angular geometric shapes and lacking timber and glass with only clear glass windows allowing a inspective peek into large rooms.

It’s cold and soulless and could easily be *white?* Adora doesn't know how she makes that connection, the fortress style mentality with the grinding gears of machinery and exact specifications of length,width and height meant to rapidly facilitate the immediate and emergency deployment of a half platoons width and a companies depth in a single area is oddly familiar to a series of endless corridors and perfectly crafted walkways.

Green not white.

Catra’s tail lingers and occasionally twists around her forearm as they walk together through the seeming maze of the Fright Zone but having lived their lives there (bar two) they’re able to easily navigate without even thinking.

A group of soldiers, wearing their helmets and the only identification marks being serial numbers and any exposed appendages wave and cheer before snapping at attention as they walk by. Adora manages a brief, blushing and confused wave while Catra sniggers and gets elbowed.

“What are they all looking at?”

Adora cocks her head to Catra and whispers.

“Us? I think? You see those numbers?” Catra’s brow furrows and she gestures with a thumb back to the serial identification on the right shoulder of the soldiers.

Adora mentally files through her unit rosters and in a few seconds, figures it out.

“Eighth battalion, those were our reserves in the Crimson Waste right?”

“Yeah, didn't need it though did we? The war went *perfectly* and you’re the hero of the hour”

Adora blushes at those words and scoffs, elbowing Catra lightly in the side.

“ *We’re* the heroes of the hour, couldn't have done it without you could I?”

Catra makes a pleasant noise in return before lightly returning the elbow, it's a good enough distraction from the writing on the wall as they go past it, Adora catches on and Catra ignores it like it was *invisible* or something.

Eighth battalion, second company was completely destroyed by Tung Lashor's gang before they could muster a defense.

She looks at it, stares, processes and a brief flashback of her holding a crumpled fax from one of the last functioning machines able to transmit and receive messages over the long distance, bad news of crippled reinforcements and affirming that they were on their own, just Adora, Catra and their reinforced but battered battalion left in the Wastes and surrounded on all sides and-

"Hey Adora? Adora!"

"Huh?" The clinking of strengthened boots and armor plating stop as Adora comes face to face with a support beam, she's. She nearly walked into it and Catra is tugging on her shoulder and gone from pleasant and supportive to worried..a second? A minute? The Horde Soldiers down the end of the corridor have *disappeared* completely and so has the *writing on the wall.*

Did she black out?

Catra grabs her face and she *grunts.* "Did you get hit on the head or something *dummy?* I figured that hair poof from last night would have softened the blow or something and I-"

"Hey!" Adora turns round and headlocks her Magicat with a grin, they start lightly playfighting like in the old times except she can't

ruin Catra's hair and instead resorts to laughing and pushing her around softly, Catra half dodges with a smile and just pulls Adora's arms in random direction and it's like she *never left* and-

"Are you ever not going to fall for that?"
"Come on, that was one time like could you let it go?"
"Not until you admit you like me!"

Sure she cant give Catra a noogie anymore but they are back to their old lives, the pre war cadets of the past take control in rambunctious playfighting where the two of them at twenty now are ignoring the cold of the Fright Zone and the perfect manufactured walls and the formation movements for Promotion day and they're electing it to spend time with each other.

"Don't make me kick your butt!""
"Pfft, as if you could"

She's chasing Catra around with glee and at full speed, completely uncaring of how she's viewed to the outside world, past an armoury, past responsibilities. Adora is impulsive, hyperactive and focused on the only person who ever understood her, Catra is so close and everything is on the best definition, Catra's freckles and lips when she laughs and bats Adora, the sparkle in her eyes and neatly trimmed eyelashes, hell even the physics of Catra's hair are given attention.

When Adora *smiles* , an expression that she’s forgotten for years, it's for *real.* When she laughs, it’s hearty and stupid and *geniune* .

When she gets to headlock Catra briefly and then lets go, her hands and fingers run along light fur and bare skin, her hot breath falling on twitching ears and making hair stand up. It’s like she never left and all of those pains of the past, the *violence* , the *abuse* , and *leaving?* .

It all melts away, because she’s *actually fucking happy* for once in her life and Catra is right by her side. It’s all carefree and fun, and it feels like it’ll never end.

Adora is here, and *Catra* is here. And she wouldn't want it any other way.

Everything is perfect.

The sound of three pairs of two footsteps, small,medium and heavy break the sort of dance that Adora has going on Catra and a stuttering nervous voice breaks the silence before she can respond or even wiggle her hands out of Catra’s.

“Um, Ad-Force Captain Adora?”

It’s a boy, well a man the same age as them. Twenty years old, skinny with an ill suited cream and red shirt and carrying something.

The scratchy voice alone has the power to make everything *halt,* make the grinding gears *stop* and everything turns upside *down* , it’s a voice that makes her turn in her sleep, a stark image among hundreds that makes her throw up when no one’s looking and right now everything is starting to fucking *spiral* out of *control.*

It’s Kyle, fucking Kyle. The anxious awkward boy in love with a lizard that she hasnt seen for three years and he’s supposed to be fucking dead, the last person Kyle screamed for was for Adora to save him before he drowned in quicksand and this doesnt fucking any fucking sense because fucking Kyle is right fucking here.

What the fuck.

She’s spiralling, twitchy nerves, a trembling upper lip and the need to flee, to find a safe place with a empty basin and spew out a half digested meal while she grips onto harsh porcelain and-

And-.

It’s gone.

The fu- the stomach churning and the sudden bout of hyperactive senses bolting into action, it’s all just disappeared and she’s

struggling to even remember what she was supposed to be anxious about.

Infact, Force Captain Adora is quite *happy* to once again see one of her soldiers of *yesterday* , Kyle.

“Kyle?”

“F-Force Captain A-Adora? I- I made you a cake as a thank you gift and I-” Kyle doesnt get to finish the rest of his sentence before Lonnie manages to wrestle the cake out of his hands as Adora hug tackles him against the wall, her heart is going nuts and for a second Kyle reeks of sand but she doesn't care.

“How did you get out of the quicksand? Thought you were gone” *I thought you were dead.*

“ *Kyle, watch the archers! Lonnie get on the shields, Rogellio use that trump stump as cover! Move Move Move!”*

“Kyle watch out!”

Kyle sniffles when he answers and he goes from a loose embrace that was automatic because Adora tackled him into something more friendly, his skinny arms tighten around Adora’s torso and he-. He chokes a little.

“You saved me, remember Force Captain? Dragging me out at the last second with a traitor on your back?” Kyle recounts, no longer smelling of sand and maybe a bit stale but Adora doesn't give a shit right now ,she’s too enthused with positive energy at the news! Even if she can't *remember* hauling Kyle out at all.

Whatever it doesn't *matter* , she has her wonderful Catra that she spent the night with and woke up to and did her make up with, she Lonnie to her left who’s come out of her hardass shell and is graciously smiling at Kyle, she has Rogello being mock jealous and she has Kyle in her arms who avoided death at the last moment.

Everything is perfect.

And those words on a nearby door that look like they’ve been inscribed with the tip of a oddly familiar knife that no one else has noticied can fuck off.

Adora is happy. She’s going to get promoted today.

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There is quite frankly, a lot of pressure. All the battalions of the Horde stand ready and waiting and their eyes will be on her the moment she begins her steps to the viewing platform where Hordak will be waiting, Lonnie will be watching, Kyle and Rogellio and every single Force Captain, Force Cadet and member of the Horde alive will witness her.
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“Shit Adora! You okay?”

And she’s so...anxious, nerves are getting twitchy and her leg won't stop bouncing as Force Captain Adora suffers in silence, what if she trips up the stairs and proves herself to be an embarrassment? What if she fucks up her speech, what if she falls, what if Adora fails?

“Adora!”

Adora is suddenly turned around and shaken out of her self inflicted anxiety and greeted right in the face by a pair of mismatched eyes, perfect makeup and flawless hair. The induced nervousness dies down right at the sight of Catra, when she manages to find the ability to breathe it’s all scent of Magicat, soft fur and twenty years together and never leaving each other's side.

“Hey, Dummy!” Catra calls out and shakes her again, rapidly blinking as if woken from a deep sleep Adora manages to regain her senses and footing and stutters out a short “wha?” before coming awake. Her trembling fingers find purchase in Catra’s waist and everything feels right again.

Catra smiles softly and she’s purring almost immediately at the touch.

“Hey Adora”

Biting her bottom lip and reaching up to clasp the fingers of her left hand with Catra's, Adora feels at peace again.
"Hey Catra"

"I uh, so feeling better?"
"Mhmmm"

"Glad to be of service Force Captain"

It's always been this way between the two of them, fighting against desperate odds, relying on no one else, Catra's innate brains and Adora's strength. They've never failed anything when they have each other and nothing bad has happened either.

"Hey,Adora?" Catra whispers as she rests her forehead against Adora's, they've done this so many times it should feel old but it's new this time, a different feeling of closeness and a little bit of regret somehow?

If Adora was a Magicat, she'd be purring.

"Yeah Catra?"

"Listen I know your gonna get promoted and all, but uh"

Catra grabs Adora's face with her free hand and longingly drags the tips of her fingers down the right cheek ,Adora's breathing picks up and Catra is so close right now that she could just-

"I wanna do something first, can I-?"

Catra seems to have trouble saying it, her voice is a little unsteady in pitch and tone like she's the nervous one for once.

"Can you what, hmm?" Adora can't help but tease a little, it's a rare moment when she gets to do it back.

"Godammit Ador-fuck you! I wanted to mark you before you went and did your whole oh look at me I'm the big bad Force Commander now and everyone look at my arm and oh wow I have even more responsibility and I-"

If Adora's eyes wern't closed right now she's pretty certain she could see Catra blush and stammer and come to the realisation that she just confessed AND blurted something out. God, moments like these when they can be awkward and dummies together? Adora missed them.

"Fuck you"

Adora scoffs.

Catra giggles.

And the tension lifts away, like it always does between them.

After theatrically debating the idea for a few moments, with Catra making increasingly mock angry noises and scratching her claws idly at Adora's fingers, Adora shrugs, nods and gives a "single" yes.

"Close your eyes?"
"Sure:

She holds her breath as her hand is dropped from Catra's, as the fingers on her neck goes away and Catra steps out between them, she circles round behind with the flicker of her tail brushing against Adora's fingers,torso,upper arm and then back and the Magicat's purring has gotten even louder.

Adora's never heard it like this before and she keeps her eye's closed.

And closed, even when a hitch of breath followed by hot air is blown on the tip of her ear.

Still shut when the pinprick of a claw lightly caresses down from the same ear to her neck.

And only open when the soft sounds of wet lips touch her in the pulse point, when the purring increases as Catra suckles down

and Adora balls her hands and stiffens at the unknown feeling pooling in her gut.
Claws drop down to hold Adora in a tight embrace, lips brush against skin on the other side as she's nuzzled again, practically fondled by the Magicat but Adora is loving every second of it.

And then she's bitten.

Softly but enough to leave a mark.

A mark that no one will ever see and will never know of except the two of them.

And the purring doesn't stop, neither does the stomach feeling or the weightlessness in Adora's heart.

The rain is strangely warmer than usual.

The massed Battalions of the Horde is a truly breathtaking sight to take in when witnessed from above on a podium, even coming up the stairs Adora can make out *thousands* of troops in neat parade grade squares with each square having its smaller ones from the company right down to the squad level. A sea of metal with black and grey armoured bodies, thousands of stun batons in thousands of holsters, hundreds of tails,ears and exterior appendages.

And it's raining too, the heavy drops bouncing off helmets and the occasional strike of lightning amplifying the glistening gleam of polished metal.

And yet not one person wavers with the wind, stumbles or moves their head. It’s perfect, synchronized and absolutely breathtaking to witness.

Even though the individual markings on each suit are hidden from view, via either rain or pure distance of line of sight Adora knows who is who and what is what, the assembled martial might of the Horde’s Battalions are numbered in grid format, one to two, two to three up and down, it's simple and logical.

And Adora makes it to the Podium, Hordak’s back to her with his red cape flowing in the wind, hands on hips and his head peering down to view his Horde. His red and black armor gleaming in its distinctiveness and seemingly unfazed by the outside elements.

“Lord Hordak, sir” Adora announces, unconsciously and automatically saluting.

Hordak grunts and waves an arm. “Force Captain Adora”. He’s straight forward as ever and she moves to stand behind him.

Above a trio of Scorpion-like airships fly over on patrol and briefly black out the numerous stars in the sky.

“Soldiers of the Horde” Hordak begins, his voice deep and rumbling and amplified by hidden loudspeakers in the floors and on top of vehicles for a three hundred and sixty degree auditory manifestation of his will that drowns out the thunder and the rain.

“Today we stand on the cusp of another swathe of land under our stewardship,

He spreads his arms, the Horde below is as silent as ever but they’re looking up at the platform, at both Hordak and Adora and the experience is... *magnifying incredible.* How many thousands of eyes are focused on her alone? What are they thinking? Are they just as proud? Does the fire of pride and accomplishment swell in their bellies?

“-mine’s reclaimed and placed under the calm and safe hand of the Horde, villages and towns prosper with no need for a paltry militia when we patrol their streets”

Neat squares, not a single misculation of space in between. It’s all perfect when she scans the assembled battalions and the fact that one of them is hers is even better, that Kyle and Lonnie and Rogelio are down there with their comrades in the sixth row and first in line, all safe and secure.

So is Grizzolor, standing right at the front with the assembled Force Captains.

There’s usually a space for the dead, since on occasions like this there’d be a gap where a Force Soldier used to be to mark their passing on where they once stood.

And there isn't one this time, not a single.

One.

Dead space. Just filled ones, full of very alive and very proud people. Her people, Adora's battalion, Adora's soldiers, the one's she bought into the Crimson Wastes and brought back out again.

"And we have our newest Force Captain to count, with the aid of Scorpia, Grizzolor and several Battalions - Force Captain Adora exemplified the greatest traits of the Horde - honor,duty,stoicism and heroics and most importantly"

Her heart has never felt so elated before as of now, she can stand strong and brave and salute with Catra behind her and the future infront.

"- with the pacification of the lands closest to us, the raider tribes conquered and those that remain have fled to the darkest corners of Etheria. At least the Crimson Waste is bathed in the tide of *true* civilisation"

Adora spots a..figure standing far taller than the rest? Out of place, standing right at the back and not clad in armoured grey but flowing gold?

"-cal tribes have joined us, resources reclaimed for better use and the road to progress is finally open! No longer will we fear attacks on our supply lines or raids conducted into our interior, we are secure. We are safe and we will finally be able to bring our full might down upon those who would defy civilization and progress!"

The rain is audible enough and physical enough to be heard and felt, it's freezing and chilling and traveling down the spine. A flash of thunder followed by a lightning fork illuminates everything in *white.*

Bright lights, two glowing orbs and a white cape, a golden hilt of something that's too blinding to observe without-.

And there's stars? Why are there fucking stars in Etheria?

And she's being stared at *again* and the swelling is going and replaced with a pit that's starting to suck away pride and honor and civilisation and replacing it with biting cold and the opposite of creativity and walkways and *where the fuck is Catra.*

There's space, so many spaces. Riddled holes of hundreds and thousands that turned numberless formations into just handfuls of people. Just Rogelio and Lonnie, a noticeable empty spot of ground between Scorpia and Force Captain Cobalt. And her head is fucking spinning *and* her gut is doing flips *and* she cant hear or smell or detect Catra anymore and there's fucking rain on Hordak's fucking armor *and* that blue Mohawk is gone and sickly white now and-

Where did all the fucking stars come from?

The thunder ends, the lightning dies down and the stark white is replaced by grey and black.

She’s getting promoted, Hordak is in front of her, Catra behind and the assembled might of the Horde below.

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This is a bit different, almost fifty percent larger.

Laying back in her bed, having stripped off all clothing bar under garments and leaving them hanging neatly up, Force Commander Adora squints and ponders at the events of today.

It’s somewhat difficult to recall how the promotion went, there’s flashes of smiling faces and salutes, audio of cheering and congratulations. Hordak shaking Adora’s hand and proclaiming her to have acted in the greatest services of the Horde. There’s the entirety of the Horde’s forces saluting her in ten thousand different ways, there’s Catra’s proud face and Adora sheepishly glancing from behind to meet her.

And yet it all seemed so. *.off* , Adora is staring at the countless little additions to her red jacket as it sits on the coat hanger, it has a larger and more prominent badge, it has magical infused markings and there’s a black arm sleeve meant to be worn over her cream shirt as it signifies her new rank as Force Commander, a position that literally can't go any further.
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It’s a rank that allowed her to choose Catra to be her number two (again) promoting the magicat to her own quarters and her own uniform, her own battalion and her own life. Adora felt pride at Catra’s own achievements and yet..

She has thousands of soldiers under her command, an entire operational theater slaved to her authority and her’s *alone* , Adora has aerial assets, factories,villages and towns and even naval units at her call and beckon and even Catra has forgone her own quarters and once again decided to join Adora in bed, to sleep together and live together like they always wanted.

They quite literally, can't go any further.

It’s like that age old *promise* , they’ve stayed together and nothing bad could ever happen again. Adora could consider that wish made when they were kids fulfilled.

And yet..

It should *taste* sweet, victory that it is. There should be a sense of genuine accomplishment and pride, a job well done and the knowledge that things possibly couldn't get any better. And said things are practically perfect *right now.*

So why does it feel so fucking weird?

A rush of footsteps outside, the first of two doors to Adora's room is unlocked and the second opens in record time and Adora barely has time to process a very loud squeal of-

"Adora!"

-before a Catra shaped flying object pounces all the way from across the room and lands straight into Adora's lap with pin-point precision.

Miscoloured eyes make contact with her own from above and they *blink.* Slowly.

With an amused "boop" Catra prods Adora in the nose, turning her shocked expression into something more along the lines of their carefree cadet days. Adora literally has to physically force herself to switch mentality just to process the new stimulation of Catra on top of her and holy shit is she blushing right now?

And then Catra *breaks* her, rocks backwards with half lidded eyes, arms behind her head and headpiece thrown away and threads her fingers through her wild brown mane and she makes eye contact again and say's *those* words with the absoluteness of knowing exactly what they mean.

"Hey Adora" There is not a single person who has ever rocked a Force Captain's attire and looked as beautifully radiant as Catra does right now.

A low whine escapes out of Adora's lips. "Hhhhhhhhh" and her thought process and entire way of thinking has been completely derailed.

Catra's purring already, and she's straddling Adora's lap and smiling and Adora could get lost studying those freckles and those lips and those eyes *forever.*

What was she supposed to be pondering about again?

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Rolling her eyes, Adora cheekily lobs a pen over at Catra's face which (since she's still getting undressed) hits her smack in the forehead.

"Who's got the , I quote. "Target forehead now huh?""

Catra dumps her clothes faster than could be every fight possible and pounces Adora, right in the face.

They laugh.

They cry.

They compliment each other, Adora call's Catra a fine Force Captain and that she was made for the role, Catra say's that no one fills out a Force Commander's uniform quite like Adora does.

Catra tucks Adora's hair behind her ear, Adora threads her fingers through the loop of Catra's pants that she didn't take off.

Catra cups her face, blushing Adora does the same, savouring every little touch.

The two women press their foreheads together, close their eyes and sigh.

Everything is perfect.

Catra's head is on her chest, Adora's fingers slowly ruffling through and detangling the magicat's hundreds of knots from a day on the trot. Catra is purring softly, the vibrations alone make everything feel better and Adora wouldn't have it any other way, everything is just right between them, their room is secure with a large double bed, they even have their own wardrobes (not lockers!) and a full ensuite.

"Catra?" Adora hums, glancing down to look over the content magicat in her arms.

"Mmm?"

Adora says what's been on her mind since they woke up together this morning. "What are we?"

Catra shrugs, tail wafting over Adora's legs,its movements analogous to Catra's mood.

"Whatever you say Adora, I'm easy"

"I mean really, what *are* we?" Adora asks again with a bigger tone of concern in her voice. Sure they've been basically joined at the hip since they were toddlers but today felt *different,* the straddling, the looks, touching each other and how Adora feels *inside.*

“What we’ve always been? I dunno” Catra looks up, blinks and stifles a yawn before returning to placing her chin on Adora’s midriff.

Adora makes to reply but there’s thoughts of another Catra in a bed smaller than this and smelling of electricity and in a different outfit, she’s remembering something she said, a confession maybe?.

Shadow Weaver.

Is that who she was supposed to be thinking of?

Adora clears her throat and untagles another knot. “Do you think Weaver was acting really strange today? She was like oddly favourable and nice towards you”

“No? She’s always been like this I think, she gave you all of those medals and shit remember? If she didnt like us then Hordak would’ve done it?”

Brow furrowing, mind going back several places in time. She can *clearly* recall Catra enveloped in a paralyzing, zapping magic at a young age and Adora running away, then making a promise afterwards and then watching Catra come home in their teens with scorch marks on her, why would Shadow Weaver be so different now?

“Catra I” Adora begins, quite clearly remembering all of those horrific things and-

“Adora?”

It’s all gone, just a wall infront and instead memories of today shunted forwards. It’s of Shadow Weaver tenderly stroking alongside Catra’s ear and congratulating her the promotion to Force Captain.

A few seconds go by, new images surfacing like they’re on one of Bow’s videos on his-

Who the fuck is Bow.

Adora shoots the fuck up.

“Catra!”

Flung backwards by the sudden change in position and Adora’s shout, Catra’s ended up on her side and she groggily opens and closes her mouth.

“Seriously Adora? Was - gonna sleep”

“Where’s the Rebellion?” Adora’s tone shifts to questioning, there’s answers and gaps and holes and she needs to bring up a map of Etheria and start plotting, sure they have the Crimson Waste and she's technically responsible for that area but the Fright Zone is bordered by so many other Kingdoms like-

“What Rebellion? Catra responds with some confusion, she crawls over to be on Adora’s lap again but Adora stops her with an outstretched arm.

“ *The* Rebellion Catra, you know? The one with the Princesses and the Kingdoms and Bow and Glimmer and-”

Adora’s walking away on the ramp of a ship, a woman slightly younger than her is wailing in desperation and screaming for her to turn back.

“Don’t do this to me please, please don’t leave us, don’t leave me”

She turns to Bow, he’s still tugging at her but he might aswell be doing it to a brick wall because Adora’s skin is fucking glowing now, she’s in calm and peaceful serenity and Bow’s normal friendly, cheerful and optimistic personality has been replaced with

a grim and sullen expression.“Take care of her for me? Be a good king and help Micah too. He’ll need it”

Who are they? Adora knows them but it’s like she’s trying to figure out half drawn people on a painting, the faces are there but smudged and the voices are muffled and-

Something is staring at her from the mirror, two glowing orbs and golden hair.

Adora’s hands tremble and she’s clutching her head with them, why is she grunting and breathing so hard? Palpitations and nervousness and twitching? *Force Captain* Adora doesn't get them but Rebellion Adora does and-

“FUCK” Screaming in pain as a flashback bursts out of the wall blocking her and its of a argument between her and Scorpia the day they got back from the Crimson Waste, Scorpia always had a crush on Catra and Adora got defensive when she was asked about date ideas.

But Scorpia was so friendly! She even offered Adora a hug!

“Adora?” Adora gasps and doesn't even register Catra’s hands cupping her cheeks and the magicat speaking words that are lost to her hearing, it’s like she’s deaf or something and why is the smell of electricity filling her nostrils?

“Gods! Okay,okay, calm down okay Adora?”

“I can’t Catra, there’s things I keep forgetting, Scorpia being nice to me like she HATES me guts and I needed to fix something and I was on a ship and you were chipped or something and Bow and Glimmer needed me but I can't remember and you were there and-”

The force of Catra’s slap knocks her out of her ramble and she shrieks, making Catra shriek.

“What the fuck was that for?”

“Sorry! You were rambling and being crazy and it was freaking me out! We should like, get some air or something or go to sleep?”

Catra makes to leave, placing her hands in Adora’s and goes to tug her off the bed when another flashback hits.

One from years ago, one where everything glitched and the world fell apart, one where the stars were in the night sky and Adora was promoted.

Catra laughs as she turns around to face Adora, walking backwards as she gestures to the Fright Zone.

“Of course I’m right. Everything’s perfect. Soon, the two of us are gonna be ruling Etheria together, just like we always planned”

Adora hesitates, something being off about the world. Shadow Weaver’s overt friendliness, Scorpias hostility and her Force Captain attire feeling uncomfortable.

"Is that what you really want? To rule the world?"

Catra falters for a second, her mask of sheer positivity dropping and revealing something significantly more hurt underneath.

"I—I mean, yeah, obviously… Isn't that what you want, too?"

"Oh"

Adora freezes.

Oh.

No.

She feels so small right now, insignificant and undeserving of the uniform on the coat hanger, the world around giving off vibes of strange and alien, of white and no stains, perfect clearness and nothing ever going wrong.

"Catra?" When Adora says that name again it's weak and soft,laden with regret and a partial hint of realization.

"What is it? Come on? Everything's perfect Adora, we need to go and do something so your hyperactive ass will sleep tonight"

Adora reaches out to grab Catra's fingers and tugs her back onto the side of the bed with her, Adora looks down and takes a deep breath. Hundreds of little conversations and memories slowly trickling back in, even as a pair of eyes continue to watch her.

"If I can do therapy, you reckon you could make things up with Scorpia and Entrapta? You've really come this far Catra and I believe in you" She added a little friendly shake and a squeeze to the Magicats body too, to reinforce that Catra really was there, in her arms and that they were together again.

“I need to ask you something” Adora tentatively lets go of Catra’s hand and steels herself by running her fingers through her own hair.

“Uh sure, I guess?” Adora doesn't need to look to know that Catra is giving her a funny look.

“How far is it?” Catra stuttered out weakly, if her neck wasn’t stiff then her head would be lolling from side to side.
“Soon, ten minutes. We’ll get there. I promise” Adora affirmed.
“You promise?”
“Yeah, I promise”

Her bottom lip trembles at first at the thought that’s been building at the back of her mind, a piece always constantly running that’s been reality checking everything since she woke up this morning, putting pieces together, comparing items from the past and applying them to the present.

Something doesn't add up.

Her upper lip follows suit.
“I - I need to ask you something and I need you to answer me honestly, okay?”

“Adora you're scaring me” Catra quips and tries to joke but it just *bounces off.* Adora’s pulse is racing at this point and she’s starting to get paranoid and watchful again.

“I love you Catra. I can't imagine my life and this world without you, I’ve missed you so much and it's taken until now to realise

that I've loved you all this time, I always have"

And she goes teary and mournful, blaming herself and thinking of the worst. Again.

"Please Catra, is this another portal? Are we together again because of the sword? What happened, what did I do?"

To her surprise, Catra just laughs it off and scoffs.

"Portal? Adora we're literally in the Fright Zone, I know you should have kept that stupid hair poof because clearly your brain damaged again and that means another trip to the-"

Adora seizes Catra by the shoulder and shakes her violently.

"IM FUCKING SERIOUS"

Catra's mouth opens to make a reply but it's too late.

"Where's Bow and Glimmer? Where's the Rebellion? I know I dont deserve that promotion because I never got it, why are you even with me, we're supposed to be enemies and wheres the fucking sword and WHO is that in the mirror?"

"WHAT FUCKING MIRROR"

"That one!" Adora snaps and forces Catra's head right at the mirror with the glowing eyes and the sword and the hair and the fucking terrifying looming presence like theres a beast stalking her in the jungle and it'll get her and she cant outrun it.

“What fucking person in the mirror? It’s a mirror Adora! Quit it, you’re scaring me”

Adora freezes, again. Thousands of pieces line up and the jigsaw begins to form and dismiss the contradictions of today. Kyle should be *dead* and yet he’s alive and reeks of sand, Scorpia *hates* Adora and yet was among the first to congratulate her, Hordak was standoffish and never *touched* anyone, the Horde *lost* hundreds if not thousands during the Crimson Waste and the surrounding areas and never had more than four battalions in the centre of the Fright Zone and a parade would have been fucking stupid and-

“Adora? There is literally *no one* , can we just go back to bed now?”

Why? Why can't she see?

Why is the furniture fading? Why has the outside thrumming of industrial machinery beginning to die down when the shift ends at two in the morning and it hasn't even broken midnight yet it’s all *gone.*

And she’s crying, *no* sobbing. A waterfall of tears and choking. Limbs clinging on to Catra in a combination of a promise to not let go and reassurance that her favourite person is still here and yet it’s not enough because the world is fading and there *are no stars in Despondos.*

Emotionally? Dejected. Mentally? Torn. Physically? Broken. She’s rambling and clutching at straws with sentiments and feelings bottled up over twenty two years finally burst out of her mouth and she couldn't stop herself if she tried *because it’s all true.*

“I’m not leaving you again I swear, I *swear* to you that I’m not letting them hurt us and I-”

Catra being abused by Shadow Weaver as a child and hissing at Adora when she reached out to touch her.

“I cant leave you not again, please talk to me Catra. Tell me what’s going on? We can fix it! I can fix it if you tell me?”

Catra’s face turns from positive at the sight of reaching Adora at Thaymor and then to painful disillusionment when Adora joins the Rebellion and beg’s Catra to stay.

“I don't know what’s going on but the two of us can do it as long as we stick together, do you remember our promise because I promise *right now* Catra and I need you to tell me Catra, why aren't you saying anything? CATRA PLEASE”

Catra’s refusal at Princess Prom, the Crystal Castle. Adora trying in vain to figure out what she did wrong and how to fix it.

The coat hangers are gone and Catra is as still as statue, she’s going cold and Adora’s tears are staining the two of them and yet she’s still holding on for dear life because she’s not letting Catra go again. She can't, she’s lost Catra before and her breathing has

gone hysterical and ragged and yet she's still holding on tight like if she lets *go* then Catra will die in her arms *again.*

"I confessed to you, don't you remember? I love you Catra, please don't go please please please, I can't leave you again, I don't want to, please tell me we can fix-fix-fix it"

The mirror is still *staring* , veins are full of ice and yet the heart is pumping blood into every section, Catra's ears have gone stiff, her normally active tail is *not* and Adora still clings because she doesn't want to let go, she wants a-

"-cottage, remember? Where everything is perfect, do you remember? Please tell me you do, I-"

Gears stop, memories in full.

Catra being dragged screaming, Catra fighting her, Adora wrenching a chip out, Catra smelling of blood and shock, Adora fighting off Clones and screaming Greyskull to no avail and taking Catra in her arms and-.

"Prime? Is he still there, where are we? You can tell me! I know you do. Just give me a fucking sign,literally anything and I'l-I'll do it, I'll do *anything* for you Catra I"

-Catra died in her arms.

Adora left Bow with a mantle of responsibility.

Glimmer cried and begged her to stay.

Adora killed hundreds as She-Ra.

She was in denial of Catra's death.

Adora went to kill Prime.

And the world went black when she ran out of space to defend herself and keep the distance up, four Clones circling and three more as backup, Adora countering and throwing punches and kicking shins but she was grabbed and pushed against a wall and her head cracked so many times that she eventually blacked out.

Just like now . The bed is starting to fade away, the Mirror is slowly disgentrating into pieces and the worldspace around her glows and cracks and glitches.

Adora manages a shaky breath despite her increasing distress and peers down in *horror* , down at her ripped gray tank top and tattered pants, black combat boots with dried blood on them.

"Catra?"

Catra fades away in her arms with her head tucked under Adora's chin, a body becoming pure light and then vanishing - into dust.

Adora is *here.*

And Catra isn't in her arms, she isn't over *there.*

Catra is gone.

And she’s left all alone for a minute or two, before she too.

Disappears.

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Do you remember the tag that says things literally keep getting worse?

Anyway! Sorry for the late update, I have part 2 written for next week and then I aim to have chapter VI and VIII out for January since Christmas time will be a pain in the ass, as always your feedback and comments are greatly appreciated. How am I doing? Did I get the Catradora right?
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VB

Adora has held Catra twice in her arms, cradled the one person she only ever truly loved and watched them die or disappear, she screamed - she cried, she wished it to stop both times and watched in despair.

Adora *told* Catra she loved her twice.

Adora *watched* Catra twice.

Adora never got to say *goodbye* .

Catra *never* said anything after Adora confessed, twice.

Because she was already dead.

The first time, Adora was in denial. She let anger flow through her veins and she hurt the remaining people she loved, she let the Force Captain, the aggressive and militstic part of her take control and Force Captain Adora rammed through everything around her, she kicked away her supports and grabbed the power of She-Ra with both hands and forced the goddess into a unstoppable weapon that butchered a hundred people or in a matter of minutes *with ease* .

And then she failed. She was emotionally unstable and unable to cope with the denial, denial that only lasts as long as you can keep it away from you and eventually it did come back.

The second time has left its mark, whether it was a figment of the mind, a trick of the portal or something else - the stages of grief and denial have finally seeped their way into the very foundations of Adora's physiological integrity, before there was rage and a willingness to get the very bloodiest of tasks done if the end result worked.

Now it's just sadness, regret and failure. Guilt that she failed, that *Adora* couldn't fix it. That the best and most powerful *Force Captain Adora* fell at the final hurdle and this *Adora* ,the one in the grey tank top and the messed up hair and the fatigue lines and shadows under the eyes is the one that's left. The one that *couldn't do it.*

Adora doesn't know where she is.

She's lonely, cold, miserable.

She misses Glimmer, Bow and everyone else.

But most of all, Adora is sad.

Because she misses Catra, and never got to say goodbye.

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ChapterV B:

Glimmer is gone, She-Ra is gone.

No back up, weaponless, bruised and emotionally compromised, the last Eternian in existence is closer than ever to achieving her goal. Prime is right there and so is she.

Can she do it? Does she want to?

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"Tremble before the majesty of Prime - for we all walk under his immortal light"

This is certainly different, when the lightning hits her in the face and forces her to squint the moment she wakes up, it's too bright and all white being beamed in from multiple angles or reflected off *everything.* Because it's all fucking white and *nothing* but that.

"Cortisol levels are significant enough to have damaged DNA"

Bright Moon would be softer, the bed would be harder and the ambient noise softer,instead its of whispering voices repeating mantras and chants all in the same base and colourless tone, no courtiers chattering to each other or the clinking of guard's boots.

"Subject's biology is robust enough though to have a complete Eternian template"

Adora is still in some form of juxtaposed post sleeping whiplash, like coming out of a medically recommended deep sleep but with interia like she was only asleep for one. Her senses are fried, muscles sore and there's back pain and her brain hurts.

"It took five brothers to restrain subject, recommend using for a future officer template"

It's not the Fright Zone either, the place lacks the constant rotational cycle of heavy machinery, shouts and calls and weapons discharge (depending on the place) and constant marching of patrols shifts relieving each other or performing their daily rounds.

"Subject has proven to be uniquely resistant to the purity"

And the colour too, it's all integrated and shiny like the scales of a large reptile, there are no concrete imperfections or metallic riveting or welding with nuts and bolts, just one continuous slab in all directions. It's not solid, there are constant rotations of quietly whirring tools and machinery that denote this as being a science lab of sorts, with Adora as the *subject.*

When she does - speak.

"Wha?"

It gains attention, her dry throaty voice while lacking water or nutrition is enough to turn several heads of identical white clothed individuals ; clones actually, all dressed the same, look the same and speak the *same.*

They speak amongst each other, shoot looks ranging from gawking at Adora's body, mumbling jargon or glance at the area around her, Adora does turn her head to inspect herself and she's still dressed the same and while there's no tubing or anything inserted into her body she still has the odd and terrifying sensation that she was drugged and now she's on the futuristic space equivalent of a operating table.

A fucking operating table. And she isn't chipped, although there’s pain from needle marks that she has to *squint* to see.

There is *panic* , but no restraints.

Shouting to let her out but she’s already free.

Anger , but she’s still thinking of Catra. The one that always calmed her.

So instead all that comes out of Adora is a muffled whimper, a combined mixture of anxiety induced realisations at both her situation now and her situation in the past.

That all that happened before, her promotion, her day with Catra, sleeping together like they used to, the nostalgia of Catra jumping on her and the weird feelings in her stomach and heart and the hope for a better life was all for naught.

She was drugged, she was in a fantasy land of her deepest repressed needs, just like the Portal when Catra used the sword to create an alternate world where Adora stayed.

All bullshit, fake and she could lie to herself but she can't right now because her heart *is not* in it.

It’s heart wrenching and its too deep to stop or even want it to, morale has been sapped to the point of non existence and she’s already on her way to succumbing to depression, the vines of guilt

are wrapping around her and to be honest, Adora doesn't care if she falls now. She had her shot and she *failed.*

Adora couldn't fix it.

And of course, a single Clone that kept staring this whole time has quietly had its dull green eyes replaced with bright ember green, its awkward posture uptight and self assured, its arm's shooting from side to side to land on the shoulder of its brothers. Their own body language forming from wary to shooting up straight into guard mode to flank their master.

She'd recognize that grandiose smile from anywhere.

"Ah Force Captain, so glad of you to drop by like this. Did you miss us?"

~~~~~

Exactly three things are clear.
~~~~~

Adora’s battered clothing that is in most cases hanging on by fibre threads are the brightest things in this cold place of white, she might aswell be in a snowstorm for how the lowered temperature is forcing every single hair on her body to stand up straight, making her shiver and constantly veer off balance in all aspects.

Prime can teleport himself to another Clone, that Clone in question ; or Prime Clone, Clone Prime? Prime? Is making the rounds of the Prime she knew from broadcasts atop landed space battleships or when she briefly met him in person in the Throne room. When it moves it does so with the strutting arrogance of someone who believes in their own implacable inevitability of total and complete victory. As it speaks, it orchestrates with flowing hand movements and dominant physical language that has the other Clones kept still in rapt attention and repeating its articulations in constant *droning* .

And lastly, Adora is not in her right mind. She can't think of a way out of this. Her head is constantly bouncing with racing thoughts and trying to filter between the past of Catra and her fuck ups with her failures, the present with its continually uncomfortable evolving of stimuli that attack the five senses with painful bright white light, taste and smell of anti bacterial gel and the lack of familiar refernerical objects is fucking up her spatial senses - Adora is *spinning* in every sense and she cant fucking concentrate long enough to even process a basic plan or even to *predict* her or her enemies next move because she’s too busy trying to wrestle with all of that *and* feeling sick and tired and nauseous.

Is she *trapped* ? Does she have any way *out* ? Catr- She *didn't* get t-.

And because she’s too busy lost in her thoughts Adora doesn't even hear the boot footfalls of the Prime Clone marching toward her and only notices when it grabs her face in its claws and wrenches her upwards to make direct eye contact until a breath away.

A loose strand of blonde hair lands on the Clone’s nose and it doesn't even flinch, instead it just keeps grinning and locks eyes and performs the *exact same* sound of sympathetic sweetness laced with the promise that all you have to do is *listen* and *obey ;* it’s identical to the speech patterns of Shadow Weaver and Adora hates herself that even she stiffens up and *listens.*

Listens to Prime worm his way into her head with empathetic condolences and a *promise.*

“You saw what the Light of Prime offers to the willing, it offers absolution and salvation for those who wish it - all *you* need to do is say yes”

He leans in ever closer, if Prime spits right now it’d be all over Adora’s face and he’s giving her a shit eating grin.

“You crave control *Adora* , Prime can give you that desire. Control to let wrongs become rights, parties every day? Mistakes rectified? All things are possible under Prime”

The sad part is that he’s *right* , for the entirety of her live from a malnourished ward kept at the edge of survivability so she wouldn't even dare to think of escape to the honorary Princess and General of an entire planet ; Adora has always been a stickler for paperwork,planning and preparation, designing obstacle courses for predicted encounters and memorizing every little detail she could and would bring herself to the brink of insanity so she could fill out every checkmark on a mental list.

“No exceptions, I hope you enjoyed a taste of what - *could be* ”

Adora fails to respond to Prime, she’s..it’s too much for her head and instead she coughs.

Taking this as a sign of submission or whatever he thinks, Prime lets out of a approving noise and spreads his arms out like a eagle and orders his two flanking guards to take Adora *somewhere,* she’s lifted up by the arms and holy fuck is it fucking painful because thier claw are *digging* into tired aching muscle and forcing it to support her body weight as her boots scrape along the perfect floor.

And the Prime Clone?

Adora shouldn't have looked but morbid curiosity got the better of her and so she watched with abject horror and stomach churning twisting to the warped and visually distorted spectacle of the Prime Clone's entire body *crack* in sync and it's head *lurch* from side to side with a single pained muffled scream.

The mannerisms fade, the eyes dull.

And it's a Clone again.

Adora would throw up but-

-she'd only get it on herself.

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-Prime's Temple Ship.

-Sixteen Hours After Arrival.

-Thirteen Hours Post Catra's Death"

-Eleven Hours After She-Ra's re emergence

-Ten Hours After Being Taken Captive-
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Every Clones she makes eye contact with as she’s dragged along the flood by her shoulders fixes Adora with the same unnerving and unblinking passive stare , it’s creeping emotionless and they’re all dressed the same too, flowing white robes at the sides and integrated armor with the body.

In comparison Adora is panting, from *unknown* exertion, *uncontrolled* panic or just everything she’s been through, she can’t hold eye contact for long, she twitches and shakes in every limb and compared to the Clone’s Adora is blind sided and practically naked with exposed skin and ripped holes in the clothing she has left.

It’s alien, it’s strange. The architecture alone juts out in every direction possible with hundreds of infinite corridors branching out in all directions and it's all in the same disgustingly mind numbing colour, *bland white* building structures with spars and spider like exterior angles, *bland white* figures with hoods and cloaks, *bland white* lighting in the floor and ceiling . It’s impossibly clean and if it wasn't for the odd hint of sickly green or differing layers of floor structure, it’d all be one continuous mind boggling mess.

And then there's the *chanting* , hundreds if not thousands of voices overlapping to form a single great congregation of noise in a language she can't and doesn't want to understand.

And Adora doesn't have the means to *process* , *think* or even *analyze* what she’s up against, there is no space for a plan, every second it's a constant bombardment of new information that needs to be filtered, sorted and held up for approval.

It’s too fucking much *right now* for her to feasibly handle. Adora *needs* time and space alone.

When they reach deeper in the station, a sub level marked with a series of numbers so long that even to someone who doesn't understand - can tell the chilling significance , that they’re in the holy place of the holy temple of Prime’s holy ship.

It’s clear now, the Clones are hooded and shuffle their way silently through corridors and walkways above and below while the chanting becomes a series of orchestrated deep hymns that begin to coat the atmosphere in the rooms and corridors and then seep in to envelope *everything.*

More time, more Clones, but now they’re starting to hum along with their movements in a trance-like state and it's honestly both weird and disturbing. And a little chilling - more chilling like its cold being blasted from air conditioning units that have never been switched off.

And then, silence.

Adora manages a weak muffle and then a pained cry as her boots catch on to something and strains the ligaments in her knees.

Deathly silence. A few months ago, before Prime and everything went even worse than it could possibly ever be. Adora had once gone out into the Whispering Woods on her own after a argument with Glimmer - angry and seething she had ripped through trees and undergrowth again and again until she stopped, the wildlife ceased activities, the crickets went dead and the only audible notes were the whistling of wind through the trees. Adora's volatile emotions had dissipated and paranoid fear took over, making her glace over every corner with apprehension and suspect even the tiniest noise.

It's kind of like that now, her senses going absolute berserk, scanning everything and the Clones are chanting again.

But she can understand them, and the words are worse than that forest all that time ago.

"Prime casts out all Shadows"
"Prime casts out all Shadows"

Even the Clones hauling her are starting to sing to the tune of just four words.

And it's absolutely *deafening* .

And Adora? She's kind of *scared* right now, *alone* and feeling *weak* .

~~~
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“Brothers,sisters..”

When the Clones, *smaller* than the one they revere retreat to seemingly pre planned positions surrounding Prime and the pool of green in the centre, *dear god it fucking smells.* Prime starts to speak and there must be a system connected to him because his deep raspy commanding voice booms out of every avenue and wall.

“I present to you today, the scale of our problems. The *gnats* that *bite* at the heels of our foundation”

And the Clones, *hundreds* if not thousands of them are on their *knees* weeping, on their feet praying, or sitting down. Watching in *silence.*

It’s absolutely awe inspiring, mind numbing and terrifying that Adora is basically surrounded on every degree possible by *bodies* , an experience she’d only felt before in the city of Bright Moon or a Horde Parade and its fucking ridiciously alarming that this is just one section of one ship (albiet a very large one) out of an Armada that has more in common with a swarm of locusts than any population metric of people.

“Oh I know all too well the lengths they will go to, to *threaten* our *security.* The sabotage *they* inflict upon *us* and they have indeed slaughtered thousands of us! Our brothers and sisters lay *dead* in droves upon our sacred ship and some even taken by the cold black reaches of space, forever drifting away from Prime’s light”

And fuck if she doesnt feel vunerable and exposed, the hyper vigilant part of her constantly screaming and banging on the walls of her head in alert and fuck will it just shut u-

Prime raises his prominent white arms above his head and bats away the winds of furious words from his followers as they react with anger, disbelief and hurt pride at the news of their dead comrades.

"Firefighters, maintenance crews, our brothers and sisters who tried only to *defend* their homes and the fires still *burn* , even now our emergency crews battle in *critical* areas of our temple. And we have.. someone to thank for that"

For Adora, it's like listening to Hordaks telegraphed and over the intercom speeches but a thousand times worse. She's still held in that same position with her boots dragging on the floor and her shoulders hurting so bad as the Clone's claws dig into her skin. And while her physical self aches from battle three times over and a compromisingly nerve pinching posture, it's still functional and ready.

She can't say the same for herself internally though, the combination of seeing Catra again aches far more than she ever thought it would and combined with the emotional overlord that resulted in whiplash that she's still feeling.

Adora is not in any disposition to make a careful thought out decision that she was renowned for.

The clamouring dies down.

And then that arm points to *her.*

He stabs a clawed finger at Adora, innumerable eyes shift to stare and she lets out a shaky petrified whimper that travels all the way down to her toes.

"Over there, kneeling for Prime is our *enemy* ! Firstborn of the Eternians, slaughter of peaceful followers of the Light and responsible for great devastation aboard our sanctuary!"

They're calling for her blood. Is she going to be hacked to death and torn apart by a mob?

"We were betrayed from within, our own rejected Prime's light and fled into the darkness but they are *dead.* But no matter my siblings, retribution from Prime will be delivered unto this one"

Adora strains to make eye contact, not only does she have to lift her head up an uncomfortable height but Prime is impossibly tall right now.

"Force Captain Adora is it? Or is it She-Ra? Fabled protector of the First Ones"

"Or is it just Adora? A *damaged* little girl with *delusionals* of a greater self on an imaginative crusade to crush Prime's light?"

Kill her!
Subject her to the light.

Prime Knows-

"I think none of those facetious titles matter *now* do they? You have rejected the Light of Prime, spat upon his *visions* that he graciously bestowed upon you. Strength, security and peace. But Prime is-"

He purses his lips and lets the crensacdo of baying voices and scarcely restrained animated movements from his followers wash over him.

"Merciful, generous. Prime Knows All, Prime sees All"

Horde Prime's voice drops to a sickeningly sweet level.

"Prime offers *you* only the chance to right your wrongs, to *apologise* to those you *hurt* . To be at peace *Adora* , Prime's light cleanses and heals, it-"

"-saves those who are forgotten, downtrodden, lost of purpose"

"And it will help *you* become happy". He grins. "You will find only a loving other, a happy couple of King and Queen, friends you thought lost will reappear with open arms"

Catra will love her for eternity, Bow and Glimmer's shining faces forever, Kyle and Seahawk and Juliet coming back to happy families and loving homes.

"I-" The sheer enormity of going back there, to seeing history adjusted and twisted towards a brighter present is enough to make her stutter, shiver and regret leaving.

She can't lie that there was always a small secret part of her that wanted such a scenario.

Even if it's only for a second, Adora's momentary falter is enough for Prime to notice,smirk and continue.

"Prime is the greatest is he not?" The cheering becomes louder.

"Prime ,your general, your god, your saviour!" Full of himself and with the most twisted facial expression that comes from a combination of thousands of blindly indoctrinated followers eating out of the palm of his hand and his belief of who he is, Prime keeps going, continuing to stir up tensions and whip them into a frenzy.

"But is Prime not great? Not merificul? Does he not see all and know all?"

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide

They’re changing that repetitive chorus again and... please stop, stop it.

“Does he not see the treachery of the Eternians? That *they manipulate* behind the scenes and convert innocent people into weapons?

When Prime calls out his accusations, it’s like he’s dictating all of it to every single person in the room individually, like his words are *just* for them and them *alone* , some of the Clones' expressions turn into uplifted joy, other’s cry and wail and beg for *more* .

It’s so loud and it’s coming from every angle possible and being bracketed straight into her eardrums and bounced around in her head to the point of which she can see the words.

Primo novit omnia,Primum omnium vide

“That they force little girls to fight, that they turn whole planets into superweapons?”

PRIMO NOVIT OMNIA,PRIMUM OMNIUM VIDE !

“Ah but Prime knows all, Prime see’s all. He is great and merciful is he not?”

“Adora, Prime offers *you* the chance to right your wrongs, to be *one* with your friends and family, to see your beloved again?”

“Will you not *take* it?”

To be honest.

She is *debating it* , she’s emotionally exhausted from dealing with the prospect that her last meeting with Catra was a fabricated alternative reality and having to admit all of that over again from pouring her heart attack to a fake Catra, for relieving painful memories and seeing the faces of those that she lost suddenly come back into being, happy and joyful and it’s like they never left. They never died, she never made a mistake, she…

She fixed it. She found a world where she *fixed it.*

What if she could? Just *let go* and remain safe with the person she loves, she’ll be safe and she’ll get to see Catra again and just erase everything, *she won't hurt no more.*

Adora is still in her grey tanktop and grey pants and black boots when the four arms around her shoulders holding her up are replaced by two.

"Brothers and sisters, there is no one who is beyond the merciful grace of Prime. This one, a former Force Captain will be made to see the beautiful and healing light of Prime"

She cant see who is picking up her up and dragging her to the pool of green goo but from a vague sense of physical perception and a automatic sensory update that never stops working, she knows that it's Prime who is heaving her *step by step* to the "Light", a place where Catra was probably taken to be turned into a robot but she cant weigh it up right now, things are muddy and hazy and She-Ra is *gone* and the strongest Adora, the Force Captain Adora that took on Huntara without a second thought and was the physical prime failed too and what can she expect to do now? She's the *weakest* , the one that n *eeded* She-Ra more than any other.

She failed, horribly.

She failed to hold on to She-Ra's power and threw away her best chance at ending this.

She failed to break through the Clones.

She failed to kill Prime, she failed to save Catra, she failed to salvage her relationship with Glimmer.

She failed.

"Purify her!"

"Show her the light"

The echo's of chanting, a combination of hate, awe and religious undertones is still bouncing around in her ears and the pool is getting closer, Prime's touch is gentler than before and his voice is too when he finishes orchestrating to his assembled mass. Booming and powerful turns to low and *suggestive.*

Prime is practically breathing down her neck when she's hauled to the edge of the green pool, still looking down at her feet when stagnant breath and vocal force hit her ears and she's still suffering from emotional whiplash and caught in a whirling vortex of depression and failure to resist.

"I see your strong connections to your friends Adora, your lovers, your comrades. Prime saw all and offers you a second *chance* . A fresh start in the Light, where there will be no more pain for a troubled heart, friendship to soothe and ease the mind and of course, those who you know best will be here for *you*- "

And the next word is enough to break a small dam with it's

promise alone.

"-always"

Adora's vocal chords finally work to spit out.

"I-"

"Come now Adora? Prime saw the fantasies and hopes, a King and Queen married, the erasure of She-Ra with only Adora and a-"

Please don't say it.

Even though Prime is standing right behind her as she's on her knees, Adora knows he's fucking grinning.

"-a cottage outside some woods, a village nearby and two young women forever together and away from their troubles"

The hands that dragged her across blood stained floors now stroke and caress her shoulders with a mimic of a parent she

never knew, it’s a deftly soft touch that drowns out the chanting and screaming and it's a reminder of the few time’s in which Shadow Weaver tried to be a genuine mother and helped her tie her shoes or allowed her to use the Garnet chamber to march up and down for practice.

“Prime can imagine *it* Adora - can you? A world without pain and misery *and* war and death. Just eternal peace and naught but pleasure. Isn't that the exact thing *you* fought for, that *you* hoped would happen?

A touch she hasn't felt in years. And kinda missed. Even the one night stands and group hugs never compared to the few nostalgic moments of childhood.

“I-”

Adora bites her cheek.

“Say it Adora, speak your mind and tell Prime of your troubles, you are *forgiven* after all”

Cracks appear in the foundation of another dam, a safe threatens to burst open and a few tears roll down her cheek and stain the perfect white marble floor. Reminders of being a cadet with few worries in the world, the perfect moments during the Alternate Reality of the portal, the sense of pride and satisfaction of her

promotion to Force Commander and the adoration of validation that it secured.

Bright warm light hitting Catra's freckles and highlighting each and every one, her tackling Adora at every moment, sleeping on her feet during curfew, twinkling mismatched eyes and the rare few times that she smiled and only when they were alone *together.*

"I want that"

She finally admits to herself and although it's done quietly, it's still broadcast across the room.

"I want that"

Prime chuckles, satisfied and confident.

"That wasn't so hard was it Adora? *Admitting* to yourself the truth, you *want* this"

Long sharp fingers, each a talon of a great Eagle caress her shoulders and massage them, Prime's voice compared to her own is the opposite of scratchy and dry.

"Think about it, you could *right wrongs,* you could see your friends again and never have to stoop to such base violence against others, we live in *paradise* here. Look around you and see

true happiness, your brothers and sisters want for nothing, they accepted the Light of Prime long ago and they are *happy* here"

The Clones have stopped, some are still shaking and praying but the majority of them are on their knees just like her, except she's right on the edge of the pool and she could just fall in right now.

Could Adora really be with Catra again? an innocent Catra that was left heartbroken by Adora leaving that left them as bitter enemies for over two years. Could she and Glimmer reconnect and go back to their happiest moments in hot tubs during brief periods of relaxation?.

God's above she's so fucking tired that concentrating on just one thing is taxing.

"The pains of the heart are all too familiar to the followers of Prime, we ache and bleed for you as-

Clawed fingers gently cup her lower jaw and push her gaze to conceive the sheer enormity of the worshipping going on all around her in all three dimensions, she makes eye contact with some Clones and while a few stare back, other's glance away in either disgust, jealousy of Prime's touch or even fear.

It's the most varied emotional state Adora's witnessed on Clones, *ever.*

"Your actions have led to the deaths of many, Adora. We know about those who lost their loved ones, innocent children cut off before their time to shine and how you are weighed down by responsibility"

Prime's words cut a chord straight through her heart and thoughts and bring back painful memories, awkward interactions and apologies, screaming at faceless shadows before they're cut down and more. Each and every one is a repeated and increasingly heavier hammer blow that forces her to retreat into herself more and more and her defenses are *crumbling.*

And his voice, it's laced with *sympathy* and *promise.* The intoxicatingly sweet suggestion of alternation and adjusted reality.

"Netossa *could* be made to understand, Rogellio *could* find his lover once more and perhaps Juliet *could* retire into blissful peace"

And then she's made to peer down at the green pool of goo or liquid or whatever's in there, a small part of her still resists and begs her not to do it but she's conflicted and pulled and twisted in so many directions and the promise of *possibility* is increasingly more alluring.

She *could* rewind the clock.

Adora might never need to wear the dreaded mantle of a Force Captain and slit a defectors throat at the age of eighteen.

She could be at *peace* .

And then Prime lays the icing on the cake when he leans in and whispers sweetly right into her left ear and it's enough to force every nerve to fire up, every hair to stand up and her battered senses to wake up and *listen.*

"What if Catra took your *hand* at Thaymor, what if you *stayed together* ?"

If she does say something in that moment, it's stuttered and breathy and unintelligible. Her mind is reeling with possibilities of the past and fixing old mistakes, her limbs are sore and welcome rest.

"What if you kept your promise Adora? The pact you made all those years ago?"

Catra fleeing with her to Brightmoon, the defeat of the Horde with *Catr* a at her side and...maybe a life together.

If she squints hard enough at the green pool of liquid standing just a pinkies away from her boots Adora might be able to define the prospect of twinkling blue and yellow eyes next to her rather than bright green with a grin above her messy and half ripped hair, it's a sad sobering thought and yet…

She'd like that. She'd like to be with Catra, she'd like to be *home.*

Whatever home means anyway, it’s an abstract concept to imagine even with Prime’s insistence and encouraging words. It's still a watercolor painting of imagination, green something, walls something, people something and if she tries to touch it then the painting simply vanishes away under physical touch.

And before she can attempt to comprehend it, Prime’s tender touch has turned forceful, his grip becomes like steel and his claws dig into her skin and *rend* it.

And his voice, dear fucking gods above and all the stars does it *scrape* into ear canals and force it’s way into her head as she’s dragged down right into the liquid and it’s only due to years of disorder forced truama that’s stopping her from going further than *torso deep.*

“I am sorry that you must suffer Adora”

The liquid while strangely rejuvenating is healing old scars and words, bringing life back into tired limbs.

All beings must suffer to become pure.

Adora is still stunned and motionless by past events, by memories, by Catra to do anything but simply stay still even while the liquid begins to *hurt* , even while Prime continues to force her down but her legs and boots ground her on the platform.

He’s humming now, a little chant that his followers repeat with every line.

“Those who seek freedom shall be granted it!”
Cast out the shadows!.

Every nerve ending is burning, multiple panic alarms register through her toes to her hands to her spine and scream *danger* .

“Affiliations must be taken away, impurities must be cleansed”

All beings must suffer for freedom, to become pure.

There is something in the water, if you could call it water. It speaks,it calls, it asks for an answer. It hurts and it heals, it offers a way out, it offers Catra’s hands, it offers Juliet's life, it offers Glimmer’s smile and Bow’s friendship.

Prime is kneeling now and grasping either side of her head while continuing his chant, he’s trying with his might to thrust her fully into the pool.

He offers a way out, the *easy* way out. The path of least resistance, the slippery slope.

And Adora *realises* that now, she realises that she's been letting out a pained muffled scream that’s been submerged and hidden from the outside world by thick green liquid. It’s liquid that attacks a colourful painting of an environment with people living their

lives and simply bleaches it clean into a blank slate of nothing but white.

It’s the very same liquid that Catra was dragged into naked while screaming for Adora to save her.

It’s the easy way out, the path that Adora was offered multiple times in her short life, she could have *gone back* to the Horde with Catra at Thaymor but she refused because she saw the atrocities, she could have submitted to Shadow Weaver but wanted *no more* as a pawn.

She could have been a yesgirl to Glimmer and gone along with her plans, agreed with everything and let her do what she wished instead of arguing because Adora believed it was *wrong.*

Adora could have *not* resisted Light Hope and never broken the sword, she could have continued to be one with She-Ra and remained as an invincible goddess but she said no because it *wasn't right.*

Adora could have chosen the past for salvation.

But that’s not right is it? It’s *hurting other people* right now, it’s letting a chipped Catra remain as a slave to Prime, it’s making a mockery of her friends and turning them into mindless puppets so she’ll feel better about the mistakes she made and try to avoid them.

Bringing pain and ruining lives, she’s always done that throughout her life but *this is wrong* . Taking away agency is what Light Hope and Shadow Weaver tried but Adora stood up to them and destroyed one’s castle and drowned the other.

She has a choice right now, she can let Prime drown her in liquid and become a chipped frightened woman that let the mistakes of her past rule her and force others, friends and people she’s never met to obey and live in some sick fantasy where nothing ever went wrong.

Where she ran away from her responsibilities.

Or she can try her best.

Maybe she can fix it.

Adora

Says

No .

No to the alternate and fantastical possibilities of submission and sacrificing the prosperity of others for her own benefit.

Prime continues to hold her down and is only really stopped by her boots straining to keep her on the platform so he's putting *more and more weight* into it. A foolish endeavour, one that's *arrogant* and *assumes* a 100% chance of success with no mistakes ever made.

She promised Angella she'd take care of Glimmer.

She promised Catra..

When Adora lets go, when she embraces her mistakes of the past and replies with a goodbye to ever fixing them in a botched reality - stops holding on to the ledge and tumbles forward into the depths of the pool with Prime right behind her as he falls in head first and he's utterly incredulous about it because the Emperor's claws are still dug into Adora's arms and it's only when she registers that his huge fucking mass has fallen all the way in and fucking screaming *obsencities* in another language that Adora frankly doesnt give a single fuck that Adora realises that she *actually did it*

And it's enough to power her onwards and twist round and hold on to the scowling and thrashing and flailing Emperor of the universe with all four limbs and she holds on tight as Prime manages to wrangle his way out of the pool and somehow cuts her free though not without a fight, spluttering and coughing with white milky eyes over green and tubes missing and a more bleached appearance that defies even his soul sucking *normal white* . He reels forward and falls over onto all fours to the shock of his Clones who simply fucking *stand there* in disbelief.

Adora crawls out of the pool, drenched from head to foot in disgusting vile liquid that's painfully rejuvenated her body, she manages to dodge a clumsy swing from a Clone ,grab its stun baton and twist the dial up to *maximum* and slams it straight into the Clone's neck chip for a full on electrocution induced paralysis before aiming a kick that sends it tumbling face first into the pool to *drown.*

Ripped trousers, damaged boots, half of a grey tank top is missing and splotches of itchy green cling on to wounds and scratches and there's not even a hair style anymore but none of that matters right now.

Prime is already running but his teleport system is down and he's shouting for his stunned followers to "attend to him", some have collapsed, others make a half hearted effort but a few jump into action and in enough numbers that it's already becoming uncountable. but they'll never catch up - if she *guns it.*

Adora has her chance.

She can fix this.

She-Ra is *gone* , Force Captain Adora is *gone* .

But *she's still here* , she might be injured a little and hungry and thirsty and probably trapped on a space station with thousands or even millions of Clones but Horde Prime is right *here.*

And so is *she.*

Adora chases Horde Prime as fast as she can through the first of many winding corridors, hundreds of boots clatter with screams and shouts in conjunction from all around and she doesnt have long before Prime gets lucky and either escapes or Adora is simply swarmed and blocked off.

But she *can* do it, all she needs is one chance. One chance to make sure Glimmer and Bow will live in peace, one chance to avenge Catra. One shot to do *one good thing.*

Adora turns the power setting on the shock baton to kill and watches as Prime's huge fleeing form ,one that towers above even the Clones and disappears behind yet another door four times his size. Even Hordak, a dying bastard that was chained to his exoskeleton, would have tried to fight but this guy? The Emperor? He's fucking running and calling for *help* so someone else could do his dirty work.

Run you son of a bitch.

Adora knows deep down that she won't be able to save Kyle or Seahawk or Grizzlor or Juliet or Spinnerella or any of the hundreds of faces that stretch from the Crimson Waste to the Bottom of the sea, faces that she can't remember the names to *but the* memories of which will stay on and burn bright, she can't save Catra either and as badly as she *wants to go back* and change it all - it's all in the past and clinging on to it as an obsession that she's done before has blinded her to the present, much less the future.

A future which she probably won't be a part of, but maybe and hopefully-

Others will.

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A/N. I think this fic can be quite neat summed up as "how could this possibly get even worse?...oh".

I aim to have this fully finished before February 2022 so we have two chapters left to go! VI and VII (and maybe sub chapters if there ends up being too many words)
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And of course, thank you for reading this far, I appreciate the likes, the kudo’s, the comments, the reviews and everything. It's food for the soul and I can't thank you enough :)

If you like it so far or yer just utterly horrified at how I've even managed to write this, could you leave some feedback? I'm always trying to better myself

VI

Chapter VI:

"Warriors"

Prime's army is on the march.

The Emperor is fleeing with Adora in hot pursuit.

Living on borrowed time and surrounded from every direction but forward, Adora must reach Prime and end him before he escapes or she's trapped.

The clock is ticking and time is not on her side.

For Glimmer.

For Etheria.

For those lost, for those alive and those that may be.

For Catra.

Adora must be strong and she must be brave.

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If She-Ra was here, it'd all be over by now.

Instead Adora has to contend not only with being chased down but the crushing and lonely atmosphere of the hallways of Prime's temple.

It’s a static and unnatural kind of cold with no air currents or wind, just a blanket of chilliness coating at around head height.

Pale lights shine a ugly likeness on everything they touch and they’re embedded in every single area to create an uncomfortable and painful visual experience.

Huge walls and doors that are covered in pure unflinching white, forever presenting an inescapable feeling of dread.

Dull repetitive chanting, repeating mantras in a forgien language that despite Adora’s inability to understand the individual words, the sheer tone and nature makes for an incredibly disconcerting experience, and it's coming from the walls, the pipes, above and below - to encompass everything.

Thousands of boots march in steady beats from all around, shiny and perfect attire and users with identical appearance.

Compared to the most basic Clone with its flowing white robes, integrated body armor and consummate ,flawless appearance. Adora is practically naked, armed with a single stun baton set to overload and with a rapidly dwindling battery, tattered tank top and ripped combat pants and boots that are falling apart.

She’s severely underdressed.

And Adora doesn't belong here.

But.

Adora is *here* and Prime is *here* .

Everyone else is over *there.*

It’s just the two of them left.

It’s not a day of travel away via spaceship or even an hour's walk to a central communications room.

Prime is within sight. If she just pushes herself *harder* , she can reach out and touch him.

(She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (OST) - Remember)

Behind are Clones, the functional few -a combination of armed guards and fanatical worshippers from the deathly green pale biomechanics of Prime's sick indoctrination operation - the ones that could keep up are nipping at her heels and she *has* to outrun them.

To the left, covered maintenance hatches open from the walls with alarming regularity and out pours a mixture of maintenance workers with blow torches, hammers and their fists, they scream and shout and chase Adora with the fire and fury of a lynching party.

And the right? Squads of first responders with stun batons and body sized shields march from embedded doorways in perfect file, they block off entrances in phalanx shaped walls of white and force Adora to evade,flank or beat them to the punch.

Prime is getting away.

As Adora comes into sight of the Emperor again, it's clear that the man probably hasn't experienced running in centuries, it's off base and unbalanced and it's really only the momentum of Prime's incredibly tall legs and considerable height and weight that keeps going as he lumbers through doors the height of buildings in comparison to Adora who darts through them without slowing.

Adora is losing him.

The deeper Adora follows the fleeing Emperor into the station, more Clone's than she could have thought possible block the way, multiple times Adora has to dodge a heavy swing from a stun baton the size of a arm in the nick of time, she leaps to the side to scramble past three Clones and gets her knee kicked out from under her but she rolls and recovers in time to *keep going.*

Prime cannot escape.

Adora *is* faster, she's the product of relentless physical conditioning and the achievements speak for herself. She *earnt* second place behind Catra both in a straight line and obstacle courses- but they never tried to *kill* the participants and while Adora manages to evade the heaviest of attacks and turn aside blows, every hit that bruises or knocks her about - contributes to slowing her down.

The more Prime gets away, the more Adora suffers from a thousand cuts and has to rely on catching a glimpse or Prime's flowing white robes or his head which stands above his followers, or simply just following an ever decreasing trail of green liquid that falls from Prime's body, courtesy of Adora dunking him in the pool that Prime subjected Catra to painful torture.

Adora has to keep going.

She pushes ever onward, boots making dirty scratches on the perfect white flooring of the Temple ship, clears a pair of closing doors in the nick of time and she's rapidly gaining on the Emperor, if she can just try *harder* - she can *fix* it.

A Clone warrior attempts to stop her from jumping the Emperor, its snarling face is the only piece of nonconformity when it follows the mental playbook to a tee that Adora's been actively working on for the past *six years* as a combination of her life in the Horde, fighting the Horde and then the Clones.

The Clone grounds itself, feet firm and wide, shield raised and stun baton electrified to *kill.* It's a defensive posture made to delay,wait for its fellows and then advance. And while Adora's rear is covered for now, its *inevitable* that more Clones will pour out from fucking everywhere.

So following the playbook, squinting,furrowing and concentrating - Adora feints a attack towards the shield, the Clone's predictable counter thrust to take out her arm with its baton is thwarted when Adora drops her stun baton - grabs onto the Clone's outstretched arm and uses momentum against it, forcing it off balance and kicks under it's shin and leaves it floundering on the floor.

Twenty three seconds, half a minute for Prime to open the distance *again.* Seven more seconds to pick up her Stun Baton and the Clone's.

Adora has to keep going.

She has to close the gap.

Great doors behind are forced open by six Clone's wielding a giant arc-welder that slices through cosmic steel, the sheer electrical contact causes several pipes to rupture under the strain and emergency flood lights replace the grand illumination of Prime, flickering and transforming the corridors from consistent stark white to terrified flashing red.

Literally bathed in a new light, bruised and bleeding in many places, both hands clutching a weapon with the static shock causing body hair in ripped clothing to stand up, Adora forces herself into another headlong sprint after Prime. She's so different from the Rebellion General of just a week ago, no smart uniform kept in place with precision tailoring nor an authoritative and commanding presence left.

It's just her.

Just Adora.

That little exercise with the Clone has cost her precious moments, she *has* to compensate for in double time because the Clone's are

pouring out of that door in the manner of an unending swarm of insects and she's being chased again, while being the *chaser.*

The chance of being overrun is higher, the slick of green trailing Prime becomes smaller with each step and the corridors are becoming increasingly difficult to navigate.

Out of all the vast array of nightmares.

This is the one she chooses for herself.

No matter the cost.

Adora must keep going.

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"Brave, Stubborn, Reckless, Kind"

A staff like the one Adora had less than a day ago would be preferable for fighting Clones, it's double handed nature allowed for quick movements and its reach negated the two meter height advantage Prime's minions enjoyed.

Unfortunately that staff is gone, damaged and rendered useless by the ultra sharp claws of a possessed Catra. And with that went Adora's fighting style that she'd been trained on for the best part of twenty years.

Instead it's a pair of stun batons, short ranged dial-variable electrocuted poles meant to be used in conjunction with a shield - a Clone's shield and a Clone's long reach. It's not that they're bad weapons - set to the highest they'll cause instantaneous shock and paralysis if applied to the *right* area.

Problem being?
Clone's are armored and stun batons have practically *zero* armor penetration without assistance, so Adora has to get in close and aim for exposed parts or flesh. She doesn't have the advantage of reach and range, she has to be *fast* and always relying on risk and reward to get in, take her shot and either dodge the return or make sure there isn't one.

Batons nullify Adora's relatively "medium" characteristics compared to Catra's ultra light and Scorpia's heavy and turn her style into an uncomfortably dangerous one. Adora's more used to a hybrid of the medium bulk fighting method of a Force Captain's unyielding prowess and the dynamic footplay of a Rebellion specialist.

For someone like Catra, blessed with incredible agility and double jointed *everything* with the reflexes of a cat and ten sharp blades it'd be easy and no real issue to see why she was so successful

against a relatively slow (in comparison) moving target like She-Ra.

Problem is:

Adora *isn't* Catra, she has to be on the ball every time she encounters a Clone, she has to time herself right *and* perfect, minimize the risk of being hit or else it'll hurt like hell and Adora doesn't have the means to immediately jump out of harm's way, she has to *plan* , she has to get it *right* every time.

Adora'd rather wield a sword and sure she's versed in almost every weapon and can use them with some degree of knowledge. It has good reach ,handling and the blade can go through Clone armor.

One problem:

A sword is the particular hallmark of *someone else* .

Someone she hurt.

And someone that Adora knows- hurt her back.

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Adora’s lungs are burning and she’s heaving with each strained breath - clearly she took a hit in the chest earlier and while it’s not slowing her down it’s forcing her to expend more energy to not just keep up but *run down* Prime.

Legs ache too, kneecaps in particular are feeling slippery and it's probably from previous overexerted injuries, it doesn't matter if they give out because the finish line is *right there.* Even if her body is screaming at her to topple around and take a breather - *she can't.*

So she keeps going, driving up the pace and running faster and faster, uncaring if she takes a hit because they’re not *important* ; something gross like wet sand is building up in her lungs and she restrains the urge to choke it out as she barrels through a doorway and forces *inhale and exhale* instead .

Prime is so close.

The dictator of a thousand worlds and perhaps thousands more is too slow to keep the distance between them, that imposing statue-like body is made for grand speeches and leading from a podium - not flat out sprinting and evasion. Adora can round the corners and barrel through doorways far faster than Prime can and she proves it every time, ornate hallways are sped through, blaring red lights signal her way to the finish line and when Prime finally comes within sight - *Adora powers on* and keeps pushing herself ever onwards.

The final step is a single long corridor - it's sides and top exposing the inner machinations of machinery of the Temple ship, hundreds of wires and biomechanics stacked upon each other and line an area wide enough to march a full Battalion through at abreast , it's a thirty five second journey at top speed and Adora then kicks open the final pair of doors.

It's a massive hangar or loading/invasion bay with no real exit in sight with a few light fixtures scattered around, it's filled with machines from aircraft to tanks to an alien assortment of weapons or a huge arsenal of some kind and right at the back is a forcefield like window into the beyond - the blackness of space and the glistening white silhouette of the thousands of battleships of Prime's armada.

Adora enters slowly and carefully,making sure to let her body repercute what energy it can and climb down from the reckless sprint to the finish line and prepare for the last chapter of her battle with Prime.

Prime.

The space dictator is standing there just twenty or so meters away with his back turned, head turning slowly to gaze upon the stars and the assembled might of his fleet.

"Prime" Adora says first, the sound of her footsteps transitioning from corridor metal to hanger space resistant floor.

Prime replies with nothing and instead a Clone from the left and the right detaches seemingly out of nowhere and start their slow walk towards Adora, one armed with the usual attire of a shield and stun but it’s dressed differently with an ornate crown and brighter eyes.

The other has a fucking staff, both ends embroiled with adorned lines that stand out from the usual stark white.

The Emperor's last defenders.

Reinforcements will be too late to join them, just two to go and then the Emperor himself.

So she picks herself up again on shaking limbs and straining muscles,checks that both stun batons are ready and primed and cracks her bones.

Steels herself too, prepares her body both emotionally and mentally to not only complete the mission she set out to do - but the *promises* she made and to perform *this* as fast as possible *and* to ensure Prime will *not* come back.

Adora *cannot* fail, she’s come this far and by doing so would be completely *unacceptable.* To both herself, the promises, the people relying on her and the weight of Etheria on her shoulders.

She can do this.

She hopes.

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If She-Ra was fighting, this'd be a whitewash and ten seconds of taking out the trash.

But She-Ra isnt *here,* and so Adora pushes down the doubt and the creeping tentacles of imposter syndrome.

In the past, Adora has stated honestly to both herself and others that (as a reasonable assumption) she believes herself to be capable of facing one Clone in combat and able to overpower it with two being a reasonable but "doable" stretch and three pushing the limit, indeed she stated this while equipped with her staff. An item that allowed her to stay out of range and dictate the circumstances.

Clone's by their nature: Are beefed up Horde Soldiers in terms of tactics and training, they're meant to be used in large formations to soak up hits with their shields, armor and durable bodies. And once in melee they use their superior strength and sheer numbers to overwhelm and overcome their opposition.
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By nature they typically lack the speed and flexibility to react by themselves, like a typical Horde soldier they move in numbers and close ranks but on their own and isolated? That's the time to strike.

These Clone's are different.

They *stalk* rather than *march* with a stiff unyielding posture. The same way a predator would, their weapons loose rather than held tight and they search for an opening in Adora's defenses rather than blindly rush in.

Fear travels up Adora's spine when she realises *quickly* that the mental handbook, twenty years of Horde training and two of fighting are *fucking meaingless* when the staff Clone - knowing its range advantage over her swings it's weapon diagonally without pause or knowing and almost takes off her kneecaps right there and then if she handn't jumped back in time.

Adora immediately counterattacks, one stun baton aiming for the hand and the other kept in reverse but the Clone bats away her strike with effort and retreats while the other closes in from behind, Adora realizes to her horror that she's been led into a distracting trap - boxed in *immediately* and that she while she can single one of them out - she'll have her back open to the other.

She has to think, *hard.*

Adora attempts to attack but it’s turned into a desperate defense when the staff Clone aims for her head and she has to duck and then batter away the shield Clone’s baton with both of hers.

She’s incredibly vulnerable.

Adora’s winded when the tip of the staff grazes her chest and she fights down the panic that she’s going to *fall* flat at the finish line, she’s outnumbered, outranged and she cant overpower her opponents either.

Adora needs to throw out the handbook right now, stop relying on premeditated attack patterns and planning and *adapt - concentrate* and be *smart* about it.

She has some obvious advantages that she can use.

She’s still faster than them n’ proves it when she beats off an assault by the staff Clone with faster reaction speed to deflect blows and well placed footwork to turn around in time to sidestep the other. And while it results in a stalemate, it's a confidence boost that she can still do this.

The Clone’s do seem to have *some* sort of pattern ,it’s significantly more intelligent and random than the usual bunch, staff Clone is aggressive and swings to disable while shield Clone relies on the defense and sheer blunt force.

Adora can deal with the shield Clone but the staff one has robbed her of her greatest advantage; range. She can't sit at the edges and dance out of harm’s way like Catra does. If she attacks, she’ll be forced to *commit.*

Catra.

That name alone brings up regretful joy, painful memories barely repressed emotional need to apologize and wish to go back in time to *fix it.*

Catra.

Catra disarmed Adora of her staff, didn't she? Adora immediately replays that fight between her and possessed Catra and distinctly remembers that Catra was forced to go for Adora’s fingers and hands to rob the former Force Captain of her greatest advantage. Adora lacks ten knives, *but* she does possess the next best thing:

Stun batons, and two of them. And unlike a staff but like a sword they only require one hand, a staff needs both with dexterity to manipulate it to function. *She only needs to take out one hand.*

Adora’s winded by a near miss of the shield Clone’s baton that briefly immobilises her right leg and she takes another hit to the shoulder that also hurts her fucking lungs and she coughs out a bit of blood but its *worth it.*

Adora has a plan now.

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(She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (OST) - The Heart of Etheria)

Two Clones are giving Adora are much harder time than the ones preceding, while Adora has a rough "plan" to take out the staff Clone and then turn her attention to the other-

-the Clones are not co-operating.

They don't grin or snarl and they don't give praise to Prime every thirty seconds. They stay back and avoid Adora's attacks as much as they attack her back and when it's at a disadvantage they pull away - while a normal Clone will simply keep *pushing in* and view its own life as forfeit, these guys value their own or at least give the impression.

Are they holding Adora back, trying to survive themselves or is something else at play?

Adora has to hurry up.
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So she pulls herself up by the bootstraps, takes a quick breather while avoiding a strike for her head and *goes again.* Her offensive must break their lines with utmost aggression, she *must* get through and hit Prime before she's swarmed by bodies.

The first fails,a upward strike with arms raised designed to smash down straight onto fingers, however the Clone *predicts it* and Adora's dual wielding stun batons land squarely at the middle ends of the staff and it becomes a desperate seesaw of strength, the Clone makes zero noise and it's Adora who's grunting *and* panting as she's forced back and she has to kick out and strike the thigh with a desperate boot to a soft spot to keep herself from being pinned.

Free of the failed conflict with the staff Clone and avoiding a strike by the second with a well timed dodge that Catra would have been proud of.

Panting, she tries *again* .

The side with batons tightly together launch to smash right into the Clone's wrist and aided by mass and momentum from baton to body weight into a crippling shot to force the engagement from a troubling two on one to a manageable single. Adora's heart is going a mile a minute and forces as much energy as she can into the strike, fully aware that if she fucks u-

The Clone predicts her attack, it's head cocked and hands perpendicular like train tracks and instead of a killshot, Adora's stun batons slam hard into the staff with a loud audible gasp with

the impact and Adora's own pained grunt as the shockwave travels painfully into her bones. A second or two glances by and Adora's failed attack forces her into retreat as she beats off yet another assault by the shield Clone that nearly bashes her in the face and when she turns around to attempt *again,* the staff Clone kicks her in the kneecaps, staggers her into reeling backwards and she manages to drop her weight down to avoid a near decapitation from the follow on strike.

Adora barely rolls out of the way in time as the stun Clone's baton slams right into the floor where her head would have been and she uses that razor thin time frame to kick into the Clone's exposed patella and the resulting dual kick knocks it over and just hopefully for long enough that she can-

Avoid the staff strike meant to break her arm and instead the tip nearly breaks her rib instead. She muffles her scream but it *fucking hurts* .

Pain can make for a useful ally though, one she's often relied upon for that adrenaline fuelled burst. Enough of it pooling into the veins for strength and purpose that it transforms from a hastily made retaliatory hit into a structured and aimed counter attack.

A distorted war cry full of anger leaves her lips.

A double pincer movement, one baton aimed at the legs for a kneecap strike that gets the Clone dodging back while her other baton moves for the knuckles, its deflected and turned away from the staff but she then swings the one aimed at the kneecap upwards and the electric charge with the staff *full on.*

It's a successful feint.

The Clone realizes its precocious situation and attempts to move back while its ally charges Adora from the back but she's just that *little faster* and manages to let the staff Clone knock her connecting baton out of the way and in doing so (by making an opening) connects her second baton with the Clone's unarmoured fingers and sheers *off* three of them while the other two instantly *paralyze* from shock a second later the wrist and forearm go limp too.

Adora has no time to revel in her victory even though she's disarmed one Clone of its primary weapon because the other is coming straight for her and she needs to mov-

Back turned, white boots pounding on metal panel floor and shield raised, Adora manages to miss being electrocuted by the baton but the energy shield makes contact with her shoulder and at the speed of the impact she's thrown to the side and topples over - forehead making contact with the floor and black splots brewing at the edge of her vision and blurry images ghosting when she immediately picks herself up and rolls to avoid the staff Clone's strike at her face, while it cant perform the maneuvers it used to, it's using the staff as some kind of improvised pole and it almost ended up in her ribcage if she didn't ignore the pain and roll away a *second* time.

Adora manages to pick herself up again without injury and *thumps* the near broken rib from earlier to spike her energy again.

The two Clone’s circle again, intending to be at both her twelve and six o’clock. Either to delay, incapacitate or kill her.

It’s *obvious* , she needs to finish this now.

Prime is still *here.*

They can predict her, they’re strong *and* smart enough to weather her attacks if she doesn't aim correctly *and* she’s running out of time.

Adora is back to where she started in a way, the injured staff Clone behind her with the red lights of the hallways backlighting her rear, the prepared shield Clone protecting Prime with the illumination of the hanger in front.

She attacks.

To her rear.

Stun baton bounces off the side of the Clone’s head, the other repeatedly smashing into the staff to keep it down and pinned while she whacks and uses that energy gained from pain to force as many concussions into the injured Clone as possible ; sure it strikes back but with one hand out of action and the other clutching the weapon, it’s helpless to stop both of Adora’s batons

and eventually she wears it down even while the other Clone tries to assist, it's comrade is too weak to *resist.*

One problem removed.

Except the staff is still tightly gripped in its fingers, fingers that could crush a windpipe and'd need precious seconds to pry open..

One problem gained.

Panting from either ardenline or energy loss - sweat turned cold and forced shivers from the low temperature and lack of insulation ; Adora turns on the final obstacle in her way. She restructures her form to become looser, arms apart with batons turned on to levels of electric instability, bruises blue marking her skin and a mixture of foreign and personal blood mixed with sweat staining what remains of her clothes and exposed red tinted flesh.

She breathes in, breathes out. Raises one baton high and the other low. Stalks the Clone who readies itself with shield front and baton back, they circle each other with Adora making feints that either miss when the Clone dodges, batons clash with each other or she hits the shield instead. Adora increases the pace and keeps hitting in the home runs and uncaring if the battery in the batons scream with danger low since they're whittling down the battery in the Clone's shield *faster* and she cares little for personal injury at this point.

It's either fury or fortunate miss that prompts a lucky disarming hit that blows out the shield's capacitor with a miniature shockwave that has the Clone reeling backward and unable to resist, Adora takes the opportunity with open arms and rushes

fast into a forward leap that has her jumping straight on top of the Clone's chest and plunging the tips of twin stun batons directly into its chest, the physical fall aides penetration and within a few seconds the Clone dies via electrocution.

Batons fried or stuck in a forgien body, Adora forcefully pries the staff out of the other Clones dead fingers with gusto and gives it a few experimental tries and swings and jabs, chest heaving and eyesight battered; she still manages to handle it well.

One left.

The Emperor.

Adora's voice is hoarse and words pained at this point and what comes out is more of a gruff issued at the same level as a elderly sergeant at drill rather than someone in their physical prime of twenty-two.

"Prime"

He hasn't turned round yet not even bothering to acknowledge that Adora's come to end his miserable fucking existance?

Rage coils her fingers tight around her new staff and she calls out again, the bile in her throat aiding the emotional severity of the meaning behind those few short words.

"Face me you fucking coward - your Clone's *are gone* and the rest are too far behind to save you, it's *over* ."

Adora expected something other than Prime to merely chuckle and gesture an arm at the massive window showing space outside. "No one is coming for *you* either Adora, your wasteful attempts at safeguarding relationships only isolated and pushed your beloved friends away, you have simply merely stalled my efforts temporarily and I can *assure* you - everything *will* proceed as planned soon"

Adora's not taking the bait and throws a jab back all while advancing, albeit cautiously. Prime's height and sheer strength is a dangerous combination.

"They're safe, from *you.* They escaped *you* despite your best efforts and they'll be back on Etheria soon, *you failed* Prime"

"Oh I failed? I'm afraid Prime only recognizes success, Prime saw you fighting your sisters a few moments ago - Adora and Prime is pleased with their efforts, Prime's enemies will be congregating in one place *thanks to you* sending the Queen and her associates back to Etheria on a ship with limited fuel"

Despite the urge to remind herself that this *is* Prime's standard modus operandi of bullshit and ego driven, a faint spark of desperation turns into a sliver of terror in Adora's voice when she replies back.

"-don't remember killing anything that aint' yours , they *failed* to stop me and now it's *just* us"

Prime makes that horrible sneer and scoffing sound even though his back is still turned and it sends shivers down Adora's spine even though she's the one with the *weapon.* She's so close to killing him though and despite that face, something seems *off.*

"These two you *murdered* are part of you Adora, your particular brand of DNA while damaged was enough to forge a new tool to be wielded by the hand of Prime - a new general with skills and that admirable sense of loyalty fused with the unbreakable will and strength of Prime's own, I shall once again have generals by my side and they will *not* fail me this time"

And Prime finally turns to face her, head cocked and lips in that gruesome, victorious smile.

"And all thanks to you, Prime welcomes and accepts your efforts"

That realisation sends Adora in a half panic and rage induced stutter, the thought of *hers* running amok at the behest of the man she loathes and mudering people and enslaving planets is fucking terrifying and she-

"I'll fucking kill you!" Adora growls and with full intent that she's going to gut Prime open like a goddamn fish.

Prime just shrugs with his head turned to the side, white bird-like claws twice or maybe three times the size of Catra's extend and flex.

"Prime will extend the offer to you one more time, you have spat in the face of Prime and his people twice and this will be a third, repent your sins and retreat or else you will never be granted amnesty again if you dare to lay your hands on him"

Is he fucking serious?

Adora has two words to say right before she levels her staff and aims herself as a human projectile at Prime in a final run to the finish line, just one more battle with the Emperor of the galaxy and a desperate bid to save her friends.

It's a scream landen hoarse shout muffled by a sudden intake of breath and ardenline as she rushes forward without a real plan or means to save herself after her final objective.

She's pretty sure she mentioned Catra.

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(I wont be controlled She-Ra OST)

It's different this time, more daunting and nerve wrecking to finally face down the Emperor practically rather than the
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imaginative theoretical.

A mixed combination of feelings, surprised she's gotten this far, the need to succeed and prove that her decisions are right and correct.

And a barely acknowledged desire to make Prime bleed. Force him to pay and kneel and then die for justice and revenge for all the hurt he's caused her.

And determination, the will and courage to see this through or die trying. There will be no zero, only a hundred.

The more Adora studies Prime and figures out a way to take him down, the more the enormity of the task weighs on her ; seemingly heavier than the thousand year old hopes of Etheria when she was a princess. Prime is *tall* , and Adora has to crane her neck to make eye contact and while she could probably take Prime down like this, his entire fighting style is undisciplined and civilian like, more emphasis on brute force and hammering then methodical footwork and practiced fighting and while Adora would eventually wear Prime down like this, stabbing and cutting to produce the time honored strategy of a thousand cuts, Prime is *extremely large* (he's wider than even She-Ra's monstrous proportions) and Adora's timeframe to kill him without interference gets lower every minute she spends dodging and even making him *bleed.*

She’s faster though and can avoid him, she has her stolen staff and it's both lighter *and* stronger than anything she's wielded before, she couldn't ask for a better weapon that can swap from fending off Prime’s attacks to on the defense to immediately following up with an attack of her own - in a way it’s more analogous to Catra fighting She-Ra than *Adora fighting Prime.*

Although the more she thinks about facing Prime, the more the cold door of existential terror on fighting a literal spectre of inhuman and non magical proportions creeps in and settles to ice in her veins and headspace, that it’s boggling and mind numbing to see two tree trunks fly at her and have the nerve and mental capability to react and dodge in the nick of time, *every time.* And then contend with the emotional ability to actually hit back at a target weighing at least *300kilograms or more* with a body phenotype more aligned with a statue than something biologically created with a petrifying degree of psychopathic intelligence. Coupled with the flowing white cape with elements of a million conquests that enhances his already vast stature, Adora is horribly out of her depth.

But the need, the promises and the words she said and kept are more powerful and mean more than the threat of being simply squashed and killed by a being four times her weight and nearly twice her height - if she has to fight a god to honor her assurances - so be it.

When Prime whispers at her, it’s still with the force of a regular person shouting and the loose hair strands on her forehead waver with the blast of air. The Emperor simply peers down at her from a height a regular monarch would need a throne for.

“I assured you, you would not get a fourth chance, Adora. You're reckless decision to *dare* touch Prime is transgression punishable by your very existence being erased from history”

Adora doesn't even skip a beat.

“Fuck you”

She wont give him the satisifcation of knowing that she’s fucking frightend underneath and that she needs to be strong and brave right now to do what she dropped herself into and to climb out of the hole she knowingly dug herself in.

So when Adora dodges Prime’s heavy blows that could snap a tree trunk with such force, she takes a leaf out of Catra’s book. She stays light on her feet when the fist’s come flying for her face and backsteps, dodges to the side or when the opportunity presents itself - a quick strike with her new acquired staff to a vulnerable chink in the Emperors armor that sometimes misses, but when it hits-.

-he bellows and shouts a nameless curse - *when the sharpened tip of Adora’s staff pierces into his wrist.* The Emperor’s demeanor changes with that, a true form or a suppressed self takes over and it's downright feral in its ferocity.

He throws a punch with the blind force of a catapult that nearly knocks Adora over and sends her flying back several meters with a crumpled bone- *if she hadnt ducked under the way and landed*

her own gut punch into the liver that gifted her with a fresh bruise but produced a audible groan as a reward.

Adora uses technique, a combination of learned boxing from the Horde,the Crimson Waste and the Rebellion, she’s focused with her punches, pinpoint with her staff strikes and adept at avoiding the heavy haymakers of the Emperor.

Can Adora do this?

Prime curses her name and threatens to butcher everything she’s ever known when she makes him *bleed red* when she manages to dodge a concrete breaking fist and lands about ten centimeters of her staff in the Emperor's vulnerable squishy - and unarmoured side.

Adora has a focused mindset and experience from fighting everything from Huntara to Rebellion Guards in a training spar, she’s moving as fast as she can and dodging with impunity that Catra would be proud of (after all she was on the opposite side of this more than once), she lands her strikes and moves away with the annoying but staying power of a gnat that Prime quite can't catch.

She can do this. As long as she doesnt get hit.

Prime doesn't rely on the martial techniques of his Clone’s or even the one’s Adora fought scant minutes ago, instead he simply pushes onwards and drives Adora back by sheer monumentum

and weight, even if his wild jab's are thrown in blind directions forwards, they're still landed with enough power that Adora has to *dodge.*

And he's getting quicker. The windup tell-tale signs slowly disappear and his eye focus on the spot the Emperor is aiming at are increasingly more difficult to predict.

And those punches.

Two at a time, sometimes another and another in follow up, sure Adora is landing hits but they're small and insignificant compared to Prime's terrifyingly gigantic frame and each second of exposure spent getting *hits in* is a multiplier of danger that could see Adora lose a arm if she *fucks up.*

She can't play this safe, especially when Prime's fist the size of a child's head almost takes *hers* off.

Adora needs to focus more, she has too much riding on the line to fuck this up. She made Angella a *promise* , she *guaranteed* Glimmer and she *swore* a safe return to Catra.

Adora needs to get to work.

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She is water, flowing around the rock of Prime's increasingly wild punches. Adora says naught because she's concentrating and waiting for an opportunity and instead of striking with piercing blows on body sections that would simply enrage Prime, she waits for an opening. Adora's analytical mind born out of a combination twenty two years of Horde, Rebellion and Rogue have honed her senses to predict, adapt and overcome, she's starting to get a grip on Prime's "fighting pattern" as base as it is and it's clear why the man relied on Generals and outsourcing his tactics, he's a scientist turned egotistical dictator that relies on brute strength.

Brute strength that Adora can sidestep, bait and then duck out of the way to present naught but air and continue to put Prime in a off state of mind by concentrating his efforts on *her* and it's aided by Adora's stolen staff putting precise piercing strikes in sections to sully the Emperor's flawless features with his own blood and dirt - and while it's one of a thousand cuts needed for a strategy like this ; it's simply a delaying action.

Prime will *fuck up* eventually.

Adora *is* the water she tells herself, she needs to forget about the terrifying real fate that could befall if she *fucks up,* she needs to be logical and calm and to erase the racing heart and thoughts and transform her complicated emotions of the past day into a simple emotionless state.

Stepback, react. Breathe - in, out. No time to think more than necessary, just a combination of learnt body movements coupled

with muscle memory and the *plan.* She *loves* planning, Adora was made Force Captain, Commander and General for a *reason* . (Catra said she was a neurotic planner) And they're counting on her to deliver because she made *promises* and *guarantees* and she wont fuck this up now - she's too close to fail and the finish line is trying to whack her in the face with a haymaker.

Adora gets into position, makes herself ready for a lightning fast series of maneuvers that'll see her targeting and taking down Prime's vulnerable joints and leave him unable to defend his throat when Adora comes for it, she just needs him to follow the base instincts of consistent anger fuelled punches that-

He's kicked her in the chest, powerful enough to send her flying back onto her *back* at least five meters away and she's not only stunned by cracking her skull onto the hard floor but the horrific derailment of her plans and *assumption* of things.

Prime is speaking about something as he advances over at a predators pace, cracking his knuckles and cheerfully delighting about how he's going to rip Adora's head off and she needs to get the fuck up now because she's either going to get stepped on or torn apart but she's fucking paraylzed by indecision forced new stimuli that's ruined *everything.*

Prime is coming and judging by the way his hands are twitching, he's fully intending to pick Adora up by the scruff and rip her asunder and she *needs to move.*

He’s so close now that craning the head to make eye contact is impossible, Adora’s heartbeat is going crazy and her lungs are expelling breaths are a fearsome rate and yet she’s rooted to the spot because her plan failed and she *needs* to-

Prime reaches down with a single claw studded hand, Adora has seconds to go until she’s-

-stabs him right in the knuckles and the end of the staff is far enough along that when Prime screams a awful blood curling shout of pain and anguish it forces Adora out of her shocked state and she actually *screams* back when the Emperor - in a combination of primal pain rage and absolute unmasked insanity with a contoured face that hollars and bellows and starts to flail around and since Adorals still clutching that staff she’s tossed around in the air like she *weighs nothing* and is subjected to twenty seconds of Prime’s furious pitching until his non-stumpy meathook smashes into Adora with a enormous backhand and she’s sent flying - no *ragdolling* into the ground and careen’s face first into floor metal, the sheer force of the impact almost has her curl up in pain but she forces her to recover and keep going. She’s dealt a serious injury and it’s undeniable proof that the self appointed god *can bleed.*

And that Adora can fix it.

Prime is slow on the uptake but gaining rapidly, his words a shambolic mixture of his alien language, threats in the one Adora can understand and pained grunts, but it’s clear that he intends to *attack,* his eyes shifting from Adora to the staff that transformed his left hand into a bloody stump still remains as a sort of

bastardized skewer stick intended to gut Adora in pure animalistic rage.

Adora picks herself up again, breathes in: One, two, three, four and breathes out: one ,two, three, four and puts her mind and body to the mad thing she’s about to do.

A leaf out of Catra’s book. Something unexpected and possibly crazy.

Adora closes the gap between her and Prime, surprising the Emperor momentarily since only a crazy person would willingly place themselves in harm's way? But Adora is in her physical prime right now and those wounds haven’t begun to slow her down yet.

Prime has his arms out open wide as he charges, the stump arm held back for a long wind up designed to knock Adora over and disable her as she’s making no moves to dodge and they’re getting closer.

Prime attacks first, the combination of body weight and momentum propelling him into an unstoppable upper body charge that’d floor even Equestria’s creatures, the staff providing him with an animalistic antler of some kind.

But Adora isn't aiming for the kill shot that Prime and anyone who knows her would’ve expected her to do.

Prime focuses *everything* on the upper body, his assault is unstoppable and impossible to be deflected or countered by any means that Adora could possess or think of, *only* She-Ra could hope to redirect the immense amount of force barreling down straight at her.

Adora doesnt dodge, nor move away.

She performs the unthinkable act of running straight at her assailant that weighs three times as much as her and picks up speed to *close* the gap, instead of attacking Prime's upper body for a killshot or even attempting to evade the staff that's being wound up and is going to take her head *off* - Adora waits until the very last second.

And aims for Horde Prime's left knee. With her body.

Weight and impact force directed kinetically to one simple spot that has her reeling in pain and slamming onto her side from a collision so hard she's rolling when she hits the ground in an unsteady and uncontrolled manner.

But Prime has it *worse.*

Adora doesn't need to visually witness the incredible train wreck of a truly massive being having their support *literally* kicked out from under them, the Emperor's fall forward turns wild and obstreperous and combined with the massive weight and

inexperience - topples away in the manner of a large animal suddenly losing its front legs.

She has to get up.

She has to finish this.

She has to fix it.

Reeling in sharp pain from, muffling the involuntary vocal response of mounting unimaginable pressure on previous wounds and forcing herself back to her and towards the fallen Emperor who's already (but slowly) getting back onto his own feet. Adora has second's to make use of the crazy attack and push in every advantage she ripped from Prime.

Height.

Weight.

Reach.

Heart beating a thousand overs.

Will to act, to do the *thing* channeling her actions.

Repressed rage gives her the strength and means.

To kill.him.

In haste to reach the Emperor before he manages to rise and continue the process all over again, Adora trips and nearly falls more than enough times due to the pain in her knees and the aches all over her body but she reaches Prime as he's still stunned from a full body impact - Adoraclambers over to the one legged Emperor and kicks him in the back of the skull to keep him *down* , she reaches over frantically to the bloody stump of the Emperor's former hand ,stamping on the fingers of the other and wrenching the staff clear with two bloody hands - Prime's head cranes up to make contact and blazing green orbs are instead dimmer and become significantly more "normal". Even though she's standing above him, Adora still feels small.

Adora's face turns twisted when the slow motion staring contest begins, she beats down the familiar feel of fear that comes with the knowledge of ending another's life and replaces it with the righteous sense that Prime *deserves it.*

Did she ask him how it feels? Did she tell him to go fuck himself or did she scream Catra's name? Adora struggles to remember if she talked at all or if Prime even made a sound or a reaction when she put a full half of the staff into the Emperor's throat and watched as that squelching choking sound gradually tapers into quiet and then silence.

Adora kicks Prime's head for good measure to confirm he's dead. The distant sound of the Clone's trying to reach their master are gone too and it's all turned silent.

“Holy shit”

She’s done it. She’s won?

The staff is pulled out and it’s messy and bloody and red, it clatters to the floor and stains it with the true color of the man who built it.

“Catra?” *I won.*

She did it!. She’s fixed it! She succeeded. She made her promises and she avenged Catra.

What should she be feeling? Euphoria? Relief? A sense of justice and pride or melancholy and base satisfaction of a job well done, a part of her is expecting a medal or a salute just like in the days gone past but those are days gone *past.*

I won Catra, I won. He’s gone forever and I wish you were here.

Prime’s corpse grins back at her when she slumps down from standing tall, her heart rate and energy infused body climb down and the feeling of victory slowly tapers away into a disinterested mood - followed shortly by a pang of depression and sadness.

Catra’s dead and all Adora did was avenge her. She won't be riding triumphantly home to celebration and crowds. She won’t be coming home at all actually, she made sure of that.

Nobody will know.

It’s just her and a dead body, just Adora in clothes that have more in common with burnt toast than articles of wear. Cold environment that produces shivers and sighs and a whole lot of *nothing* to go around.

When Adora speaks again , it’s with a bubbling lip laced with loneliness and sagging shoulders and a pang of loss.

“I won Catra”

“I fixed it”

“I-” *She chokes.*

Part of her just asks the question right there and then.

Was it worth it? She’s killed hundreds to get there, she’s thrown away all of her friends and buried others to achieve her goals. She’s won but- there’s something missing,a hole in her heart or imagined expectation of more? That it’d be a grand fight and heroic bout of arms and skill rather than pure desperation and bare survival .

Truth be told, it’s getting a little empty here.

There’s nothing else to do.

Revel in victory? Cry?

Adora doesn't know and quite frankly ; she didn't expect to get this far. *To win, to fix it.*

She reached the finish line and discovered no medals or celebrations nor a screaming crowd, just an empty race track behind and nothing out in front.

Catra.

She did this for Catra? To avenge her and Juliet and Spinny and Seahawk and so many others, that Adora could *stop* the invasion if she managed to off Prime and now he’s fucking dead just like the others but she doesnt feel any better, she had a deathwish coming here and in some small part; expected to have died - possibly trying and hopefully succeeded before dying, then she wouldnt have to worry about going home and facing the prospect of a life without Catra and nothing to do because then she’d end up destroying herself without a war with constant battles to *plan* and *plan* and wage and never sleep.

She’s spiraling again because there’s nothing to *focus* on. Catra can’t be saved and can’t be avenged now, Prime can't be sought after or chased because he’s dead and Etheria is over there and utterly unreachable and Adora is over here and she’s fucking cold and wishes she could *feel* nothing but she’s feeling *something* and doesnt like it.

The staff is next to her feet and it’s stained with someone’s blood, Adora’s body is more colorful than the *white* around but it’s with ugly bruises running from the timescale of red to yellow and the rips in her clothing show wounds running from basic light chafing to blunt trauma lacerations and moderate to serious contusions from repeated body slamming or being ragdolled around.

Adora looks like *shit* , feels like *shit* and everything is *shit.*
Everything is collapsing because-

Catra.

Racing thoughts and pounding heartbeat of imagined scenarios of the one person she’d have stepped away with, nausea and light sweating of the hoops and physical pain she went through to the Clone’s they killed and almost losing Catra from a fall that Adora barely managed to avoid herself.

Pain in chest and difficulty breathing, holding on to ribcage and forcing herself to counteract seemingly shorter lung capacity when the dreaded retrospective thought’s come that Adora should have taken her chances and jumped down with Catra or done

something *different.* That a *different* Adora would have done it better and Catra might have lived.

"Catra?"

Is she sobbing or is it imagined with a dry throat and dusty eyes?.

"Catra"

Adora *wants* for a better outcome that felt like it was always out of reach but a few minor things could have *changed it.*

"I'm sorry"

Shadow Weaver and Cadets, Thaymor, Princess Prom, The Crystal Castle, The Crimson Waste and The Portal and of course.

Prime's Headquarters with the massive screens and the ledge into nothingness and the *promise* she made.

"I really am"

The cottage and the field. The hopefulness of a new life and the prospects of together without interruption with the chance of no all-nighters and leading people into certain death.

It’s all gone isn't it? Thoughts and memories blending together with the chaotic fury of a paint brushes palette mixed in dirt and crayons and it's so overwhelming and things are coming back and they need to go *away* because-

Movement.

Adora turns her body to investigate.

Something slides into a place above the hip and below the naval, it’s cold and doesn't register as anything first.

A head leans over, a grinning pale face with a barely grown in beard and a lazy third eye that stutters open.

It’s Prime.

She didn't kill him.

Panic? Fight back? New objective? Where.is.the.plan?

Prime’s voice filters through the cascading series of conflicting thoughts and it’s underpinned with that self-assured

megalomania. The one that puts Adora off balance and gets under her skin and it's even worse because-

"I should thank you for such a thrilling experience Adora, however I was quite clear when I spoke regarding the consequences of touching Prime"

-she's been stabbed. And she's being mocked for her efforts because *none* of it worked and she's going to have to do it all over again.

The dagger she dropped in that pile of bodies ten hours ago is lodged in her body and the excruciating pain is-.

Prime has it.

Prime stabbed her.

Ado-

Prime is still alive.

She *killed* him and he's *back* from the dead and it hurts so fucking much that it requires a extraordinary level of willpower to stay upright rather than sink to her knees in surrender. Flashes of

agony burn at every nerve ending and the urge to *scream* is mounting with every moment of increasing pressure.

Adora does mutter or plead *something* - or rather it comes out without consent in a tortured grunt of distress, the words force her eyes to travel down to her right hand expecting to see a spark of something, a sword or a axe or even a dagger with expectation of bodily transformation of a injured but functional self to a war god capable of annihlating hundreads in but a few simple minutes.

The howl for help hits her ears, fizzles at the fingertips and sparks travel to the palm and even Prime pauses with a sharp intake of breath.

Five words and twenty two simple letters amalgamated into a ancient magical battle rite of fusion and power, for Adora it was a phrase that would solve everything and then it was lost, she used it to justify running away from her problems and now its a very real and a very serious cry for *help.*

The first part comes out as a choke.

For The Honor-

Second is a barely managed wheeze.

-of Grayskull

She waits, Prime even calls out for his followers and the distant sounds of an approaching army become real once again. Adora hopes and she needs it - She-Ra's power to save herself and kill Prime again but the sparking is-

Nothing happens.

Bones chill, hair stands up and Prime chuckles in that haughty tone at the assured realization that the subject of Adora's frantic call for assistance is mute.

Prime sinks the dagger in and twists it.

She-Ra isn't coming.

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Two chapters to go, VII and Eight. Sorry for the wait, it's been a crazy few weeks and I've finally managed to be with my wife
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again after separation from covid so getting work done while being constantly snuggled can be difficult D:.

I hope it was a good read! Definitely nearing the end and I never thought I'd end up writing my longest ever fic (so far) with this!.

So how did I do? As always, comments are literally food for the soul and seeing them warms me up like no other <3

Anyway, as per the tags say. It's only going to get worse…

VII

"Remember when we used to hide under the blankets while the other cadets were asleep and have our own sleepover with stolen ration bars and we'd talk about-"

"I know, I miss those times"

"I do too,it's not the same anymore. We're all older now and I doubt the two of us could fit in those singles now…but still, there is a part of me that desperately wants to do it again"

"To be back in those times where the only worry was getting a hot shower in the morning and the color of the ration bars for the day. Simpler and easy times rather…well this"

"I miss you Catra"

"I miss you too, Adora"

Getting stabbed is hard to describe to those fortunate enough to have not experienced it.

It's like watching a Horde Tank get penetrated by a magical energy beam that penetrates the tough armor plating and shoots straight out of the side, taking mechanical blood like crew members and needed machinery and dumping them outside carelessly.

At first, the area around it goes cold and numb, all Adora feels is the entirety of the dagger , its smooth edges painted with her insides, its texture and temperature.

With realization and nerve's kicking into gear, only then does the screaming start, an endless queue of screaming obscenities with gripped white knuckles and every muscle tightening with unmanageable tenseness.

Adora has been stabbed *before* , Shadow Weaver, the Horde, the Crimson Waste's and every conflict then for the next four years (and counting) to name a few..

Still she *screams* , practically crying with her head thrown back while the maniacal laughter of Prime *booms* in her ears.

But Adora does recover, she's not coughing up blood, her limbs are still movable and she's not losing energy.

So it's a non fatal stab wound, it's *manageable.* And it's *painful* . Adora can work with it.

Part of Force Captain conditioning *is working with it* ,dumping depression and guilt and loneliness and burning them into useful tools that fire up the body and supercharge production of strength building adrenaline and pain killing endorphins.

It's rage, absolute fucking rage that has her grinding her own teeth down and sparking every last drop of ardenline and pain numbing hormone, cancelling the bloody nerves around the

impact area and transferring energy to *get back up.* Ignore the pain and the desperation, forget about She-Ra and the weight of world and just fucking *do it.*

If Prime has to die a second time, so be it. She must have missed something anyway.

Hissing through her teeth as the blade grinds against her insides, Adora twists in place and

the Prime Clone clearly aint the same as the others when Adora locks gazes with him at a slightly more even eye level, he's a slightly different looking Clone than the regular with brighter eyes and face with *expression* plus the new grown mustache and third eye, clearly he needs to be *put down* twice.

She'll have to leave the dagger in so Prime cant use it, and so her insides - stay inside.

Whatever words she spits out is more grunt and grease than an actual attempt at communication, maybe she's too far gone for this or her emotional communication has finally broken down after years of being locked away.

She wipes the sweat off her brow with bloody hands, cracks her knuckles and lets fury take its course to fuel her veins with its red energy.

"-"

Prime blinks three times, one for each disgusting little eye and he's so full of self assurance and victory that his first death meant little when he does begin to speak in that haughty and monarchical tone to make her feel small as a insect would in the presence of a mighty animal.

"Cleary *Force Captain I-* "

It has the opposite effect, lending energy and pissing her off.

Adora throws a punch with the stagger more in tune with inebriation than martial arms training and it goes right at Prime's face and snaps his jaw upwards to make him *shut* the fuck up. He staggers when Adora follows up with a backhand that smacks his cheek to the side and forces Prime back.

Partially to make him shut the fuck up and partially to give herself breathing room.

Panting and groaning as the exertion and pressure on the dagger embedded in her gut brings up a sharp stab of pain, Adora nonetheless swipes her staff off the floor and staggers back to Prime with red stripes lining her body and sweat from overworking herself to the brink *four times* in the space of a day..

She has to *focus.*

But it hurts so much. Every little movement, even a twist or a limb sends a spike of uncomfortable pain and she has to *ignore* it, she has to take the chip off the Prime clone and she *cannot* fail. Disregard the headache and the blood in her mouth and the aching bones that scream for *just five more minutes* .

Adora has a mission, an objective to complete.

Etheria and its people are *depending* on her to deliver just like they did with the hundreds of times that She-Ra succeded, if she *fails* then they'lll get hurt or die or chipped by that sick fuck of a man thousands of years old and he'll keep going until he harms everyone Adora swore to protect as part as her rite as She-Ra - Princess of Power.

Adora doesn't *get* to relax or to sit down. Her responsibilities and her mantle come first and she made that choice with Shadow Weaver, Angella and the destruction of her sword at the Crystal Castle combined with rejection of Light Hope's philosophy and refusing to side with Prime despite the promises of everything she ever wanted.

She is going to save Etheria, no matter what it takes and whatever the burden of cost will be, she'll wear it.

The weight of the world sits squarely and solely on her shoulders and it's heavier than a single stab wound will ever be.

Adora *has* to fix it.

There is no other option.

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ChapterVII:

"We Must Be Strong And We Must Be Brave"

The Emperor of the universe has died and come back to life.

The clock is ticking and time is not on her side.

Adora *can't give up* ,she's *too close* .

She *will* - *kill* him.

You *have* to do this Adora.
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You're the only one left.

There’s one last chance left Adora, it’s ten minutes to midnight.

It must be done.

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There is no emergency red backlighting to counter the sheer white of the Temple ships hanger, everything is painted in various shades of white from half constructed battleships suspended like pinatas on the hanger ceiling to thousands of inactive drones all sporting the same bland and perfectly duplicated in Prime’s nature.

The Crimson Waste, a mostly lifeless desert where for eight hours a day the sheer natural brightness of the sun would force all living creatures to hang their heads low and squint otherwise they’d be blinded, was a more varied landscape than *this.* Where reflections of artificial *white* would bounce on the color *white* and would then beam pure *white* directly into the user’s eye’s if they’re not careful.

Adora however, does not have time for this.
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Adora immediately goes on the offensive, she's battering away Prime's claw-like hands and repeatedly slamming him in the gut and joints with deft twists and turns with her staff, using both ends and their advantages to its best effects.

Prime is faster and seemingly more capable, he won't be knocking Adora flat with one hit but he has received some kind of *upgrade* with this new body. Whatever it is - it's a new model if its weird third eye and abilities are anything to go by. Even if the movements are jittery and unnatural in the same way that wearing the wrong shoe size makes it difficult to walk.

Thank fuck Adora has a staff.

Desperation of a promise made and to be kept fuels her with energy.

A heart beating with fury keeps her topped up with adrenaline as she blocks another fist to the face and whacks Prime in the side of the head for good measure.

And the weight of the world, those counting on Adora to succeed partially nullifies the pain of having a dagger lodged in her side and poking at her gut.

And that leftover pain simply keeps her *going.*

The march of an army reverberts off the walls and floors, even though the doors are blocked or closed the sheer sound is enough to be as audible as a beating hammer and only intensify the clear fast moving sand shift of an hourglass running out.

She staggers back from a fist slamming into her shoulder and ducks to avoid a haymaker aimed at her head - but the thought of Prime coming to Etheria and converting everyone to mindless slaves is more powerful right now than massive bruises.

If Adora does speak, it's a half deprecative monologue to herself and venting frustrations at Prime.

“Go fuck yourself! I won't let you hurt them!”

Adora grunts through a closed jaw and a pained hiss at a naked sore shoulder that’ll cramp later.

Time is running out, Prime *cannot* be allowed to escape.

Panting through masses of exerted energy - shifting from left to right to juggle the pain, Adora makes a bet.

One, two, three . Adora puts all weight on her right leg, leans backwards and pretends to have *fucked up* .

Prime see’s a feinted weakness and exposes himself. He laughs - or snarls.

Adora doesn't understand the language.

Both fists come flying without pause, one for the stomach and one for the face. Two massive body shots that’ll pop organs and crush bones.

Adora rolls with the punches, judging her support to *be enough* she falls back on the knee and spins with practiced dexterity to avoid the gut punch *and* the face punch, offering no resistance and allowing it to flow over her like water over a rock - the impact *hurts* but it creates an opening*.*

And momentum.

Being spun round does however have its benefits.

Adora swings round with the staff pointed in one direction all the way to Prime’s exposed and vulnerable side and stabs him with the pointed *tip.*

Prime *howls* in agony.

Adora then turns the staff upwards and uses the opportunity to swing it all the way upwards to Prime’s chin and *discombobulate* - snapping the Emperor's head to create disorientation and follows up with a sweeping kick to the back of the knee and the Emperor topples over.

And she stabs him in the fucking throat, again.

The Emperor is dead.

Again.

Adora waits, one,two, three,four.

Nothing, just blood and a gurgling sound followed by the eyes darkening and then the light flicking away.

Adora breathes a sigh of relief, relaxes and sags - wipes her forehead clean of the sweat and kicks Prime’s corpse in the throat to make sure.

And that's when a pair of pounding boots that support the mass of a body two hundred plus kilograms and more thunder across the floor with the weight and sound of a fucking train and Adora is simply too stunned to react in time - she can accept Prime having a back up but *this* ?Prime *;* with a third *and* a fourth eye lifts

Adora up by the scruff with one straining arm and snaps the staff in half with the other.

In desperation Adora flails out to try and wiggle free but Prime simply *kicks* Adora with the power of a sport player's punt and she's flying across the hanger and ends up in an agonizing heap on the floor.

Prime isn't dead.

He's come back for round three.

And he's fucking estatic about it.

"Come now Adora, did you forget?" A hand half the size of a face and attached to an arm longer than a staff opens at the palm.

He *smirks* , the two small eyes flickering open and closed with disturbing artificiality.

"Prime know's all *child* - Prime sees all"

Adora is down to her bloody fists, and everything hurts.

She has to pick herself *up* , she *has* to do this.

She has to *fix* this. No matter the cost to herself and whether or not she'll survive.

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It's fucking *agony.*

The kind of body twisting ,rib bruising, spine hurting and flashes at visions edge *agony.* The stuff that would make any ordinary person give up the fight and let the torture take over and *scream.* To simply remain on the floor and wave the white flag, admit defeat and never get up.

Adora is and has never been, just an ordinary person. She's the product of Force Captain conditioning and puts the welfare and condition of others over herself, not to mention she can just ignore such… *inconveniences* for now.

Adora has more pressing concerns than external damage to herself. The bad knee that pops when she flexes it can *wait* - and so too can the exhaustion of desperate muscle screaming for a second to catch oxygen.

It's her fucking lungs. An intolerable and cramped series of grating noises whenever she opens her mouth come out rather than
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unmoistened dehydrated speech or practiced respiration of conditioning.

It’s not regular breathing, it’s a bark of a dry cough mixed with wet sand from the lung and speckles of red blood coating both skin and floor, every harsh forced exhale blurs Adora’s vision with alternations of white and black at the edges - and that awful ringing sound that pings from ear to ear refuses to diminish.

And Adora hasn't even picked herself off the floor yet, she’s still lying in a heap of hurt.

Adora *needs* to think, rack her brains and come up with a solution ; a plan right *now.*

She pushes her memory back to Catra and every Clone encountered in the past three months , whatever size or shape they all had one thing in common that never failed to materialize - they could *all* be possessed by Prime. Their eyes would brighten and the voices would change, but that also meant that like with Catra, the connection could be severed if the chip at the back of the neck was ripped off and usually resulted in the Clone either dying or becoming paraylzed.

So all Adora has to do is get close enough, rip the chip out with her bare hands and somehow survive the trip there, her body fucking aches and that stab wound with the weapon still inside is inflamed with pain bought by the kick and the harsh landing.

And Prime has changed too.

In comparison this Prime is all elegance and deadly, it's movements are fluid and responsive and nothing like the heavy bone breaking strikes of the first or the growth spurt of the second.

The previous Clone was a juvenile.

This is an adult.

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It's hand to hand. With no weapon to use, the playing field has shifted dramatically in Prime's favor.

Unsecured and raggedy blonde hair versus a shaven marable scalp.
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A loose and flexible form facing off against tall and tight.

Two feet bouncing on their balls against a stiff mountain of a biological creature.

Adora dusting off her boxing skills, Prime sticking to an unknown playbook.

Adora throws the first punch - shifting to her good leg and sneaking a hit under Prime's defenses and hitting where she hopes is the liver for an incapacitating hit, all she gets is a grunt and manages to dive away from the retaliatory strike thanks to her being as flexible as possible.

Prime is barely winded though, and Adora is near panting from previous exertion of *hours spent like this.*

Still, a first blow.

If that even matters at this point. The chip is the area to aim for and with the weight class being so distortedly obliged toward Prime, with just her bare fists and body at hand Adora has little that can actually immobilize or significantly hurt the Emperor.

Adora cannot give up ground or retreat for another day either, Prime's minions are close and they barrel through sealed blast doors and are getting closer every moment, there is no time to slowly chip away at Prime's defenses and a form a coherent strategy and even if there *was* time - Adora is slowing down through a combination of sustained words and internal damage from the knees to the lungs and she has to thump her fist into the knife created wound at her stomach to keep the adrenaline flowing from sheer self inflicted pain alone that creates both energy and…a scream each and every time.

And Prime is fucking *goading* her. His voice is clear and fresh.

"Come now Adora, is this truly the best you can offer? A mere boxer's effort?"

Compared to Adora's vocally dry and rough own.

"Shut the fuck up"

Heavy disorientating body blows via shoulder rushes.

"Can you truly not do better? I was under the impression that Hordak at least trained his Force Captains, no?"

Legs sweeping into the back of knees that are well timed and devastatingly effective.

“I must say, I am *disappointed* .”

Jabs, uppercuts and gut punches laden with increasing speed and frustration, if this was any other enemy they’d be dead or crippled from the hits Adora is landing but Prime just *refuses* to acknowledge it.

Even when Adora crosses her arms and traps Prime’s own punch between and follows into a counterjab that breaks Prime’s fucking *nose.*

With no reaction.

What is he made of?

Adora manages to pull back, takes a breather with hands on knees and considers her options.

Prime's unyielding stoicness and sheer physical resilience coupled with his piercing vocal taunts only further escalate the transformation of Adora's attacks from calm and calculated in metholdy to increasingly desperate in their violence and brutality, each one shortly predated by a dry sandpaper cough or a barely restrained bark of audible despondency from fighting a living wall with just a single weakness at its back.

A vulnerable area - *but* without a manufactured weapon - Adora with all her tired martial prowess cannot reach. And despite her frantic tries, from bone breaking assaults that herald body slams and great punches that increase in their aggression every time Adora slams her wounds with a coiled fist and pained grunts to spike needed adrenaline it's-

-it's not enough.

She's running out of time.

Adora is *going* to lose

It's with an increasingly frustrating level of self resentment that continues to burrow its way into Adora's rapidly spirally and unraveling hold on herself that she not only gets cold feet-

-she's cold *everywhere*

Why didn't she figure out the chip first?

Why couldn't she have killed Prime at the gel chamber?

Why didn't she interrogate the Clo-Wrong Hordak for everything he knew? Correct application of stun batons would have revealed at least *one* of Prime's weaknesses, there *has* to be one right?

And then Prime attacks, an overwhelming assault of a conditioned body that forces Adora to block or dodge every and all blows aimed at her.

And even when she's *perfect.*

When bracing her forearms to stop a haymaker that rattles the bones from the fingertips down, when she grabs one of Prime's legs after a missed kick and uses that to throw the Emperor on the floor.

When Adora uses her boxing skills to evade,deflect and fight back. It's basically fighting a wall. And it's as evidently clear as the dagger stuck in her gut that makes moving painful and uncomfortable.

That with all the dogged determination in the world and the willpower to see it through.

With just her physical body to rely on, Adora *cannot* fight Prime.

The dodging and the panting, the pain of hitting solid flesh and resulting in *nothing* , the feeling of watching energy reserves dwindle and grazes turn into wounds - Adora needs a plan.

Or a weapon.

Something sharp and that can be wielded a single hand, something that will break through and pierce the chip like with Catra's.

Adora racks her brain as she fights a desperate defense in depth, using the space in the hanger between her and Prime to maintain a distance she wouldn't get grappabled in or narrowly avoiding by rolling (despite the stabbing pain in her gut) or deflecting.

The stun batons are over *there,* too far away and she'd have to run and expose herself.

Or.

A knife is right *here.*

A sharp weapon able to *pierce and tear* (and do what her fists cannot) is embedded in her insides, it'll do the job and while it'd put her in the danger zone with no reach or flexibility - the suggestion of possible safety is long since dead so she might as well go for it.

Pulling it out and using it is the *only* option, it'd increase Adora's chances of success and succeeding in the mission as surely as it would open up a stab wound and cause a slow but sure loss of blood and her eventual demise. She's burning up energy already via simple expenditure of keeping herself warm, fighting Prime and exerting through countless multitude of wounds which means

that in conclusion ; eventually Adora *will fall* from sheer exhaustion.

A demise is fine, as long as she *wins.*

Because truthfully;

Adora isn’t afraid of death.

She’s terrified of *failing.*

Without question, Adora wraps her fingers on the hilt of the dagger embedded in her gut from the back and doesn't even attempt to mask the shrill scream from her lips as the fucking thing moves and *twists.*

So she *pulls.*

Despite the agazoning agitation of her penetrated insides being juggled around by sharp objects, Adora keeps at it - drawing the rest of the hilt out and cringing at the speckles (and then small lines) of her blood on the floor as she continues to backpedal away from Prime.

A scream becomes a pained series of grunts. Black spots form at the edges of her vision and then tears flow freely from the ducts,

jaw snapping shut and free hand clenching into a tight fist when the first edges of the dagger break free of her skin.

More blood.

The rest comes out soon after, Adora's hearing goes numb for a second and Prime is advancing with haste. She shakily staggers from side to side with full body shivers and moans in freezing pain from the cold both wrenched from the inside and oppressive environment from outside.

But she has a knife now.

And she's bleeding.

Whatever sand remained in the hourglass has disappeared by more than half - by giving herself a weapon.

Adora *is* that hourglass now.

By choice.

She'd do anything to win.

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My Name Is Adora And I'm So Cold.

It's not with a quick stab bourne of fleetfoot and dashing moves that signifies Adora's new attack against the Emperor of the known galaxy with a unknown but rapidly decreasing time to go before reinforcements arrive or her own death from a….variety of factors occurs.

Rather than a Force Captain's overwhelming assault with martial timing, or a hybrid mix of Rebellion training and Catra's teachings of boxing and quick movements. It's more barbaric with brutal hacks punctuated by coughs and a stomach lurching every time.

Adora staggers to the side - a stumble all the way from left to right , panting with red cheeks as her forehead goes white, one hand gripping a dagger formerly painted with her own insides and the other clutching her stomach, the organ with a hole in one side and barely kept together skin in the other.
~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~

The last Eternian with her ragged clothes, half naked tanktop and open sores attempts to *shank* Horde Prime with the grace of a back alley street robber than someone who'd spent twenty two years preparing and fighting multiple wars.

But still, Adora keeps going. Even as she slows down and struggles to sidestep blows and kicks, her dagger slices through bare flesh while the tortuous thumping headache and flashing white burns brighter in her retina than Prime's stark flashing clothing.

A stab into a wrist there when Prime over extends and Adora narrowly avoids a headbutt, instead forcing herself to stay in the danger zone of being in hugging distance of someone twice her body mass.

She says nothing - just a audible pained grunt or a pant every time because it's too much energy, while Prime's words or screams or taunts and shouts are just white noise as she manages to break past every few attempts and each time Adora's dagger sings true and she causes another vein to open ; or a finger sliced to uselessness.

A minute or two later, Adora is just hanging in there by a thread and it's when she sink's her dagger in between outstretched ribs, coupled with a kidney shot and signature kneecapping that Adora finally does get to the chip at the back of Prime's neck - and in just the nick of time before the Emperor can recover - Adora jams the dagger right in and twists at the biomechanical implant and watches with a mixture of satisfaction and disgust as the fluids contained within pop and then leak out in all directions as Prime screams, his spine spasms and he dies yet another death.

Probably from the slow and agonizing torture of paralyzation.

Adora doesn't drop to her knees this time to gather her strength, nor does she revel in her victory by dropping her weapon.

She sort of just stands there, swaying in an invisible breeze from side to side, unfurling and furling her fingers with hasty breaths and pained squints from looking down with a thumping headache to watch as more of her lifeforce drops out of numerous wounds.

She cant think to stop, her brain keeps going in its hypervigilance - Adora barely remembers to lick her dry lips as she watches every corner, hears the sound of the approaching army and the decreasing hissing of Prime’s neck chip. Did she kill him? Is he dead? Adora hopes and *wants* it.

Soon enough, a conclusion forms.

A figure drops out of a ship three times the size of Mara’s tethered to the roof of the hanger, it’s large and Clone like.

And it speaks.

Adora doesnt let her heart sink, neither does she blindly charge forward again or come up with a new strategy because she’s exhausted *everything* already..

She could laugh hysterically in bewilderment, she could scream in rage, she might shiver in panic and shout at herself for being stupid - but Adora’s too fucking tired for any of that. Exhaustion both physical and emotion have taken their toll and it’s abundantly clear in how Adora moves and thinks.

She’s tired, she’s shuffling towards her target that she’s killed three times, she’s shivering from the cold and doesn't really know what else to do. Does she have to decapitate him now? How many Clone’s does Prime have? Is this the last one?

The figure rises to its full height and towers even from the distance, tentacles of biomechanical dissipate from its body and drop to the floor in masses of heaps. The shadow of the ship conceals its true features until it steps out of the darkness and into the light.

It’s fully grown beard and four eye’s lock on at the same time that all too familiar smirk appears with that booming voice made for parades and grand speeches.

This time before it speaks, Prime runs his shiny new claws through his face, sighing and moaning as if he's greeting an old

friend - he doesn't stop there either as the Emperor cracks his neck and shrugs his shoulders as though dying *three* times over was merely an amusing inconvenience to burn time.

It's a complete carbon copy of Prime from sixteen hours and, just a few minutes ago. A flawless body with nary a hint of scratch of damage, it's like Adora never killed it three times in both adult and adolescent.

"I must thank you Adora, that was a …insightful experience, however Prime has grown bored of this charade. Prime has a busy schedule and this enlightening situation must come to an end"

No.

Just fucking stay dead would you?

"Prime is eternal Adora, he cannot be slain by your mere mortal means. He outlasts and he-"

"Shut the fuck up"

Adora tiredly and dryly interrupts with a cough.

And moves to kill Prime, again.

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(Coronation - Jose Pavli)

Adora shambles rather than runs, idly flipping the dagger in her hand back to front instead of priming it to be ready, her movements are small to keep in mind that she needs to conserve energy rather than expend it all and hope to gain it back like *before.*

"Come on Adora, just a bit. Just a little bit, just some more. Come on come on come one" Adora mutters quietly to herself, clutching her dagger arm and shuffles forwards to within super close range of Prime, if she had a staff or even a baton it'd be so much easier but they're gone now.

Adora blinks painfully, breathes in and out with a dry throat that's starting to cry out for water.

"One more time, just one more. The head the head, go for the head"

It's obvious, Prime's different and the mastermind so she'll have to decapitate him or something before the signal gets out, it'll be fine, she can do it just like she did the previous three times, Prime can't stand up to her martial skills even if she's bleeding on the floor and staggering around and in a increasingly painful throbbing situation.
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Is Prime gesturing to her to come hither? It's on his lips and his hand movement and body language, is the man that obsessed with some kind of experience that he'd willingly invite being killed? Whatever. Adora is nearly there, just a few more steps and she can end this and Glimmer and Bow and everyone on Etheria will be safe, just a few more-

Prime strides forwards, makes to punch Adora's head off, she dodges and fients with her dagger, following up by quickly swapping it to the other hand as she quickly shuffles between Prime's arms and raises her arm to stab him in the-

How did Prime move that quick? His claws are crushing her shoulder, upper and lower arm all at once and she needs to-

Grit her teeth and get it *done* .

Something cracks and *snaps,* or a rather a multitude of that happens at once from the right as Adora stabs Prime in the gut with her left, making him howl and yet he still has that annoying satisfied because-

It takes a hot second for the body to send signals to the brain and for the brain to process such signals into information.

Her right arm doesn't function or move when she t *ells it to* , fine so she stares at it and wills it to move but there's ugly claw like marks and five of them staining the skin and it isn't responding at all but the fingers are and-

The pain begins, searing from wrist to shoulder from the skin right down to the nerves, traveling up and down and bouncing repeatedly until it becomes a horrifying single mass of *hurt.*

It still takes *another* second to register.

Prime broke her arm.

All the way from the wrist to the shoulder. When she dares to glance at it to assess damage, it’s simply floppy bones with no resistance when she flexes it and ugly traumatic purple discolored all over bare skin.

And gods, *it fucking hurts.*

“FUCK, FUCK, FUCK. FUCCCCCCCK”

Adora howls, nursing her broken arm and wincing with tears already forming, she hobbles on both legs and hisses at the slightest interruption to the broken nerves in her lower and upper right arm.

“FUCKING SHIT, FUCK, FUCKING SHIT, SHIT FUCK, I-”

This is worse than being electrocuted by Shadow Weaver.

No amount of emotional pain suppressing conditioning can even begin to block the all encompassing shearing pain of broken bones from the tendon to the nerves, it’s like being set on fire and being numb at the same time - in short, it’s fucking agazoning.

“Holy shit, fucking holy shit, fuck shit fuck. Go away, no fuck No no no no no” She needs to stop hyperventilating and calm the fuck down because Prime is still there but her body and mind refuses to listen with the pain and thoughts and bad and it’s fucking terrifying because she *cant stop.* She cant stop her stomach from flipping, or her heart rate that’s pounding fucking faster than her spiralling headache.

And Prime is still *there* , watching with and admiring his handiwork, even mockingly inspecting a pair of sleeping drones as if to gesture his divine right over the shambling figure of a proud bird with a broken wing.

She’s in *range* , energy dimming like a dying lightbulb but all she needs is a few *good* hits. To disarm via weakspots, immobilize the joints and then go for the killing blow.

Tired. *Emotionally too.*

Sapping. *Joints feeling loose and weak.*

Panting. *Sandpaper lungs and dried vocals.*

Stumbling. *Popping knees and blurring vision that clashes with the overpowering lens flare of sheer white.*

"Plan plan go for the wrists an- use the a-arm - need to go for the h-head first and then the chip"

Limbs are stiff and it's like trying to move rusted metal but it doesnt matter, Adora know's that she can do it she just needs to do it *right* , have a plan and follow it through - and dont fuck it up.

God she wishes Catra was here. What would she look like without the cult outfit while in a better place? Could Catra have found peace?

God Prime is so tall that he creates a shadow.

"You can do it, just one more"

It's more of a *wheeze* now.

"Finish line - right there - comeon comeoncomeon"

Adora timely dodges the first fist aimed at knocking her over at the shoulder by side stepping, then ducking under a haymaker designed to crush her skull, she weaves through Prime attempting to clap her body with his arms by using her broken floppy one as a physical and excruciating distraction.

With desperation aiding what little speed she has left, Adora manages to keep one of Prime's arms down by stabbing it in the elbow.

With tired muscles straining in oxygen depleted pain bordering on starvation , Adora still manages to force Prime , more than two heads taller to buckle enough at the knees for his head to be in range, the two lock eyes briefly with Adora's determined and bloodshot blue versus Prime's bright and disturbingly neutral green that betrays nothing on a body that's been stabbed all over and is casually bleeding all over the floor and mixing with Adora's precious red.

The dagger is raised as high as possible on a arm that's screaming for a break, Adora puts all of her weight and strength into that last push that'll go straight into Prime's eye and give her the time needed to cut the head of the snake off for the good and prove that everything she's done will have been worth it, the deaths, the sacrifices and the promises made will justify getting rid of this crazy space menace.

Gritted teeth, blurred vision and with a pained whimper from sheer long term strain - Adora makes her final lunge to end the

threat of Horde Prime forever. The dagger shoots up past Prime's breastbone and in just a second it'll be-

No ,no no no no.

The arm is stopped by a single clawed white hand, fingers as long as knives twisting at the wrist and despite all of Adora's struggle and strength she's forced downwards as Prime's incredible muscle mass makes disarming her a easy for him, he squeezes at the base of Adora's hand -forcing her to scream at her bones being crushed and the dagger is dropped and falls away into clutter.

Adora desperately tries to wiggle out of Prime's lock on her wrist but to no avail, it's like getting clamped by a production line as Prime picks her up by the forearm and up to his level, Adora's feet dangle and she cries out and kicks out in an attempt to get free but despite all of the wounds she inflicted and her attempts to lash out at the Emperors vulnerable points, he simply shrugs them off like a creature from the Whispering Woods would ignore an explosive arrow.

Prime simply *stares* at Adora's struggle to break free of his grasp.

She's screaming inside, desperate to find some way to dull the pain and get free but those four eyes locking on are completely dead inside even with the brightness, it's like looking into a dark tunnel with a brief light at the end - terrifying and foreboding.

“I did say Adora, Prime is eternal”

And with that and a grunt, Prime’s other damaged arm comes around and he casually punches Adora so hard in the chest that several ribs crack, pain flares and Adora cries out and then coughs up blood.

The nerve *ending* pain however this time does not supercharge Adora's efforts and neither does it aid her with much needed concentration. Its incapacitating agony rather than useful energizer - and it puts an end to Adora's final , desperate efforts, quickly even as she attempts to get up.

“Ah I see that Eternian physical resilience once again, Prime is most pleased to acknowledge this and thanks you for your contribution to field testing Prime’s cloning apparatus, he thanks you for this.”

With a shrug, Prime drops Adora to the floor in a clatter that barely has her recovering in time while wheezing blue and coughing and choking red, the Emperor merely smiles.

"However your efforts are commendable effort ultimately futile, Alas Prime does acknowledge with some regret that the talent and prowess will be wasted on the first generation like with before-unreached and untapped potential but with time like his brothers and your future sisters they will be nurtured into a glorious new future under Prime's welcoming light for he is but a simple gardener and you will be the template for a new seedling"

He gestures to someone or something from the side and snaps his fingers with the casualness of ordering food at a restaurant.

"Take her leg, she need not stand in the presence of Prime, kneeling will suffice"

An energy blast similar to Hordak's arm weapon blows out Adora's kneecap and she topples forwards onto her functional left hand and right knee.

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Is this hopeless?

Physically broken and in the heart of enemy territory with no backup,weapon or plan.

Prime in all of his cold and calculating genius is celebrating his victory.

Adora is nursing her broken shoulder, destroyed leg and cracked ribs.

And she's surrounded on all sides.
~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~

Just a minute or two later, the first of many Clones pour in through the doors, marching columns of arm cannon warriors in white and proud chests with identical locksteps in the thousands quickly fill the previously vacant occupant hanger space. At first it's a single fire of identical featureless Clone’s but within minutes, it's a terrifying tide of them.

Despite the sudden influx and mass of warm bodies, it’s still bone chilling for a shivering and collapsed Adora.

Prime is reveling in his victory, with spread arms and a posture reminiscent of the proud statues in Brightmoon celebrating glorious leaders from the past, Prime gestures his mass of followers from all directions to stand in formations and observe his triumph.

When he speaks, it's with a booming voice that fills the hanger space from middle to all corners, his followers chant and rave with apt attention in an alien language that Adora could never hope to understand.

Not that she’d need to decipher it, with the proud body movements and repeating slogans that travel back and forth between hundreds in an audible wave, it’s clear that this is a moment of pure ,satisfied victory for Prime.

Victory over Adora, the celebration of her failure.

From his imaginary pedestal, Prime peers over and then down to Adora with a vicious smile full of green teeth. The closest fifty or so of his Clone's following his gaze to *sneer.* Seeing so many pairs of identical eyes just staring is as chilling as the freezing temperature, right *down* to the bone.

"And then we come back to you, Adora. A perfect specimen for later experiments and an example of the emotional Etherians - or is it Eternians? The similarity of the two can be amusingly confusing but then again only one exists in planet form, for now"

Adora fails to reply, instead brooding over her failure to rip off Prime's head, or kill him for good the first time they met or for her to do something *right* , it's like she's checking off a list of moments she could have *done it.*

Prime opens his eyes to the full, that fetus like third one snapping open and shut while he waves a hand to the right as if to accentuate his future point.

She couldnt have done it if she didnt fuck up.

Prime somehow senses her internal battle, or maybe he's just that good at guessing people because he's going on yet another speech that's painfully accurate in both its truth and how much every sentence is a dagger colder than the atmosphere sent straight into Adora's increasingly fragile sense of self.

The critical part that never stops , the voice that second guesses every decision and highlights mistakes, the one that screams how Adora *should* have brought the whole team with her or *somehow* gotten Catra alive and well and that Adora should have done *everything right* .

Gloating, Prime brings her out of it - to mock her for mistakes made.

"Oh?. Were you laboring under the false pretenses and the childish belief that Prime could simply be dispatched away because of the connection we share in our necks? A valiant but foolish attempt"

Prime leans in, voice going low with a deep rumble in his throat and a sadistic smile lining his words.

"You should have paid attention - after all the mantra my children share to all is not opinion but rather *fact,* Prime knows all, Prime see's all and Prime is *eternal* . Adora"

Satisfied with Adora's horrified expression, born out of both self criticism, agonizing pain and terror at being all alone and unable to do anything about it - Prime continues his monologue, each sentence accompanied by increasingly flashier body language and words that are lapped up by his followers who stay rapt with attention and applaud each spoken speech.

“I must applaud you on your excellent deception, I did truly believe that you wished to join us- your mannerisms and attitude convinced me completely, a job well done but it is a pity that it proved little in the end”

Prime deliberates, thinking and resting his chin on a gloved hand.

“Or maybe?”

He fucking smirks.

“Did you truly wish to join us? Were you almost at the edge and close to embracing Prime when you encountered the glory of the cleansing pool? I must admit I didn't believe you had it in you - well done *She-Ra”*

Prime snarls, grabbing Adora by the shoulder and forcing her to put pressure onto her knees, the Emperor chuckles darkly - reveling in *victory* .

“Did you know? The cleansing pool made it..impossible for Prime to join his brothers even if but temporarily, if you hadn't wasted your time uselessly meandering and caught up to Prime - you may have achieved your goals after all - Adora, isn't that just…”

No. no. no.

Adora bites down to stop herself from letting out a scream of-

"frustrating , no?"

His tone turns mocking and leering. Vicious in its portrayal and striking alongside every exposed vein.

"You had She-Ra - you decimated my forces protecting me, and even before that you had the chance to commit your nuclear weapons to every vulnerable part of my station… *you* had so many *chances* to bring destruction upon Prime's reign and yet-"

Adora whimpers. If she had the capacity to cry right now she would. She imagines taking Glimmer, Bow and She-Ra on a glorious crusade that would have succeeded if Adora hadn't *fucked it up.*

"You *failed* at every turn, Adora"

She screams and struggles but Prime's got her upper body dangling like she's a puppet and he's the master. It's useless, no matter how much she twists to gain leverage or drop her body weight to escape - Prime is simply too strong to overcome like this and everything is starting to hurt again and she's pretty sure that

she’s losing sight in her left eye because there’s a blinding light making her flinch and Prime is showing *no* reaction.

It hurts - *everything* hurts.

“Or did you come here to die, Adora? Without She-Ra your chances of victory were practically insignificant and survival even more so, did you really think you could pull it off and dismantle an Empire thousands old?. Whatever your reasons for this are or were, Prime finds them to be most amusing”

Adora wiggles to no avail, muffles down a shriek as her abrupt movement antagonizes her broken shoulder and cracked ribs.

“This is all *your* fault, you know? Prime stated that Prime is eternal and yet you *continue* to struggle, where have your *actions* led you Adora?”

Prime’s words are punching daggers right into Adora’s soul and forcing her to wince with every one, the sound of his voice? Triumphant, cocky and self assured in his ultimate victory.

“Countless people have been killed ,their cities razed and it all is *your* fault, Etheria *will* be set on fire , and it will all be *your* fault.”

No.

"Your friends cannot reach you because *you* sent them away in disillusionment, again you are the one to *blame* "

He's lying, he has to be!.

"No one is coming for you, your actions and egocentric decisions have led you down this path and there is no tool to dig yourself out of it."

Adora whimpers, struggles against her bleeding body and restraints, she has to fix this, she can still do it she just needs to-

"Was it worth it in the end? When will you realize that you *cannot* solve this problem, when you came here I offered you the chance to join Prime and you refused *three times.* Prime has no need of you any more, would you like to know why?"

Adora would shriek in pain - or disbelief if she had the means to.

"Your DNA has already been uploaded, soon the mantle of Adora the Force Captain will be injected into a new template of Clone and your descendents will lead the army of the faithful across the stars - I did mention that all creatures have a place in the service of Prime and Prime *never* lies"

"I offered you gracious mercy and you spurned my good graces *thrice* , this is your well deserved reckoning no?"

Adora manages just two words in a short grunt of defiance amidst the agony.

"Fuck you"

"Is that still denial I see? You may only need to look to witness the fate of those who defy Prime - lifeless planets stripped of use and laid bare are all that remains of those who reject the light of Prime"

No.

A large panel the size of a tank slides open to show a nearby planet being turned into ruin, a series of firestorms begin to form under the trail of Prime's battleships and it's clear that the planet is being marked for complete destruction.

Just like Etheria.

It's fucking horrifying. And chilling.

"Those who defy Prime are destined to not succeed, they will perish into ash or if they are useful will join his light, your friends will become *my* little sisters and brothers for eternity but you-"

Prime starts crushing Adora's shoulder again and she's biting her tongue to stop herself from yowling.

"Will *never* see them again - this is the price of your short lived treachery, your pathetic defiance in the face of Prime"

Prime's voice turns darker, his booming voice returning and he growls in twisted pleasure as he forces Adora *flat* to the floor , his boot stamped between her shoulder blades and he's *enjoying this* . His victory.

"I am *old* Adora, I was there for the rise and the fall of your people. Did you seriously believe that you could undo thousands of years in a single stroke? Prime has reigned eternal and has crushed his enemies beneath his gaze until only Prime and his followers of true light remain"

Is she crying? Or is everything hurting so badly that she can no longer tell the difference. Adora's oddly reminded of an insect she saw get crushed under a wheel, it desperately tried to crawl away and it's limbs flailed in every direction to no avail.

"You *stupid* girl, so full of bravado and courage that you *thought* , you could simply *believe* in yourself and everything would work out? - I can guarantee you that *it will not.* I will erase you from memory, your name will fade from the lips of those who once knew you and the dirty stain of Adora and She-Ra will pass into oblivion as the white cloth of Prime wipes it away from the annals of history"

The boot still presses her into the ground but it's lighter now, Prime is calling out orders and the hum of machinery begins to fill the ambience, hundreds of boots clatter into position and then formations form.

“This has been amusing but I have work to do, four months is no time at all for Prime but it is a small dent in a very *busy* schedule. Your resistance has been for naught, you are alone and abandoned and all that is left of you and your measly Rebellion will be subjected to a terrible and eternal night forever damned away by Prime’s light.”

The words that do filter out of her mouth is an unintelligible cold shiver rather than the warmth of coherent speech.

“Lastly I do wonder if I should allow myself to experience your last moments, what are you thinking of? Is it a last minute attempt of the mind to justify what you’ve done and hope your legacy will live on?”

Adora chokes. So many memories of both good and bad flow through her mind with their number greater than the tears rolling down her cheeks. Catra laughing, Bow reuniting with his dads, Sea Hawk’s death and Scorpia laying down her arms, they’re all flashbacks that have burned their way into her mind forever and despite the contradiction of so many juxtaposed moments, it’s comforting in a way and dulls the pain both emotional and physical by just a comfortable little.

They’re all people Adora had a laugh with, cried with, protected and had fond memories of, even if some went bad and others left, it’s all something she *tried* to do good with.

“Whatever fancifull illusion you are deluding yourself into , I can attest it is naught but a lie - nothing more than the decay of the mind to make one final attempt to circumvent its inevitable demise”

Prime may be right, Adora is getting kind of delusional and distracted, her vision blurring from pain and the mass light reflection of the ceiling bulbs, shiny floor and everything else that’s just pure white.

Because she’s seein *g something.*

She struggles to make it out, something glowing brighter than the Clones but easier on the eyes, visually it's difficult to make out and it may be just a simple visual hallucination, a trick on the mind like Prime said but a light flickers a Clone shouts something and while the language is impossible to discern, it's a makeshift piece of evidence.

Glimmer and her aunt at Msyactor, the light jokes making harmless fun of Adora being unable to relax - Angella’s amusement at Adora saluting her and paying respects, the guards of Brightmoon welcoming a trainer.

-The more Adora gawks at the figure, the more a strange reinforcement of sunken moment and forgotten times emerge from the edges of reality, they’re painting colors in a blank white world and despite the cracked ribs, broken bones and the last horrifically depressing twelve hours.

Adora manages a half smile of remembering better times.

That glowing figure is standing in the middle of a company, none of the Clone’s pay it attention as it practically slides through.

Prime is speaking again, his voice should be a deafening roar to drown out all others but Adora pays him no attention.

The figure is tall, same height as Prime with gorgeous pants and a spectacular crown, a single flowing ponytail and a graceful figure. When it moves it’s with complete precision and silence like it doesn't exist to anyone but Adora and a ringing alarm in her ear from outside.

“I-” Adora makes to say, her voice cracking with just a single letter but she presses on with bloodshot eyes, scraggly hair and tattered clothes.

“I know- know you” The golden figure cocks its head. “I think”

Adora’s brain works in two different angles, in it’s desperation it scrambles through past conversation on one end while the other brings up nightmares and dreams of the past six months, routing barely remembered images of stressful days and terrified sleep terrors.

And also, Adora. The promises she made, unbowed and unbroken, an emerging emotional fortification against the darkness that lifts the heart with shimmering courage and a slight hope.

I know you have no reason to trust me, Your Majesty. But I've seen for myself the atrocities the Horde has committed against the people of Etheria, and I'm ready to fight to stop them. If you give me the chance, I know I can help the Rebellion turn the tide of the war.

And of course, that same promise but years later.

My name is Adora, I am a Force Captain or well I was. I was a Rebellion Commander and a Princess and now I am not. I made a promise to you years ago that I would never quit, that I would stand by you no matter what and the circumstances would never change-

-I. Glimmer is gone and a new foe is upon us. I am no longer She-Ra but that matters little. I made that promise to all of you and I am not forsaking it, I am renewing it. I will fight and keep going until I die for the peoples I swore to protect, I will never rest and will never stop until Prime and his followers are gone.

I will assume the mantle of general , I will lead and I will plan. I will do this, I will win this war for us or I will die trying.

My name is Adora. (And I wish I had She-Ra with me)

The figure is closer now, the details of it are easier to read, there's individual lines of clothing, markings on its arms and bracers and boots, the sword is different hues of color and it's golden eyes reflect a shade of blue -it's.

It's the same person or entity from the nightmares of sleep's all nighters, it's the figure that haunted Adora's sleepless steps. It was in the Rebellion camp, it was in Mara's ship and it was in the mirror watching during Adora's fictional reality of a victory in the Horde and it *broke* that reality.

Despite the ease of strain the figure bought, Adora is still wary of it.

"Who are you? Come to gloat?" She asks.

The figure shakes its head, sadly.

"Oh I am Adora, Prime is most victorious in your final moments" Prime interjects but he's not part of the conversation, he's just a background character.

"Why were you following me? You've been everywhere and I still don't know anything about you"

"Adora, *look* at me. I am the victor, Prime *has won* and you are talking to *him* "

The figure takes a step back with crossed arms and it's hair is almost fox like in the way it moves, gods it's so beautiful it practically sparks long forgotten hair envy.

"Then why? Why are you here. There's no else, just me and I'- I'm dying or something"

Adora admits, a tear dropping from her eye as her body slowly begins to refuse to move from tiredness, damage of wear,tear and blunt force injury.

The figure crouches down to Adora's height, it's mouth opens to speak with nothing coming out but despite it, Adora understands all the same and its with a spark of horrifying and hopeful realization of who the figure is that reaches into her core and the piece of the puzzle that's eluded her for so long is finally revealed.

The figure's sorrowful animation matches her own, eyes reflecting a lifetime of hurt and hurting, cheeks puffy with red, arms lined with marks of desperation and self harm.

I'm sorry.

Adora turns her head to the waiting armies and machines to the left and right, hundreds if not thousands in a cold hanger flanked by the freezing temperatures of space.

In front is Prime, the conqueror of galaxies and soon to be Etheria. A man renowned for his impeccable charisma and incredible ego is bellowing at the top of his voice for Adora to *listen* and *obey* him - just like the armies of subjects who'll never get to experience anything past the most baseless of emotion.

And besides, Adora has someone standing right by her side. A princess likes being of incredibly warm colors. And truth be told, Adora isn't scared of her anymore.

Adora turns her head, if the being wasn't basically magical then her breath would be on Adora's cheek.

"I know now, and I'm sorry. But I can't do anything right now, I'm trapped here and I sent my friends away, I don't know what to do"

"I, I can't let Prime win, he'll hurt them, all of them and I *have* to do something about it"

Adora tentatively reaches out in front with her non broken arm and even then it's grinding and sore.

"Can you help me?"

The figure nods, brushing a non physical arm the size of a large branch against Adora's and causing the nerves to warm with a pleasant sensation.

The response, despite a mute one, is evident.

Yes.

All of the times Adora stood up for what she believed in slowly began to circle back. The moments where she took a stand for what was right despite the consequences. The lifetime of attempting to right wrongs and doing her best.

The figure knows, and Adora knows who she *is.*

With the aid of a fire in her heart and positive thoughts pushing back the dark,Adora manages to speak in full coherent sentences with the removal of a dry throat, she cries, she chokes and she screws up some words but the truth is coming out and Adora made a promise to never run away from the *truth.*

"I've been in denial of you for so long-that I forgot what I was running from" *Only that I've been running.*

"-so scared of you, I've been afraid and you've been in my nightmares" *I thought you were haunting me, taunting me, hurting me.*

"I hurt you and you hurt me, but my-my friends" *I'm here and they're over there, in a ship - on Etheria. But they're still close to me.*

"-cant let him hurt them and I know I've fucked up" *And I've hurt my friends too.*

"But I can't do this without you. I can't fix this on my own - I *need* you" *I'm not running anymore.*

"-o please,just this once. I need your help to save the people I love" *I can't do this alone and I know that now.*

"Can we do this?" *Together?*

One last time?

She- *Ra.*

“.....”

“.....”

You can’t give up Adora, you’ve never given up on ANYTHING on your life and never on me, or Bow or Catra ”

My friends are on the other side. I am not going anywhere. I'm not leaving anyone behind

I’m ready to fight to stop them. If you give me the chance, I know I can help the Rebellion turn the tide of the war.

“I want that house with you, I want to be rid of the war and I want to never have to command anyone ever again in my life. I wanna sleep in the morning and wake up at ten and laze around for a few hours, I want a ring on my finger and on yours and I never want to see you wear shoes again in your life”

Bow, Glimmer, Mermista, Perfuma and Entrapta, Scorpia and Frosta to name a few, hundreds of guards and soldiers, mothers and children, people Adora and She-Ra met and protected, fought for and spilled their blood over.

Prime is going to hurt them, make them into soulless automatons for his twisted fantasy of a perfect world that’s as dull and painfully boring as a blank canvas.

Adora finally turns to Prime with righteous conviction filling her belly and a fire in her eyes, she stands on a broken leg and breathes in deep with cracked ribs, she points straight and true with a busted arm and speaks clearly with a damaged throat.

"Etheria needs us, and I'm not going to let you hurt anyone else… I-"

The cold becomes a factor no longer, broken bones become one again and the veil of darkness is lifted with conviction and love.

Love for her friends, the will to see them survive and flourish without a sword dangling over their heads, love for Catra who died in Adora's arms and the love and will for self sacrifice.

The conviction and love to do what *is* right.

Adora turns to Horde Prime ,her body begins to shine and for once the Emperor of the galaxy is *stunned in silence.*

"My friends are in danger. I am *not* going anywhere and I *will* stop you"

Or rather, afraid.

A golden sword in her hand the length of an arm manifests into existence and the magical manifestation of She-Ra disappears from Adora's side.

Adora is glowing.

Prime fails to respond. His Clones look on in absolute confused fixation, surrounding light fixtures warp, explode or their light distorts into a multitude of colors, sleeping drones are knocked aside as a cascading spectrum of hues and tints erupts from every nearby crevice of white blankness and *it all* envelopes a single girl with ripped clothing and a broken arm.

And that's not even the most awesomely astounding display of magical power sourced from within combined with the joining of two, it's a string of four vocalizations turned into a shockwave of apex proportions that cause containers to buckle, drone's to malfunction and Clone's to fall back and cover themselves from.

Just five single words woven together into a single sentence of pure power - a rallying cry, a beacon of hope or a means to a long lasting end.

For The Honor, Of Grayskull

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For Glimmer, for her friends, for the people she swore to protect and for Catra.

This She-Ra is two rolled into one, the ancient guardian of Etheria finally free of the First One's magical controlling technology that restricted her into countless iterations and variations, she finally stands taller and infused with the natural of magic rather than artificial.

The form is Adora's like twice before but borne rather of love and a need to protect others. There's no ridiculous combination of a naive girls idea of a princess fused with a milistric background of a Captain's history, rather long white pants and boots with golden wing decals honoring a queen, a golden gorget with a style as a homage to Bow, golden bracers that run the upper arm and a breastplate with a heart attached.

A crown rather than a tiara in the shape of a magicats upbringing, long light blonde hair that speaks to Adora more than the uncomfortable two plus meter costume that was her idea of She-Ra for more than two years.

It's love, duty and a passion to protect. In many ways the fused relationship of a twenty two year old and a magical woman whose life numbers in the thousands.

Adora was a cheerleader before.

She is a Valkyrie now.

She stands tall and upright, nose level with Prime who begins to back off and bark or *rather scream* a litany of orders to the hundreds of Clones present, some charge their arm cannons and others move in with shield and baton while a select few flank their liege and lord in a protective circle.

There's no feeling of intense need to prove herself to the Rebellion and default at all times to a demigod due to low self esteem ; and neither is the all consuming need for vengeance and pain combined into a vessel that wrestled constantly with a unstable alter ego and unknowingly at the time, or a brutal combination of suicidal self destruction that ended premately upon learning of Catra's fate.

Rather this time it's a peaceful serene mind that results in the joining of two, a young and grizzled girl with little more than twenty years of life and most of it war and an ancient guardian who'd seen far better days.

There's no blinding rage clouding the mind, suppression of the self in terrible repression or a constant need to second guess, rather as Adora as She-Ra and She-Ra as Adora ,they look on to the assembled might of Prime's Clone's battalions who form massive

shield walls up front and arm cannon snipers from behind it's- it's more of an odd and rarely felt sense of peacefulness following a long nap from a bath in Mystacor than facing down the greatest enemy Etheria had ever known in one final battle.

Adora and She-Ra prepare themselves, breathe in and out. Closes and open the eyes with a tranquil exhale.

And then promptly blocks a massive red of energy blasted from three arm cannons that is deflected into a nearby block of drones that causes a fiery chain reaction.

She-Ra's sword, or rather a massive greatsword that's stylized and less cumbersome than its controlling predecessor, is wielded in just a single massive hand.

It cleaves the first three advancing Clone's in half with *ease* and then goes for another six and six more back to back without a sweat - and is thrown with the weight and speed of a great javelin that impales another two together before dematerialising and appearing in its users use again.

She-Ra's bracer reflects a pair of laser cannons into the hanger ceiling and blows a chunk of wire and metal out.

A hand the size of a head, backed by an incredible level of muscle sinew picks a bot up and throws it across the room for more than

a hundred meters that ignites a fuel point and its lines that snake around the hanger - scorching vital and vulnerable areas while spreading to more connected points in a steadily out of control inferno with warning sirens blaring louder and louder with the scream of a alarming choir.

The first of many advancing phalanxes are given the same fate with great holes ripped in their lines from thrown objects the size of tanks at first and then by sword, magic and powerful limbs next.

White lights blare a siren red, automatic voices warn in a forgien language as an anchored battleship two kilometers long and away has it’s frontal tethers engulfed in flames and it collapses into the hanger floor, further causing mayhem and destruction - engulfing a whole company in fire and demicating a line of a thousand bots.

She-Ra advances through the flames that cling to her clothing and skin that scorch and leave terrible burn marks, but she is uncaring of such a mortal concern.

Clone’s are ripped in half, awakened bots become scrap metal and the few flying drones are hurled and turned into deadly bombs that tear great holes in formations.

Prime is running.

And She-Ra is close behind.

As good as she could give it, with material prowess of twenty years and a complex mind of experience and ability - Adora could only ever hope to take on two or maybe three Clone’s at once, they held the weight and strength advantage over her and towered at over two meters.

She-Ra simply tosses them around, she takes on ten or twenty at once without breaking a sweat and all the while advancing steadily towards her target.

Prime begins to retreat, slowly at first and then a fast walk towards the exit, more and more Clone’s descend to protect him in a great triangle with weapons drawn.

Arm cannons and lasers fire on her and the numbers are *intensified* , some are deflected off armor, some hit their mark and slow her down, a few actually hurt.

She-Ra dodges the majority of them though, according to guards and former Horde Soldiers ; seeing a being so tall and powerful and broader than any person could ever be, equipped with arms and armor of a demigod. To see her move in action with fluidity of grace that exists on a scale and strength beyond anything mortal.

It’s both terrifying and awe inspiring.

And that was Adora learning, Adora's uncomfortableness in a princess get up that never fit.

This She-Ra no longer suffers from restraints.

Fifty Clone's are chopped apart, have their limbs punched off or are crumpled when thrown into walls or each other.

Then the energy blasts come, a series of focused and directed magical attacks that originated from the point of the sword and come in slashing strikes that leave huge scorch marks in the perfect marble white floor and disrupt assembling formations of Clone's that attempt to guard their Emperor from the upcoming threat.

Prime screams something and the massive hanger doors that protect the inside from space begin to open, a great rush of air and atmosphere begin to be sucked out into the void with thousands of terrified Clone's and advanced space age equipment not securely fastened are tossed out in the freezing and radiation baked vastness of space.

They scream, they flail and cry out for salvation and reassurance to no avail and within a few seconds the voices silence and the figures simply cease to exist.

They called out for the one whose casual and callous disregard for their own lives and an inflated egotistical and narcissistic opinion

of his own was quite frankly *disgusting* to experience.

Prime has just safiriced an entire hanger of followers to save himself from Adora without care and hesitation. He puts a sealed blast door between him and his hunter.

It doesn't work, She-Ra is simply unfazed by the chill and push of the void and continues walking, albeit slower towards the door and cuts it open with her sword. Another one seals shut behind and she begins the chase, great sprinting footfalls later that cover ground at speeds in excess of a sprinters wildest dreams-

-defending Clone's that hurriedly pour out of nearby rooms are basically mere paperweights to the might of She-Ra, some open fire with their laser cannons with questionable accuracy, eithers its out of terror of She-Ra or that thier god is fleeing.

Prime continues to run, barking out orders and screaming for his guards to attend him. One's like the two Adora fought appear and while they give significantly better resistance than the rest with some even lasting a few seconds, they are ultimately powerless when confronted with the awesome and unyielding power of She-Ra.

Some Clone's even try to defend Prime by slowing She-Ra down, using their bodies and very lives to buy time for Prime who casually throws them into battle. They matter little, Adora kicks a Clone so hard into a wall it ceases to exist.

More blast doors, more running, more of Prime desperately putting the lives of his flock between him and She-Ra and none of it matters.

Doors are wrenched open with the sword with the same manner as a can opener, panels are punched through and hundreds have died just for the sake of one man who had to flee.

With Prime in sight - bolting down a large corridor with a single dead Clone with a broken stun baton at its feet, Adora and She-Ra transform their sword into a whip and three seconds later, Horde Prime is caught by the ankles and comes to a sudden and ungracefully crashing halt. No matter how much he tries to crawl away using his incredible strength - She-Ra is stronger. And scoops the Emperor of the galaxy up in the same manner one would gather fish.

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Prime is, to say the least - completely furious.

He screams, he rages, he calls out for invisible guards to attend him. He trashes around angrily and flails with wild limbs and while they bruise and hurt, it’s all relative and more like paper cuts to
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She-Ra who drags the Emperor down a corridor by the collar of his clothing.

An hour ago or even a day ago - Adora would have had significantly different thoughts and feelings on this, she'd have gutted Prime by the throat and thrown his body down a shaft or stuck his corpse in space somehow. Now she's oddly content and with a sort of blankness surrounding her emotional state.

She could respond to Prime's increasingly agitated cries, how he'll bring runiation to his enemies and crush the universe of its dissenters and darkness, how Etheria will be turned into nothing more than a weapon with the surface cracked open and the people converted into this flock.

Before that'll have provoked a response, one of rage or self doubting but with She-Ra's strange level headedness providing a blanket of support and a overwhelming positive sense of clarity bringing peace and stability, Adora is content with listening to her own footfalls and the distant hum of machinery rather than the deluded rants of a madman.

And not before too long, they come to a fork in the road that Adora has come across before.

Her hesitation to act provokes a pleading response full of false lies and perverted promises.

“Child, I command you to release Prime from your custody and all will be forgiven. I-Prime will guarantee your safety amongst my flock and your friends will remain unharmed, I ask you now Adora to-”

Sometime ago Adora would have listened with horror and let those words dictate her sense of self, but she's different now in more ways than one. The naked vanity is disgusting, the tried words of honey repulsing and Prime’s fucked up operation utterly unreasonable.

And so she chooses the other fork, down by a road she knows is *right* .

Very soon, they come to a familiar place. One lined with an uncountable number of biomechanical tubes in every corner and under every floor, so many platforms of worship it’s beyond reckoning and a single great altar in the center with a pool before it. It’s a memory laid bare of both Adora’s experience of nearly falling to Prime’s seduction and knowledge that Catra was twisted into something evil.

A tiny pang of anger flares up that calls for Prime to be gutted with her sword right now and just execute him on the spot but Adora knows better *now.*

Instead she drags along the three meter tall and 300 kilogram self proclaimed Emperor of the galaxy along the floor, a wriggling and writhing mass of a man degraded to a prisoner screaming for help

that'll never come. It's a satisfying conclusion and an end for all three of them.

"You'll die here Adora, you will never leave this station. Prime's followers will find you and end you and even if you succeed you'll be trapped forever and never be able to see your friends again"

Prime is trying a different route now, trying to distract Adora as she looks around for… *something.*

"Such needless waste, it did not have to be like this Adora. All you need to do is to simply co operate and you will find yourself on Etheria with Glimmer and Bow - with happiness and joy at your fingertips and none the wiser of the events that has happened, Prime is a reasonable and caring man and he can guarantee this, why not let *me* go and we can simply *forget* about the past, no?"

As.

Adora swallows.

"It's-"

She thinks of Glimmer and Bow with sleepovers and dinners in mind, their beautiful smiles and loving care that brought Adora from the brink of self destruction following her initial disaster as She-Ra.

She blinks, swallows again and flexes her shoulders, dropping Prime to the floor with a thud.

He makes eye contact and gives a knowing *crooked* smile.

"I knew you would be reasonable Adora, Prime knows and Prime sees all , he knew you would come to your senses and he will-"

She-Ra drops her sword, letting it fall with a reverating clutter that echoes all around the massive and empty chamber.

She walks over to Prime, places a hand on his back and gives herself one final deep breath.

"It's time for you to go"

Prime acknowledges and thanks her, making to get up and return to greet his followers - safe and secure in the knowledge that he won again and that Prime does indeed *always* win.

Until he finds he can walk further no more, because She-Ra's massive hand on his shoulder is pulling him back. He turns round with a puzzled face full of confusion and furrowed eyebrows.

“Adora, you sai-”

“I know, it’s time for *you* to go”

“Prime i-ss going, he accepts your mercy and will reimburse you in kind, Prime will-”

She-Ra grabs Prime by the collar and hauls him past his feet, she neither snarls nor scowls but her voice is dark and low with its intensity.

“I said, it’s time for you to *go* ”

Prime takes a second.

“What do you mean? Is this a trick?”

And the color drains from his face.

“No, you said it yourself, remember? I should have done it here with no hesitation instead of chasing you around, well we’re right back where we started”

The Emperor rushes on all fours in a bid to get away.

“No, no no no. Prime does not- he knows that this is a simple misunderstanding that Ador- you. Prime cannot be slain your

methods, he knows all and sees all that this is but a temporary measure and he will be back to rebuild and come from the ashes and he will-”

Adora turns around with Prime securely in her grasp towards the platform, every step is seemingly magnified with Prime’s whimper of terror and yet a unwillingness to see it clear for how it really is, they pass the circle where Prime orchestrated a sermon to thousands, past the body of a Clone that committed sucide and very soon the three of them are before the great green pool of cleansing.

“There will be no comfort for you as Prime swears it now. Your miserable planet will be consumed in flame and your friends will cry for his divine mercy. You have chosen darkness and your end will come as Prime-”

Prime struggles in Adora’s grasp, he makes threats and claims of godhood. It’s pathetic really and kind of sad to witness.

She grabs his face with her free hand and looks deep into his eyes, closing her own and concentrating. Adora finds a bright yellow light engulfing them. She see’s Prime’s soul laid bare and it's a crooked and twisted thing, kept alive by scientific machinations well past any natural expiration date.

And Prime only reveals his true self upon inspection, a truly deranged and miserable wreck of a person that desperately clings to eternal life in a hollow and voidless “paradise”. It’s not living ,it’s just existing without any reason to -and with it finally laid bare, Prime explodes in defensive anger.

“EVERY SLIGHT YOU HAVE MADE, EVERY INJUSTICE AND CHOICE HAS ONLY DEEPEND YOUR SINS, YOUR PRIDE HAS LED YOU TO THIS AND YOU WILL SUFFER FOR IT, PRIME WILL RISE FROM THE ASHES AND HE WILL MAKE YOU BLEED AND PAY FOR IN WAYS YOU WILL NEVER CONTEMPLATE”

Adora ignores the feeble cries of a doomed man and looks down below to the bubbling alien mass of vile liquid just a step in front.

“SO IT HAS BEEN AND SO IT SHALL BE, PRIME GUARANTEES IT AND WHAT HE SPEAKS OF SHALL ALWAYS COME TO FRUITION”.

She takes a half step forwards and raises Prime infront to dangle over the pool that he sent so many to turn into unnatural forms of themselves, become mindless drones or to die in. All for one man's twisted aspirations of borrowed immortality

“YOU SHALL CRY, ALL OF YOU SHALL CRY FOR PRIME’S MERCY, SO IT HAS BEEN AND SO IT SHALL ALWAYS BE”

Adora drops Horde Prime into the pool , fetches her sword and waits for thirty seconds - satisfied that her magical senses have confirmed that Prime was indeed speaking the truth, she waits for his wriggling,clawing mass to float up grasp for safety with suffocating breaths. He tries to grasp on to any near handles with slippering claws and disgusting green fluid runs out of his mouth - the formerly gigantic figure that prides itself as being quite literally larger in life is choking on its own design, it’s four eyes opening

and shutting randomly rather than in sync and when Prime fails to swipes at She-Ra leg for leverage he descend into a desperate water filled rant.

Adora as She-Ra leans over with a hand on her knees and the other reaching behind for something, with a spectrum of calm not seen before in the last ten hours of misery and pain -she observes the last few moments of Prime with a blank face and a steady heart.

"You-you-you. You DARE to commit such a mockery to m-me to Prime. He will bring upon you a fiery lance of light to extinguish the dark that you reside in, Prime is ETERNAL and BEYOND your foolish means of-"

and without hesitation runs her sword through the Emperor's head.

A few seconds later and the distorted soul of Prime begins to leave his body, a black mass of corruption that's been the reason why Prime always escaped death with Adora, but now with her magically enchanted sight - the curtain has been pulled back and the master manipulator's tricks revealed.

You miscalculated.

The soul sort of screams, more of a tiny whine than anything when it gets popped like a balloon. The vacant body of Prime simply floats around in the cleansing pool, bobbing up and down like a cork and eventually a sort of strange but welcome silence falls upon the chamber where just two hours ago.

A ceremony of thousands took place.

And now just one person stands.

Adora and She-Ra.

~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~

Were you there when I tried to heal Catra?

Yes.

Did it work?

I am unsure, it was a botched healing.
~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~

That's it, he's gone. Should I be feeling victory or melancholy?

It's an odd kind of quiet, the same type when exploring old ruins with the knowledge that the masses used to congregate and live there ,but with the passing of time and people, nothing sentient remains and whatever used to call the temple room of Horde Prime - no longer do.

Adora is here.

She-Ra is just a bit over there.

Prime's corpse floats around.

Catra is dead.

Bow and Glimmer are on their way home.

Etheria is out of reach.

Adora's injuries are still present, ribs cracked and bones broken.

And it's cold too, like icy water on the skin.

The transition from She-Ra back to Adora was not a clean nor a comfortable one, coming back from a demigod that can shrug off laser cannons to then having Adora's body shrunken and limbs damaged again, rather than previously which was a complete heal and feeling refreshed -it's basically the opposite.

Adora sits on a pew, nursing her critically damaged body while She-Ra sits on the other side, she's not real in the physical sense since Adora can (and has) brushed her hands through like it's a hologram but it's more of a magical manifestation of understandably awkward silence for the past ten minutes - given the past events.

"Fuck -f-got stabbed"

Wincing in pain as she forgets to not flex her dominant arm again or more her torso, Adora does pop the *question.*

With her usual foot in mouth open and a hoarse throat.

"So, She-Ra right? I-I didn't know that you'd come back, was it you in the ship and during my dreams"

She-Ra sort of fidgets ,not making eye contact and staring straight ahead, her previously flowing cape and hair now sort of crumpled against her body and those muscle lines seem to be damaged. It's extremely disorienting to witness the proud Valkyrie like this.

"I. Yes, it was me" A pause, an awkward glance. "I was in your dreams, trying to reach you but it was difficult to do so"

"Why?"

“You broke the sword, our connection was likewise broken. I had to find my way back to an unwilling host- or well, you”

“-sorry,thought She-Ra was gone and it was just fragments left or something”

With a hiss of pain after she breathes too much antagonizing her busted ribs, Adora breaks off her own eye contact.

I tried calling for you -so many times, Prime’s invasion and wi”

Looking down at the ground makes it easier to say.

“With Catra and trying to heal her, I tried *so* hard! Why?”

She-Ra stiffens, letting her magical sword fall to the ground with no sound. She sighs and rolls her tongue around before speaking.

“Do you really wish to know Adora?”

The reply is without hesitation.

“Yes”

She-Ra nods.

"Our…connection was unreliable and not strong enough, She-Ra requires a certain emotion to function without the sword and as a guardian of Etheria she or well- *I* can only be activated with strong emotions rather than a simple keyboard, the sword is-was our control mechanism and a grounding, without that it is more… difficult to summon Sh-me. As an analogy you cannot cross through a door that is shut, whether or not it means to be"

Adora begins to understand the true enormity of what she did.

"The sword of protection? I guess that *that one* aint it?"

"Yes, you destroyed it and it will never function again"

"What does that mean? Can you summon a new host for She-Ra? Am I the last one? Is it just us now or is something else the matter?" Adora blurts out the questions that've been lingering in the back of her mind ,some for *years* and others for mere days.

Why was I chosen?

And for the first time, She-Ra turns to look over her shoulder at Adora and make full contact, she seems to be smaller and less intimidating than last time but still a demigod. In a way she's just a bigger and golden version of Adora - the awkwardness persists with the occasional stutter and a stiff back. The proud Valkyrie is bent and bowed and yet carries herself effortlessly, an incredible contradiction and one that reminds Adora of herself.

Changing the conversation when a lull appears, Adora pivots to another topic that's bugging her.

“Are you okay? You don't look so good, I thought She-Ra regenerated or something?”

The reply is She-Ra turning round fully, showcasing and exposing the extensive wound her body has taken, rather than before where a transformation would instantly heal the both of them, She-Ra has cuts and bruises from melee and blackened skin from arm cannons.

“I am “okay” but I feel slightly lethargic and my limbs are..awkward to move. It is possible that our broken connection severed She-Ra’s ability to regenerate and forced wounds received from before,during and after transformation to become permanent. However I am more than capable of performing my duties…probably painfully”

Adora wishes to reach over to reassure the goddess with an empathic touch on the shoulder before realizing that She-Ra really exists only in her mind and her right arm is broken.

"Reckon he's truly gone then, Prime?"

Stabbing through the floating Emperor's corpse with her sword, She-Ra seems to ponder.

"To be truthful I do not know. It’s a question I cannot be sure of a certain answer, an eternity of arrogant complacency bought about his downfall and I do believe he was not obsfafiating about being trapped here, however that does not mean a backup has or has not been activated and that potential threat leaves Etheria still in danger"

She turns to Adora.

"You ran from me, although you did not know if it was me. I found it to be painful and I tried to reach you. I am truly sorry for the loss of your love and if I could have aided, I would. Instead I lurked at the edges of my wielders state, seemingly bound only to observe rather than act”

“I didn't ask to become She-Ra though”

“I know,. A woman is chosen and she becomes She-Ra with no debate or discourse, the mantle of which is neither an easy one or one that can be ignored - it just is”

She-Ra kneels with a silent grunt as her knee wobbles and her fingers shake briefly.

“I do not receive the luxury of choice either, I have been with twenty nine She-Ra’s with some taking to the role with grace, others exploiting it for their own gain and some rejecting it. You

are the first in a thousand years and you have resisted it the most, I both can and cannot sympathize with you”

The demigoddess studies the architecture of Prime’s inner temple while she speaks with a childlike fascination, she’s probably so used to Etheria’s warm natural and diverse state that the cold artificial sameness of space age alloys is not only a terrifyingly new thing but a stark contrast to everything she’s experienced.

Adora can definitely relate to that.

“But without the sword, the item that functions as a portable runestone and an empowerment tool, it is no longer possible for a new She-Ra to come into being, for the record I am not from Eternia but their methods changed how She-Ra is chosen. Etheria cannot claim a new wearer and this is it. We do not have the time nor the means to create a new line of succession and so I suppose this is it”

“We, Adora - are the last She-Ra. With the sword broken I will not return to greet the next wielder of the sword as there will be none, death is a eventual fate that befell every She-Ra before you but I have not experienced it - it will be my first and last time and not something I wish to go through but”

She-Ra pauses

The words that come through are strained, even a goddess can find it difficult to speak level and plain.

“I…. accept it, just as you accepted your fate then I too shall follow”

If Adora was capable of shedding a tear at this point, she would. Rather she listens as She-Ra continues to talk, speaking her mind and relaying information from the past and present in a unique viewpoint that only a thousands of years old immaterial being could.

"If there is a thing I have learnt however from thousands of years and dozens of She-Ra's it's that everything has to come to end, we may see the true permanent death of a man who brought mass ruin to the Eternian Empire and was yet laid low partly by his own arrogance- we too shall follow in death ,perhaps not today but soon"

"Was that supposed to sound positive?"

"No, but this is. Mara died to prevent the destruction of the universe and to save her friends, and so many She-Ra's sacrificed themselves for similarly heroic endeavors , whether or not they wished to embrace eternity with no regrets - they simply did what they believed was *right.* What matters is not a long life but the quality of it, love - happy memories and time spent with those you care for are far more fulfilling than a millennium of bleak stagnation"

"I guess so, I think of sleepovers and clubs, eating good food and brief adventures when it comes to that, I'm not sure if it outweighs the bad I've done in life but I'd rather have this than die at the age of eighty with regrets"

She-Ra gives a grim smile.

“I too have many similarities, could I have warned and aided Mara? Should I have influenced the Elemental Princesses to make less drastic decisions to save themselves? I do not know and they are memories that…hurt”

“I know all too well how that feels, but what happened - happened and being nostalgic….well it didn't end up too good” Adora shudders, remembering the rage influenced persona of Force Captain that manipulated and abused, the Rebellion Commander that relied too much on other’s power and let her insecurities eat her up from the inside.

“Exactly, I cannot express the sorrow I feel towards the life you’ve led but I can guarantee that we will not die alone. I do not believe I shall outlive you and doing so would be wrong of me”

“I-....thank you, Catra wouldn't have wanted me to go out by myself and I miss her, but I’d rather have done this than let her be a slave for the rest of her life”

“I agree, however we must end this threat to the planet and people we protect. I am ready to seek out and destroy this station ,hopefully it will put a end to Horde Prime and if not -shall cripple him for years and perhaps decades”

Adora makes to stand up, her broken leg wobbles and she barely manages to catch herself with a pained whimper and hissing through her teeth.

“I’m not sure if I’ll be much help, I can’t walk but I’ll try”

She-Ra silently glides over to Adora’s side, a gigantic bruised hand making its way to rest quietly on Adora’s shoulder.

“No need to, despite my own wounds I can make it under our own strength, when you are ready to join together I shall agree”

With flashes of the few good times, images of the Princess friend group eating ice cream and all together for a camera’s shot with Seahawk’s pirate pose and Spinerlla kissing her wife or even a stock photo of her promotion to leading a Battalion - a rarely smiling Catra and her tail curled around Adora’s hip with Rogelio, Lonnie and especially Kyle together in the foreground.

Memories of a past long intertwined with the dead - people that haunted Adora for years during sleep. Some died for her, for those they loved.

And Adora isn't going to let *their* sacrifices be in vain.

“I’ll do it if it means that , *that monster* can’t hurt my friends. They deserve to be *happy* ”

“I believe you deserve to be happy too Adora, we all do”

“It’s too late now and I made my choice- I have regrets but I’d probably repeat them, maybe a different me would have done things different but it’s too late to worry about the past”

And make others' futures a brighter place.

Wheezing with pain in her ribs and stifling an urge to throw up stomach acid and water, Adora sandpaper coughs specks of blood before keeling over with a terrible dry heave followed by a sad moan and a full body shiver.

"I-when I was nearing the end, when Prime had his boot at my throat - I thought of Catra, I thought of her when she clung to me when we were kids and teenagers, how she stuck by my side in the Horde and how I believed our attachment would last forever"

With a trembling lip sent into quivers and showing complete vulnerability , Adora continues a confession through tears.

"And I hurt her *so much* , I didn't realize at first but seeing her grow in front of my eyes forced me to realize how badly I missed and wanted and...loved her"

With a deep sigh, fingers unfurling from fist and a wistful look, she curls in on herself

. "I wanted a place for the two of us to call our own, away from all of this. But now that dream is as dead as she is and I fucking ache for her"

Catra cutting her hair and wearing a more stylized version of her outfit to remove all of Prime's influence, she'd call Adora's name and after a brief second of looking into each other's eyes, one of them would press their foreheads together.

With a comforting arm made of metamorphosis slung around Adora's shoulders, She-Ra….well she tries her best.

"I am truly, deeply sorry for your loss. At the very least she died in the arms of someone who loved her unconditionally"

Adora wipes away a tear that was never shed.

"I loved- love her very much and - it took me twenty to figure it out"

"-I, thank you"

She distracts herself with Prime's floating corpse , thinks for a second and then sighs.

"Do you think we should, I don't know- jump into the reactor or something?"

"Probably, the sword which holds a fraction of She-Ra destroyed the Crystal Castle which was designed to withstand powerful weaponry, I imagine a detonation of She-Ra's power would be a power magnified"

"You know that means the end of us, right?"

"I do, but if it is the only way, then shall be so"

“I…….yeah, I expected to not survive this anyway, didn't think I’d go out quite like this but nobody ever does I guess”

“One moment though, I know it may sound strange but you may wish to compose your final thoughts, even if I shall be the only one reading it. Some members of Squadron Grayskull believe it calmed the mind and set it ready for a last adventure”

“I do, I can’t guarantee they’ll be a exciting read - there’s a- a lot to go through”

No one’s ever is.

Adora looks into She-Ra, She-Ra looks into Adora. The demigod slowly fades out from her ethereal form and wraps around Adora’s figure, the sword on the floor disappears and a magic tingling threads through her fingers.

Wounds are not healed, bruises remain and a headache persists but it is as it *shall be.* Adora and She-Ra have a job to do and if that involves the end of the line for them, if it saves Glimmer and Bow and ensures Catra did not die in vain - *then so be it.*

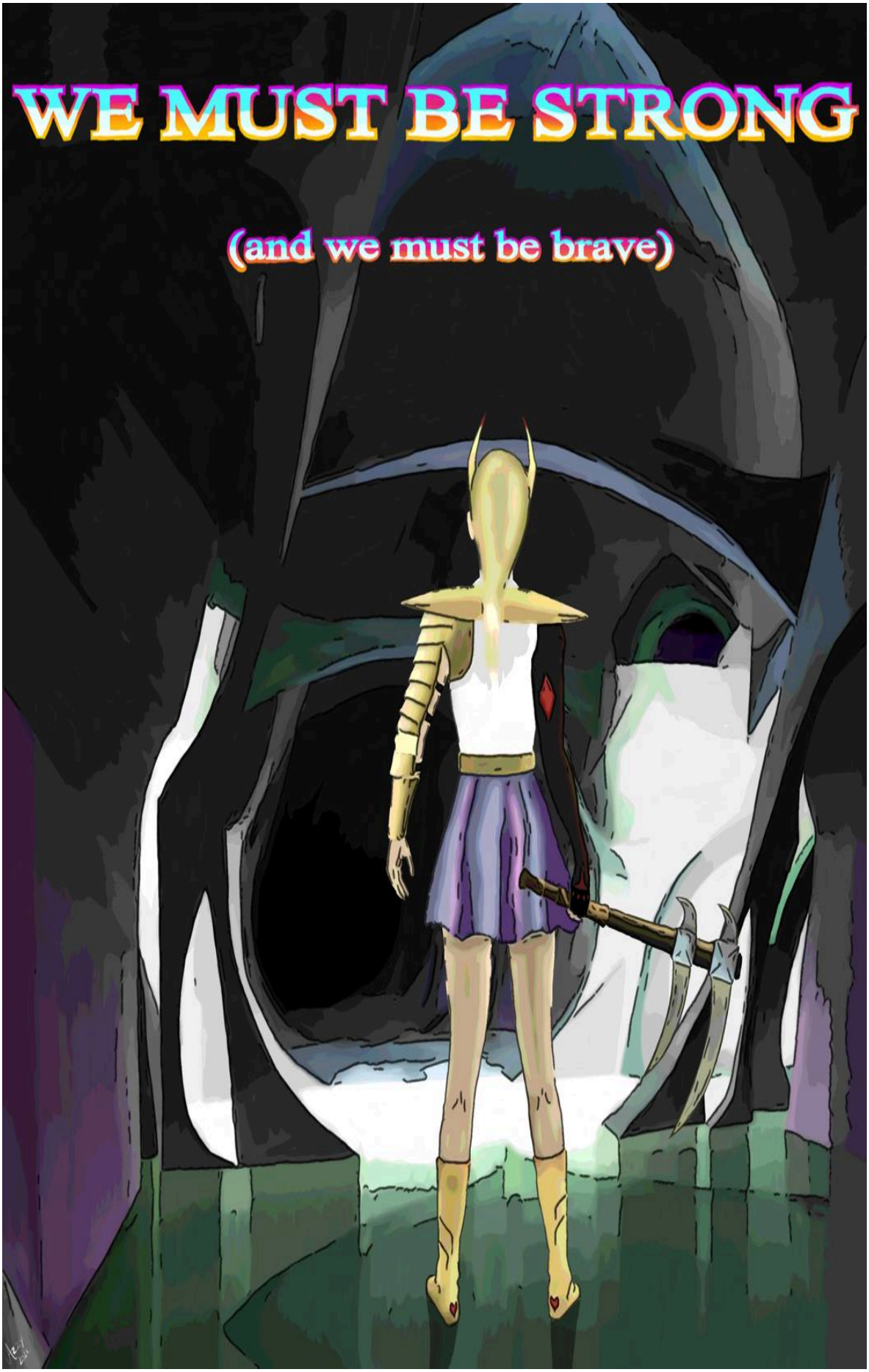
On a leg that is broken but still holds up, an arm that struggles to carry a longsword and fractured ribs that permit only the lightest of breaths. Adora once again stands out in the open, her hair mangled and messy, clothes ripped and torn but yet a fire still persists in her eyes and blazes in her heart.

She looks up to the invisible heavens, past the dead bodies that litter her surroundings and without hesitation, anger or fear - speaks the five words that defined mythology and persisted throughout the ages.

“For The Honor Of Grayskull”

This time, not an awesome deafening shout that rips hinges off and tears the fabric of the environment.

But a whisper.


WE MUST BE STRONG
(and we must be brave)

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If you think this was a fun one, I'm writing the next chapter right now and it's bringing me close to an emotional breakdown.

Follow me on twitter for cosplays, writing and random shit. KaffeeKupp

Artwork by Azzy
~~~~~

Eight

Ask me something stupid like where do I think I'd be in six years time?

I'd tell you I'd finally have a complete schedule and a way to avoid sleep.

Ask me under a truth spell and I'd tell you I'd like to try not being a soldier or a martyr for a cause or even a weapon.

Maybe I'd like to be late to a Princess's First Ball.

Of course that's crazy, cuz it'll never happen.

I'm too busy.

Confidential Psychological Report.

Adora (last name not given or known)

Service record:

-Force Cadet Adora: Sixteen Years

-Force Captain-Candidate Adora:Two Years

-Force Captain Adora:Two Years

-Force Commander Crimson Waste: One Day?

-Ex Horde Soldier:Six Hours

-Bright Moon Soldier Adora :Six Hours

-She-Ra Princess Of Power: Two Years

-Bright Moon Army First Lieutenant Adora: Two Years

-Bright Moon Army Commander Adora: Six Months

-General Of The Rebellion Adora: Three Months

For Viewing Only..

A Summary.

Adora was first referred to me by her friends around a year ago after the coronation of Queen Glimmer. Adora’s friends were concerned about her increasingly heavy work/life schedule and her apparent inability to find self-treatment. Adora appears to experience severe difficulties maintaining a functioning, healthy life outside of work, her role as one of the Rebellion's Commanders and a strategist, as well as her duties as She-Ra, Princess of Power. Aside from that, Adora has also shown significant signs of stress, post traumatic stress disorder, anxiety, an incredible willingness to throw herself into dangerous situations with little regard for her own well being, and shows a clear number of unhealthy behaviors.

From what I can gather, Adora is around twenty two years old at the time of writing this report. She was originally a First One (an Eternian),somehow brought to Etheria as a orphan, and brought up as Shadow Weaver's ward together with Catra. There, she stayed in the Horde for twenty years working her way up from a cadet, to a soldier, and then to a Force Captain. At the age of eighteen, she was deployed to the Crimson Waste in order to pacify several tribes and raider gangs. At the age of twenty, she was due to be promoted to the top ranks of the Horde as a"Force Commander" but on the day of the promotion, she joined the Rebellion. Having found the Sword of Protection she was persuaded to come over to our side by Bow and Crown Princess Glimmer.

At this time, however, and according to Princess Scorpia (whom I've been speaking to), Adora as a Force Captain at the age of twenty post-Crimson Waste and Adora as a Force Cadet pre-Crimson Waste are two very different people. From what I can gather, Adora was still anxiety-prone and had several stressors. Though, she was significantly more emotionally and mentally stable. While she was still very neurodivergent from a typical teenager, she lacked the traumatic emotional outlook, prone to panic attacks and trouble controlling herself. Basically speaking, if there was a single point that Adora truly changed into the person she is today, the transition from Cadet to Captain and a two-year-long deployment altered her mindset and psychology forever. Adora very much emposses a more unstable and closed-off mentality in her life now, a far cry from what the Cadet that she used to be.

This is around the time that signs of the previously-mentioned stressors should have been noticed by Adora's friends and myself. Adora was inducted into the role as Princess of Power and immediately thrown into action, often being heralded as a savior by the population. She apparently often encountered severe

performance anxiety and stress when she felt like she was unable to meet the role.

Likewise, the Horde brings its youths up as child soldiers and tends to partake heavily in hazing rituals, abuse, and disciplinary actions. Since Adora was in the care of Shadow Weaver (a noted advocate of abusive practises for more than thirty years), she was likely pushed hard as a child all the way until she joined the Rebellion. I believe she was instilled with a mixture of a Martyr, Golden Child, and Hero complex in the likeliness of Shadow Weaver and the Horde's twisted philosophy.

Adora also practices an extremely disjointed view of herself. I do believe that Adora's sense of self, which is the perception of the collection of characteristics that define the self, was removed by Shadow Weaver. Adora compares her value with how others view how valuable she is, hence a reliance on external validation in the absence of self validation. She also requires praise and support from others (even the barest hint of it) to make herself feel worthy of love and give her a sense of self-identity.

It is also important to mention that Adora failed (in her view) to convince her life-long friend, Catra, to join the Rebellion. While she has not mentioned it, it is quite easy to determine that Adora has significant emotional investment in Catra. Thetwo fought on opposing sides for around two years. Evenas She-Ra,Adora took great pains to never physically injure Catra. According to people close to her, she was often found in bathrooms and isolated areas in a state of distress after every time the two of them fought. Adora very much views Catra as a significant person and it is clear that the two spent the majority of their developing years together and relied on the other greatly for support.

It is with deep regret that I let my physical infatuation with Adora get the best of me. I failed to recognise the signs of a girl that was clearly struggling. It is only with our recent therapy sessions that I have begun to realize the full extent of Adora’s severe and critical emotional and mental instability.

Adora herself has been dismissive of our sessions, often focused on other tasks,ignoring me, or viewing therapy with outright hostility. This, in of itself,is a defense mechanism from her years under Shadow Weaver. Adora has always been a closed-off person and this is no different.

Adora’s coping mechanisms have been to bury herself in her work to the point of exhaustion and then take stimulants to keep going. From the moment Bow and Glimmer found her my first meeting her within my kingdom, or even as far back in the Horde has been to bury herself in work to the point of exhaustion and then take stimulants and keep going,t is very much the view of people around her that Adora lacks the ability or the willingness to stop herself from descending into a self-destructive cycle. If working herself to collapse doesn't solve the issue, then Adora will descend into a panicked state, run off to the nearest closed place she can find, and list off every problem in her head hysterically.

However, reading between the lines, asking questions and through general observation, I have come to the very disturbing and sad conclusion that Adora is very much living in a state of perpetual and constant stress. She has a habit of twitching when asked questions regarding Catra and often buries herself in work,

fighting, or planning to avoid confrontation with her ongoing mental and emotional problems.

Since the unfortunate departure of Queen Glimmer, the near decapitation of the Rebellion's command structure, and assuming the role of the overall leader in defacto charge of an *entire planet* , Adora has had very little sleep and rest/recuperation. It is common to find her awake at all hoursbriefing troops, conducting inspections and, more often than not, leading from the front and fighting directly. Adora often refuses to rest and has to be directly paraylzed or given medical injections to aid her to sleep. Evenwhile forced off combat duties by her friends, Adora can be found in her tent displaying vocal acts of self negative behaviour, engaging with prostitutes, or pulling all nighters and issuing orders anyway. Adora also leans towards tendencies and acts that She-Ra performed, viewing it as her duty to keep up to the same level. While observing and gathering information from on the field, I can only say, sadly, that it is a prime example of selfdestructive behavior.

Adora also often fails to eat, leading to clear signs of malnutrition. She has deep lines of stress and more often than not has a permanently clenched jaw, shadows under the eyes, and is physically unable to keep still. She is prone to bouts of irritation, self-harm and self-disparagement, none of which indicate an even remotely stable frame of mind. I do honestly believe that Adora views herself with a great deal of self-loathing.

While I would recommend an immediate cessation of combat duties and a trip to Mystacor with therapists skilled in magic who are far better than me.

It is with a great deal of worry that I must admit that the Rebellion needs Adora more than ever, despite her parting ways with She-Ra (or something along those lines) and no longer being the Princess of Power. Recent developments have led to Adora becoming the only qualified field commander able to command the Rebellion on a planet-wide scale. It is with distress and sadness that Adora has been consigned to the self-repeating cycle in which she is the only one able to perform her job. This feeds directly into her Hero Complex which in of itself is already rapidly developing into a negative mental state of mind that then feeds into Adora's already existing stress.

As a summary and being called to combat myself, I regret being unable to properly give the full state of poor Adora's deteriorating mental, emotional, and physical health. For the full justice she deserves and the treatment she needs to work to become a happy and functional person, this is the worst possible set of circumstances for her to be in. I shudder at the thought of how she must view herself.

As unprofessional as this may be, I diagnose Adora (no surname given) with post-traumatic stress disorder, major depression, panic disorder, agoraphobia, and obsessive-compulsive disorder. There may possibly be more.

I will always have questions. What truly happened to make Adora like this? What is her true relationship with Catra and the rest of us? Most importantly, who would she be if she was never sent to the Crimson Waste? Would she be more accepting of She-Ra, of us, of herself? We'll never know the answer and I can only hope we can find a way to help Adora find her way to a more peaceful life when she comes back.

I fully recommend Adora be taken off the frontline and into immediate care with no less than a full team of Mystacor therapy specialists and placed away from her stressors as much as possible. It is the least we can do for her and it is something she deserves. As much as I have encountered a jaded, angry and negative person, I do believe that there is a very hurt and desperate person underneath needing urgent attention from critical and deep psychological damage since birth. Hopefully, deep and intensive therapy with support from those around her will help Adora begin the process of no longer needing to crave validation from other people, to work on creating a positive view of herself, and of course to be able to believe in herself.

This is confidential information that I request not be shared with anyone else.

- Princess Perfuma.

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It is not that the stars came to Etheria,

It is that Etheria came to the stars.

~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~

You're playing a game, I'm making war here. You know what will happen? They'll overwhelm Frosta and Mermista with bots, fire on Perfuma, draw Bow into the open, and pin him down. Glimmer will run out of teleports and I'll be too fucking busy trying to hold everything down that all I can do is watch while all of you arekilled.

You wanted me to wage war, please let me. I–

I can't fuck this up. I can't fail you.

It's been six months.

Starships fell and rose to skyscrapers, puncturing the landscape with their wrecked presence.

Mighty castles that once dominated the topography retreated into underground bunkers.

People lessened and then grew.

The aftermath is a different world.

Stars provide illumination at night and yet a chilling reminder of the interlocking of the present and the future.

So much has changed. Queen Glimmer was only gone for a few months.
~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~~

Etheria is sort of familiar and yet eerily not so similar. For one, the diversification of food is welcome. Knowing that a late-morning breakfast can be whatever the cooks dream up is a much appreciated step up from bland, printed food of the same type every day *for months* on end.

The natural light shining in through windows, coming at first from above and between the few remaining tree's around Brightmoon and partially obscured by a wrecked battleship, is a long awaited and sought-after hope. The light is warm to the touch and a beautiful embrace rather than the distant cold of lurid and discomforting fixed lighting.

But there is no doubt that Etheria has changed much in just nine short months, a time normally seen as part of a chapter in the annals of a monarch's history. It will probably require a book itself for just even a third of its history to be remembered properly. The sudden onslaught of galactic assault, the destruction to the environment by massive ships tumbling uncontrollably from orbit, and the untimely culmination of a devastating thirty years of warfare has left terrible scars on the planet and its people.

Every day, Glimmer wakes up to a fresh meal on rotation and is reminded of this when the sun kisses her face and the first visible object out the window is a wrecked planetary bombardment cannon. The morning begins and ends with Bow in her bed and her friends at her side.

Well the friends that survived.

These days however are no longer comprised of fun jaunts against the forces of evil or recruiting new members to fight for the cause, those times are over. With a broken planet and a near post apocalypse avoided, a good part of Queen Glimmer's itinerary can be summed up in just three words.

Planetwide damage control.

Most of the days consist of a meeting with the other princesses and surviving members of The Rebellion's council it sadly lacks generals,mostly comprising of just princesses now. Glimmer can list the non-Princesses left in her inner circle on one hand: Bow, her father and her aunt; a list of people that should have been *so much more* but they're…gone now.

Resistance in Etheria post-Hordak and post-Prime is usually in small, dispersed groups in the countryside or in the Crimson Waste. It lacks the signature heavy equipment from Etherian-made tanks to space age drones and support spacecraft. The few remaining organized groups typically range from "being a regional security threat" to "can only threaten a small village", so the mop up operations months after the Armada fell out of orbit and crashed into Etheria went easier than expected. Some clones aswell as Horde soldiers put down their weapons and eventually attempted to integrate into society with mixed results from both themselves and the population.

Lonnie and Wrong Hordak being notable successful members.

They tend to act as liaisons. With time and concessions promised by Glimmer, they will eventually be offered the chance to fully integrate with a kingdom. Which include that of Mermista's, who immediately refused. But with the Fright Zone erased, perhaps the Scorpion kingdom could rise again?

Glimmer ponders this as she sits alone at a cliff overlooking a bare landscape that's creeping into a savanna-like terrain rather than the rich forest of the Whispering Woods it was less than a year ago. It's another sad casualty of both the thirty-years war and the ecological devastation of falling starships.

Plowing into the seas and causing mass flooding or straight-up tsunamis that reached inland that drowned people and left famine and mass infrastructure damage in their wake was the first topic that Glimmer dealt with when she came back. Apparently using nuclear weapons on the mainframe back on Prime's starship caused a mass loss of control. While it immediately bought a halt to the imminent takeover of Etheria, people, and the land itself, died in *droves.*

Resting her chin on a knee and letting a gentle breeze blow through her cape, Glimmer wondered if she could have done something differently. Could the Crystal Castle have been saved? Would Mermista and Perfuma been at odds if Glimmer had cooled their jets at the first meeting rather than having to twist Perfuma's arm to get her to agree to supply food to Salinas while Mermista bitched about Adora killing her boyfriend with snide comments about Glimmer's boy toy and *husband* ? Suffering from an already short mood courtesy of stressfull late nights and caffeine withdrawal, Glimmer teleported out of the meeting.

She probably should have bought her husband with her–

"You know that just because you *can* teleport out of meetings doesn't mean you *should* , right?"

A jogging man with a shortness of breath interrupts her isolation, his stubble and bun somewhat at odds but fitting in with the political hilarity of an exposed midriff, plus a suit, joins her.

"Hello, Husband," Glimmer replies nonchalantly, receiving a kiss on her forehead as the two of them clasp wrists, their heart-shaped bracelets interlocking with the same deft love as their wedding. Bow had grown significantly. Gone is the shaven face, replaced with the slow growing of a beard. His quiver remains but is tucked away and hidden behind a long light cape and his tuxedo is blue now.he exposed midriff is still there though.

“Hello, wife. You do know that we had a long and arduous discussion about grain to go through before you teleported off?” Bow’s voice is starting to alter too, losing the famous and often cracking tone becoming more diplomatic - worthy of a Monarch’s consort.

“Eh, it was Perfuma’s thing. Besides, Mermista was being a bitch again” Glimmer huffs and warms the cold morning grass under Bow’s butt with a snap of her fingers. Her own voice too had changed significantly. It’d lost the edge of a teenager and transformed into the steady and sure tone of a Queen.

“No– she– yeah, she kinda is,” Bow agrees as he joins Glimmer’s gaze in watching a small flock of wildlife drink from one of the few untouched water sources in the distance. It’s a little sad that what was once an everyday event to see is now something to be witnessed.

Glimmer rests her head on her husband’s shoulder, slowly inhaling the perfume he was gifted for their wedding. It’s a good smell and a calming scent given that almost every day is damage control day.

“Seriously! She’s such a bitch now. I have to fight and wrangle with her every time! She won’t ever stop being so fucking annoying,” Glimmer complains, recalling their weekly shouting matches with Mermista threatening to pull her aid from the costal regions and making Salineas into an isolated kingdom.

“I know, she’s changed quite a bit since *then* . I’ve tried to get her and everyone to pull together but…it's not the same anymore,” Bow sighed and agreed as he threads fingers through Glimmer’s hair, fixing it into the asymmetrical, *queenly,* bobcut.

“You’ve done your best, Bow, better than what I could do anyway. It’s not our fault if Mermista wants to bitch out and–”

Memories of the good old days begin to flood back in. The fifteen-plus members of the Princess Alliance kicking ass and taking

names for almost t *wo years* with drinks and celebrations after every victory and even Mermista was–

"How's Entrapta doing?" Glimmer said, changing the conversation before she let herself get consumed with the water princess *again* . It had led to a downward spiral of emotion that caused her to leave today's meeting.

Bow shrugged, probably sensing his wife's anxiety, wraped an arm around her cape,careful to not ruffle it, and pulled out his souped-out tracker point sothey can both see the screen.

"Good news, actually!"

"Oh? Are you telling me something is going *well?* Are you giving the Queen false hope, Husband?"

Bow's cheery attitude returned when his voice-activated pad showed various icons, production numbers, Entrapta's increasing staff, and other sciencey and techy things.

"So Entrapta and I have been busy. We've managed to copy most of the tech on those ships and the clones. We have, at the very least, figured out how their technology works from medical science and laser beams. Entrapta is–"

Glimmer immediately interrupts. "Please tell me we can use this in case Prime ever comes back. We need to defend ourselves and magic alone won't save us."

"It will! We can repurpose and reengineer the bombardment cannons. We could even mount them in space if the repulsors Entrapta has been working on work!"

Glimmer breathed a sigh of relief. The horrifying thought of Prime returning with Etheria practically defenseless and in an even worse shape than it was a year ago was a personal nightmare scenario.

Bow' gets more animated as he talks, He fidgeted around and moved (very cutely) as his excitement bounces off and draws a crack of a smile on Glimmer's face that becomes a laugh and a cuddle as her husband makes swooping noises to go along with his presentation.

"Ooohh I gotta show you this!" *His voice actually cracks.*

"This is an update on those metal workings? We've managed to *actually* start fabricating spaceship alloy thanks to the–"

Bow drumrolls.

"Etherian makers society! Durable and on-demand metals that'll survive a Scorpia lightning attack. She uh- she helped us test it while Perfuma made kale cookies."

The thought of Perfuma putting kale in yet something else was kinda funny to be honest. Plus, now that they had a source of materials, it'd make the weekly meetings that much more bearable.

"And Entrapta is…"

"Oh, she's getting back to herself. You know…making comments and logs. She's really come out of her shell this month and I'm proud of her for doing so."

Back to herself because of Adora.

"It's good to hear at the very least. Good news and not needing to worry about her anymore- right?" Glimmer asks, hopeful that she won't have to delegate specialist people to watch over Entrapta's wellbeing.

Bow closed his trackerpad and reached down to interlock their fingers together.

"Positively, she's doing way better and the nightmares have stopped. She's back with the Makers Society and on speaking

grounds with Wrong Hordak!”

Glimmer breathed out.

“That’s a fucking relief. Thank you.”

After the events on the spacecraft, Entrapta retreated into herself, falling back into the depressive routine similar to Beast Island where she’d had to be guided into eating food and even taking a showe againr.

“It’s been a rough time but the light’s here and she’s happy and well,” Bow added, Glimmer noded with an affirmative smile.

“I’m glad. I was worried she’d never recover. Any other news, Bow?”

“A bunch actually. You should probably get one of those pads. They’re super useful for getting messages and talking to people in other Kingdoms without having to, y’know, physically get there.”

“I prefer teleporting there.”

“Well, yeah, but not all of us can teleport!” Bow lightly jabbed Glimmer in the ribs in jest, who in return teleported to her husband's side and flicked his nose.

“Alright, lay it on me,” Glimmer saidas she flopped over onto her back. She started to make a snow angel as she felt the few remaining blades of grass with her fingertips.

“Are you really gonna–” With an exaggerated roll of his eyes and hand on his hips, Bow looked down, tryingto suppress his amusement.

“Yep!” is the answer, popped with an accentuatedP.

“First off is Perfuma,” Bow replied as he lay beside her, bow and quiver laid to the side.

“She has–” He got out his tablet again, “--managed to be doing better than expected given the latest food exports and Plumeria is keeping pretty much everyone on the continent fed so not much to complain other th–”

Bow groaned and said with a sigh, “Ah.”

“If it’s going to be a problem with kale colors I am going to–”

Bow interjected, showing data on his tablet of tons of food exported and the regions they’ve been transported to- basically every bar in Brightmoon and Salineas.

“Surge capacity, actually. Plumeria isn’t used to this kind of hard work. They’ve met our demand for now but they’re running out of people for shifts. Entrapta’s data says we’ve got a week before food shortages start. We need that food or else we’ll start seeing riots. Hungry people tend to cause problems.”

“Huh.”

Bow doesn't need to say it and this was definitely something Glimmer should have been in the meeting for instead of teleporting away for selfish peace and quiet. She is *the queen* and now starving subjects and refugees are a hair’s breath away. Politically speaking, it’s now her problem; a *big fucking problem.*

“Shit.”

“To be honest this is something we should have addressed–”

“I know, I know. Gimme a sec.”

Glimmer wracked her brain and thought out loud as Bow watched on, giving encouraging hums and a rub to the shoulder.

“Workers. Perfuma needs workers, right? Presumably strong and able-bodied people who can work long shifts. Do we have anyone that can do that? Like find refugees who are willing to?”

“We’d need to find a large group and our refugees are pretty heavily scattered and disorganized.”

“We–”

She tries to think of any readily available people that could help.

The barely functioning army that’s needed for defense if Prime ever comes back? No.

Neither can anyone in the technical field. They’re either under Entrapta’s command now or are busy desperately rebuilding Etheria’s shattered infrastructure.

Refugees are scattered everywhere and it’d take too long to gather them all up. Even then it’d be a mixed bag of varying abilities.

“What about the Horde soldiers and clones? We have people with them and they’re in large groups, right? They’re military people who’ve stuck together,able bodied, and can move things around. Do you reckon we could offer them freedom points or something? Scorpia and Lonnie could help and we could get Wrong Hordak to rally a few.”

“Couldn't hurt to try, right?” Bow agreed, nodding along with encouragement.

Glimmer flashed a real smile.

“I’m getting better at being the Queen”

Her husband replies with a light squeeze, “That you are.”

“Do you wish you were still a princess instead of Queen?”

“I do sometimes. I really do. It’s like standing at the top of a tower and everyone else is within shouting distance but it’s really lonely. I wish…I wish it could be different”

“Like being able to charge out like we used to?”

"It's– no– priorities change when you become Queen and you're responsible for everyone, doubly so when you've been gone for months. The former king returns and then half the planet is either underwater or on fire! I'm just tired. I wish I had everyone with me and I dont cuz they're fucking gone."

The wind changes, not in a bad way though. But it’s lighter. It’s gone from a fresh breeze to a mere tickle that sways individual strands of hair and blows them into the faces of the two lovers camped out on a former grasslands’s cliffs edge. The remaining patches of grass under them are no longer wet and comfortably dry under the gaze of the early afternoon sun.

Glimmer’s head rests on Bow’s shoulder. Bow’s arm lay wrapped around Glimmer’s waist. They low hum to each other for idle communication, conversation regarding the morning's events having long since evaporated. It leaves just a Queen and her lover with themselves for comfortable and quiet company. It could even be described as a victory of some sorts.

Considering the increasingly busy political, diplomatic, and interior urban life, it is quite literally a fresh breeze to be out in the remains of Etheria’s gentle rolling countryside and away from the bustle and constant noise of the planet's largest settlement.

“Bow,” Glimmer groans with a lazy stretch of her arms, “Did we miss anything today?”

Bow pondered for a moment and shook his head. “We covered everything on the itinerary. Can’t think of anything else that was supposed to happen for the meeting.”

Glimmer groaned, rubbing her forehead with one hand. “Fucking Mermista has it out for us, I swear.” She massaged the side that’s starting to call out for a much-needed morning coffee.

“Hey,” Bow reached out and linked his fingers around Glimmer’s unoccupied hand, “it’ll be okay. She’ll be okay again eventually but we can't leave her out. She did lose her boyfriend and whether or not she blames Adora for it–”

“I know. I wish this went another way, but it’s the hand we have. It’s just a lot of people missing now.”

“She still values us enough to actually come all the way over here. We just need to not poke her and I think we’ll all come around eventually.”

“Netossa, though,” Glimmer gives a humorless laugh.

“Yeah. I think she’s a lost cause at this point. She’ll keep going until she drops, to be honest.”

The net-wielding princess hadn’t been seen doing anything *but* hammering the few remaining holdout followers of the Horde, whether Etherian or space-based in her unending quest for vengeance.

“It’s kind of sad, really. She was devoted to Spinny but…now she’s gone and the last thing I remember seeing was *that look* in her eyes.”

Bow breathed out and leaned in.

“Adora had that look, too.”

He says it darkly. While Bow probably didn't mean *that* , a light cliff caresses the back of the Queen’s neck at the brief recollection of experiencing Adora’s vengeful and furious transformation into a distorted She-Ra from the safety of the ship. It was *terrifying* to experience from relative safety. A shambolic wreck of a woman turned to physical manifestation of pure anguish.

“I know.”

“I mean we do have her, *in* a pinch *she* could start leading the armies? She’s got the experience you kn–” Bow asks,alluding to the one person they sort of had on hand that could do it. The two of them know damn well that she’s not in any shape or form to.

Glimmer takes a moment to compose herself.

“She’s not here right now. Even if she did, not sure if she even wants to be honest. It’d be a difficult and unpopular decision and only something I’d consider in a genuine emergency.”

That was the end of that for a few more minutes. Glimmer closed her eyes and tried hard to ignore the occasional shriek of machinery from Etherians desperately dismantling Prime’s war bots in the distance. He instead focused on listening to a rare chirp of a bird or the remote noise from a herd of wild animals.

Peace, bliss, and harmony - a relative rarity these days. Bow catches on too and with some shifting and moving around between the two of them. They relaxed and listened to the gentle nature of Etheria. For Glimmer and Bow, it represents a chance to step back and dip into the memory pool of how life used to be when they were younger and it was just the two of them.

Ten minutes? Twenty? Go by of serenity. It’s peaceful enough. With Bow holding her into a loose cuddle and with the warm heat of the afternoon sun pushing her towards a more lethargic state. Glimmer found herself moving towards a brief afternoon nap.

“I’m glad Scorpia and Perfuma are getting married. Hopefully seeing two people from opposite sides will help tensions calm down a bit.”

“Eurgh?”

And then Bow’s trackerpad breaks the peace with an urgent electronic beep. With a tired and groggy groan, Bow gingerly reached out for it while yawning. Judging by the noises he made, he expected it to be something non consequential so the two of them could return to calm.

It isn't.

“Glimmer!”

“Ah!”

Bow yelped and flapped his hands, startling Glimmer out of her sleepy state as she launches a purple null lance out of her finger tips in drowsy panic. It that torches dry grassland that is then immediately extinguished before it could create an inferno.

“Glimmer!”

“Sorry! What is it?”

With shaky hands, Bow passed the trackerpad over. While normal, urgent matters typically have a massive paragraph attached and a fuckton of warnings. This one has the live feed of a single room. The message is clear despite its vagueness to *anyone else.*

Glimmer understood immediately, even if she’s just starting to wake up.

“Put them on, Bow.”

The livefeed turns to a doctor, a woman in a lab coat with the emblem of Mystacor as a badge on her left breast. The room is quickly left behind and she leaned against a wall.

“Queen Glimmer?” The doctor asked, not too urgently but still with a strain of anxiety in her voice.

Glimmer shifts over to sit down by herself with Bow maneuvering himself next to her like he did before. The two of them at the least looked somewhat professional rather than being caught mid cuddling. “Yeah? Uh, thank you for calling, Doctor Quen - but I

was under the impression that you'd be calling with an update later?"

The doctor adjusts the volume on her end and the couple leaned in to hear the distant sound of two women in the background arguing. One had the practiced and soothing voice of a Mystacor therapist and the other was scratchy and confused.

"Yeah-yeah. I'm sorry for interrupting your day, Your Majesty, but I have a urgent update regarding the patient you sent and paid for as sh–"

"She's awake?" Glimmer asks with *actual* shock.

"How?" Bow adds.

Quen blinked slowly and then flipped the camera from her to the space she's in, showing a massive degree of advanced medical equipment. Bow recognized some and gasped as he remarked that he and Entrapta salvaged and repaired some of it from Prime's ship.

"I–" Quen snatched a glace towards the commotion which seemed to die down. The voices in the room behind went from a one-sided shouting match to a woman being comforted and asking questions that the microphone couldn't quite pick up.

“Thanks to the Makers Society’s efforts and that most of our therapists survived, we managed to contain and partially reverse the neural and nerve damage. That, combined with the patient’s magical properties and previous healing magic, she managed to recover moderately well enough that she’s awake now–”

“--sort of”

Bow whispered in Glimmer’s ear, “It’s only been seven months. They told us she’d be out for years.”

With a stiffness and thinking of possible consequences, plus the inquisitiveness that never left her since childhood, Glimmer straightened up and asked a question that she hopeed would have a *good* answer.

“Can she move?”

“Glimmer what are you thinking?” Bow hisses.

“Trust me, Bow.”

Quen shakes her head. “She’s well enough to speak coherently and she can move her limbs but she’ll be on assisted living for a while until–”

“Quen, can you show me her?” Glimmer interjects, the gears in her head beginning to move towards a formulating plan, one that she stuffed in the “emergency” category.

“Love, what are we planning here?” Bow fixed his previous question with some apprehension.

The doctor obliged, opening the door to the room. It was showing it to be covered in soothing colors bathed in a warm light to promote calm and relaxation, a mixture of blues to treat depression and pain, followed by a light green symbolic of nature and stress relief. There aremedical machines, too, and an array of casual furniture and exercise machines exhibiting clearly no expense was spared in funding this one single room out of the four that Glimmer paid for.

The camera focused on two people, the third out of the way. The patient out of the two calmed down with no wild movements or vexed vocalizations. compared to the ruckus they’d heard just moments ago and according to the second therapist's body language, it’s definitely an improvement.

Quen starts, shifting the trackerpad around as she pulled up a list with documents. The screen became half patient and half paperwork.

“She’s been awake for a few hours, we didn't contact you initially until we were certain she’d slip back into a coma but as you no doubt saw or heard, the patient is quite cognitively awake. However, I believe that she–”

“So she’s fully awake,” Glimmer interrupts with a spark threading between her fingers.

“Yes she is but physically it’s still a–”

Glimmer imagines Mystacor again and the magical rooms like this one that sit below it. There was the incredible disparity of function and services compared to flash and education and all those winding tunnels and secret corridors.

She’d made a decision.

“Thank you, doctor. She’ll be back with you soon.”

“Your Majesty?”

With a combination of studied training sessions from the best sorcerers in the land and the fully unlocked power of the Moonstone -Glimmer calculated the distance, the amount of force and energy she’d need to exert, and visually locked on with the patient she’d spent so many resources into restoring back from near death. With a snap of her finger precipitating magic thundering out of them in a terrific thunderclap, a portal opens that wrenches time and space apart and plucks the patient away with absolute clarity and accuracy and left the befuddled therapists of Mystacor with no property damage.

A rush of air forms out of nowhere and in the circular shape of a sphere erupts next to them. The controlled shockwave blew grass for at least a ten-meter circumference before it disappeared as quickly as it arrived.

It spat out a person. Or, well, a person bursted out of a hole ripped through the fabric of Etheria's very biosphere - having been transported a continent away to here in less than two seconds and with *absolute* precision.

A figure is gently deposited through magical assistance borne out of careful manipulation by Glimmer controlling tiny beads of purple sorcery through her fingertips to where the figure is laid down as comfortably as possible on the soft land below.

The person, a women, is just a little taller than Glimmer. Her limbs no longer bearing lean muscle and rather kept in a neutral shape from magic and physical therapy. Gone, too, are ripped items of clothing and aggressive lines of fabric, rather a white long t-shirt covers the girl's top with a worn but still functional red jacket over it.

A pair of shorts and bare feet complete the mix. At the very least, the person is in a much better shape than when they first arrived on Etheria seven months ago.

The woman, seemingly coming out of a deep sleep despite her agitated conversation just a minute ago, bolted upright but immediately struggles to maintain such a quick form and flails in panic as her body betrays her and refuses to stay upright on its own.

Bow shifted over to help her up, but the woman refuses it. She instead rolled over to stare at Glimmer directly in the eyes, her fingers flexing and a low moan escaping from her throat before wetting her lips and speaking in an accent that hadn't been heard in a long time.

"Seriously?"

The figure looks around with a bewildered expression.

"What the shit?"

The patient groans.

"Sparkles?"

Glimmer stiffens, half of her recoiling on sight from seeing her prime enemy of *two and a half* years right in front of her once again and the other softened are seeing her only friend for three months and someone that she poured an enormous amount of resources into - making sure she didn't die. *Again.*

“Hello, Catra”

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Catra rolled around a few times, struggling and swearing in her attempts to get up on her legs. It's awkward and painful to watch, but the former Horde commander adamantly denies help. It ledto Bow and Glimmer simply spectating as the catgirl fails again and again with increasing desperation, her tail twitching erratically and its purpose as a counterbalance null.

In a way it’s distressing to see someone famed and renowned for their agility - simply *struggle* to stand up.

Bow leaned in, keeping his voice down.

“You really pulled her out of there for this?”

Instead of whispering, Glimmer clears her voice. Her plan, or the rough ramshackle idea that popped into her head, can be best described as “improvisation” rather than a step-by-step checklist. That’s something *Adora* would have done.

“Yeah pretty much, I mean she’s conscious–”

They both turn to witness Catra stumble over and loudly scream before giving up and lying on her back.

“-and we can fix *that* later. Magic and physical therapy’ll do the trick.”

Bow fixed her with a concerned *“Are you serious?”* look.

“Probably,” Glimmer shrugs.
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Catra called out a second later, still frowning as her ears pull back. “I can hear you two ya know?”

Bow and Glimmer share a look. “Sorry.”

With a deep sigh, a reluctant forehead wipe,and an audible grunt, Catra turns to face them. She looked a little peeved and Glimmer supposes that she probably owed Catra some answers. Judging by the look the two of them just shared, it’d probably be private.

“Bow could you? Give us some alone time?” she asked.“And hand me the trackerpad - please.”

Bow quietly said his goodbyes. He gave a kiss on the cheek for Glimmer and a promise not to wander too far. He waved at Catra, one that is awkwardly returned with a headcock and a disjointed attempt at returning the gesture.

In all honesty, with Catra staring at her and in all likelihood expecting a reason for why she’s suddenly now on Etheria, teleported out of a underground base and finding her limbs to be just recovering from a six month coma of non-use and only sustained by magic, Glimmer starts to wish that she had Adora’s gift for planning for all eventualities rather than the “make it up as you go along” approach that she went with.

“I’m guessing you wanna know why, right?”

Still, she had a duty to explain. Catra is one of her subjects, technically. *Among other things.*

“Mhmmm,” Catra cracks her knuckles and hisses at the dormant fluid popping .

“You were…” Glimmer has to find the right words, “on the ship when we found you. I– we…”

Words are difficult, Catra is hugging Adora’s red jacket and silently sniffed the sleeves, her ears flattened and out sideways in a sort of comforted body language.

It’s almost as painful to witness as it is to speak.

“We didn't think you’d make it to be honest. A combination of botched healing and some kind of pill kept you alive but barely.Not to mention the nerve damage and, well, *everything.”* Glimmer gestured with her hands as the flustered memory of holding the crew together creeped back up in her head as they ran the gauntlet of Prime’s fleet on autopilot with no way to change course.

“I remember uh,” Catra scratches her head slowly, “passing out a lot. I don't remember the ship though. You guys had a ship? Sparkles? Nerve damage?”

“Yeah Mara’s one, the uh. One in the Crimson Waste’s. It’s in much better shape now, actually, and was more of a rustbucket when we flew back.”

Glimmer rubbed the back of her neck. “Didn't think we’d make it actually, the whole thing was falling apart and Darla kept glitching out. Nerve damage? Yeah you, Adora jammed you with some pills and then I think she tried to heal you but it didn't work properly or something and–”

“Queen Glimmer, the damage to the skeleton, muscles and nerve damage from what is essentially a combination of an electric sucide pill, two coma inducing tablets, and the worst case of an unstable emotionally laden and inexperienced attempt at healing will make just alleviating the strain extremely difficult. This is not to mention the magnitude at which it takes to rejuvenate the body. I honestly think we should–”

Glimmer snapped back to reality, a portion of a letter from Catra’s therapist/doctor briefly invading her mind and she pushed it aside.

“It doesn't matter. You're alive and that's what counts, right?” she says with a small smile.

Catra blinked and turned away. “Jeez, Sparkles, don't need to make it sound like a big deal.”

But truly it is. You died twice and the best sorcerers on the planet thought you were beyond help.

With a huff, Catra shifted over with a brief wince of pain to face Glimmer again, the claws on one hand idly tracing through the grass.

Two innocent words tumble out of her mouth, eleven letters that Glimmer’s been dreading to hear and has fled from properly confronting for more than half a year. It was a string of bundled trauma that’d just unraveled the darkest and most painful thirty minutes of the Queen’s life.

“Where’s Adora?”

“And why am I wearing her clothes?”

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The sun shined on a wrecked Etheria, but the landscape before them is relatively unharmed and showing green rather than gray.

Wild animals called to each other in the distance. They ate, drank, and moved along with their day.

Queen Glimmer is trying very hard to not mirror her outward appearance while everything inside of her is *screaming* .
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Catra, the woman that died twice in a day and is completely unaware of the events of the last seven months, is expecting answers to a question she may not entirely understand. She laid on her side with half-crippled limbs supporting her and a damaged tail that only managed to barely reflect her emotional state.

“Sparkles”

Catra noted Glimmer’s absence of an answer. What is she supposed to reply with? That Adora’s been gone for seven months and that she left in a storm of fire and fury to kill Prime and sent a screaming Glimmer, a hapless Bow, and a traumatized Entrapta away to Etheria because she couldn't hold herself together?

“Sparkles?”

Glimmer forcefully relieved that emotionally excruciating moment, the confession of a pale and veiny Adora having thrown off her exterior clothing and, in a fit of stress-induced panic and a seemingly willingness to die, threw herself off the deep. N *othing, absolutely nothing,* Glimmer and Bow could do was *enough.*

“I wasn't good enough, for everyone, for Catra.”

Adora. Don't leave us. Please. We can–” Is what Glimmer screamed internally.

“It’s simple, easy. I can fix this, Glimmer, everyone can go home.”

I've got you, I’m not letting go. For once in your fucking life just stay with me and dont go away.

Adora’s fingers caressing her own, trailing rough skin over soft and that battered face and ruined hair speaking softly and saying goodbye while Glimmer shrieked uselessly and cried.

“Glimmer? You okay there?” Catra’s voice snapped the Queen back to reality. She found herself sitting down and hugging her knees. There’s a tear stain on her knee and it took a second to

realize that she cried a bit while relieving the truly awful memory of witnessing Adora leave.

"Yes?! –what." Glimmer rubs at her eyes and shakes her head. It's either fatigue or just exhaustion but this thing that's been eating away at her is starting to rear its ugly head.

"Yeah yeah I know I–"

"Do you really wanna know?"

"Yeah."

Deep breath, slow exhale and one of Perfuma's pre game mental juice ups do nothing to prepare Glimmer for this - informing a friend's loved one that their friend is probably gone.

"She's gone."

Catra recoiled at first, her face narrowed, and she snorted as if to dismiss it.

"How? We were on a *ship* Sparkles and I have her clothes? I'm like, *wearing* them."

"You don't–" Glimmer buried her face in her hands, "she left because she thought you were dead and that kinda broke her. We couldn't do anything to stop or reason it's like part of her just stopped functioning and–"

"The way back took a few days. It was actual misery with waking up every few hours of searching the ship top to bottom hoping

Adora'd somehow snuck back on and that she hadn't given up on herself and committed...y'know.”

Biting her cheek so her speech’ll remain coherent and to keep a stiff upper like her mom. Glimmer also summoned something to steady herself against as the repressed trauma of seeing a loved depart in anger threatened to spill over, that her last memory of Adora was watching the women’s world fall apart.

"--ried so much almost passed out. Bow nearly lost himself trying to keep everyone together and Entrapta was inconsolable after seeing...something.She wouldn't tell us and I don't wanna know… she's only recently been not-traumatized, y'know, and we can't have her regressing.”

And the fucking clone in a chef’s outfit.

"Wrong Hordak didnt have a fucking clue of what was going on and I swear I could’ve killed him.”

“I begged Adora not to leave. Can you imagine bargaining with someone for *their* life and they just refuse? It’s like she just *gave up* on living and just wanted to go out with a bang. I saw her transform into She-Ra or something like it and I–”

“It was horrible Catra, and it fucking *terrified* me-- and–”

Glimmer needed a fucking second to collect herself, to calm her magically attuned body down and stave off the flight or flight reflex from just remembering the thousands of icepicks that dominated the air and space around her that she was the only one to feel it. The *thing that* wrenched out of the fabric of reality, born maybe out of the terrible combination of Adora's fears and insecurities created an aura of black *dread.* Like the chilling realization of an apex predator in the forest.

"I-I was so *cold.* Whatever she ripped out …can you imagine being so terrified for yourself and your friend that you shut down completely, Catra?"

then she was gone and that's the last I ever saw of Adora.. It's been seven months and we haven't heard or had any notice of her."

"What about a signal or something? We were in space right?" Is Catra bargaining or does she refuse to believe? Glimmer can understand since she spent over a week in a guilt-filled state and almost passed out.

" *Nothing,* Catra. Just nothing. One of the battleships had a working sensor and one of the clones said it detected a massive burst of energy like a bomb or something went off and it was probably Prime's ship blowing up and if they're right then–"

Glimmer bit her lip.

“Adora was on that ship. Nothing could have survived apparently and I–”

“I–” Catra began, upper lip quivering and tears swelling up in her eyes. She doesn't even look away, just stares at the ground. It’s heartbreaking to see and if Glimmer wasn't in such a shit mood she’d comfort the women physically.

“She–” Glimmer steels herself, “she said she loved you. I don't know if that's helpful or not but the last time she was happy,that’s what she said. Well, shetold us with an actual smile on her face after she bought you in.”

“It was supposed to–” Catra’s whimpering now. Lip trembled so bad it’s basically ugly crying. “--be a cottage. She promised me when she held me in her arms and I thought I was gonna die, she gave me.”

“Cat–” Glimmer tried to interrupt but stopped herself when Catra breaks out into a full-on, stuffy-nose confession, hands limp by her side and ears fully deflated.

It’s an experience that Glimmer was subjected to just a while ago, the feeling of oneself falling apart at the seams, a seemingly never ending cycle of the stages of depression that dominated the daily ritual.

“--said she’d never leave me again. wouldn't give up on me”

“Green place, didnt care what it looked like. Just a house for the two of us away from the shit side of life.”

Catra looked Glimmer in the eye and broke both of their hearts–

“She meant it. Promised me. Us. I believe and she wanted it but I–”

Because Adora communicated the same thing to Glimmer, promising they’d talk about their problems when they all returned home. That together, they’d *fix it* , that the two of them would try *again.*

And that didn't happen.

“Because Adora’s gone,” Glimmer tearfully remarks.

And the way Catra looked at her with a forlorn stare and tears streaking down her cheeks, well it disclosed everything.

“Look Catra she– Adora was not–” Glimmer pondered how she’s supposed to phrase that the former Princess of Power was *losing* it, like they’d hear her–

“She definitely wasn't okay. When she first came to us she was *alright* at the start. As time went on, the screaming at night started and we tried to comfort her. She went off on her own a lot and knuckled down whenever we tried to talk about it I–”

“No matter how much we tried to help, she refused and kept putting it off. Just–”

She quickly scrolled up to the report Perfuma made on Adora and stuffed the trackerpad into Catra’s finger. “Read this? It’s pretty grim but it’s how she was…at the-at the end.”

The catgirl frowns as she’s handed it. She is quickly engrossed if the rapid eye movement and the facial expressions are anything to go by. Her damaged tail initially flickered by her side, but as the minutes drag on and as Catra sucks in a breath and mutters painful words, her tail moves closer and tighter to her body. Her ears flatten and when she finishes reading, Catra nearly threw the pad away.

Glimmer inhaled, says nothing, and fidgets a bit. She’d had to break the same news to others, hundreds, maybe, but despite the near repetition of bad news, it *never* gets any easier.

Catra collected herself for a moment with shaking hands, lip corners pulled down and shoulders sagging

“I–” Catra begins but fails to finish, Glimmer noticed that she has to bite her cheek.

When the two of them make eye contact, Catra’s upper eyelids droop and she has trouble starting her words.

"I–" It's clearly emotional *effort* for her to speak and *fuck* does Glimmer wanna hug Catra right now to comfort and tell her it'll be all right but…would it?

"I knew it was bad, but *fuck.* I should have known. I-- the Crimson Waste was a hellhole but I never thought– fuck."

Nodding, Glimmer extends a careful hand out to reassuringly rub Catra's shoulder and is greeted with no resistance. Instead the girl's voice drops even further and it's *heartbreaking* to hear.

"She's gone, isn't she?" With her lips pressed together in acknowledgement, Glimmer sadly whispers a *yes* .

Is Catra crying?

"I'm finally back on Etheria and *here* with you and she's just, somewhere over *there* ? I don't even know where to look."

One day, or maybe later, Glimmer will have that conversation with Catra. She'll explain Adora's complete one-eighty from joyful and wanting to go home to complete soul-rending instability, shedding her distinctive clothes, wishing that she'd taken Catra's place, and starting a fight solely so she could go off and fight Prime - probably dying in the process.

She came so close. aving Catra in her arms changed Adora, and almost for the better. But it went wrong. So, so, wrong.

Catra will know that she's needed by Etheria to lead her armies if Prime ever comes back. She'll know that Scorpia and Perfuma will be getting married in a few months and that she's invited, Catra'll probably wear Adora's clothes until they fall off and, while Glimmer and Bow and hopefully Scorpia and Perfuma will support

her, it's a toss up about the others. There will be fights and arguments, food shortages, and combating environmental and biosphere collapse on a level not seen since the Black Garnet supercharge.

Catra died twice. Adora probably is. She'll be added as a statue, maybe two if Glimmer gets her way. She-Ra was never a controversial subject but Adora? She burned a lot of bridges and herself in the process. People are dead in droves from unstoppable attacks she led from the front, towns razed to the ground in unyielding defense. Violence and pain followed Adora's legacy as surely as footprints in the snow did. As much as she dragged Etheria kicking and screaming into victory, Adora also…

Well, Adora won the war for them no doubt, but the price of doing so - just looking beyond one of the few patches of fresh ground left - is a clear indication that it was at an immense cost to everyone.

Not to mention herself.

Out of the corner of her eye and just barely noticing it, Glimmer perceives Catra to mumble something and while it's barely audible to the ears - but given her recent political experience at understanding what people say under her breath, Glimmer does manage to lip read some of it.

It looks like either resignation or reciprocation, a painful one - to a someone.

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I decided to write something.

I don't know who I’m sending this to.

I don't intend for this ever to be sent or read but everyone deserves a moment to gather their thoughts

So here we go.

I know I’m not a good person.

I’m sorry.

I’m sorry things are like this. I’m sorry for hurting you all and I’m sorry that it’s ended this way.

I’m sorry that I’ve done terrible, terrible things. I’ve hurt a lot of people, sometimes for good reasons but mostly bad.

I regret it. I don't like it but I’d do it again because that means I will have done my best to ensure that you are all safe. To the best of my ability, I will try my best, always.

I’m *here* right now, and everyone I’ve ever been friends with, loved, slept with or knew are over *there* , with you.

I miss you, I miss you all and I miss Catra. I miss those few moments of being able to express myself truly, the real *me,* and ditch the personality of a Force Captain, She-Ra, or a Rebellion Commander. I miss warm touches, I miss good food, I miss laughter, and I miss love.

As much as I want desperately want to feel the weird nervousness, the confused obsession, and the little butterflies in the stomach again, I know deep down that it’d be wrong, I’d

figure out eventually that it'd be artificial and I wouldn't be able to forgive myself and even if it took place in a alternate reality, there'd always be a part of mine that screamed for the truth and I would...always have to let it go. I will take responsibility for my actions and the burden I borne for everyone I wanted to protect, if I have to do this on my own and sacrifice myself for the greater good then…so be it.

So it's better this way I guess, maybe there was some way for things to have changed or be different, maybe I could have been sent to Thaymor first instead of the Crimson Waste and a younger more innocent Adora might very well have joined the Rebellion at a young eighteen instead of twenty with a Force Captain's badge and belt and without an incredible amount of emotional and mental baggage that resulted in..well me.

There is probably something wrong with me. I know that I'm exceptional at hurting people. Shadow Weaver trained me to do so from the moment I could hold something in my hands but that ain't an excuse. I should have strived to be better, *been better.*

Instead I'm stuck with broken bones and dead bodies around me, I don't have much hope of getting out of here and I miss you all. I miss Glimmer's endless optimism and will to get things done, I miss Bow's incredible selflessness and his crop top, I miss Mermista, and Perfuma, and I miss Catra.

I miss her smile, the gleam in her eye when she'd beat me in a race and when we'd laugh together as cadets. I wish I could kiss her senseless until I run out of breath, cup her beautiful face with my hands and press our foreheads together. I wanted a life with her and I think she wanted one with me, but that's gone now.

In the end, I guess Etheria was never really my home. I don't think I ever really had one. Even if I try to conceptualize the idea of a house it's always brief and conceived in water and I can't grab it. If I had a home it would be with all of you, I think.

But that died when Catra did..I died when Catra died, but I'm glad that we found each other and that I went back for her and I got to hold her in those final moments even if I didn't know what those moments were at the time. And I know I'd throw myself at her on that ledge again without hesitation and maybe a different Adora could have done things differently - but I aint her. I'm not that different Adora; I'm this screwed up and damaged Adora.

I can't stop thinking, can't stop making up plans and planning ahead and putting things into boxes and waiting for an enemy. I don't have a stop button and I won't ever be able to get rid of it. I know that in the slim hope that if things went well I would be back on Etheria but a part of me dreads that because I'd still be running around and thinking of something to fix.

I hope you'll win in the end, that I've done something to aid or assist you in some way. I will try on my end to put a stop to Prime's invasion and while he's dead, there's no guarantee he won't come back or there will be reinforcements enroute. I hope you've found a way out of this either with some ancient super weapon or just classic improvisation. I don't expect to return or see you again, I can't speak Prime's language and I've never been good at tech and I'm hungry and thirsty and there's no food or water here. I'm also kinda cold and my body hurts…a lot.

She-Ra is trying to help but I think this is it I think. I don't expect to survive this and I'm okay with it. I've always placed the good and well being of my friends above myself and I know Perfuma told me to value myself, but I really can't. It's too difficult and it feels wrong.

I will try to remember the good things about all of you. I hope that you're all safe and things will rebuild. Grass will grow over empty plains and the dead will be buried and remembered, I'm going to try and remember good things and not the bad ones because those break my heart.

I wish I could see you all again. I wish I could have another sleepover with Bow and Glimmer, I wish I could teach Perfuma

and Frosta how to play martial sports,I wish I could have said goodbye better rather than leave everyone in tears, and I wish I could have told Catra that I loved her when she was breathing and able to respond.

But despite that, I will be left with nice memories of you, of all of us. I could have been a Force Captain forever and never experienced a sweet treat, riding a horse, or raiding kitchens at one am in the morning. I could have had more but at the same time, I could have had far less. It’s important to remember that.

I am truly sorry things ended up like this. I really am. But this is me, and all I’ve done in life is hurt the people around me and I don't think that would change, even if we could somehow go back in time...I’m. I’m too damaged for that. I know I won't get a happy ending but that doesnt mean others can’t. It’s the least I can do.

I know this letter will never be sent, it will never reach any of you and I kind of want it to or be read at all but it feels good to write it down.

I’ve also made up with She-Ra if that counts for anything at all. We’ve forgiven each other to some extent and I stopped running away from her. We’re sort of friends now? It's taken a while to get here but I’ll do my best to accept her and that I am She-Ra.

And Adora.

I just have one request, even though it’ll never be answered.

Remember She-Ra. She tried and she’s the last one. I’m sorry that I hurt her and she’s sorry that she hurt me.

And
Please

Remember me , I’m over here on my own and all of you are over there - if I look out the window then maybe I can hope to see you.

Love,
Adora.


R'22

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Eight months, 100k plus words and writing the most emotionally destructive fic of my life so far.

Thank you to everyone who came this far, a special mention to RationsandSpades who did proofreading for this chapter, this is has been an extremely tough write and while it could have gone differently, I believe this was the only way to go.

I’m going to release a different version of chapter eight in a week, it’s dealing more hands on with the political meetings and Msytacor and while effort was put in, I feel that it didn't overall mesh with the vibe of the fic.

Follow me on twitter KaffeeKupp

Your feedback is greatly appreciated.

Comission by Dylan R Fagan Artwork
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Eight B

A/N. This is very much a series of politically minded conversations and dealings with Glimmer being heavily overworked and relying on a few trump cards, this is incomplete as it's basically deleted scenes but I thought it would be prudent to release it as its own 8.25 chapter to give a better idea of Glimmer's powers and how Etheria is doing + it's political classes and Princesses.

See end notes.

Chapter Eight:

Remember.

It is not that the stars came to Etheria.

It is that Etheria came to the stars.

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You're playing a game, I'm making war here. You know what will happen? They'll overwhelm Frosta and Mermista with bots, fire on Perfuma and draw Bow into the open and pin him down, Glimmer will run out of teleports and I'll be too fucking busy trying to hold everything down that all I can do is watch all of you be killed.

You wanted me to wage war, please let me. I-

I can't fuck this up, I can't fail you.
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It’s been six months.

Starships fell and rose to skyscrapers - puncturing the landscape with their wrecked presence.

Mighty castles that once dominated the topography retreated into underground bunkers.

Peoples lessened and then grew.

The aftermath is a different world.

Stars provide illumination at night and yet a chilling reminder of the interlocking of the present and the future.

Etheria is sort of familiar and yet eerily not so similar, for one the diversification of food is welcome - knowing that a late morning breakfast can be whatever the cooks dream up is a much appreciated step up from bland printed food of the same type every day *for months* on end.

The natural light shining in through windows, coming at first from above and between the few remaining tree’s around Brightmoon and partially obscured by a wrecked battleship is a long awaited and dreamt-for sought after hope, the light is warm to the touch and a beautiful embrace rather than distant cold of lurid and discomforting fixed lighting.

But there is no doubt that Etheria has changed much in just nine short months, a time normally seen as part of a chapter in the annals of a monarch's history will probably require a book itself for just even a third of its history to be remembered properly. The sudden onslaught of galactic assault, the destruction to the environment by massive ships tumbling uncontrollably from orbit and the untimely culmination of a devastating thirty years of warfare has left terrible scars on the planet and its people.

Every day, Glimmer wakes up to a fresh meal on rotation and is reminded of this when the sun kisses her face and the first visible object out the window is a wrecked planetary bombardment cannon. The morning begins and ends with Bow in her bed and her friends at her side.

Well the friends that survived.

These days however are no longer comprised of fun jaunts against the forces of evil or recruiting new members to fight for the cause, those times are over and with a broken planet and a near post apocalypse avoided. Part Queen Glimmer's itinerary can be summed up in just three words.

Planetwide damage control.

And then most of the days consist of a meeting with the other princesses and surviving members of The Rebellion's council, sadly lacking generals and mostly comprising of just princesses now. Glimmer can list the non Princess's left in her circle on one hand. Bow, her father,her aunt and Wrong-Hordak. A list of people that should have been more but they're…gone now.

The war room of Bright Moon still has an uncomfortable air of emptiness to it. Vacant chairs representing the fallen and never moved out of respect outnumber the ones occupied. Hole's in the walls from damage either intentional or simply blasted out from shockwaves when the starships fell from orbit.

New faces sit on chairs ripped from storage. Some like Scorpia sit directly with their partners, others away from each other, the ones at the beginning like Bow and Frosta are relaxed and eager while Glimmer's father and his sister huddle together, Micah's twenty year stint of freedom having eroded his administrative and political abilities and he since forfeited the throne and returned to Mystacor for a teaching position.

With the assembled parties in place - each representing a kingdom, a tribe or a new group of settlers. Queen Glimmer leans on the grand war table with one hand and casts a ball of light in the air to signal the sixth council meeting of The Rebellion.

"Mermista, where are we with land reclamation and holding the sea back?"

The princess of the sea, dressed in casual clothes and a tub of ice cream where Seahawks seat used to be - mumbles and groans tiredly.

"It's going"

With an eyeroll and manipulating the ball of light into Mermista's eyes to wake her up, *Queen* Glimmer asks *again.*

"Mermista."

Mermista, with a tired shrug and a deflated voice lacking famed sarcasm rolls a chart indicating new water depths and land that's currently underwater. She's been through a lot and with the death of Seahaw - has lost a part of herself, visually.

"Seagates managed to contain most of the flooding from Seaworthy to Plumeria but the environmental effects have destabilized like other regions. I guess Thaymor and the Fright Zone are sort of flooded and the Crimson Waste's monsoon season is most of the year now- report over"

Could you be any more specific Glimmer mumbles under her breath.

Unfortunately, Mermista manages to catch that and for a few seconds the old one is back, except angrier and a water bottle on an empty table explodes.

"I'm sorry, is like having *your boytoy* not being killed by Adora made this easier for you by like any chance?"

Silence descends, mostly with some muttering. Frosta gawks awkwardly across the room, Perfuma and Scorpia turn their heads away and Bow clears his throat.

"Uh, I'm sure we can all-"

Interjecting with the classical diplomatic tone and a raised hand, Perfuma turns to Scorpia for support who nods.

"Work this out? Being at each other throats is such a negative action, think of the positivity we could achieve togeth-"

"Not right now, I'm talking to *Glitter* "

Glimmer with narrowed eyes and a clenched fist about having h *er husband referred to as a boytoy* , is about to retort with something to level the playing field is stopped by Bow who lays a hand on her arm.

"Love, it's not worth it" He softly strokes up and down her forearm.

With a huff, Queen Glimmer bites her cheek and adopts her most impartial voice - one from learning and watching her mother's reaction and vocal tone when speaking to guests that Bright Moon was on neutral terms with.

"Thank you for your report Princess Mermista, I'm glad to have you clearing up our sea's and aiding our villages"

Mermista fixes Glimmer with a glare across the room, Glimmer raises an eyebrow back and shines the light away from the Princess, daring her to say something.

A few pregnant seconds go by, nobody speaks and Mermista; with a huff leaves.

“Guess she still blames Adora huh?” Bow leans in with a whisper, Glimmer nods sadly.

Castaspella breaks the ice and turns the conversation elsewhere, as she always has ever since her and Angella argued with Glimmer was a kid.

“So!” She rubs her hands together and with Micahs approval, conjures up a bunch of scrolls ranging from environmental maps to spells that litter the table from Perfuma’s end all the way up to Bow’s nose.

“I, with the assistance of my wonderful brother, had a little rummage around in the libraries of Mystacor! And together we-”

Micah actually drumrolls. And summons a plate of food.

“-figured out that our magic can manipulate and melt metal! Isn’t that such helpful news!” Smiling broadly and clapping her hands together, Castaspella then levitates a piece of plating over from the wrecked battleship out of the window and Micah turns it into a brightly coloured plant plot and then adds a daisy for good measure.

Glimmer’s response - a breath of fresh air out of having good news for once is sadly interrupted by purple pigtails sticking out of the ceiling, then a crash of a dozen recorders, Emily the robot falls through and takes a piece of the battered ceiling with her on the way down and Entrapta lands on top.

Scorpia reaches over to make sure she’s alright but the scientist then takes one look at the plant pot and immediately launches into one of her theories.

“Oh! Have you finally figured out how to use the materials? I estimate there to be at least nineteen million tons of available base metallic units to use, I should be able to integrate them with our own existing technology base and meld the two into a combination of starmetal and locally manufactured material to the point of which I can then re engineer the methods used to produce it and then set up a domestic production facility so we can be self sufficient with regards to manufacturing high quality star metal material! Not to mention I c-”

With a practiced ability at this point to be able to redirect Entrapta’s increasingly scientific driven tirade, Bow manages to steer the conversation into something the rest of the table (confused looks and open mouths) to understand.

“Entrapta? Could you slow down for a sec’ please? Are you saying we could build this stuff on our own?”

Entrapta nods furiously, picking the plant pot up with a cybernetic extension and turning it back and forth, inspecting it with practiced eyes.

“Yes - maybe - eventually, tests are needed but with the abundance of material it should only take me two- no three! Actually just.one.year”

Bow shifts focus to Glimmer -a question mark of “should I go ahead with this?” - Glimmer nods - Bow being her most trusted confidant *and* Prince Consort *knows* exactly what Glimmer *wants.*

“I see, do you believe it’s possible to also fabricate or use the weapons in those battleships?”

Entrapta makes a humming sound as she probably contemplates actually ripping off orbital bombardment cannons and test firing them in the lab.

“Yes, I’d need additional manpower and facilities to be able to do it though, as you understand Bow I am only one person and I’d

need help to be able to transport such technological wonders away from populated areas and land is at a premium right now do yo-”

“The Etherian makers society should be able to help and I think we could maybe-” Bow again looks to Glimmer for support.

“We can make some land available for you outside of the Fright Zone,, how quickly could you get this set up?”

“Tomorrow, the Fright Zone? Lots of buildings to test and it's basically deserted! A perfect testing ground for dangerous and beautiful space weapons the size of a house! I cannot begin to fathom how much we cou-”.

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Glimmer called a break and took a walk around the castle of Bright Moon with her husband side by side after Entrapta barged through and busted down a pair of few remaining intact doors in the war room in her excitement to start working,Bright Moon is a little eerie now - with half of the staff and inhabitants simply disappeared, dead or fled there’s a lot more empty space now.

Despite the destruction, she’s still wearing her pink bodysuit with its regal markings, keeping the asymmetrical hair bob and the flowing lavender cape behind her serves as a point of unity for the peoples of Etheria, if they still have their Queen - the Rebellion survives. And her own personal unification with Bow has a signifying gold wrist band made in a pair for the two of them.

Her husband has grown significantly, gone is the shaven face - replaced with the slow growing of a beard, his quiver remains but
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is tucked away and hidden behind a long light cape and his tuxedo is blue now, but the exposed midriff is still there.

Glimmer groans, rubbing her forehead with one hand. “Fucking Mermista has it out for us I swear” She massages that side that’s starting to call out for a much needed morning coffee.

“Hey” Bow reaches out and links his fingers around Glimmer’s unoccupied hand. “It’ll be okay, she’ll be okay again eventually but we can't leave her out, she did lose her boyfriend and whether or not she blames Adora for it-”

“I know, I wish this went another way but it’s the hand we have, just a lot of people missing now”

“She still values us enough to actually come all the way over here, so we just need to not poke her and I think we’ll all come around eventually”

“Netossa though” Glimmer gives a humorless laugh.

“Yeah I think she’s a lost cause at this point, she’ll keep going until she drops to be honest”

The net wielding princess hadn’t been seen doing anything *but* hammering the few remaining holdout followers of the Horde ,whether Etheria or space based in her unending quest for vengeance.

“It’s kind of sad really, she was devoted to Spinny but - now she’s gone and the last thing I remember seeing was *that look* in her eyes”

Bow breathes out and leans in.

“Adora had that look too”

He says darkly.

“I mean couldn't *you* get know, *her* to start leading the armies? She’s got the experience you kn-”

“She’s not here right now and even if she did, not sure if she even wants to”

“Queen Glimmer?” Perfuma interrupts as she runs up behind them, Scorpia in tow who narrowly avoids shoulder rushing into a nearby guard.

“Princess Perfuma? How are you doing?” Bow waves Perfuma over who responds with a thumbs up.

“Pleasant! Even after the unpleasantness of today's meeting, with my future wife here and my energy in a bright green, I believe things are going okay”

Perfuma”s outfit hasn't really changed, except for her once long locks of hair being trimmed down - Scorpia is the one who *has.* Gone is the complete side shave as there’s evidence of hair growth and the Horde outfit has disappeared entirely, the Princess of the Scorpion Kingdom wearing what is instead a simple tanktop with a flower emblazoned in the front that’s joined with a Scorpion.

“And how is Plumeria doing? Specifically.” Glimmer takes the moment to ask without others being present, she’s since learned that taking people to one side and talking to them candidly is usually more useful than a grand meeting.

“Couldn't complain? Thanks to Princess Mermista's efforts , we’re doing better than expected! Food exports including kale continue as you asked and our heart stone continues to provide us with everything we need” Perfuma beams, taking Scorpia”s hand in her own and summoning a flower on top of her head.

Remembering a plan she formed before the meeting that wasn't put into motion due to interruptions, Glimmer instead decides to

put it out into the open now.

“I see, do you think you could increase production? We have massive food shortages in the other Kingdoms and the refugee crisis is getting worse, Plumeria is our breadbasket and we need your help in feeding everyone”

“Uh”

Perfuma blinks.

“We uh”

Scorpia instead takes the lead after visually sensing her girlfriends hesitation.

“Everyone in Plumeria is working on crops and extended harvests, we don't have any more people to spare to send food around”.

“We need that food or else we’ll start seeing riots, hungry people tend to cause problems” Bow leans in and whispers a nugget of advice that Glimmer - after a long lesson of not listening to it over a year ago - takes.

“We-”

She thinks of any readily available people that could help.

The barely functioning army that’s needed for defense if Prime ever comes back? No.

Neither can anyone in the technical field since they’re either under Entrapta’s command now or are busy desperately rebuilding Etheria’s shattered infrastructure.

Refugees are scattered everywhere and it’d take too long to gather them all up and even then it’d be a mixed bag of varying abilities.

“Bow? Any suggestions?” Glimmer hisses.

“We could always, y’know. Get those prisoners to work” Bow sideglances

“The Horde?”

“Yeah, maybe the Clone’s too. Scorpia would the former Horde be able to work fields?”

Scorpia shrugs. “Probably, they’d prefer it to working in the Fright Zone”

Perfuma coughs lightly, trying to smile but it’s clear she’s got a strong opinion on this.
“If I may, Plumeria is a land of positivity and social progress, we cann- I will *not* allow people with a negative path in life to work”

Shit.
Glimmer *needs* those exports.

She needs to think of something,a sort of neutral but politically positive solution to this, some kind of soundbite that’ll work over with the majority of people.

The Fright Zone has been mostly abandoned but it’s people haven't, Princess Netossa might be hunting the last few holdouts but that doesn't mean they’re all that’s left.

“We can pay them!” She blurts out.

“Who?”

“And maybe they could earn freedom points or something”

“My Queen, who are we paying and who is earning “freedom points?” Perfuma fixes her with a confused sidelong glance while Scorpia raises an eyebrow and Bow’s head kind of goes back and forth, he’s so used to Glimmer telling him everything at this point so this is kinda new.

“The uh” Glimmer snaps her fingers and rolls her tongue. “The Clone’s! Wrong Hordaks people and the Horde Soldiers left in the prisons, they’re not doing anything other than taking up space. We could tell them they could earn their freedom and become citizens by working the lands or the battleships, and a bonus they’re already pretty strong right?”

In the end , after much convincing about it being the more compassionate and socially right solution with a detachment of Rebellion soldiers to keep them under wraps if anyone goes wrong, Perfuma does agree (with minimal eye twitching) to have Clone’s and “Hordies” work her farmlands while muttering about negative energy.

The two pairs say their goodbyes, Bow promising to see the soon to-be-married-couple in a few days, Glimmer trying her best to be level and positive with Scorpia who mostly follows Perfuma’s MO of overly flowery talk.

“Oh Perfuma?” Glimmer calls with a side long look.

“Yeah?”

“Thank you for the report on her, it was…”

One of the most depressing reads of my life.

She tries her best attempt at a smile. “Insightful”

And then Glimmer makes her decision of what she wants to do for the rest of the day, rather than talk endlessly through meetings that usually go nowhere or longue around signing forms, she and Bow are going to Mystacor.

Bow protests.

Glimmer teleports the two of them to the same field they've always landed on and then jumped off onto the magically inclined floating landmasses of Mystacor

A field connected to the mainland that is quite sadly now a fortified camp buzzing with drones, robots and a small ceremony of Clone's celebrating the imminent return of Horde Prime.

Prince Consort Bow actually swears.

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"It's the exact reason we need to go all in, they won't be expecting us to to attack in full force"

"You don't understand - the Rebellion's been fighting always in small groups, we need to break the deadlock and send in everyone"

"Who's going in first? Me of course"

"I - I don't need She-Ra"

Resistance in Etheria post Hordak and post Prime is usually in small dispersed groups in the countryside or in the Crimson Waste - lacking signature heavy equipment from Etherian made tanks to space age Drones and support spacecraft the few remaining organized groups typically range from "being a regional security threat" to "can only threaten a small village", so the mop up operations months after the Armada fell out of orbit and crashed into Etheria went easier than expected. Some Clone's aswell as Horde soldiers put down their weapons and eventually attempted
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to integrate into society with mixed results from both themselves and the population.

Lonnie and Wrong Hordak being notable successful members.

These guys though. There's a security laser fence running all the way around, there's prefabricated structures,turrets and living quarters and even a shrine of Prime in the center. All in the same drab and bland colors of eraser white with no flaw or customization, compared to Glimmer and Bow's colorful, somewhat regal and bright clothing - the camp is a fashion disaster.

And there's lots, *lots* of Clone's. An entire company's worth of two meter tall identical frowning bald crested followers of a psychotic space Emperor armed with stun batons, arm cannons and with twenty heavy footdrone's powering up from crouches and a small airforce of now suddenly armed *and* active flying ones.

The sun crests over the cliff to Mystacor, the first Drone practically combusts with a flick of the fingers from the Queen. The area surrounding is all grass and vegetation - an idyllic paradise of wildlife considering it's probably one of the few area's that hasn't been torched ,battled over or had a spaceship crash into it and form a crater a kilometer wide.

Glimmer didn't intend to be directly here or even knew about this camp but she's been out of the field for *far too* long. Glimmer hasn't had a buzzing feeling like this since she wrecked Prime's ship during Entrapta's thermonuclear bombing.

She's spent month after month embroiled in meetings and diplomatic visits that went more along the lines of verbal trench warfare, never being able to get out much or even flex her Moonstone enriched powers.

Glimmer *could* teleport away to safety - she very easily has the means to - just by thinking of a destination and holding onto Bow

and it’d make sense for someone of her position and importance to.

But.

Glimmer doesn’t run away any more. And she’s spent too long hunkered down without any real outlet other than endless diplomacy. Another month and the Queen’s pretty sure she’d be climbing up the walls.

So a camp full of Clone’s that follow Prime and with nothing around to worry about with regards to saving or simple collerator damage on valuable infrastructure and an irreplaceable people.

Glimmer would be a fool to pass up such an opportunity.

Besides, it’d be what *Adora* would do. She’d size up the situation, contrast it to her and the forces she had on hand and if it’d do, it’d do. She’d charge in and make sure it wouldn't be a problem for later on.

A philosophy Glimmer has followed ever since she met that red jacketed hair poofed asshole and best friend all those years ago.

Without even charging or serious effort, a purple null lance flies out of Queen Glimmer’s fingertips that promptly slices through the forcefield, sets two buildings on fire and simply erases three Clone’s *from existence* at the sub atomic level.

She’s going to enjoy this.

“Uh Glimmer, I know that you have the Moonstone and everything bu-”

Glimmer teleports a specially made longbow and an arrow quill directly into Bow’s hands.

“You were saying? Come on love, we’ve haven't done this in *forever* ” Glimmer says nonchalantly as she uses a sparkle like flamethrower.

Bow's arrow knocks three Drone's out of the sky and he dodges a plasma beam. "Just saying, some forewarning would have been nice!"

"Hey! I cant see what's gonna be there when I teleport, we covered this stuff when I was twelve"

"Fine, fine, just. We should probably be back in time for dinner right?"

"It's a deal!" "Now let's kick back and relax okay?"

Despite Bow's reservations, some of which given their recent marriage and history could be well founded and the others are just his usual concerns, none of it matters though because, agaisnt the two of them with Glimmer's supercharged Moonstone magic and Bow's incredible marksmanship - the Clone's and their space tech with unmanned drones really don't stand a chance.

"Glimmer! What are we supposed to be doing anyway?"

Photokenketic blasts of light repeatedly boom out of Glimmer's hands as she teleports from each side of the camp to the other, creating a fiery whirlwind in the grass that steadily envelopes and then outright torches squads of Clone's and their buildings.

"Having fun! Are you?"

God its a breath of fucking fresh air.

Bow continues to down flying Drones with the same method that the two of them perfect - Glimmer teleports in the air (and basically somersaults) and clears the ground while Bow takes cover and takes out the air.

A squad of Clone's firing laser cannons? A beam of light from Glimmer's middle finger that is precipitated by repeated thunderous cracks of sound barrier that turns them into paste.

Two ground Drones readying missile packs to hit Glimmer as she teleports multiple altitudes and positions are disabled by Bow's emp arrows - courtesy of the makers society - pierce their armor and fly straight into the weakpoints.

Glimmer whoops as she backflips off a building, jumps in the air and speedily teleports between a pair of Clone before sparkle flamethrowing them, she's having fun.

Fun because it's like active duty again with Adora and Bow, when it was them against the world and honestly fuck Horde Prime and his Clone's in particular, they're responsible for the near destruction of the ecological stability of Etheria.

Bow keeps his cool and only says something when its to communicate something urgent, gone are the days of constant chattering during times of action when the best friends squad would be talking over each other, now they're a well oiled machine -Bow and Glimmer know each other's strengths and practically fall in lockstep. Or more of a complicated dance of death dealing really..

They're responsible for Adora, they're responsible for the millions dead, displaced and in near starvation.

Fuck them.

These guys? They deserve to die, and Glimmer will enjoy the exhilarating thrill of combat once again after what feels is eons.

Cascading spell casts of a combination of light and dark magic that open up pits in the very earth and swallow squads whole before closing up, a staff that briefly illuminates the area around it before it literally casts an artificial thunderbolt that disintegrates and evaporates all living tissue it touches. Arrows of different makes ranging from electronic electrocuting shock to armor piercing explosive.

Ten minutes later, the burning carcass of the Horde camp is reduced to rubble and corpses.

Mission accomplished.

Mystacor is next.

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"Look, all Horde soldiers down from cadets to Force Officers follow their Captains without hesitation, if we take this one out then they'll be disorganized and run"

"You don't get it, we NEED to either bury, suffocate or kill them. There's no inbetween"

"Fine, I'll do it"

Afterwards Bow and Glimmer have a conversation about Adora, lamenting that she's not here anymore and that she threw herself into being killed and they have mixed feelings about her doing it on her own but also sort of understanding why, they just miss her and wish she could be around to witness and be with them and her friends as they slowly rebuild Etheria and look to the stars for the first time in eons.

Aside from the population decline like every other major settlement on Etheria - in all honesty Mystacor hasn't changed much, it's primary purpose of facilitating, training and serving as a primary location for Princess's learning their connection with the runestones, magically gifted scions of age old families and
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everyone in between. Glimmer trained here when she was young, some time after the believed death of her father, Micah and her mothers following a year long state of shock promoted the need for a magical education.

“Sorry about the meeting today, Mermista usually isn't like that and I was actually hoping to spend more time with you”

And now, despite the decades long war and the presumed death of a parent and the real death of another, losing friends and trusted associates from birth left and right.

“Don't worry about it kiddo, stuff came up but it’s sorted now - thanks for getting rid of that camp by the way , they kind of just crept up on us - it’s more embarrassing actually than threatening”

Queen Glimmer of Etheria is walking down a hallway with the former King Micah of Etheria, the former king and her father. A man who up until a few months was lost to the world, to his spouse and his daughter.

“I guess, it felt more like stretching my legs”

Now, crowned in the simple robes of a teacher and armed with an everyday staff and a casual headpiece, Micah seems to be more at home lecturing students and lodging with his sister while receiving visits from his daughter than ruling a planet and holding back an intergalactic space army.

With Castaspella and Bow in tow behind, the two of them conserving shared interests. Glimmer and Micah lead the way into the bowels of the teleporting city from transerving beautiful enchanted marble work of stonemasons and tall statues celebrating renowned figures to a more practical and neutral work. It’s an area Glimmer never visited nor had reasons to.

“Did you read the report? Bow did this morning and it was a pretty sobering read”

Micah turns on the candle lights of a hallway with a gesture as they turn into it. His voice turns from the usual cheery "nothing gets me down" attitude to something more somber and brooding.

"-I did"

That was the end of that really. The lack of conversation that followed precluded the facilities they visited with even Bow and Castaspella's animated conversation slowly dwindling until the only noise they too made were simply footsteps and the occasional casting of convenient magical spells as they proceeded deeper and deeper into the colder depths of Mystacor.

Bow, did you read it?

Yeah-...yeah I did, wish I hadn't but it was mandatory and I kind of felt compelled to.

I'm sorry if it felt that way, but Perfuma gave all of us a copy and I didnt wanna leave you in the dark, I trust you more than anyone and you deserved to read it as much as the other princesses.

It's not that, I just-. How didn't we see this coming? Did we fail them? How bad were we as friends that they spiraled out of control and chose to do that rather than talk to us?

Bow I-.

Glimmer?

It’s a question for the people trained for this to do, we’ll do what we can and the best people are working on this, if there's a way to fix this, they’ll find it. Do you trust me on this?

I trust you.

I love you Bow.

I love you too, Glimmer.

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Basically the rest of the chapter falls into lockstep with Glimmer being there for Catra waking up and the two of them teleporting to the grasslands.

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The main problem with having this is that Be Brave/Watch me burn was supposed to be entirely focused and self contained on the actions and reactions of the cast of the save the cat, so having significantly more characters felt like it was dragging away from what was basically a extended episode.

I hope this was a insight into how post Adora blowing up the spaceship (and dying) and Glimmer struggling to maintain control to the point of which she’d enlist catra’s help would come along.

There wont be any more chapters or content after this, writing this fic has been emotionally and mentally draining, thank you for reading and as always -feed back would be appreciated.

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